



# PONNI'S BELOVED

Volume 2 : The Storm



An English Translation of  
Kalki Krishnamurthy's Ponniyin Selvan by

**SUMEETHA MANIKANDAN**

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**AN ENGLISH TRANSLATION OF  
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SELVAN**

by

**Sumeetha Manikandan**

**Part 2 of 5 - The Storm**



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## ABOUT THE AUTHOR

*Sumeetha Manikandan is a top bestselling romance author whose novellas 'Perfect Groom' and 'These Lines of Mehendi' (which was published as a paperback novel called 'Love Again') have been on the top of Amazon India charts ever since their publication. A bookaholic, thinker, feminist and a daydreamer, she reads across genres and is a crazy fan of history, romance and science fiction novels.*

*An avid reader of historical novels, she has been translating Kalki Krishnamurthy's classic Tamil novel Ponniyin Selvan for the past ten years and hopes to translate more of his novels into English.*

*Sumeetha is married to filmmaker K.S. Manikandan and lives with her nine-year-old daughter in Chennai.*

## Acknowledgement

First and foremost, I would like to acknowledge my father who used to tell me the story of Ponniyin Selvan every evening during dinner and fueled my interest to read the book.

My Aunt Ranganayaki who lent me her Ponniyin Selvan books all those years ago when I was in school. I still treasure them to this day.

Navin and Vidya Sigamany for publishing the first drafts of Ponni's Beloved on their website Zine 5.com almost ten years ago.

Author Venkatesh Ramakrishnan who encouraged me to resume the translation again.

I would like to thank my editor Inderpreet Kaur Uppal for her stellar efforts in editing and proofreading.

Friends like Raja King, Fowzia Iqbal, Abirami Baskaran, Sastha Prakash, Ramanujam Jaganathan, Thirukambigai Devi and countless others who followed the translation avidly and promoted it among numerous groups.

I would also like to dedicate this book to all those fans who have been asking me for years to publish my translation and to my husband who claims to be the first among them.



## AUTHOR'S NOTE

Kalki Krishnamurthy's Ponniyin Selvan was the first Tamil novel that I read. To tell you the truth, I learnt to read Tamil using elementary school books, just so that I could read this story.

They say that good books and great authors can transform lives. I have found it to be true in my case. I started translating this book ten years ago, as a hobby and realized that I could write. Today, I am a freelance writer who makes a living out of writing, and I owe my profession to this novel!

Many authors have written phenomenal books in Tamil literature after Kalki Krishnamurthy, but Ponniyin Selvan still remains the most popular book, widely read by many. Ponniyin Selvan has the right mixture of all things that makes an epic – political intrigue, conspiracy, betrayal, huge dollops of romance, infidelity, seduction, passion, alluring women, unrequited love, sacrifice and pure love.

*Ponni's Beloved* is an English translation, and as many readers have pointed out, no translation can do justice to the original. I have tried to capture the essence and soul of Kalki's writing in my translation.

I recently visited all the places (in India) that are mentioned in this novel. We started on Aadi 18 (Aug 3, 2019) for this trail trip almost on the footsteps of Vandiya Devan and saw all the fascinating places that he mentions in the journey. I have included some of the photos in this volume. For those who wish to sign up for this tour trail, do contact Tour Bee (7299646588). The tour trail was well organized and at the curator had many interesting stories about each place that we visited.

Thank you,  
Sumeetha Manikandan





## FOREWORD

Kalki Krishnamurthy's *Ponniyin Selvan* was serialized in the post-independence era and it ran for four long years. Talking about a golden era in Tamil history, it ensnared the imagination of huge swathe of the Tamil population with people queuing in railway stations long before dawn to lay their hands on that week's edition of the Kalki magazine.

An entire generation dwelt upon the freshness of the novel and surprisingly it was not condemned to the recesses of the mind as a childhood fancy but continued to entice readers of subsequent generations as they were born and introduced to the Tamil language. The novel still has a colossal following but bounded by the hedges of a language that is not easy to learn, it strictly remained out of the mainstream and well within the realms of the Tamil speaking world.

Tamil people have been habitual migrants and the diaspora is spread over numerous countries. In today's generation, though many of them can speak fluent Tamil they lack the patience to read the Tamil script that is spread over 1000 pages of a novel. And that's when the need arises a need for a good translation.

When I read the novel late in my thirties, the social media was just picking up and I was introduced to the yahoo group of Ponniyin Selvan fans around the year 2001. For the first time, readers from different age groups, settled in different lands were congregating online.

It was there that I came across a translation of Ponniyin Selvan into English. (There had been one earlier in print but that left much to be desired for those who had read the original. In fact, at one point the earlier translator mentioned 'Maize' for the Tamil word Cholam. But it

was pointed out in the group that Maize entered India 500 years after the storyline period.)

The online translation was a bold bid by a youngster. As much as the substance within, the attempt bedazzled a lot of us because for 40 years or more it was almost sacrilege to deal with Kalki's works. The one sequel in the market at that time had been mauled by the copyright owners!

Over the next decade many of the members of the Yahoo group became novelists, biographers, bloggers, heritage activists and a host of history and literature connected personalities. And I would like to list Sumeetha's translation of Kalki's work as a starting point for all this.

A translated work should remind us of the original and it should have the author's imprint on the words. I think Sumeetha comes out in flying colours on both fronts. I am sure her work would open up the genius of Kalki to many who were deprived of it all these days.

### ***Biography of Venkatesh Ramakrishnan:***

Author Venkatesh Ramakrishnan is a Chennai based bilingual novelist from India. South Indian historical fiction is his forte. He has published 3 novels in Tamil, 2 of them are sequels to the famous Kalki Krishnamurthy novels Ponniyin Selvan and Sivagamiyin Sabatham respectively, with the titles Kaviri Mainthan and Kanji Tharagai. One of his other fictional work in Tamil is Thillayil Oru Kollaikaran. Gods, Kings & Slaves. The Siege of Madurai is his first novel in English.

# Character List

## CHOLA ROYAL FAMILY

**Paranthaka II** – Emperor of the Chola and Pandya kingdoms from 957 to 970 CE, when this story happens. His handsomeness earned him the popular epithet of Sundara Chola, meaning Handsome Chola.

**Vanamadevi** - Consort of Paranthaka II and empress of the Cholas, she is the mother of Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan, Princess Kundavai and Prince Arulmozhivarman. Her father is the nobleman Thirukovallur Malayaman.

**Aditya Karikalan** - Eldest son of Sundara Chola and Vanamadevi and crown prince to the Chola throne, Aditya Karikalan is a peerless warrior who defeated and killed the Pandya king and established Chola suzerainty over his kingdom.

**Kundavai** - Younger sister of Aditya Karikalan and the daughter of Sundara Chola and Vanamadevi. Kundavai is cherished throughout the kingdom for her wit, wisdom, grace and intelligence. She lives in Pazhaiaarai along with her companions and friends.

**Arulmozhivarman** - The youngest son of Sundara Chola and Vanamadevi, Arulmozhivarman is known throughout the kingdom as 'Ponniyin Selvan'. At the time of the story, he is in Ilangai (Sri Lanka) on a campaign against King Mahindan and had captured many parts of the island. He later ascended the Chola throne as Raja Raja Cholan (985 - 1014 CE).

**Gandaradithan** - Son of Paranthaka I and Sundara Chola's uncle. He was the Chola king from 950 to 957 CE. Gandaradithan was known for his piety.

**Sembiyanmadevi** - King Gandaradithan's queen who was equally virtuous and spiritual. She belongs to the clan of Mazhavarayar and married the king despite his advanced age.

**Madhuranthakan** - Son of King Gandaradhithan and Sembiyanmadevi and the first cousin of Sundara Chola.

**Arinjaya Chola** - Son of Paranthaka I and the father of Sundara Chola. He reigned for a very short period from 956 to 957 CE.

**Kalyani** - Wife of King Arinjaya Chola and the mother of Sundara Chola. She belongs to Vaithumbarayar clan.

**Rajadhithan** - Eldest son and heir apparent of Paranthaka I. Prince Rajadhithan died in the Thakkolam war (950 CE) after which the crown passed on to his younger brother.

**Paranthaka I** - Grandfather of Sundara Chola, Paranthaka I ruled from 907 to 955 CE.

## **Noble Clans**

### **PAZHUVUR CLAN**

**Periya Pazhuvetarayar** - Lord Treasurer of the Chola kingdom and a peerless warrior who carried 64 battle scars on his body. He is the patriarch and the petty king of the powerful Pazhuvur clan and is an influential courtier and nobleman at the Chola court.

**Nandini Devi** - Queen and wife of Periya Pazhuvetarayar, Nandini is a young woman renowned for her beauty. Nandini's antecedents are a mystery and her past life is shrouded in secrecy.

**Chinna Pazhuvetarayar** - Also known as Kalanthaka Kanda, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar is the younger brother of Periya Pazhuvetarayar and is the commander of the Thanjavur fort. A powerful man with a strong physique, he is also the father-in-law of Prince Madhuranthakan.

### **KODUMBALUR CLAN**

**Budivikrama Kesari** - The commander of troops in Ilangai, he is also known as Kodumbalur Periya Vellar. He is the patriarch of the Kodumbalur Clan.

**Vanathi** - A Kodumbalur princess and the niece of Budivikrama Kesari, Vanathi is also the cherished companion and friend of Princess Kundavai, who hopes to wed her to Prince Arulmozhivarman.

**Kodumbalur Siriya Vellar** - Father of Vanathi and the younger brother of Budivikrama Kesari, he died valiantly in Ilangai after leading a campaign across the sea.

### **SAMBUVERAYAR CLAN**

**Singannar Sambuvarayar** - A powerful lord who ruled over Kadambur.

**Kandanmaran** - Son of Sambuvarayar who also fought along with Aditya Karikalan in many wars.

**Manimegalai** - Daughter of Sambuvarayar and the sister of Kandanmaran.

## **MALAYAMAN CLAN**

**Thirukkovalur Malayaman** - Patriarch of the Malayaman clan and the father-in-law of Sundara Chola. He is close to his oldest grandson Aditya Karikalan.

## **VANAR CLAN**

**Vandiya Devan** - Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan is Aditya Karikalan's bodyguard, friend and confidante.

## **PANDYA KING'S BODYGUARDS**

**Ravidasan** - The ringleader of the conspirators who wish to avenge the death of their king. He is also known as 'Mandiravadi'.

**Soman Sambavan** - One of the conspirators and a member of Ravidasan's gang.

**Edupankari** - One of the Pandya conspirators who works in the Kadambur palace and overhears the noblemen's plots about the Chola succession.

**Devaralan** - One of the Pandya conspirators who works in the Kadambur palace.

## **OTHER IMPORTANT CHARACTERS**

**Azhwarkadiyan Nambi** - A Vaishnavite and a spy who is also known as Thirumalai or Thirumalaiappan. He also claims to be Nandini Devi's brother.

**Parthibendra Pallavan** - Close confidante and friend of Aditya Karikalan.

**Kudanthai Jodhidar** - An astrologer in Kudanthai (present-day Kumbakonam) who is patronized by Kundavai.

**Senthan Amuthan** - A devout man who would offer the flowers of his garden to Thallikullathar Temple in Thanjavur. Vandiya Devan stays in his house while visiting Thanjavur.

**Poonguzhali** - Senthan Amuthan's cousin who lives in Kodi Karai.





## **Glossary of Terms**

**Abathudavigal** – The army of bodyguards that guarded the Pandya King

**Adey** – An expression used to refer someone with derision and disrespect

**Adigaley** – A respectful term used to address a monk

**Amma** – Mother

**Ammavasai** – New Moon

**Anna** - Elder brother

**Anni** - Elder brother's wife

**Anthapuram** - Women's quarters in a palace, usually located in an interior and protected part

**Akka** - Elder sister

**Appa** - Father

**Ayya** – A respectful term in Tamil used to address men

**Ayyo / Ayyayo** – An exclamation of distress

**Battar** – Term used to refer to the priest

**Bikshu** – A Buddhist Monk

**Chi Chi** – An expression of disgust

**Dalapathy** - Army Commander

**Devi** – Used to address royal or noble women

**Dhanadhigari** – Treasurer

**Dhoomketu** – A comet

**Gurunatha** – Teacher

**Jodhidar** – An Astrologer

**Kalapathy** – Ship's Captain or Commander

**Maha Mandiri** – Prime Minister

**Maharaja** – My King

**Maha Guru** – Chief among teachers

**Mandapam** – A canopy, usually built of stone with four or more pillars.

**Mandiravadi** – Magician

**Malai** – A Mountain

**Olai** – Palm leaf used to write messages

**Padai** - Army

**Paatti** – Grandmother

**Pujari** – A priest

**Prabhu** – A respectful term to address a lord, prince or the king

**Rani** – Queen

**Raja Drogam** – Treason against the king

**Rakshashi** - Demoness

**Senapathy** – Army Commander

**Samudra Rajan** – The Sea God

**Sangu Sakkaram** – Conch and discus

**Thambi** – Younger brother

**Thatha** – Grandfather

**Theevu** – An Island

**Vajrayudham** – Thunderbolt

**Vaikuntam** – The abode of Lord Vishnu

**Vihara** – A Monastery

## **The story so far...**

About a thousand years ago, a young soldier called Vandiya Devan was traveling towards the Chola Kingdom bearing important messages for Emperor Sundara Chola and Princess Kundavai from the Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan. One night, he stays at Kadambur at his friend Kandanmaran's palace. Coincidentally that day, Kandanmaran's father is playing host to many important noble lords of the Chola kingdom and he had invited Periya Pazhuvetarayar, the Lord Treasurer of the Cholas. Vandiya Devan inadvertently finds out that all the noble lords under the leadership of Periya Pazhuvetarayar were plotting to crown Prince Madhuranthakan (Sundara Chola's first cousin) as the emperor after Sundara Chola's demise. He is disgusted to learn that Pazhuvetarayar was taking Madhuranthakan around with him in a veiled palanquin, while most people mistook him to be his wife.

Vandiya Devan also meets a Veera Vaishnavan named Azhwarkadiyan Nambi (also known as Thirumalai) in Kadambur who follows him around and is seen trying to listen in on the secret meeting of the nobles.

The Veera Vaishnavan wants to meet Periya Pazhuvetrayar's wife, Nandini, because she was his step-sister once upon a time. Nandini was found by Azhwarkadiyan's parents in a garden as a new-born baby and brought up as their own daughter. Three years ago, when the Cholas and Pandyas were engaged in a bitter battle in the Pandya kingdom, the Pandya soldiers had brought the wounded Veera Pandyan (king of Pandyas) to Nandini's hut, who tried to help him. Sadly, the Chola soldiers find out about this and Aditya Karikalan beheads the king. Periya Pazhuvetarayar, who was with them, takes Nandini away and marries her. Since then Azhwarkadiyan has been trying to meet Nandini.

In the meantime, Princess Kundavai comes to Kudanthai along with her companion Princess Vanathi to meet an astrologer. At the astrologer's house, Vandiya Devan meets Kundavai and falls in love with her though he has no clue about her identity. He meets her again in Arisalaru (near Kudanthai) while trying to save her friends from a dead crocodile.

Azhwarkadiyan also stumbles upon a conspiracy hatched by a handful of Pandya soldiers who were once bodyguards of Veera Pandyan to assassinate the Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan, his brother Prince Arulmozhivarman and the emperor Sundara Chola.

Vandiya Devan approaches Thanjavur and is worried about how to meet the emperor alone and warn him about the dangerous plot that the noble lords were hatching. He encounters a veiled palanquin on the way and thinking that it's Prince Madhuranthakan he accosts them, only to find that it is Nandini Devi. He uses Azhwarkadiyan's name to seek help from her and she gives him the Pazhuvur signet ring with a palm leaf emblem to enter the fort.

Inside the fort, he befriends a flower-seller's assistant named Senthana Amuthan and stays in his garden house for a night. On the next day, he goes to the Thanjavur fort and gains entry into the palace thanks to the Pazhuvur ring. He meets Chinna Pazhuvetarayar (Periya Pazhuvetarayar's brother), the commander of the fort, and tells him that his brother had sent him. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar allows him to meet the emperor in private but the emperor gets distracted by poets who arrive to meet him. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar becomes suspicious and tries to confine him to his guest chamber but Vandiya Devan escapes from his guards and ends up hiding in Nandini's palace gardens. Nandini meets him and offers him a position in her palace but he refuses saying that he had agreed to work for Kundavai. She tries to seduce him into accepting the position but is interrupted by the arrival of the chief of the Pandya bodyguards whom Azhwarkadiyan had encountered earlier. We learn that Nandini is helping them with gold to avenge the gory death of their king.

Vandiya Devan remains hidden nearby and he finds a way out of the fort through a dark tunnel. At the end of the tunnel, he meets Kandanmaran, who is stabbed by a guard. Vandiya Devan kills the guard and saves Kandanmaran's life. He leaves the wounded Kandanmaran at Senthana Amuthan's house and leaves for Pazhaiaarai to meet Kundavai.

At Pazhaiaarai, Vandiya Devan enters the city masquerading as an actor with a drama troupe. He meets Kundavai and informs her about the plot that the nobles are hatching under the leadership of the Pazhuvetarayar brothers. Kundavai gives him a message for her brother in Ilangai and tasks him to bring her brother home. Bearing the message, Vandiya Devan leaves for Kodi Karai to take a boat to Ilangai.

At Kanchipuram, Aditya Karikalan and his friend Pallava Parthibendran are furious with the Pazhuvur brothers for branding their messenger as a spy. His maternal grandfather, Malayaman advises him to be patient. They decide to send

Parthibendran to Ilangai to get Arulmozhivarman back home. Karikalan confides in Parthibendran about his secret passion for Nandini, whom he had met at Pazhaiaarai, and his wish to marry her. He reveals how devastated he was when he found out that she was tending to Veera Pandyan's wounds. He regrets beheading Veera Pandyan despite Nandini's pleas. His anger at learning that she was Pazhuvetrayar's wife now was the sole reason he was not going to Thanjavur to meet his father. At the end of this conversation, Parthibendran gets ready to go Ilangai.



## Chapter 1 – Poonguzhali

The waves washed gently against the shore and receded, marking a peaceful dusky evening in Kodi Karai<sup>[1]</sup>. The sky was dotted with birds flying back home across the pristine white sands of the soft beach. In the woods near the beach, the air seemed still, and the sun was fast sinking behind a veil of clouds.



Kodi Karai Beach Today

A small boat, its oars being plied by a young woman, made its way towards the shore. She reminds us of Senthan Amuthan's description of his uncle's daughter Poonguzhali.

Yes, she is indeed Poonguzhali. Perhaps to justify her beautiful name, she had decorated her hair with a flower and her lovely curly

tresses fell in cascades upon her shoulders. An attractive necklace of shells adorned her neck but indeed, it seemed pleasing to the eye only because she wore it.

What could be more alluring than a beautiful maiden plying a boat? Surely, it would be her melodious voice. Sitting languidly on the boat, she sang a haunting song about the sea and it seemed as if the wind stood still to listen to her honeyed voice. Even the sinking sun stood still for a while before ushering in the night.

While the waves of the sea are placid and gentle,  
why does the sea within me surge and rise?

When the mother earth sleeps in peace,  
why should my heart rise in anguish?

Even the birds of the forest search for their nests!  
Hunters and archers seek their homes too!

When the heaven and earth are enveloped in peace  
why is a storm stirring within the heart of that doe-eyed girl?

The sea will stand still and the breeze will crawl in,  
But why does the wind swirl so strong in that girl's heart?

Listening to her, one wonders what sorrow this young maiden might be hiding in the deepest recess of her heart that seemed to give such a poignant tinge of sadness to her voice.

The song ended as she neared the shore. Reaching the beach, she nimbly got out of the boat and pulled it behind her, deftly securing it and let it rest near the many other boats tied there. She looked around the beach and spotted the light from the lighthouse that acted as a beacon warning ships lest they come too near the shore. Beyond the woods, a temple stood hidden among the trees.

Two hundred years ago, Sundaramurthy Nayanar<sup>[2]</sup> had come to Kodi Karai Kuzhagar temple<sup>[3]</sup> and had sung his famous Devaram<sup>[4]</sup> about how Lord Shiva stood alone amidst the sea and the beach.



My Lord! Why are you here all alone on this lonely beach? This place isn't worthy of you! You are needed in a place where throngs of devotees would place their offerings at your divine feet and not on a lonely stretch of beach.

Yet even after two hundred years, Kodi Karai still remains a secluded stretch of beach, sand and woods at the time of our story. The thick forest that surrounded the temple was populated with wild animals and hooting owls, making it more dangerous than it was two hundred years ago. There was, however, one difference. Two hundred years ago, there was no lighthouse here it had been built during the reign of Emperor Paranthakan I and since then it had become a home for a few families who took care of the lighthouse and the temple.



Kodi Karai Lighthouse today

Poonguzhali looked around her and thought of going towards the lighthouse and then she saw the temple Gopuram<sup>[5]</sup> of Kuzhagar temple and decided to go there instead. As she made the decision, the temple bells started ringing melodiously.

*Why am I going home so early? Let me visit the temple. I can ask the Battar<sup>[6]</sup> to sing divine devaram songs and then take the prasadam<sup>[7]</sup> home.*

Deciding thus, she walked quickly towards the temple. On the way, she saw a herd of deer running towards the forest. Among them was a lovely young deer, graceful and childlike. Poonguzhali's enthusiasm knew no bounds when she saw the herd. She ran along with them as if she was going to catch them but no matter how fast you run, you cannot really compete with the agility of the deer. The herd overtook her and ran gracefully ahead.

At one place, all the deer collectively leapt as if they were escaping from a dangerous deep pool but one of the smaller ones fell in the middle. Sinking in the quicksand, it tried to claw its way up but moaned piteously when the attempt failed. The mother deer and the rest of the herd had stopped running and were watching the small deer worriedly, but they couldn't help the young one.

Poonguzhali immediately set about to help the small doe. She noted carefully where the quicksand ended and approached the place where the deer was stuck. The herd and the mother deer looked at her suspiciously not knowing her intentions. Softly, she cooed at them with a strange sound and that seemed to reassure them. She bent over the quicksand pool and grabbed the little deer's legs and pulled it to safety. The little deer stood trembling from fear for some time and then turned around and ran to its mother for succour and comfort. Soon the entire herd started running at breakneck speed.

"Such ungrateful creatures!" she exclaimed and then comforted herself saying, "Though they are certainly better than humans who are worse than ungrateful."

She started walking towards Kuzhagar temple into the forest. The thick grove of the forest was so dense that strangers who are unfamiliar with the terrain could easily get lost and roam around clueless for long. Nestled amidst the trees stood the old temple looking a bit desolate and deserted. She entered the temple and went straight to the inner sanctum. The temple priest looked at her in surprise and smiled. Visitors hereabouts were rare and attractive young boat girls were more than welcome.



**Kuzhagar Temple**

After she finished her prayers, the priest gave her a coconut and the prasadam to eat and said, “Will you wait for a while? I will come along with you.”

“I will wait for you ayya<sup>[8]</sup>! I am in no hurry.”

Saying thus, she came out and nimbly climbed on one of the trees to hoist herself on the temple walls. Along the walls, there was a statue of Nandi<sup>[9]</sup>, the bull. Sitting with her back on the considerable bulk of Nandi, she leisurely ate the coconut and the temple prasadam.

As darkness enveloped the temple as dusk set in, she heard horses galloping. She looked intently at the direction of the sound and her heart stirred with a long-gone memory that threatened to choke her with an indescribable sorrow.

*Who is coming here? What do I care who it is? There are too many strangers coming around here these days, citing royal duties. Yesterday too, two people had come wanting to go to Ilangai. They looked so disgusting but Anna took them on his boat after they gave him a bag full of gold coins. May thunder fall upon their gold! Who wants it here? What purpose can gold serve when you are living amidst a forest? But Anna and Anni's world revolves around money. They just want more and more!*



**Wild horses in Kodi Karai beach**

As the sound of galloping horses came closer, she noted that there were two riders. It looked as though if they had travelled a long distance. The man on the first horse was quite young, handsome, broad-chested and looked like a soldier. However, when compared with another face that she had enthroned in her heart, she found him downright ugly. On second thoughts, his face looked like an owl!

As readers might have guessed, the first man on the horse is our hero, Vandiya Devan. Behind him came the physician's son who had accompanied him from Pazhaiaarai. They both were saddle sore and weary, yet Vandiya Devan's face lit up when he saw Poonguzhali lounging atop the temple wall, carelessly eating the coconut. When he saw that she too was looking eagerly at his face, his enthusiasm knew no bounds. He stopped the horse and looked at her with a smile. If he had known that she had been comparing his face to that of an owl, he might not be so enthusiastic to talk to her. Thankfully, God found it worthwhile to make humans hide their innermost thoughts from others.

When Poonguzhali realized that the man on the horse was staring at her, she immediately jumped down on the soft sand of the temple and started running along the temple wall.

When Vandiya Devan saw her running, he too got down from his horse and started after her. Now, who can divine why she felt like running away from a man who was staring at her or what prompted Vandiya Devan to take off after her. We can only conclude that each one of them was following their natural instincts in the order of the world.

## Chapter 2 – The Quicksand

Vandiya Devan chased the girl through the thick forest. Nimble and quick, she skirted through trees, pits and mounds and would vanish from his line of sight for a while and just when he would be ready to give up she would appear again.

Looking at her, Vandiya Devan was reminded of the magical deer that Lord Rama<sup>[10]</sup> had to chase in the Pachavati<sup>[11]</sup> forest.

*My god! This girl is not a magical deer but she has all the swiftness and the grace of a deer.*

Just as he was thinking about her, he also wondered why he was chasing her in the first place. To justify his actions, he also imagined a reason for it. Even as he neared Kodi Karai he was reminded of Senthana Amuthan's description about Poonguzhali.

This must be Poonguzhali, Senthana's uncle's daughter. It might be beneficial to make friends with her as he also needed a guide to take



him to the lighthouse.

Though the lighthouse was visible at a distance, he had found it difficult to approach the place once they got into the forest. Confused and disoriented, he and the physician's son were roaming aimlessly when they came upon Poonguzhali at the temple. He had wanted to ask her for directions to go to the lighthouse but before he could open his mouth, she had started running.

*What to do now? Shall I leave her and go back?*

He didn't want to acknowledge to himself that a girl had bested him in running either!

Even while he thought thus, they came out of the woods and he could see the beach ahead and the calm sea.

*What a glorious sight! The lighthouse was also visible and was lit with fire. Shall I leave this girl and go towards the lighthouse? No, it will be easier to catch her on this beach and she was running towards the beach. How long can she run there? he reasoned. What if she was a sea nymph? Will she disappear when she reaches the water?*

He regretted not bringing his horse here. Astride it, he would have caught her within no time.

Running wildly after her, he saw that she had stopped running abruptly ahead of him and had turned left and was running towards the woods again. With his legs protesting loudly and breath rasping, he chased her.

He imagined what would she say if he caught hold of her and said, "Girl, stop running! I have got a message from your lover in Thanjavur." How surprised will she be? While it was true that Senthana Amuthan did not send any message to her but what of it? He just needed to give his imagination a free rein!

Thinking thus, he sprang after her hoping to catch her before she disappeared again. He didn't know what happened exactly but found himself shouting, "Ayyo!" It took him a moment to realize what had happened. He found himself drowning in mud and he was going down in the quick sand.

*My God! How did this happen? How did I end up here?*

The place looked dry enough when he had stepped on it but looks are deceptive. Vandiya Devan had heard of quicksand near beaches and marshy areas that have swallowed even elephants! To his horror, he realized that he was fast sinking and had nothing to hold himself and hoist up.

*What will happen to my dreams?*

He realized that only Poonguzhali could save him now. He shouted loudly, "Ayyo! I am dying. I am drowning in this quicksand. Please save me!"

Poonguzhali stopped running and turned around. She noted his dangerous situation and decided to help him. There was a half sunken boat on the quicksand pool. She got on it nimbly and came to the other side of the pool. Bracing her legs on the hard floor, she reached out and held her hand to Vandiya Devan. Her seemingly lean arms had an iron grip that belied her slight figure. Vandiya Devan was astonished by her strength and could only compare it with that of Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's iron grip.

After he came out of the quicksand, he laughed out loud though his legs were trembling.

"Do you really think that you saved me from that quicksand? Did you perhaps think that I wouldn't have come out of it without your help?" he asked her cheekily.

“Then why were you screaming? asked Poonguzhali looking annoyed.

“To stop you from running.”

“Really! Then let me push you back in that quicksand. This time around, you can rescue yourself,” saying this she tried to push him back

“Ayyayo!” shouted Vandiya Devan and moved away from her warily.

“What are you scared of now?”

“I am not scared for my life but I don’t want to get muddy again. As such, I am half drowned in mud.”

Poonguzhali smiled and said, “There is the sea, go and clean yourself there.

“Only if you can come with me as a guide,” said Vandiya Devan and they both started walking towards the beach.

“Why did you run so wildly after looking at me? Did you perchance think that I was some demon or a vicious ghost?”

“No. I didn’t think you were a demon. I thought you looked like an owl.” She said and laughed.

Vandiya Devan who was vain and considered himself to be very handsome found this to be an unpardonable slight from a woman. He got very angry and muttered, “My owl-like face is a perfect match for your monkey-face.”

“What did you say?”

“Nothing. I asked why you ran away.”

“Why did you chase after me?”

“I wanted to ask you for directions to go towards the lighthouse.”

“There is the lighthouse. Can’t you see? Why ask me?”

“I couldn’t find the way after entering the woods. That’s why? Why did you run away?”

“Men are vicious beasts. I don’t like them.”

“Even Senthana Amuthan?”

“Who?”

“Thanjavur Senthana Amuthan.”

“What do you know about him?”

“I know that he is your lover.”

“What? What?”

“Your name is Poonguzhali isn’t it?”

“Yes. I am Poonguzhali. What did you just now say about Senthana Amuthan? He is my...”

“I said, ‘He is your lover.’”

Poonguzhali laughed out loud and asked, “Who told you this?”

“Who else but Senthana Amuthan.”

“Thanjavur<sup>[12]</sup> is very far away from here, that’s why he must have lied thus.”

“Otherwise...”

“If he had told this in front of me, I would have buried him in that quicksand.”

“So what? Here is a big beach to wash all that mud off.”

“That quicksand has drowned cows, horses and even elephants.”

Vandiya Devan found himself getting goose pimples. He couldn't forget the sinking sensation he had felt as he found himself drowning within its muddy mouth inch by inch.

*What if Poonguzhali had not rescued him? By now, he might have been buried there up till his neck!*

He found himself trembling even as he thought about it.

“What else did Senthana Amuthan say about me?”

“He said that you were his uncle's daughter and that there is no one to compare your beauty even in Devendran's<sup>[13]</sup> court.”

“Looks like your friend has gone all the way to Devendran's court. What else?”

“He said that you sing very well and that even the sea listens to your song. Is that true?”

“You will find out soon. Go wash at the beach.”

### Chapter 3 – A Girl's Madness

The sky was dotted with thousands of twinkling stars. A lovely half moon rose up into the sky near the sea's horizon as moon beams danced on the sea waves. It was a beautiful sight worthy enough for a poet to describe. Sadly, for Vandiya Devan there were mundane things to do, like washing off the mud.

"Why are you standing? Go and wash the mud. I have to go home or else my anni<sup>[14]</sup> will not give me any food tonight."

"Is the sea very deep here?" he asked timidly.

"I haven't seen a more faint-hearted warrior than you. The sea here is very shallow. You can go all the way to the middle of the sea and find that the water just comes up to your hips. That's why we have to light up the lighthouse, to warn the ships to stay away."

Vandiya Devan got into the water after much hesitation. After washing himself quickly, he walked over to her wringing his clothes dry. Just then, he noticed his companion, the physician's son coming towards him on the beach along with the horses.

"He is coming here with the horses. What if they get stuck in the quick sand?"

"Warn him!" exclaimed Poonguzhali walking after him as he ran towards the horses warning them to stay away.

When Poonguzhali joined them, she found Vandiya Devan holding the horse's reins. She caressed the horse and spoke something to it that made it inch closer to her.

"My horse seems to like you. That's good."

“Why is it good?”

“I have to go to Ilangai<sup>[15]</sup>. I thought I would leave this horse here with you. Will you look after it?”

“Yes. I will. All animals like me. It’s only the human beings who don’t.”

“Why do you say that? Senthana Amuthan has completely lost...”

“That’s because I prefer the company of animals to humans.”

“What harm did human beings ever do to you?”

“Humans and men, in general, are ungracious rogues. They are all full of lies and deceit.”

“You should not think about all men like this. I have known Senthana Amuthan to be a good man. And my companion here, the physician’s son is also a good man...”

“What about you?”

“I am also a good man. But it would be odd to talk good things about myself.”

“Why are you both here?”

“The emperor is unwell. We have been sent here by the chief physician at Pazhaiaarai<sup>[16]</sup> to gather rare medicinal herbs to make a potent medicine that would cure him.”

“You said that you would be going to Ilangai as well...”

“The herbs that are not available here will need to be brought from Ilangai. Which is why I am going there. It seems that a portion of

Sanjeevini Mountain<sup>[17]</sup> that was brought by Hanuman<sup>[18]</sup> is still in Ilangai.”

“Yes. That’s right. And that’s probably why hundreds of people are dying there due to the shivering fever.”

“Is that so? I didn’t know this. And I doubt if that Pazhaiaarai physician also knows about it.”

“It seems that lying is a habitual occupation of all men. Two days ago, two men came here saying that they wished to go Ilangai but their lies were believable to some extent.”

“Who were they? What did they lie about?”

“They said that they were sent here by some mandiravadi<sup>[19]</sup>. They wanted to go to Ilangai to get a tiger’s claw and an elephant’s tail hair to make a protective talisman for the emperor. My brother took them on in his boat.”

“Oh! Is that so?” said Vandiya Devan. He was reminded of yet another mandiravadi that he had known briefly.

*My God! Why did I get stuck in this murky business of carrying messages and spying? Who would be those two men who had left for Ilangai two days ago? How far can I trust this girl? What if she too is a part of that Mandiravadi’s gang? No, no. She is an innocent girl. I might need her help in future so it is better to be friends with her.*

“Poonguzhali! Let me tell you the truth. I am going to Ilangai on an important and secret mission. I would like to tell you all about it...”

“No don’t. Don’t you know that a woman can’t be trusted with important and secret information?”

“Yes. They say so about other ordinary women in the world. But you are not an ordinary woman.”



“Says who? You have known me for precisely one hour now.”

“Poonguzhali! The minute I saw you sitting on the temple wall, I really liked you. I want to ask you something but you should give me a truthful answer.”

“Ask?”

“Is Senthana Amuthan truly not your lover? Will you not marry him?”

“Why do you ask?”

“Senthana Amuthan is my friend. I will not act in any way that would harm our friendship. But if he is not your lover...”

“Continue... why do you hesitate?”

“If he is not your lover, I would like to fill in that position. Poonguzhali! There is no feeling more divine than true love in this world. Even Saints like Appar, Sundarar and Sambandar sang their beautiful verses imagining God as their lover. So many great poets have sung such beautiful songs about love. Can anything compare with Kalidasa's<sup>[20]</sup> divine verses of love? Even Krishna<sup>[21]</sup> got entangled in love with his gopis<sup>[22]</sup>...”

“Ayya! Let me tell you one thing.”

“Tell me.”

“I do like you and it doesn't disgust me to look at you but...”

“Aha! I am very lucky.”

“But do not talk about 'love' or anything related to that.”

“Why not?”

“Senthan Amuthan is not my lover but I have other lovers...”

“Other lovers? Who? How many? Where?”

“I meet them at midnight. You can follow me if you wish and I will show them to you.” She said and laughed.

Her laughter disturbed Vandiya Devan greatly. He thought to himself, ‘Looks like this girl is mad. I don’t think she would help my mission in any way. It’s better not to tell her anything.’

They had by then reached the houses that stood near the lighthouse. Hearing them approach, an old man and a woman came out of the house.

“Poonguzhali! Who are these men? Where did you find them?”

“I didn’t find them appa<sup>[23]</sup>! They found me.”

“It’s all the same. I have told you so many times to come back home before it gets dark. Do you ever listen? Two days ago, you got two strangers here and today as well. Why are they here?”

“They have come here to search for medicinal herbs to make a medicine for the emperor, appa!”

“Ayya! Is that true?”

“Yes. Here is a message from the royal scribe of Pazhaiaarai,” said Vandiya Devan and took out the message. While he was at it, another olai<sup>[24]</sup> fell from his waistcloth. He picked it hurriedly, angry with himself for being careless and muttered, ‘I am such a fool.’

Poonguzhali’s father took the olai and read it in the light of the lighthouse. He turned towards his wife and said, “This is a message from Princess Kundavai. These men are here on royal business. We

need to give them food and shelter. Go and tell your daughter-in-law to prepare enough food for them.”

## Chapter 4: Midnight

After a simple dinner at Poonguzhali's house, Vandiya Devan sought her father's help to go to Ilangai. However, Thyagavidanga Karaiyar expressed his regrets. "Once there were many boats banked in this beach but now they all have gone to Sethu Karai<sup>[25]</sup> to help our army cross the sea to Ilangai. I own two boats and my son has taken two men across the sea and I do not know when he will return. What do I do?"

"Who were those men? Your daughter said that they seemed strange."

"Yes. They were strange and I didn't like them too. I do not know who they were and why they were going to Ilangai. They showed the Pazhuvur signet ring and despite that I wouldn't have asked my son to go but my daughter-in-law is very greedy and when they gave a bag full of gold coins, she urged my son to take them in the boat..."

"Ayya! How can this be? How can your son listen to a woman who has no knowledge about anything?" he asked and then added hesitantly, "I am sorry. This is your family matter and I have no right to judge anybody."

"Thambi<sup>[26]</sup>! There is nothing wrong with what you said. There is a curse on my family. My son..." he said hesitantly

Vandiya Devan remembered Senthana Amuthan's description about his family.

"Is your son deaf and mute?"

"Something like that..."

Vandiya Devan then told him about how he had met Senthan Amuthan and had stayed at his home in Thanjavur.

“Ah! So you are that man? I got news about your escape days ago and I also heard that Pazhuvur soldiers are searching for you everywhere.”

“Maybe. I don’t know.”

“Now I know why you wish to sail to Ilangai.”

“Ayya, I am not going to Ilangai to escape from the Pazhuvur soldiers. I am bearing a message for a very important person in Ilangai. If you do not believe me, I can show it to you.”

“That’s unnecessary thambi! I trust Princess Kundavai’s words more than anything else but I still can’t help you with a boat.”

“Ayya, you said you had two boats.”

“Yes. A boat is here but there is no one to ferry you to Ilangai. If you and your friend know how to use it, you are free to take it.”

“But we do not know how to ferry the boat and that too in the middle of the sea. Moreover, I do not know how to swim properly in the first place. And I am a bit scared of water too...”

“Even if you knew how to swim, ferrying a boat in the sea needs a lot of skill and those without any experience cannot go alone.”

“And I am not taking the physician’s son along with me to Ilangai. He will be staying here, collecting medicinal herbs. Ayya, you will have to help me somehow.”

“Only one person can help you but I am not sure if it would be possible. It will be very difficult to convince... however if you are lucky it might even work. Who knows?”

“Ayya, please tell me who it is? I will try and talk to this person.”

“In Kodi Karai, you will not find anybody as skilled as Poonguzhali. She is very experienced at sea and has gone to Ilangai many times. I will ask her if she is willing to take you. You also try and ask her whenever you get the chance.”

“Ayya, please call her now. We can ask her.”

“No. She is a very willful girl. If she says ‘no’ right now then nothing in this world can change her decision. Tomorrow, I will speak with her at the right moment. You too can try your luck,” said Thyagavidanga Karaiyar and went towards the lighthouse.

That night, Vandiya Devan lay down to sleep at the verandah of Poonguzhali’s house. His companion, the physician’s son was already asleep. Saddle sore and bone weary, Vandiya Devan too drifted off to sleep but he woke up with a start when he heard the front door of the house opening. Someone came out of the house and walked out briskly. From the light of the lighthouse, Vandiya Devan was able to discern that it was Poonguzhali.

“Where is she going at this hour?” thought Vandiya Devan.

When she had playfully invited him to follow her in the middle of the night, he had thought that she was joking. No, she was really leaving the house in the middle of the night. “I will show you my lovers,” she had said. *Could that be true? Could she really have more than one lover?*

*There is some mystery in all this. Let me follow her and learn the truth. I will need her help to go to Ilangai and tomorrow I will need to convince her to take me in her boat. Who knows? Maybe she will get into some danger in these woods and I could save her from it. That might make her more amenable to help me.*

Vandiya Devan rose silently and followed her carefully. He couldn't forget the dread that he had felt when he had stepped into the quicksand so he followed her swiftly without losing sight of her.

The area around the lighthouse and the beach were well lit thanks to the lighthouse and it was easy to follow her here but when she entered the woods, Vandiya Devan struggled to keep up with her as she started walking very fast.

Through the wild terrain of the forest, the ground was uneven in many places, Poonguzhali who was familiar with the path, walked through it confidently while Vandiya Devan found it difficult to keep her within his line of sight. He climbed a large mound of sand and found her walking below but she suddenly vanished!

Surprised and shocked to have lost her thus, Vandiya Devan got down from the mound.

How could she vanish like that? Is this some kind of magic? Could she perhaps have fallen into a pit?

He reached the place where she had vanished and looked around. Looking carefully, he found a small path that wound its way down towards a thick grove of trees. It was so dark that he couldn't see his way in the darkness. The windy woods assumed a terrible form and he found himself comparing its trees to formless ghosts and wraiths. The dark shadows of the trees looked menacingly at him even as he contemplated his next move.

Vandiya Devan lost his nerve and decided to go back.

*Who knows what dangers these woods may hide? Vicious beasts and poisonous snakes might be lurking behind these shadows to attack me. Beasts like a cheetah or a leopard might pounce from one of these trees too! What foolishness is this? Why didn't I bring my spear along?*

*What's that noise? Who could that be? Who is that standing on that tree?*

Vandiya Devan's legs started trembling even as he started recollecting all the ghost stories that he had heard from his childhood. Even as he thought of turning back he heard a voice. It was a beautiful voice that sang a hauntingly poignant song.

While the waves of the sea are placid and gentle,  
why does the sea within me surge and rise?

When the mother earth sleeps in peace,  
why should my heart rise in anguish?

Even the birds of the forest search for their nests!  
Hunters and archers seek their homes too!

When the heaven and earth are enveloped in peace  
why is a storm stirring within the heart of that doe-eyed girl?

The sea will stand still and the breeze would crawl in,  
But why does the wind swirl so strong in that girl's heart?

Vandiya Devan went ahead through the path and followed the direction of Poonguzhali's voice. As the path meandered towards the peak of the mound, he could see her standing on the top, singing even as she looked at the stars. One of the stars that dotted the sky was the long dhoomketu<sup>[27]</sup>. Her mesmerizing voice and the still woods nestled under the stars seemed surrealistic to Vandiya Devan.

He stood right behind her and from the top of the mound, the distant glow of the lighthouse and the dark rolling beach waves were also seen.

"Oh! You have come after all. When I last saw, you were sleeping like Kumbakarnan<sup>[28]</sup>," she said.



"I woke up when I heard the door open and then I saw you. You walked so fast and didn't even look back. It is so difficult to follow you."

"Why did you follow me?"

"Good question! Don't you remember it was you who asked me to come along?"

"Did I? Do you remember why?"

"Of course. You said that you would show me your lovers. So where are they?"

"Look behind you. They are there," she said.

## Chapter 5 – In the Middle of the Sea

Vandiya Devan looked behind and a silent scream escaped his mouth. With his heart beating wildly he could feel goose pimples racing through all over his body. What he saw terrified him beyond any nightmare that he had ever seen.

Through the vast expanse of beach and the forest, he could see firelights. These were not ordinary fires caused by the burning of a wood or a log. These were naturally occurring fire bubbles that are normally seen near marshy lands. At some places, the fire bubbles danced around wildly and vanished while in others they spread around terrifying the hearts of the onlookers.

To Vandiya Devan's eyes, they looked like the headless body of an Asura<sup>[29]</sup> who had countless fiery mouths trying to devour anything and anyone that came in their way. No wonder these fire bubbles were called kolli vaai pisasu<sup>[30]</sup>.

Vandiya Devan couldn't take his eyes off the fire bubbles even though all his senses were screaming for him to get away from the scene. Even Periya Pazhuvetrayar's dark palace seemed tame when compared to this terror. Someone laughed behind him. Who else but Poonguzhali.

At any other occasion, such laughter might have evoked terror enough in him to flee the scene but it had the opposite effect on Vandiya Devan. I told him that there was a real woman standing next to him and it helped to dispel the blind terror that had seized him minutes ago.

"Did you see them?" she asked. "These fire bubbles are my lovers. I come here every night to woo them."

This girl is mad, Vandiya Devan decided. *How can I trust her to take me to Ilangai? He looked back at the Kolli Vaai Pisasu and tried to remember a half-buried memory of what he had heard about them.*

“Do you think, your friend Senthana Amuthan can compete with these lovers for my attention?” asked Poonguzhali but he did not answer her immediately as he had just remembered somebody’s explanation about the terrifying wonder he was seeing.

“These are naturally occurring wonders just as a mountain explodes and waves of fire come out of its mouth.” Terrifying tales about *Kolli Vaai Pisasu* were told to discourage children from going near the sea, he told himself and his fear dissipated. He turned his mind to the problem at hand.

*How to convince this girl to leave these woods and come home?*

“Poonguzhali! Your lovers will not go anywhere. They will remain here for eternity. Shall we go back home?” he asked, but she did not reply.

Instead, she started crying. “What is this? Why do I get myself into such trouble?” sighed Vandiya Devan mentally and tried again. “Poonguzhali! Shall we leave?” but she didn’t stop crying. Vandiya Devan had had enough.

“Fine. Do as you wish. I am sleepy. I am leaving.” He said and got down from mound and started towards the lighthouse. Poonguzhali stopped crying and came after him soon. Walking along with her, Vandiya Devan thought,

*How can I trust this mad girl to take me to Ilangai? Nevertheless, there is no other way I have to somehow use sweet words to convince her to help me.*

“There is a comet seen in the sky. What do you think about it?” asked Poonguzhali

“Yes. A comet is seen. That’s all. I have no opinion about it.”

“But many say that whenever a comet appears in the sky, something untoward will happen in our lives.”

“Yes. I have heard that too.”

“What do you think?”

“I have no knowledge of astrology but I do know that many people in the kingdom are talking about it and are worried.”

They walked along silently for some time and then Poonguzhali asked, “Is it true that the emperor is seriously ill?”

“Yes. He is very ill. He is paralyzed in his legs and can’t move from his bed. That’s why Pazhaiaarai physician has sent me here to get medicinal herbs. Poonguzhali! Will you help me?”

Instead of answering his question, she asked, “Many people are talking about how the emperor will die soon. Is that true?”

“If you refuse to help me now, it might even come true. There are many rare medicinal herbs in Ilangai and it seems the physician needs them to make a new medicine for the emperor. Will take me in your boat to Ilangai?”

“If the emperor dies suddenly who do you think will ascend the throne?”

“Why should we care who ascends the throne? What is it to us? Why should we worry about it?”

“Why shouldn’t we worry? Aren’t we the citizens of this kingdom? Whoever sits on the throne will rule over us. We have all the right to worry about it.”

Her answer intrigued Vandiya Devan. He thought, *“This girl is definitely not mad. I should be careful with her. There must be some other reason for her strange behaviour.”*

“Why are you silent? Who do you think will become the next emperor?” asked Poonguzhali again.

“Crown Prince Aditya is the next heir apparent. He should become the next emperor.”

“What about Prince Madhuranthakan? Doesn’t he have any rights?”

“He has refused to accept the throne.”

“He refused earlier but it seems like he wants to become the emperor now.”

“It doesn’t really matter what he wants. People don’t support his claim.”

“I have heard that many nobles and chieftains are supporting him.”

“Yes. That’s true. I am surprised that even you have heard about these rumours.”

“What would happen if the emperor dies suddenly?”

“The kingdom will be plunged into confusion and anarchy. I need your help to avoid such unfortunate events.”

“How can I help you?”

“I need to go to Ilangai urgently. I have been asked to get rare medicinal herbs from there for the emperor. Will you take me in your boat?”

“Why are you asking me? Aren’t you ashamed of begging for a woman’s help to cross the sea?”

“Your father said that there is no one else here to take me across. Even your brother has gone away.”

“What if he is not there? Don’t you have two hands? Doesn’t your friend have two hands?”

“But we don’t know how to row a boat in the middle of the sea...”

“Rowing a boat is not a magic trick. You just need to use those muscles of yours...”

“But how will we know the direction once we are in the middle of the sea. What if we get lost...”

“Then get lost for all that I care...”

They had reached the lighthouse by then. Vandiya Devan didn’t want to pursue the argument as it might end up in blatant refusal from Poonguzhali. Even though she had refused to help him, her questions had given him a sliver of hope.

When he lay down outside the house, sleep did not come easily. His mind was clouded and his heart was confused and during the last phase of the night, he fell asleep only to awaken in his dreams.

They were in her boat sailing away through the dark sea. Sitting across him, Poonguzhali was plying the oars with a beautiful smile. Vandiya Devan looked around him and found that they were in the middle of the sea. Kodi Karai beach had vanished and he could see only water in all directions. A gentle breeze wafted through the boat and played around with Poonguzhali’s lovely curly hair. His heart was brimming with hope and happiness and he forgot where he was going and why? He felt as if he had braved so many dangers for so long only to reach Poonguzhali.

But something was missing? What was it? Ah! Yes. Poonguzhali's song.

"Poonguzhali! Won't you sing for me?"

"What will you give me if I sing for you?"

"I will come near and give you a..."

Poonguzhali immediately took out a short, curved dagger from her lap and said, "Look here you! If you ever cross across that sail and come near me, I will stab your heart and throw you in the sea. The sharks are quite hungry!"

## Chapter 6 - The Hidden Mandapam

The next morning, Vandiya Devan got up well after dawn. Since he had not slept for much of the night, he found it difficult to awaken properly and for a minute, he was not sure whether the light that was waking him up was from the sun or the lighthouse. Poonguzhali's mother informed him that Thyagavidanga Karaiyar had gone to the temple.

Poonguzhali was not at home and he was hesitant to ask about her whereabouts. He went to the temple to seek her but only found her father who was gathering flowers from the woods nearby for the temple rituals. When he enquired about Poonguzhali, her father said that she had not come there.

"She might be roaming in the woods chasing the deer herds or might be walking along the beach. Try to find her and ask her to help you."

"Thambi! Be careful with her. Do not say anything that can be misconstrued, then she will become dangerous."

Vandiya Devan remembered the earlier night's dream and acknowledged the old man's warning. He entered the woods to search for her but was discouraged within a few minutes and came out to the beach. The pristine sands of the beach glowed gold in the morning sun but there was no sign of her through the long stretch.

'She will come home for her mid-morning meal, I will catch her then.' he thought.

The calm beach and the gentle waves beckoned him near and he found himself wanting to take a dip.

*Didn't Poonguzhali say that the beach here was very shallow? It is also important that I try to rid myself of this irrational fear of water?*



*How can I go in a boat across the sea feeling scared of water?  
What's the harm in taking a dip, anyway?*

Thinking thus, Vandiya Devan removed his sword and his waistcloth that held the message he was carrying to Prince Arulmozhi and left them in the sands and got into the water. Inching slowly towards the water, he moved in hesitantly and found that the water was only waist high, "What's the use of this sea? One can't even take a proper bath here."

Aha! I have come so far inside the water thinking that it is not deep. What if the sea suddenly rises and there are huge waves? One can never be sure of anything where the sea is concerned.

Thinking thus, he started walking back to the beach.

*Aha! Here comes Poonguzhali! Let me get out of the water and catch her before she disappears again. I need to somehow convince her to take me to Ilangai today. Looks like she is coming towards me. What is she saying?*

He started wading through the beach waves hurriedly to reach her.

*What is she doing? Why is she picking up my waistcloth?* "Hey, girl! Put that down! That's mine." *Why is she not listening?*

"Listen! Hey, girl! Stop right there. That's mine. MINE!"

Even as he started shouting, Poonguzhali turned around and said something that he couldn't hear and then she started running towards the woods. Angered and incensed by her action, Vandiya Devan too started running towards her.

*That wicked girl! No! Not just wicked. She is raving mad. How do I take the waistcloth and the important message that the princess has given from her?*

After tumbling twice in the water, he came out of the beach and ran towards the sand hurriedly. His wet clothes impeded his movements and he coughed out the water that he had inadvertently swallowed when he fell in.

Poonguzhali was running towards the woods almost as gracefully as the deer herd before her. Despite the situation, Vandiya Devan couldn't stop himself from admiring her gait and comparing her beauty with that of the beautiful deer.

*Women like her who live close to nature are more beautiful than those who live closeted away from it. But I can't say all that to this girl. If I do she might misunderstand me and... her father too had warned about her. But why is she running so fast and that too with my belongings? If she enters the woods, I would lose the chance to go to Ilangai.*

Even as he thought that Poonguzhali entered the thick woods and disappeared and Vandiya Devan berated himself for his stupidity. Entering the woods hurriedly, he scratched himself against the many thorny bushes. Looking all around, he shouted, "Poonguzhali! Poonguzhali! Where are you?" Soon, he started asking, "Tree! Have you seen Poonguzhali? Crow! Have you seen Poonguzhali?"

*What is happening to me? Looks like I am becoming mad too!*

Panting breathlessly, he rested under a tree, even as he looked around for any sign of the missing girl, something fell on him from the top. It was his waistcloth! He opened it eagerly and checked inside. The message and the gold coins were intact.

"Is your gold safe?" asked a voice from the top of the tree. Vandiya Devan looked up and saw her sitting high up the tree branches.

Angry and irritated he said, "I have never seen a more demented girl than you."

“And I haven’t seen an owl like you before. My God! That expression on your face was priceless!”

“Why are you doing this to me? Why did you take my belongings? If it was gold that you wanted...”

“Who needs your gold here?”

“Then why did you take it and come here?”

“If I had not done that you would not have come to the woods but would have gone to my house.”

“What if I had gone there?”

“Why don’t you get on this tree and look for yourself?”

“What will I see if I get on the tree?”

“You will see ten horses and soldiers and their shining weapons that have come in search of you.”

Vandiya Devan looked at her wondering whether she was telling the truth. He immediately tied the waistcloth tightly around his midriff and climbed the tree nimbly. He was not convinced with her explanation.

*Who knows? Maybe she dropped the gold coins and the olai by mistake and might want to snatch it back by force.*

With such misgivings, he climbed to the top of the tree branch and stood next to her and looked in the direction she had pointed to. She was right. There were indeed soldiers and horses standing outside her house.

*Who could they be? They must be Pazhuvur soldiers who have come all the way here to capture me? Poonguzhali has indeed saved me from a grave danger. But why?*

They both got down from the tree. "Poonguzhali! You have saved me from these soldiers. I thank you from the bottom of the heart."

"What a big liar you are? All men are liars." She pouted

"I am not like all other men. I am different."

"Hmm. Maybe you are different."

"Poonguzhali! May I ask you a question?"

"Ask. It is up to me whether I want to answer or not."

"Why did you save me? Why this sudden pity towards me?"

It was evident that his question had surprised her. She thought for a while and said, "I am partial towards idiots like yourself."

"Then I am glad that I turned out to be one. How did you know that these soldiers have come after me?"

"It was easy to guess and moreover your friend confirmed my suspicions today morning."

"What did he blabber?"

"Early in the morning, he said that he wished to search for medicinal herbs in the woods. So I brought him here. These enchanting woods made him fall in love with me. He declared his undying love for me, right here with many eloquent words. I told him that, 'Your friend too is in love with me....'

"What? What?"

"Wait! Hear the rest. I told him that you too were in love with me. Immediately he revealed his suspicions about you. He said that you

were fleeing from some royal punishment and that you had come all the way here to escape from soldiers who are looking to capture you. He said, 'Don't spoil your life by trusting such a man. He will surely ruin you. Instead, you should marry me.'

I told him, 'You are in such a tearing hurry to get married. Shouldn't we ask for the permission of our elders?'

Cunningly, for this, he said, 'Let us elope and marry just as Murugan<sup>[31]</sup> eloped with Valli<sup>[32]</sup>.'

'And you call this man your friend! A very good friend indeed!'

"That gutless rogue!" shouted Vandiya Devan.

"By then, we heard the sound of galloping horses and I bid him to climb the tree to see who had come. He got up the tree and you should have seen him then. His legs were shaking! I felt like laughing out loud," said Poonguzhali and laughed remembering the scene.

"Enough of that. Tell me what happened next."

"He came down from the tree and said, 'See what I told you was so true! These soldiers have come here to capture him.' I told him that they might capture him too, as he had come along with you and asked him to hide in the woods until they went away. He agreed and then did just what I had expected..."

"What did he do?"

"He agreed to hide himself here and then went straight to those soldiers and got captured by them..."

"Ayyo! Poor boy!"

"Don't pity him too much. Save some for yourself."

“Why? Why do you say that?”

“He went to the soldiers and asked, ‘Who are you people and why are you here?’ They said, ‘We are hunters. We are here to hunt for deer meat.’

‘I know for whom you have come here.’

They looked at each other with surprise and asked him more questions and he finally told them, ‘I know that you have come in search of Vandiya Devan. I can show you where he is hiding. But you will have to promise me to leave me alone.’ They agreed and he immediately took them to my house.”

“That scoundrel!”

“After they left, I came searching for you and found you bathing in the sea.”

“Why didn’t you tell me all this there? Why did you run so fast taking my waistcloth?”

“If I had not done that I doubt if you would have come after me so fast. You might not have believed my words or worse you might even have decided to tackle those soldiers alone. There was no time to convince you there.”

*How could I think this girl to be mad? At every point, she has proved herself to be not only clever but also exceedingly intelligent. It would be impossible for me to escape from this danger without trusting her.*

“Poonguzhali! You have no inkling of how big a help you have rendered me today. I wish you could help me again...”

“What do you want?”

“You know my friend’s true colours now. There is no point in trusting him. I can only look to you for help. I need you to take me in your boat to Ilangai.”

“You must believe me when I say that I have done nothing wrong. I have a very important mission to complete in Ilangai. You will need to do this for me.”

“If I do so, what will you give me?” asked Poonguzhali. Her eyes looked bashful and shy and her beautiful smile was spellbinding. Vandiya Devan remembered the dream of previous night and was astonished by the fact that she had asked him the same question in his dream too. He almost gave her the same answer, but with great effort, he bit his words down and said, “Poonguzhali! If you help me now, you will have my undying gratitude. I don’t know if there is anything that I can do for you in return for this favour. If there is anything, you only need to tell me about it.”

Poonguzhali was looking at him with thoughtful eyes.

“If there is anything that you need from me, any help, please tell me. I will do it for you,” he said

“Are you truly saying this or just for the sake of getting your...”

“I promise. I am saying this truly.”

“If you are saying this truly then I will tell you when the time is right I hope you will not refuse me.”

“I will never forget it. I will consider myself to be in your debt until you tell me what you want.”

“Alright. Then come with me. I will take you to a place in these woods. You can stay there safely, until the evening. I am afraid you will need to stay there without any food...”

“You don’t worry about that. I had a hearty meal this morning. Your sister-in-law served me rice quite grudgingly and I ate more than my usual portion just to spite her. I will not need any more food until evening.”

“I am not sure whether I can get any food by this evening. I will try to get some for you. You will have to stay in this place until it is dark. After the sun sets, I will come there and signal you with the call of a cuckoo. Only when you hear this signal should you come out of the place. Understood?

“Yes. I will wait for your signal.”

“We will leave in my boat after dusk.”

She took him to a small mound in the middle of the forest. Hidden amidst a thick grove of trees, he found that it was an old dilapidated mandapam<sup>[33]</sup> that was completely hidden amidst the green foliage.

“Once there was a tiger living in this mandapam. After it died, this became a private refuge for me. Almost a home. I come here whenever I wish to be left alone. In that pot, you will find water to drink. Stay here until it gets dark. No matter what you hear around you, people, horses or animal sounds, do not come out of this mandapam.”

“What if some wild animal comes here? Like a tiger or a bear?”

“There are no tigers in these woods, only wild boars and wolves. I hope you are not frightened of them.”

“I am not frightened. It’s just that I left my spear at your home.”

“Here... Take this and use it as a weapon,” said Poonguzhali, handing him a strange spear-shaped weapon. With sharp edges at both ends, it also had many pointed spikes. It reminded him of Indra’s<sup>[34]</sup> divine weapon, the Vajrayudham<sup>[35]</sup>.



“What sort of weapon is this? I have never seen this before,” He asked.

“This is the bone of a fish’s tail. I used it to kill the tiger that was hiding here.”

## Chapter 7 - Samudra Kumari

That day Vandiya Devan spent half the time sleeping and the other half, he whiled away wondering about the strange behaviour of Poonguzhali.

*What an unusual girl! Such a beautiful name but why is her character so different and difficult.*

To him, she seemed like a tart mixture of sweet and strange.

*She carelessly mentions killing a tiger, cries while looking at the marsh fire bubbles, sings a hauntingly beautiful song and then nonchalantly goes ahead and saves me from the murderous Pazhuvur soldiers. Why does she behave so strangely at times?*

He surmised that there was some bitter incident in her past that probably made her behave thus.

*Or perhaps it could even be a sweet incident. Women are strange by nature. Some women were strange right from their birth but her parents seemed like normal people - calm, collected and at peace with their lot in life.*

*Forget the behaviour, why is she so interested in saving my life? Why did she help me escape the Pazhuvur soldiers? Why did she bring me here to hide? She has also agreed to take me in her boat to Ilangai. Will she perhaps betray me in the end? No. No. That can't be true. She wants some help from me. She said she would ask me later but what kind of 'help' could that be?*

While he sat thinking about her, the forest came alive with myriad sounds just as Poonguzhali had warned him. The neighing of horses, people, animal sounds, the chirping of birds followed by ominous silence. He realized that the Pazhuvur soldiers were

searching for him in the woods. He was also astonished by the betrayal of his companion, the physician's son.

*Foolish boy! The idea of him falling in love with Poonguzhali was so laughable. Can a rat fall in love with a lioness? But this girl used his foolishness so well. With just a few words, she managed to raise a jealous storm in his heart so much so that he was willing to betray me, his companion of so many days! Women truly can be very dangerous.*

*However, I will need to accept something honestly and wholeheartedly! I have been under the illusion that there is no one in the world who could challenge me in being clever but this boat girl from nowhere has proved me wrong.*

*The way she had lured me away from the beach to these forests proved just how intelligent she really is.*

*It also proves that I should never let my guard down, ever. Just imagine what could have happened if we were still at the beach. The Pazhuvur soldiers would have caught me and all my aspirations would have turned to dust!*

Sunset was glorious that evening in Kodi Karai. The southern sea bends towards the west and when you look towards the beach from a high point, you can see the sea in all three directions - east, west and south. Vandiya Devan could however not see it that evening as Poonguzhali had warned him not to come out of the hidden mandapam.

With the sunset, darkness descended. Vandiya Devan climbed to the top of the mandapam to keep a lookout. He could see the lighthouse glowing at a distance. With millions of stars dotting the sky, he sat there for long waiting for Poonguzhali's signal. At long last, a melodious "coo-oo coo-oo" sound was heard. Vandiya Devan sprang alive from the mandapam's roof and came out to the woods to meet Poonguzhali.

She signalled him to be quiet and said, "Come with me quietly."

They walked towards the beach silently, where her boat was ready for their journey with a sail and a long sturdy rope. Moving fast, Vandiya Devan tried to help Poonguzhali to drag the boat into the sea but she said, "Please don't," and launched it into the sea, while she held the rope. When he tried to get into it she said, "Shush! Wait! You can get in after some time."

After some distance when there were no more waves in the sea, they both got into the boat. The small boat shook a great deal when Vandiya Devan got into it. With his limbs trembling, he tried to control the innate fear of water that he always had.

"Can we talk now?" he asked

"Yes. If you have ceased trembling with fear, we can."

"Who is trembling here? Definitely not me."

"Good."

"Don't you have to put up the sail?"

"If we put up the sail now, we will be seen from the beach. What if someone comes and catches us?"

"I will take care of everything, you don't have to be frightened," said Vandiya Devan and proceeded to tell her all about his brave deeds.

"The wind is blowing from the opposite direction. If we open the sail now, we will be back on the shores of Kodi Karai. After midnight, the winds will change. We can put the sail up then."

"Oh! Looks like you know a lot about these things. That's why your father insisted that I take your help."

“My father! Who is that?”

“What do you mean? Your father, Thyagavidanga Karaiyar!”

“He is my father only on the shore. When I am in the sea...”

“When you are in the sea, will your father change?”

“Yes. Here the glorious lord of the sea, Samudra Raja<sup>[36]</sup> is my father. Do you know what my other name is? Samudra Kumari<sup>[37]</sup>! Didn’t anyone tell you?”

“No, Samudra Kumari is such a strange name.”

“Don’t people call Prince Arulmozhivarmar Ponniyin Selvan? Similarly I am called Samudra Kumari.”

When he heard the prince’s name, Vandiya Devan’s hand automatically went to his waistcloth where he had kept the message given by Kundavai. Noticing his action, Poonguzhali asked, “Is it safe?”

“What is safe?”

“The thing you have kept in your waist cloth.”

Vandiya Devan was taken aback and a germ of suspicion grew in his mind. Poonguzhali in the meanwhile was mechanically plying the oars.

“When will we reach Ilangai?”

“If two people could ply the oars, we could reach there by dawn, if the winds are favourable.”

“Let me help you with the oars,” he said and took the oar that rested next to him and soon found out how difficult a task it was to move the boat. His cumbersome attempts stopped the boat in the middle of the sea.

“What is this? How come the boat moves only when you are plying the oars?”

“I am Samudra Kumari. That’s why. You don’t have to help me, I will make sure that you reach Ilangai safely.”

He sat quietly for a while and tried to look around. Kodi Karai beach was no longer seen. There was water everywhere. Looking around at the boat he noticed a plank in the middle of the boat.

“What’s this plank for?”

“It is to balance the boat in the water so that it does not shake too much.”

“Really! Somehow it doesn’t seem to be working. Look how badly the boat is shaking.”

“You call this shaking. You should see the sea during the monsoon and its swirling high winds.”

“What will happen if these high winds come? Will this boat survive?”

“It depends on the force of the wind. Most times, the boat will survive the onslaught of high winds but when a storm or a hurricane comes, the plank can be used to save us from drowning even if the boat is lost.”

“Will the high wind drown the boat?”

“I have seen storms and whirlwinds devouring big ships. What chance does a small boat like this have?”

“What is a whirlwind?”

“You don’t know that? When high winds from two different directions meet, a whirlwind is created. During the months of Thai and Masi<sup>[38]</sup> we have Kondal Kattru<sup>[39]</sup> in these seas. It is very safe to travel during those months. It is easy to go to Ilangai and come back within a day. But during the months of Vaigasi<sup>[40]</sup>, Chozha Kattru<sup>[41]</sup> blows around. When these winds clash around the sea, huge waves come about and they churn the waters like we make butter. Mountain-high waves rise above and deep chasms are created in the sea. If a boat like this gets trapped in a whirlwind, you will surely meet the gods soon.”

Vandiya Devan suddenly lost all his bravado and started trembling in every limb. His suspicion about her intentions too became strong. “Ayyo! I am not coming with you. Please take the boat back to the shore.”

“What are you blabbering? Be quiet. If you are frightened, close your eyes and sleep.”

“No! You are a wicked woman. You have brought me all the way here only to drown me.”

“What is this madness?”

“I am not mad. Will you turn the boat or not? Or shall I jump into the sea?”

“Go ahead and jump. But before you do, you can hand over the olai that you are taking to Ponniyin Selvar.”

“Oh! How did you know about that?”

“I learned about it this morning when I took your waistcloth. I wouldn’t have agreed to ferry you otherwise.”

“You are truly evil! I should never have trusted you. Will you turn the boat or not?”

“If I was Princess Kundavai, I would never have trusted such an important message with a fickle minded messenger like you.”

“Aha! So you also know who sent the message. I have no doubt about your intentions now. Will you turn the boat or shall I jump?”

“Go ahead! Jump!”

Crazed with panic and fear, Vandiya Devan jumped into the sea. Thinking that the water level would be same as it was at Kodi Karai beach, Vandiya Devan braved the waters, only to realize that they were now sailing in the middle of the sea, where it was very deep. When he realized that, he started shouting and struggling in panic.

Though he knew how to swim in shallow waters, the boundless depth of the sea scared him and, in his panic, he forgot how to swim. While swimming in a lake or a river, he would take a look at the bank to gain courage and swim ashore but he was in the middle of the sea with no sight of the shore. The mild waves tossed him up and down. Senseless with fear and fright, he lost the strength to shout out for help. He could see the boat sailing away and lost all hopes of survival. *This is it. I am going to die in this sea. And along with me this message for Ponniyin Selvar will be lost as well.* Kundavai Devi's face rose before his mind's eye and it seemed to ask, 'How could you do this?'

*Aha! I had so many dreams. I wanted to win back my old kingdom and had dreamed of ruling it along with Kundavai as my queen. And they have become mere dreams, all because of this wicked girl. She is a bloodthirsty ghoul. She probably learned her tricks from that enchantress Nandini. She could even be a spy of the Pazhuvetarayars. If only I could get my hands around her neck, I will strangle her. Why am I having such murderous thoughts before*



*dying? Let me think about God. O! Lord Shiva! Mother Parvathi<sup>[42]</sup>! Lord Muruga<sup>[43]</sup>! O! Maha Vishnu<sup>[44]</sup> who resides in the mighty ocean of this universe... Kundavai Devi, please forgive me. I am leaving this world without completing my mission. I can see the boat now. If only I could get that girl in my hands..."*

When Vandiya Devan jumped into the sea in fury, Poonguzhali was indifferent for a while. She thought that he would toss around for some time and then come back swimming to the boat to save himself. She even put some distance between him and the boat to make him more desperate. But after a while, she realized that he was genuinely in trouble and that he didn't know how to swim.

*He doesn't know how to swim properly. And even if he did, he must have forgotten in his panic." His screams now seemed feebler and soon he would start swallowing salt water and drown. I am such a fool, she thought. I should have kept my mouth shut until we reached Ilangai. I shouldn't have told him that I knew about his secret. Who thought that this reckless fool would jump into the sea thus?*

Poonguzhali immediately brought the boat closer to him and said, "Come! Come! Get into the boat." But Vandiya Devan did not hear her. He was in the throes of drowning and had lost the power of seeing and hearing anything but whenever the waves tossed him up, he tried to scream. Flailing his hands around, he tried desperately to keep his head above the water. Poonguzhali noted all this in a second and decided that it would be impossible for him to get into the boat on his own. When she looked at him in the moonlight, she could see his panic-stricken face that had failed to understand that she was trying to help him. She knew that she had to somehow haul him out of the sea onto the boat.

This is such a nice trouble of my own making, she thought.

She immediately tied the rope to her waist and the other end to the plank in the boat and then jumped. Swimming with powerful strokes, she neared Vandiya Devan.

Vandiya Devan recognized her and his face became murderous. Poonguzhali was familiar with the actions of a drowning man. Before they drowned, they would possess inhuman elephantine strength and would try to hold onto to whatever they could come across. To save themselves, they would even try to hoist themselves up on the shoulders of their rescuer, killing them too. She realized that Vandiya Devan was in the same last stage of drowning.

She approached him carefully from the back and made a strong fist with her hands and hit him squarely on his forehead. Her hands were strong and her punch was hard on his head. His vision split into a million fragments and in each of them, he could see Samudra Kumari laughing gaily, just before he lost consciousness.

## Chapter 8 - The Ghost Island

It seems that the sky goddess is as intelligent as the humans. We humans ignore the god within us and search for him everywhere from temples to holy places. In the same manner, the sky goddess lets the sun god slip out of her grasp into the sea and searches for him all through the night with her million starry eyes.

When Vandiya Devan gained consciousness, he felt as though innumerable firelights were lighted upon the sky. Soon he realized that they were not firelights but stars and that he was lying prone in the boat in his wet clothes. His hand automatically touched his waistcloth to note whether the important olai and his other belongings were intact or not. He also realized that he was tied to the middle plank of the boat with a sturdy rope. Taking a deep breath, he looked at the sky and found himself at peace. With a gentle breeze serenading him, he heard a lovely familiar song.

*That strange girl, Poonguzhali!* He realized that she must have rescued him somehow after he had recklessly jumped into the sea.

*If she had harboured cruel intentions with an ulterior motive, why would she save him? How did she manage to get me into this boat? It must have been quite difficult.*

*Why is she getting up now? Aha! She is raising the sails for the boat. That is such a difficult task. Let me help her.*

“Poonguzhali! Poonguzhali!”

“Untie me. Let me help you too.”

“It is enough if you sit quietly. You can untie yourself if you want but please don’t jump into the sea again.”

Vandiya Devan untied himself and sat down while Poonguzhali raised the sail. Once the sail was up, the boat seemed to speed along with the winds.

“Samudra Kumari!”

“What is it?”

“I am thirsty.”

“That’s to be expected. You drank a lot of sea water last night,” she took a small jug from the boat and handed it to him.

“I even managed to get some food for you but it got lost when you jumped into the sea, thankfully this jug did not fall in.”

Vandiya Devan handed jug back to her and said, “I misunderstood you Poonguzhali. I am sorry.”

“That’s alright. I am a boat girl and you are a stranger. Come dawn, we are going to part.”

“What hour is it?”

“Look at the Seven Sages<sup>[45]</sup> to find out.”

Vandiya Devan looked up and noted that the Seven Sages had travelled halfway across the sky since the last time he had noted it. But the Dhruva Natchatram<sup>[46]</sup> was rooted at the same place.

*So many people must have used this star to know their position on the sea. Someone had compared this star to someone... who was it? Yes. That astrologer, Kudandhai Jodhidar. Didn't he tell me that Prince Arulmozhivarmar was like Dhruva natchatram? Will I really see him soon?*

Poonguzhali asked, “Did you find the time? It will soon be dawn. The winds are favourable now. We will reach Naga Theevu<sup>[47]</sup> soon.”

“Naga Theevu!”

“Yes. In the north of Ilangai, there are many small islands. If you get down there, you don’t have to take the boat again. You can walk along the coast to reach the mainland,”

“What will you do after you leave me there?”

“How does it concern you?”

“Why shouldn’t it concern me? You have done a huge favour to me by bringing me here in your boat. I am indebted to you. You told me yesterday that you would ask me something in return, what do you want?”

“I have changed my mind about it. You do not owe me anything and I have no intention of asking you to return the favour. You are an ungrateful man.”

Vandiya Devan lowered his eyes with shame and felt that she was justified in saying so.

“Samudra Kumari! I am ashamed by my actions yesterday. It was wrong of me to suspect you thus. Please forgive me.”

“Alright. Forget everything and think about what you are going to do in Ilangai. What will you do after I leave you there? Would you be able to find the prince on your own?”

“God helped me to cross this sea. He will help me to find the prince.”

“Looks like you trust the god above all else. Do you really think that god cares about mere human beings like us?”

“I don’t know that. I have never tried to analyse god and his ways. Whenever I am in trouble, I think about god and he sends me help. When I had to cross the sea, god sent you to me.”

“No, he did not. Nor did he come in my dreams asking me to help you...”

“Then why did you help me? Why did you save me?”

“It’s got nothing to do with you. It’s personal.”

Vandiya Devan sat thinking for long about her reasons. His vain mind initially thought that Poonguzhali might have started liking his handsome person but he rejected it outright. It was too fanciful a thought even for him.

*No. She is not in love with me. There must be some other reason for helping me. Let me keep her talking and get the truth.*

“I am a bit worried about one thing though...”

“What would that be?”

“I have heard that there are many mountains and forests in Ilangai and that half of the island is covered with forests and mountains. They say that there are many wild and ferocious animals.”

He continued , “There are hordes of wild elephants in the forests there. Sometimes they even come out of the forest. I have heard that people in Ilangai are savages.”

“That is a lie.”

“Alright. If you say it is a lie, it must be so. But I am worried about how I will find Prince Arulmozhivarmar there.”

“But didn’t you just say that god will help you, a few moments ago.”

“Yes. I thought that it wouldn’t be difficult to find the Sun amidst the clouds.”

“Then?”

“But what if clouds hide the sun within them?”

“No cloud can hide the sun that you seek. If they try, they too would start glowing as bright as the sun.”

Vandiya Devan noted Poonguzhali’s enthusiasm when she spoke about Prince Arulmozhiarman. Just like the other people in the Chola Kingdom, she too seemed to have boundless love and respect for this prince.

“Find the Chola army in Ilangai and you will find the prince.”

“But... I heard that Chola army is spread all over Ilangai.”

“That is true. From Maandotham<sup>[48]</sup> to Pulastiya Nagaram<sup>[49]</sup>, the Chola armies are encamped in all the places they have captured.”

“If that is so, then how will I find the prince? It will take days and days before I know for sure where he is exactly? And you know how urgent and important this olai is?”

Samudra Kumari was silent for a while.

“If there is a way to find out where the prince is, then I need not roam around unnecessarily.”

“There is a way.”

“I knew that you would be able to find one. That’s why I asked you.”

“Next to Naga Theevu, there is Boodha Theevu<sup>[50]</sup>.”

“The name of the island sounds very scary.”

“There is no need to get scared. Once this island was called Boudha Theevu (Island of Buddha). With time and age, the name got distorted to Boodha Theevu (Ghost Island). Nowadays, many people get scared hearing the name of the island so not many venture there.”

“...except for brave girls like you apparently,” finished Vandiya Devan.

“If you wait at the shores of Boodha Theevu, I can find out where Ponniyin Selvar is at present.”

“Who will you ask in Boodha Theevu?”

“There is a ghost in Boodha Theevu. That’s who I will ask,”

“Will you show me that ghost?”

“No. You will have to promise me to stay ashore with the boat, only then will I go to the island and get the information for you.”

“Alright. As you wish.”

With a gentle breeze blowing and the steady movement of the boat, Vandiya Devan settled down to sleep again even as dawn was breaking in the sky.



## Chapter 9 - This is Ilangai

By the time Vandiya Devan woke up again, it was dawn and a glorious sight awaited him at the shores. The sun shone through the waters making it seem almost golden. At the horizon, there awaited an isle in emerald hues, fresh and green. His first sight of Ilangai was breathtakingly lovely. To the right, there was another island beckoning them with a seductive grace. All through the shore, he could see many such beautiful islands enticing them with their pristine beauty. The beauty of the land awed Vandiya Devan so much that he felt that they were created by god only to show the world how beautiful a place can be.

Spellbound, Vandiya Devan lay silent for a few moments, when Poonguzhali remarked, as if she was reading his thoughts, "This is not heaven. This is Ilangai."

"Yes. You are right. But for a moment I thought I was in heaven."

"This is not heaven but a place that could be heaven if only soldiers and war-mongers like you would leave it alone."

"Are you calling me a war-monger now?"

"Why shouldn't I? People like you who are interested only in conquering lands and enslaving people are the reason why places like Ilangai are turning into hell."

"Would you call Ponniyin Selvar a war-monger now as well?"

"Why are you talking about the prince now?"

"You said that you would find out where the prince is now."

"Yes. I told you that I would find where he is and not what he is."

As the boat neared the shores, Vandiya Devan looked around with interest. “What do you say? The island you see in the front is Boodha Theevu. To your right is Naga Theevu. Shall I go to Naga Theevu? Will you find your way to the Chola army camp?”

“No. Let us go to Boodha Theevu. It doesn’t matter if my journey is delayed by a few hours. I would rather know where the prince is exactly before I start.”

“Alright but remember you promised to stay with the boat.”

Soon the boat neared the shores of Boodha Theevu. Poonguzhali bid Vandiya Devan to watch over the boat and then walked into the island, disappearing amidst its foliage.

He thought about the name of the island and wondered idly about the ghost that would be giving Poonguzhali the information about the prince. Within an hour, the girl who had occupied his thoughts was back.

She walked briskly towards the boat and bid Vandiya Devan to get in.

“What did you find out?”

“Prime Minister Anirudha Bhrahmarayar has come to Maandotham to meet the prince. It is believed that the prince must have come there to meet him but I am not sure how long he will stay there.”

“How far is Maandotham from here?”

“Quite far. You will need to make your way through the forest. Don’t imagine that it would be anything like the forest you saw in Kodi Karai. Here it is very easy to get lost among the trees that almost touch the sky. You will also encounter many elephant herds through

the forest, not to mention other beasts that inhabit the place. You will need to travel very carefully.”

“Hmm. If only I could have someone like you to show me the way through this strange land, it would be wonderful.”

“If you need help at every step of the way, why don’t you hand that olai to me and I might as well deliver it for you. No, I can’t do it. You were sent specifically by Princess Kundavai no? Only you will have to give it to him.”

“That’s fine Poonguzhali. I will complete my mission, no matter what. You helped me to get here, that in itself is a big help.”

The boat now approached Naga Theevu and Poonguzhali plied the oars steadily but it was evident from her face that her thoughts were elsewhere.

“Samudra Kumari!”

“What?”

“You told me that you would ask me for some help later. Now is the time. Soon I will get down from this boat and go in search of the prince. Tell me what you want?”

Poonguzhali looked thoughtful and remained silent for a while. Vandiya Devan continued, “The help that you have rendered to me is very important. In a way, you have helped the entire Chola kingdom by ferrying me here. In return, if there is anything that I can do for you, please tell me.”

“Do you honestly want to do something for me, in return?”

“I solemnly promise in your father’s name, Samudra Rajan.”

“...which means you are writing all this in water.”

“No. I really want to do something for you in return. I solemnly call upon the gods and the five elements of nature to bear witness to my sincerity.”

“Alright. I am not saying this because I believe this oath of yours. Scoundrels and liars swear oaths all the time but when I saw you for the first time, I intuitively knew that you were a good man.”

“They say that first impression that a person has about another is often the right one.”

“After meeting Ponniyin Selvar, when he is alone and free, ask him just one question. ‘Prince! Do you remember Samudra Kumari?’ If he says ‘yes’ then tell him that it was I, who had brought you to Ilangai.”

*Aha! Poonguzhali! Is this your secret? So a little sparrow like you, wishes to reach the heights of an eagle? This can't be good for you...* thought Vandiya Devan but thankfully did not voice it.

“Is that all? You were hesitating so much, for this. I thought you were going to ask for something really big. I will definitely tell the prince about you. Even if he does not remember you, I will remind him of you.”

“Ayyo! Don't say anything to him if he does not remember.”

“No. I will tell him.”

“What will you tell?”

“I will tell him what happened, how you helped me. “Ponniyin Selva! Do you remember Samudra Kumari? If you don't, then please try to remember her now. It was she who helped me to escape the murderous Pazhuvur soldiers. It was she who brought me to Ilangai in her boat. It was she who saved me from drowning in the sea when

I jumped into it like a fool. Without her help, I couldn't have come all the way here and given you this olai." What do you think?"

"So far so good, but don't add anything more to this and don't tell him that I asked you to tell him all this."

"Do you think I don't even know that?"

"If the prince says something to you, make sure that you come back to me and tell me everything word by word."

"Of course, I will. But where will I find you?"

"That's not difficult. I will be either in Kodi Karai or in Boodha Theevu or somewhere in between."

"While going back home, shall I stop at Boodha Theevu to check whether you are there?"

"You are not to enter the island under any circumstances. If you do, there will be danger. See if this boat is there at the shores. Yesterday, I cooed like a cuckoo. Can you make a sound just like that?"

"No. But I can scream like a peacock. Want to hear?" saying thus, Vandiya Devan tried to imitate the high-pitched scream of a peacock only to elicit a delightful laughter from his beautiful companion.

Soon the boat was at the shores of Naga Theevu and Vandiya Devan embarked on the beach for yet another adventure but not before throwing one last glance at the strange boat girl who had brought him there. He had a vain last hope that she might just change her mind and accompany him into the strange land but Poonguzhali had already forgotten all about him and was back in the dreamland she lived in.

## Chapter 10 - Anirudha Bhramarayar

It looks like we have ignored a very important character whom we met right at the beginning of this story, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi. We apologize most sincerely for this oversight both to the Nambi and to our readers. It is important to get a pardon, especially from the Nambi as he is thoroughly incensed and angry right now.

With his front locks flying wildly, he furiously surveyed the scene that unfolded in front of him at Rameshwaram<sup>[51]</sup>. With his stout stick in his arms, he is surrounded by hordes of Saivites. For a minute, we worry about his fate but the Vaishnavan had assumed the wrathful Narasimha<sup>[52]</sup> avatar, the most fearful of Vishnu's ten avatars and was successfully deflecting the Saivite attack.

Azhwarkadiyan had left Pazhaiaarai on the very day he had eavesdropped on Vandiya Devan's and Kundavai's conversation at her palace. Travelling south, he briefly stopped at Madurai to learn something important and then was on his way again. Intent on his work, he didn't even stop anywhere to argue, debate or prove Vishnu's might to poor ignorant Saivites.

The day Vandiya Devan left Kodi Karai with Poonguzhali, Azhwarkadiyan reached Rameshwaram. The minute he stepped on the holy ground of Rameshwaram, there was an emotional upheaval in Azhwarkadiyan's heart and he was ready to unleash all the Vaishnavism that he held holy on the loitering Saivites, who were only too ready to bait him. All around Rameshwaram, there were many Saivites who acted as guides to those who came on a pilgrimage, by taking them to the temple and ensuring that they took a holy dip at all important Tirthas<sup>[53]</sup>. Thinking that Azhwarkadiyan would require guidance, many approached him.

"Come! Come! There are 64 holy tirthas around Rameshwaram. You can bathe in all of them to wash off these unholy Vaishnava marks

on your body. Even Lord Rama<sup>[54]</sup> did penance here to atone for his Brahmahathi Dosham<sup>[55]</sup>. You too can atone for the sin of wearing these Vaishnava marks on your body.”

“Listen to me. There is Rama Tirtham, Lakshmana Tirtham, Hanuman Tirtham, Sugreeva Tirtham<sup>[56]</sup>. They all did holy penance to atone for their sins. You come with me to Hanuman Tirtham<sup>[57]</sup> first. I will help you with the right penance and rituals.”

Yet another battar interjected and said, “Don’t listen to any of these people. I will take you to the temple where Shri Rama worshipped the Shiva lingam made from the beach sand by Sita’s<sup>[58]</sup> own hands. Come with me now.”

Azhwarkadiyan looked around the battars with fury and said, “You foolish people! Stop these nonsensical tales. It would be better for all if you could go to all these Tirthas and wash your mouth.”

“Is that so? Do you think we would become sinners merely by uttering the name, ‘Rama’, ‘Lakshmana’? Don’t you worry! This holy place is called ‘Rameshwaram’ because Rama worshipped Shiva<sup>[59]</sup> here to atone for his sins and to that end, even the sin attached to the word ‘Rama’ gets pardoned, thanks to our Lord Shiva.”

“Foolish men! You people still do not know the meaning of this holy place.”

“Is that so? Then why don’t you enlighten us?”

“Shiva got Brahmahathi Dosham when he plucked one of the five heads of Brahma<sup>[60]</sup>. To atone for that sin, Shiva worshipped Rama at this holy place where the imprints of his foot can still be found. That’s why this is called Rameshwaram – a place where Shiva worshipped Rama.”

“Just who do you think you are to call us foolish?”

“I dare to call you foolish because you are. As for me, I am the servant of Namazhwar<sup>[61]</sup>, who serves our Lord Vishnu. I am Azhwarkadiyan, the one carries a stout stick to break the heads of Saivites.”

“Oh! Azhwarkadiyan! Why do you have that bit of tuft on your forehead? Why don’t you shave it away, then it would match the interior of your head?”

“Yes. I am planning to shave off my front tuft at this holy place.”

“Somebody bring a barber here. Let him come with the sharpest knife in his possession to remove all the hair in his head, root and all...”

“Why do we have to wait for a barber? We can do it ourselves. Does anyone have a sharp knife?”

“Just a moment! I need to tell you people one thing. Once, I used to have a head full of hair. I broke the head of a saivar and took one portion of the hair. Now I only have this tuft. I have sworn to remove this too after breaking the head of a saivar. I couldn’t have come to a better place to fulfil my vow. Come now. Show me your heads. Let me break it and remove this tuft of hair.”

“Adey<sup>[62]</sup>! Look at the cheek of this Vaishnavan...”

“Do you really think you can break all our heads?”

“Do you really think I am just boasting about my hair then?” asked Azhwarkadiyan and started swinging his stick above his head.

“Catch him! Kill him!” shouted some of the battars though none had the gall to come near the stick-wielding Vaishnavan.

At that moment they heard shouts and hails of a different sort nearby. “Hail! Tribhuvana Chakravarthi<sup>[63]</sup> Sundara Chola



Paranthakar's esteemed Prime Minister Anirudha Bhramarayar.

The skirmishing battars and Azhwarkadiyan froze for a moment and looked at the soldiers who were heralding the arrival of the prime minister. Azhwarkadiyan was more surprised than all, as he immediately brought his stick down and stood calmly.

Standing by the streetcorner near the Rameshwaram temple, one could see the vast expanse of the sea, ships and boats and a busy shore with ships being loaded and unloaded with goods and merchandise.

Soldiers bearing the tiger flag and drummers were stationed at the head of the ship on which the prime minister was now approaching the shore. It appeared as if he had noted the fight that would have erupted between Azhwarkadiyan and the Saiva battars. Standing amidst the warring Saivars, Azwarkadiyan tried to cut a sorry figure. Anirudha Bhramarayar signalled him to come near and asked, "Thirumalai! What's happening here?"

"Gurunatha<sup>[64]</sup>! Am I dreaming or is this for real? Lord Krishna is very right about the life being a 'maya'<sup>[65]</sup> indeed."

"Thirumalai! I thought you were a staunch Vaishnavan. Since when have you been following Advaita<sup>[66]</sup> philosophy?"

"Gurunatha! When a scion of a traditional Vaishnava family like yourself can become a Saivite, why can't I become an Advaita<sup>[67]</sup>?"

"Wait! Wait! Who told you that I have become a Saivite?"

"The Saivite marks<sup>[68]</sup> upon your person."

"Aha! Thirumalai! You are still giving importance to these mere marks on the body. How does it matter if you mark your forehead with a vertical or horizontal line?"

“Gurunatha! I know nothing in this world. Only you can enlighten me about it.”

“Alright! Then come to the place where I am staying. Do you see that small island over there? Come to the mandapam in there and meet me.”

“Gurunatha! These skirmishing battars must allow me to come there,” said Azhwarkadiyan pointing towards them. The battars who were silently watching the conversation until then, came towards the Prime minister and said, “Brahmadi Rajare<sup>[69]</sup>! This Vaishnavan is threatening to break our heads. Please punish him.” The other battars too tried to interject with suggestions about the appropriate punishment to cure his impudence.

“I will take care of his punishment. You can go now,” said Anirudhar but it failed to pacify them.

“Why can’t we punish him ourselves? We want to remove that tuft of hair on his forehead and wash off the Vaishnava marks on his body and give him good dunking in all the holy Tirthas of Lord Shiva...”

“What did you say?” growled Azhwarkadiyan, fury sparkling in his eyes.

Anirudhar interjected and said, “Don’t you people worry about it. I will think of an appropriate punishment for him.” Saying thus, he ordered his soldiers to surround Azhwarkadiyan and to bring him to his guest house.

## Chapter 11 - Therinja Kaikola Padai

There were many islands dotting the landscape of Rameshwaram. Prime Minister Anirudha Bhramarayar was staying in one of these islands in a large mandapam along with his entourage. Royal scribes, bodyguards, soldiers and palanquin bearers stood at their stations, while the prime minister got down from the boat and walked up to the mandapam to listen to the petitions of many of those who had come to meet him.

Five people came forward to meet him. They looked prosperous and rich and came bearing a plate that held a navarathna<sup>[70]</sup> haaram<sup>[71]</sup>. Offering the plate respectfully to the prime minister, they bowed low and offered salutations. Anirudhar accepted their gift and gave it to his master of coins and said, “Keep this aside for Sembiyanmadevi’s temple renovation.”

He looked at his visitors and asked, “Please introduce yourself.”

“We represent the Nana desa tisaiyayirattu ainnutruvar<sup>[72]</sup>,”

“Good. Is your business prospering in the Pandya Kingdom?”

“Yes indeed. Our business is expanding.”

“What do people talk about in the Pandya Kingdom?”

“Most are of the opinion that Chola reign is better than that of the Pandyas. Many ardently admire Prince Arulmozhivarmar’s generosity and bravery. The prince’s brave exploits in Ilangai are known even there.”

“What’s the state of trade across the sea in the island kingdoms?”

“Business is flourishing thanks to the peaceful reign of Emperor Sundara Chola. All our merchant ships returned with precious goods

and merchandise,”

“Did your ships face any trouble with the pirates?”

“We haven’t faced any trouble in the past year, not since our Chola Navy destroyed the pirates who were looting merchants in the Manka Vaar Theevu<sup>[73]</sup>.”

“Very good. What arrangements have you made regarding the message that I had sent to you?”

“We have followed your orders. We have brought a thousand sacks of rice, five hundred sacks of corn and hundred sacks of pulses along with us to Rameshwaram. Please make arrangements to send it to Ilangai.”

“Can you send it to Ilangai in your ship?”

“Yes. We can send it. Can you tell us when the war in Ilangai will end?”

“Ah! Now how can I predict that? Don’t you merchants have an official astrologer in your guild? What does he say?”

“Brahma Rajarey! We are finding it difficult to believe our astrologer’s predictions.”

“Why? What does he say?”

“He says that there will be victory wherever Prince Arulmozhivarmar goes. He says that under his reign, the Chola navy will capture all the island kingdoms beyond our seas. He says that our flag will fly high over many kingdoms.”

“If that is so, then your fortunes would rise surely.”

“That’s true. He has assured us that our trade with the island kingdoms will flourish.”

“Very good. With the blessings of Sri Ranganathar<sup>[74]</sup>, may his predictions come true. Until the war goes on in Ilangai, you will need to send food supplies once a month. You may leave now.”

After the merchants left, a soldier announced, “The commanders of Therinja Kaikola Padai<sup>[75]</sup> are waiting for an audience,”

“Ask them to come.”

Three men bearing arms, armour and long swords approached the prime minister. Tall, broad-chested and gaunt, they had a commanding presence that proclaimed their vocation.

Anirudhar looked at the men in front of him and said, “You are the commanders of Sundara Chola Therinja Kaikola Padai?”

“That’s right Prime minister. But we are ashamed to call ourselves thus.”

“Why is that?”

“We have been whiling away our time by sitting here idly. We are afraid that we might forget how to fight.”

“How many regiments are there in your army? How many soldiers?”

“There are three regiments in our army. We each of us, are commanders of these regiments. Each regiment has 2000 soldiers lazing around on ample food.”

“What is it that you wish?”

“We wish to be sent to Ilangai. We would like to join Prince Arulmozhivarmar and fight alongside him,”

“Alright. When I go to Thanjavur, I will petition your appeal to the emperor.”

“Brahmarajare! What if the war in Ilangai comes to a conclusion before that?”

“You don’t have to worry about that. The war in Ilangai is unlikely to end so soon,”

“Is that so? Are the Ilangai soldiers so proficient in the art of war? Please send us there, we will win it sooner than that,”

“I have no doubt about it. The bravery of Therinja Kaikola Padai is legendary. Your war tactics and brave deeds are worthy enough for poetry and songs.”

“Yes. Our soldiers’ brave deeds during the Pandya war is praiseworthy. Thanks to their bravery, we were able to vanquish the Pandyas and the Cheras.”

“The Pandya and Chera army came out on the battlefield to fight with us. It was easy to battle them as they were there in plain sight but in Ilangai, the situation is different. How would you fight an army that you cannot see?”

“Are you saying that the Ilangai soldiers have learnt magic tricks? Do they belong to the era of Ramayana<sup>[76]</sup> to vanish into thin air? Do they fight with us from magic chariots that can ride the sky?”

“No, but it is true that they have vanished. The war has come to a standstill right now because our army needs to find their hideout to fight. Ilangai King Mahindan too has also gone missing. Our soldiers in Ilangai haven’t fought any battles in these six months, as they are busy searching for the king and his army. What’s the point in sending your army there? You too would sit idle there.”

“Maha Mandiri!<sup>[77]</sup> Please send us there. We will find Mahindan and his army even if they have hidden themselves within the bowels of the earth. If we fail, we will name our army as ‘Vellar’s slave army’”

“Please don’t resort to such drastic measures. Everybody knows about the valorous deeds of your army. When I reach Thanjavur, I will consult with the emperor about your request and send word. Please be patient until then. In the meanwhile, your army can help to restore peace and order in the Pandya Kingdom.”

“Maha Mandiri! There is no uprising or rebellion happening in the Pandya Kingdom. The people are happy about the peace that we established and are busy rebuilding their lives. The royal line of Pandya Kings has been destroyed.”

“Ah! That’s wrong. There are still many out there who would claim the Pandya throne and they would try to regain their right through force.”

“Who are they? Where are they? We will take care of them immediately.”

“You will know about them soon enough. The dead Pandya king, Veera Pandyan has hidden his valuable ancient golden crown, diamond studded sword and the precious gemstone haram that was gifted to his ancestors by Lord Indra somewhere in the Rohana Mountain in Ilangai. Until we find these treasures, the Pandya war is far from over...”

“True. We need to retrieve these treasures and we need to crown Prince Arulmozhivarmar with the golden crown of the Pandyas...”

“What? Why do you say that?”

“We have merely expressed the wishes of everybody in this kingdom...”

“Be that as it may, let us not discuss successional matters here. I have another news that would please you people...”

“Yes, maha mandiri...”

“Once Ilangai is totally under Chola sovereignty, Prince Arulmozhivarmar is planning a battle campaign to capture island kingdoms that lie beyond our seas. He is also planning an expedition towards Vengai, Kalingam<sup>[78]</sup> and the northern kingdoms. He wants to follow in the footsteps of his ancestor Karikala Vallavan<sup>[79]</sup> and hoist the tiger flag in the Himalayas. Brave Commanders! Our prince will soon undertake these expeditions and when he does, he will need brave soldiers and astute commanders like you to accompany him. Please advise your soldiers to be patient until then...”

Delighted by the future plans of Arulmozhivarmar, the commanders shouted themselves hoarse, “Long live Sundara Chola! Long live Arulmozhivarmar! Long live maha mandiri!”

“Maha Mandiri! We have just one more petition! You do know that the name of our army is ‘Sundara Chola Therinja Kaikola Padai<sup>[80]</sup>’,”

“Yes. I do,”

“We have taken a sacred oath to fight and die in the service of Emperor Sundara Chola...”

“I know that too.”

“Our loyalty binds us to the emperor and we will not join anybody else nor will heed anybody else’s authority.”

“That’s exactly what I would expect from you.”

“We were once a part of Pazhuvetrayar’s army. We do not wish to be suspected unduly because of that.”



“Why do you say that? Now, who would suspect you?”

“We have heard many alarming rumours from Thanjavur.”

“They are mere rumours. I request you not to believe in any of them or repeat them elsewhere.”

“We are worried that Kodumbalur Vellar’s supporters and followers might create such suspicion about us.”

“They will not. Even if they do, no one will believe them.”

“There is nothing certain in this world... human life is frail.”

“May the emperor live a long life.”

“But he has been unwell for some time now,”

“And there is a comet seen in the sky.”

“If something untoward happens to the emperor, our army wishes to swear a holy oath to serve Prince Arulmozhivarmar,”

“It is your duty to follow the commands of your emperor.”

“Then please petition to the emperor on our behalf or else grant us an audience with him.”

“No. I do not think it would be wise for you to go to Thanjavur. It will give rise to unnecessary conflicts and confusion. I will place your petition before him and let him decide. I will let you know his decision soon. You have my permission to take leave.”

After the commanders left his presence, the prime minister murmured, “Aha! What is this magnetic attraction that people have for the prince? Many seem to fall under his spell after meeting him once.”

Later, he called aloud and said, “Bring that fat Vaishnavan here. I wish to speak to him.”

## **Chapter 12 - Master and the Disciple**

At this juncture, it is important that the readers know more historical information about a certain character in this novel. In the district of Thiruchirapalli and Lalgudi Taluk, there is a village called Anbil. About forty years ago (this novel was written in 1951) a villager was rebuilding his old house and had dug the foundation pits when he made an amazing discovery. He discovered a whole bunch of copper plates inscribed with writing. Bulky and heavy, he kept this discovery at home for some time.

Later, he handed the copper plates to Shri Lakshman Chettiyar who took them to Maha Mahopadhyay Swaminatha Iyer as he felt that the copper plates held some important historical information. Realising the importance of these plates, he handed over the plates to Shri T.A. Gopinath Rao who knew how to decipher ancient scripts. Gopinath Rao was, in turn, delighted to have the copper plates as they were a veritable treasure trove of important information related to the Cholas.

The copper plates chronicled the names of Chola Kings and that of Emperor Sundara Chola who had granted Pathu Veli land to his Prime Minister Anirudha Bhramarayar four years after his ascension to the throne. The royal scribe who had inscribed his name as Madhava Bhattar listed the names of all the kings who had preceded Emperor Sundara Chola.

The plates also had information about the illustrious Vaishnava family of Anirudha Bhramarayar right from his great grandfather to his parents. It also praised the service that this family had rendered to the temple of Sriranganathar. These copper plates were of great historical importance as they confirmed many important details of the Chola lineage and dynasty and contained much interesting information that was hitherto unknown. Since then, these copper plates have been referred to as 'Anbil Sepidiggal' (Anbil Plates). It is essential for the readers to know that Anirudha Bhramarayar was important enough for the Chola Kingdom to record the grants made to him for posterity through copper plates.

The soldiers brought Azhwarkadiyan Nambi inside the mandapam where Anirudhar was giving audience. Azhwarkadiyan immediately approached the prime minister and went around him three times before bowing low to him.

“Om! Hreem Shreem Hasht<sup>[\[81\]](#)</sup>! Master! With your permission, I shall take leave.”

Smiling at his disciple's antics, Anirudhar asked, "Thirumalai! What is this? Where do you wish to leave?"

"I would like to surrender the name 'Azhwarkadiyan' to the holy waters of Rameshwaram and transform into a Kala Moogar Saivan. I would like to don a necklace of skulls and hold a large skull in hand and travel from one place to another uttering the holy mantra of 'Om! Hreem Shreem Hasht'. I wouldn't hesitate to break the head of any Vaishnavan who comes in my way..."

"That's all very fine. Will my head suffer the same fate?"

"Master! Do you perchance still follow the holy Vaishnava tradition?"

"Thirumalai! Why do you have such doubts? Who do you think I am?"

"I do have doubts about you master. Are you not the great grandson of Anbil Anandaazhwar Swamigal who had dedicated his life to the service of Shri Ranganathar?"

"Yes indeed! I am."

"Are you the grandson of Anbil Anirudha Bhatarcharya who taught one and many about the holy scriptures of Vaishnava tradition?"

"That's right and I am his namesake too."

"Are you the son of Narayana Bhattacharya who sang the beautiful songs of our Azhwars<sup>[82]</sup>?"

"Yes. I am."

"If that is so, then my eyes are betraying me and I can't believe what I just heard."

"What makes you doubt your eyes and ears?"

“I heard that you had organized the temple festivities in the Shiva temple here?”

“You heard right. I did organize it.”

“Aren’t you the same master who taught me that there is no God greater than our Lord Vishnu? Didn’t you teach me that there is no hymn holier than our Narayana Mantram<sup>[83]</sup>?”

“Yes indeed, I taught you that.”

“Master! When you as a guru can do things that are contrary to your own teachings then you should not have objections to me becoming a Kala Moogar Saivan<sup>[84]</sup>.”

“Thirumalai! Are you talking about my visit to the Shiva Temple?”

“Master! Which deity did you pray to at the Shiva Temple?”

“To our Lord Narayana of course.”

“I have heard that Lord Rama worshipped Shiva as a Lingam in the temple here. That’s why these Veera Saiva battars here are provoking me endlessly.”

“Thirumalai! Don’t you remember this hymn by Nammazhwar<sup>[85]</sup>?”  
Saying thus, Anirudhar recited a hymn from memory.

“Thirumalai! Even our Sadagopar<sup>[86]</sup> saw the form of Lord Vishnu in all inanimate objects and you are still objecting to a visit that I paid to a Shiva Temple.”

“Master! You are right. I will henceforth learn all the hymns of Nammazhwar and dedicate my life to gathering such pearls of wisdom. I beseech you to grant me a boon!”

“First tell me about this boon and then I will think about granting it.”

“Some time ago, I visited the Veerananarayana Perumal Kovil where I had sung some songs by Nammazhwar. I met Ishwara Battar who has dedicated his life to the service of the temple. Along with him, was his young son who asked me whether I knew any more songs. To my shame, I had to acknowledge that I didn't. I wish to dedicate my life and time to the holy service of Shri Narayana henceforth. That's the boon I beseech from you master!”

“Thirumalai! There will be many other souls who will dedicate their lives to the noble work of Azhwars and Lord Vishnu. You and I have dedicated our lives to the service of the Chola Kingdom. Don't you remember the holy oath that we swore when we started working?”

“I do remember master. But I have been having doubts about this work for some time, especially when I hear people talking all sorts of things about you.”

“Is that so? What are they saying about me?”

“Many are saying that ever since the emperor bestowed lands on your person, you have forgotten all about the holy Vaishnava tradition and travelled across the sea on a ship without any heed to ...”

“I am not worried about what people say about me. We cannot stay in one place like frogs in the well<sup>[87]</sup>. And about the emperor bestowing lands to me, do remember one thing, I was the emperor's Prime minister for four long years before he made that generous grant to me.”

“Do you know how long the emperor and I have been friends? We studied together under the same guru and learned mathematics, astronomy, political strategy, literature and history. At that time, no one thought that Sundara Cholar would ascend the throne. Who knew that his uncles Rajadhithar and Gandarathithar would die so

suddenly? Who knew that his own father Arinjaya Cholar would die of wounds suffered in the battle? Sundara Cholar knew that there were bound to be many difficulties and hurdles if he ascended. He said that he would accept the throne only if I became his maha mandiri. That's when I swore to help him in governing the kingdom and have been fulfilling that vow since then. Don't you know all this Thirumalai?"

"I know about this master but sadly the people of the kingdom do not know about this and they talk all sorts of things about you."

"I am not bothered about what people talk. I too have had many doubts about this profession of mine ever since I left the traditional service of Ranganathar<sup>[88]</sup> to serve the emperor. However, for the past two days, I have had no doubts about my decision. You must be aware of the fact that I came here to travel to Maandotham in Ilangai."

"Yes. I knew that."

"Do you know Maandotham still resembles the city that Sambandhar and Sundaramurthy Nayanaar sang of a few years ago?"

"Master! I trust you did not travel all the way to Maandotham just to enjoy the beauty of the place?"

"No. I went there to meet Prince Arulmozhivarmar and I am thinking of sending you there."

"Did you meet the prince, master?" asked Azhwarkadiyan with a trace of eagerness and impatience in his voice.

Noting this Anirudhar said, "Aha! Even you are eager to meet him I guess. Yes. Thirumalai! I met and spoke to him and learned many astounding tales about his feats in Ilangai. The king of Ilangai, Mahindan once had a huge army at his disposal. Today, that army has vanished into thin air. There were many Pandya and Chera

soldiers in Mahindan's<sup>[89]</sup> army. When they learned that our prince was coming there, they too dropped their weapons and vanished without a trace. Without an army, how will Mahindan fight anybody, so he too vanished into the rocky mountains of Rohana<sup>[90]</sup>. So right now, there are no enemies in Ilangai for the prince to fight."

"Master! If this is the state of affairs in Ilangai, don't you think it is better for our prince to return to the Chola Kingdom? As it is so much ruckus has been created over the issue of sending food from here to the soldiers there."

"That's not a wise move to make. I said the enemies have vanished for the time being but they are not vanquished. If the prince comes back home, Mahindan would come out from his hideout and the war would begin once again. We need to fully establish our sovereignty on Ilangai and must gain the trust and love of the people there. That's what our prince is doing there. Do you know what our soldiers in Ilangai are doing? They are helping in the rebuilding of Buddha viharas<sup>[91]</sup> that were destroyed in Anuradhapuram."

"Looks like our prince will renounce Saivism and Vaishnavam and become a Buddhist ultimately. How can we let this happen?"

"Who is asking you and me here? People like us can live and die all our lives as staunch Vaishnavites but such things cannot apply to those who are born to rule. Such people need to acknowledge and embrace all faiths and their sects. I am impressed by the fact that our prince has realized this important fact all by himself. I have heard people say that there is a holy Sangu Chakra mark on the prince's hands. I haven't seen it yet and nor did I ask him to show it to me but irrespective of whether such a mark exists in his hands or not, I know one thing for sure. Our prince was born to rule as a great emperor. Did you see the commanders of Kaikola Padai who came to meet me a few minutes ago? They want to fight under the banner of our prince. And the merchants of the guild who are known for their thriftiness become more than generous when it comes to our prince."



“A few days ago, I had met a wise mendicant near Podhigai Malai<sup>[92]</sup>. Do you know what he said? He said that for a long period, the fortunes of kingdoms in the South have been shrouded by a cloud but soon we will rise to form a formidable force. He said that a king will arise in the South to become a great emperor and many other great men of worth and knowledge would appear here soon. After meeting the prince, I have no doubt that the words of this seer would come true soon.”

“Master! You are building beautiful castles in the air while many are trying to destroy the very foundations of this Kingdom. If you had seen the things that I have seen and heard the things that I have heard, you wouldn’t be sitting here so happily discussing a seer’s prophecy.”

“Thirumalai! You are right. I got carried away. Come now, tell me all about your travel...”

“Master! Do you want me to tell you here? If the wind god hears my news, he will be scared. If the sea heard about my travel, he will be stunned immobile. The news that I have brought would stun all the gods and the earth as well.”

“If that is so, then come let me take some place where no one can overhear your news.”

## Chapter 13 - Ponniyin Selvan

Just when Vandiya Devan was finding his way by foot towards Maandotham and Anirudhar and Azhwarkadiyan were conversing about the kingdom's affairs, Princess Kundavai and Vanathi were on their way to Thanjavur on a royal elephant.

Kundavai Devi had not visited Thanjavur for some time now. For one thing, the capital did not have enough palaces to house the princess and her retinue and this meant that she would have to stay at her father's royal residence which was not only inconvenient but also lacked privacy. Independent by nature, Kundavai couldn't abide by the rules of security laid down by the Pazhuvur brothers. Apart from that, she found it difficult to bear the arrogant behaviour of Nandini, the Pazhuvur queen whose insolence knew no bounds. Her father too accepted her reservations and did not demand her presence at the capital often.

Soon after meeting Vandiya Devan, Kundavai felt that none of these reasons mattered much when the safety of the kingdom and that of the throne were under question.

How can I roam joyously around the gardens of Pazhaiaarai when the kingdom is in such grave danger? With the crown prince away in Kanchipuram and her younger brother in Ilangai, who would take care of the kingdom?

Her brother had cautioned her more than once to use spies to learn what was happening in the capital. She felt that the time for covert knowledge was past and knew that she had to be in Thanjavur, beside her father.

So far, she had been uncomfortable with the arrogance and ambitious behaviour of the Pazhuvur brothers and when she learned

about their plot to crown Madhuranthakan she knew that it was time to pay a visit to the Capital.

That poor boy Madhuranthakan! God knows what they are planning to do with him. They had also somehow garnered the support of important chieftains and petty kings to help his cause. They might even stoop to kill the emperor to fulfil their ambition. They wouldn't find a more opportune time to act than now with both the princes away from the Capital, it would be very easy to crown Madhuranthakan as the next king. If they were short of ideas, that Rakshashi<sup>[93]</sup> Nandini would supply them with a few murderous ones.

These were the thoughts that prompted Kundavai to leave her carefree world at Pazhaiaarai and move towards the fort of Thanjavur. At the capital, it would be easy to see through the machinations of the Pazhuvur brothers and hopefully, save the kingdom from danger.

Why do they wish to crown Madhuranthakan? Do they truly believe that he deserves the throne? No. They want a puppet king on the throne, someone who would listen to everything that they say while the real power would rest in the hands of Pazhuvetarayar and his queen. She would then rule over the Chola Kingdom and hold sway over everybody's life, including hers. 'No! This will not come to pass when I am alive.' Let me see how clever she really is.

While living in Thanjavur would be uncomfortable enough, her parents would undoubtedly ask, "Why have you come here instead of staying comfortably at Pazhaiaarai?" It would be impossible to go anywhere outside the Fort without the permission of Thanjavur Commander Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. If that were not enough, the idle womenfolk at the palace would start talking about her marriage, which left her seething with irritation. She would have to meet Nandini upon occasion and bear her arrogant behaviour and ungracious self. However, none of these was worth a consideration when the kingdom was in such grave danger. She also intuitively sensed an imminent danger nearing her father.

Apart from all these considerations, there was yet another important reason for her travel. She wanted to know whether Vandiya Devan had reached his destination or not. She knew that the Pazhuvur brothers had sent soldiers to Kodi Karai to capture him.

Will they be successful in capturing him? She thought not.

If they do, they would bring him to Thanjavur and wouldn't it be helpful if she were there too. They dare not do any harm to a messenger sent by the crown prince, that's why they have brought about the false charge of attempted murder on him. If they can blame him for trying to murder Sambuvarayar's son<sup>[94]</sup>, they would be within their rights to imprison him. There was no doubt about the fact that it was a false charge but it might be difficult to prove it. She was determined to speak to Kandanmaran and learn his version of the story as well.

While Kundavai's mind was unravelling the political intrigues and imminent threats against her father's kingdom, her companion and friend Vanathi's innocent mind was engaged with just one thought.

When would Prince Arulmozhivarmar come home?

"Akka! You said that you have asked him to come home immediately? Where will he arrive? At Pazhaiaarai or Thanjavur?"

She was wondering whether the prince would arrive at Pazhaiaarai when they were visiting Thanjavur.

Kundavai who was otherwise engaged didn't hear her question properly. "Are you asking about Ponniyin Selvan, Vanathi?"

"Yes, akka. I was asking about him. You have called him 'Ponniyin Selvan' yet again. Won't you tell me the story behind that name? We have all the time in the world, as this elephant is moving very slowly."

“If the elephant were to go anymore faster than this, we wouldn’t be able to sit on it. Do you know what happened in the Thakkolam<sup>[95]</sup> war?”

“No. I don’t. I want to know the story behind the name ‘Ponniyin Selvan’.”

“Looks like you will not forget about that. Alright, here is the story.”

In the early years of Sundara Chola’s ascension to the throne, his family life was very happy. He used to take many pleasure trips in the palace boats along the banks of the Kaveri. With sounds of laughter, encouragement and poetic verses, the emperor loved to travel along with his family, whenever he felt the need for some leisure to ease the burden of royal affairs.

Once, while they were travelling thus, the emperor and the Queen were engaged in a serious conversation and there arose an alarm, “Where is the child? Where is Arulmozhi?”

Startled they looked around to find their youngest son missing from the boat. Kundavai who had raised the alarm searched around and soon the servants and the emperor himself jumped into the river to search for the lost child.

Kundavai was seven years old then, while Arulmozhi was five years old and was the darling child of the entire kingdom. More than anybody else, it was Kundavai who took care of him and loved him almost like a mother rather than a sister. When she found her younger brother missing, she was alarmed and shaken. Worried, she looked everywhere and around the boat to see whether he had fallen into the water by accident. But for how long could they search for the missing child in the water and where to search? Learning about the danger to their darling child, the queen and some of her womenfolk fainted away in fear, while some cried bitterly.

Suddenly there was a miracle. They saw her at a distance from the bank, a woman holding the missing child in her hands. Half submerged in the water, she held out the child in her hand. Her beautiful face, arms and shoulders were the only things that were seen. The emperor, who was swimming nearby, immediately took the child from her and by then the palace boat had neared them. He gave the child to the servants and got into the boat and suddenly fainted.

With the emperor indisposed and a frightened child to pacify, the queen and her servants forgot all about the woman who had saved the child. After some time when things settled down, they pondered over who saved the child. No one came forward to claim the honour of saving the little Prince's life. No one had noticed what happened to the woman after she handed over the child to the emperor. After endless discussion, they decided that it must have been Mother Kaveri who had saved the prince. Since then every year, they held a special puja for River Ponni and Ponniyin Selvan became one of titles that the prince bore.

## Chapter 14 - Two Full Moons

There was a flurry of action in Thanjavur city that day. Their beloved princess who had stopped coming to the capital city for some reason had consented to come, at last. That was cause enough for a celebration among the citizenry. Princess Kundavai held a special place in their hearts. Her beauty, intelligence, grace, wit and benevolence were a matter of pride for them. Many quoted her as an example to their children, while young women of the kingdom aspired to be like her.

People were eagerly awaiting her arrival as they had heard a rumour that she would be present at the capital for the Navarathiri<sup>[96]</sup> festival. A sea of people had gathered at the Fort gates anxiously waiting for the princess to arrive. Just as the sea waits for the beautiful full moon to rise, this crowd too wanted at least a mere glimpse of their lovely princess.

At long last, the full moon rose and instead of one, there were two full moons to gaze upon! Princess Kundavai's elephant parted the crowds easily and stood near the Fort doors, waiting for it to open. With a loud clang of metal, the fort doors opened to reveal the welcome party that had come to invite the princess in with the palace retinue. Flanked on both the sides by the Pazhvur brothers, the Pazhuvur queen's pearl studded palanquin too had come bearing its mistress.

While Kundavai got down from her elephant, Nandini got down from her palanquin hurriedly and came forward with formal salutations that were due to a Princess. Kundavai smiled at her and accepted her greetings. It was a spectacle that delighted the crowds beyond any words; after all, there was scant opportunity for them to watch the two most beautiful women in the Chola Kingdom come together thus.

They compared the beauty of both women enthusiastically! Nandini was fair complexioned while Kundavai was lotus-hued. Nandini's beautiful dark eyes were large, round and lovely, while Kundavai had eyes that resembled a doe. Nandini's nose was shaped in proportion to her round face while Kundavai's nose was perfectly sculpted. Nandini had sensuous full lips that begged to be kissed while Kundavai's thin lips resembled a flower bud. Nandini's hair was dressed with flowers in her customary aandal kondai <sup>[97]</sup> while Kundavai's hair was piled up in an ornamental bun that almost resembled a crown.

The citizens of Thanjavur were not very happy with the Pazhuvur queen. There was much cause to ridicule her and also to feel jealous of her newfound power and authority. However, they forgot all their grievances when they saw her greeting their Princess with a beautiful smile.

We wonder what their reaction would have been if they had only been privy to the conversation that occurred between these two women.

"Welcome! Princess! We thought that you had forgotten all about us! But thankfully you came today!"

"Is that so Rani? If I live far away, does it mean that I have forgotten everybody? Can I assume that since you rarely visit Pazhaiaarai, you have forgotten all about me?"

"Just as bees naturally swarm around sweet-smelling flowers, anybody would want to visit beautiful Pazhaiaarai, while this Thanjai<sup>[98]</sup> fort is anything but beautiful. To visit here, one does need a strong reason and a gracious invitation."

"How can you say such a thing? How can you call Thanjavur as an ugly city, when you have captured 'all things beautiful' here?"



“Yes. I have heard that rumour too, Princess. Some seem to be saying that we have kept your father, the emperor as a prisoner here. But now that you are here, you can surely free him,” said Nandini, even as a flash of anger came and disappeared in her eyes.

“What is this you are saying? Not even Lord Indra<sup>[99]</sup> and his gods can imprison my father, leave alone mere mortals. I was not referring to him, I was talking about you, the beautiful Nandini Devi.”

“Well said, Princess. I would be much obliged if you could say this in my husband’s hearing. I am indeed living here like a bird in a gold cage if you could only recommend...”

“What’s the use of my recommendation when you are being kept in a ‘love prison’.

“Very true Devi. That too, when an old man falls in love, there is no hope of release. My situation is worse than those who have been shut in the underground prison of Thanjavur.”

“Well Rani, there is nothing to say about it, especially since you wished to be imprisoned of your own will. When one is as virtuous as Sita, Arundhati, Nalayani and Kannagi<sup>[100]</sup>, you wouldn’t want to be set free of this prison. Would you? What is this? Why are these women shouting?” asked Kundavai suddenly distracted from her conversation.

A throng of women was shouting themselves hoarse to gain Kundavai’s attention. Both Kundavai and Nandini stepped in their direction to listen to their petition. They wanted permission to come inside the fort during the nine days of Navarathri and wanted Kundavai to petition on their behalf to the Fort Commander to grant them permission.

Kundavai turned towards Nandini and said, “Rani! I would be much obliged if you could tell your husband or your brother-in-law about this and allow these women to visit the fort every day during

Navrathri. Surely, no harm can come through these women, especially when we have the Pazhuvur brothers commanding the four corners of the kingdom,”

“Princess! You are wrong. Why have you stopped with the four corners of the kingdom, the Pazhuvur brother will also be commanding the lands beyond the Chola Kingdom too. You will see that soon enough!”

Nandini’s words startled Kundavai and she thought, what does this rakshashi mean by this?

By then, Nandini had signalled Periya Pazhuvetarayar to come near and had sounded him out about the women’s petition and Kundavai’s request to which he said, “Just as my princess commands!”

Happy and enthused by this, the crowd entered the fort along with the princess and her retinue. For the next nine days, crowds from the neighbouring villages came to the fort every day to see their beloved princess. Periya Pazhuvetarayar kept his word and allowed all and sundry to enter the fort. The Fort doors remained open during all hours and everyone came and went as they wished. Within the fort and outside, many temple festivities were organized to celebrate the auspicious nine days of Navrathri. Apart from the festivities, many came to see Kundavai and the lovely Pazhuvur queen.

While all was smile and laughter on the outside, they both were seething with anger and hatred on the inside. A shadow war was being fought between them that went unnoticed by the people around. Unlike men, they used words as their weapons and their eyes as their spears to wound each other. One might even compare their struggle to that of a never-ending war between two beautifully dangerous snakes.

In this war of words, both women reached heights of enthusiasm when they won a round and retreated to lick their wounds in private

when they lost. While Kundavai was engaged thus, her companion Princess Vanathi felt utterly lost. Kundavai couldn't spare the time to talk to her and though she went along with her, she found it difficult to understand what was happening around her. Instead, she was happy to dwell in the world that she had created around herself.

## **Chapter 15 - A Voice of Distress**

The Chola Kingdom in those days was the epitome of art, dance, drama and music. In particular, the theatrical artists and their plays were very popular with the general populace. There were many streets in Thanjavur dedicated solely for the performance of drama and arts. However, the best of the artists lived right at the royal palace of Emperor Sundara Chola.

Well renowned for their stellar performance, the playwrights of Chola Kingdom wrote many new plays inspired by the glorious history of their kings and their victories. Some of their best plays featured Chola heroes of renown, Karikala Vallavan, Vijayalaya Chola, Paranthaka Devar and many other kings of the past.

On the occasion of Navrathri, the artists put up a show for the royal audience at the palace for three days in a row. The royal theatre was set in a large courtyard that could easily accommodate more than a thousand people while the royal women viewed the performance from an enclosure with silk screens and cushions. The queen and many other royal ladies sat through the performance of most plays here. Kundavai and Vanathi too attended them on the last three days of the Navrathri. On many occasions, Nandini too joined Kundavai and her companions. The womenfolk didn't like this but they couldn't show their displeasure openly, especially when Kundavai welcomed her with the utmost respect. That apart, life might get very unpleasant for those who courted the displeasure of the Pazhuvur queen and her Lord. When Kundavai herself regarded her with such respect, they had no choice but to follow her example.

Of all the plays that were performed, the play on Emperor Paranthaka Devar's life was well received by the audience. The audience's reaction to this play also served as a mirror to the public opinion.

Among all the Chola Kings, Paranthaka I was hailed as the bravest and wisest emperor. During his long reign of 41 years, the Chola Kingdom reached the heights of prosperity. The Tiger flag ruled over the lands from Ilangai to the Tungabhadra River. He led many campaigns and won many victories by crushing the Pandya rule in Madurai. He was also known for his piety and devotion and he gave gold to gild the roof of Chidambaram temple<sup>[101]</sup>.

Unfortunately, during the last years of his reign, the Chola Kingdom lost its hold on the neighbouring kingdoms. Kannara Devan brought a large army to attack from Irattai Mandalam<sup>[102]</sup> to attack the Cholas. Emperor Parathaka's eldest son and Crown Prince Rajadithya led their army in the battle but when a poison-coated arrow tragically killed him, the Chola Kingdom's fortunes fell.

Dramatizing the death of this brave prince, the play was an emotional reminder for the audience about events that had happened not so long in the past. There was also yet another reason why the public enjoyed this play more than the others. During the reign of Parathaka I, two royal lords played a very important role in the events to come – Pazhuvetrayar and Vellar. Both these Lords were immensely powerful, brave and performed many valorous deeds in the service of their emperor. They were also related to the emperor through marriage. The Pazhuvur lord, Kandan Amuthan depicted in the play was the father of the present Pazhuvur lords, while the Vellar lord was the father of Kodumbalur Siriya Vellar. In other words, he was Vanathi's grandsire.

The play was very carefully enacted to glorify the deeds of both the Lords and to avoid any misinterpretation by the audience. They also showed the audience how Emperor Parathaka I acted impartially towards both the lords while acknowledging them for their contributions. Despite the good intentions of the artists, the play opened the doors for favouritism among the audience as they quickly took sides to support their favourite lord. When the Pazhuvur lord came on stage, the Pazhuvur soldiers cheered him loudly and when the Vellar lord waged a war, his supporters clapped uproariously.

What began, as a harmless tug-of-war soon became quite serious thanks to Princess Kundavai.

When the cheering of the Vellar crowd sounded loud, Kundavai would lean towards Vanathi and say, “Look Vanathi! Your side is winning.” Innocent and naïve, Vanathi would smile and express her happiness at this. When the Pazhuvur soldiers cheered aloud, she would lean towards Nandini and say, “Rani<sup>[103]</sup>! Looks like your side is winning now!”

Nandini didn’t relish the prospect of Kundavai placing her on the same pedestal as Vanathi. With Kundavai’s encouragement, the audience’s preference and opinions were soon apparent enough for all to see. Nandini’s anger knew no bounds and she was tempted to leave the mid-way through the play, but it would only signify her defeat, hence she sat back grudgingly.

Kundavai didn’t miss anything. She could read Nandini’s mind easily. Her face reflected all the emotions that she was undergoing. However, she was intrigued by Nandini’s reaction to the defeat of the Pandya emperor. When the play showed the Pandya king being refused help by the Ilangai king, the audience cheered madly forgetting their own differences but Nandini’s face showed deep misery and sadness. For the rest of the play, Kundavai couldn’t help wondering about Nandini’s reaction to the Pandya King’s defeat.

Hoping to learn more about it, Kundavai tried to engage her in conversation. “I wish that the emperor was well enough to see this play. If only his health had permitted...”

“He will recover soon Princess, now that you are here to look after him. If the medicinal herbs from Ilangai too arrive on time, his recovery would be very fast indeed.”

“Medicinal herbs from Ilangai?”

“Why Princess? I heard that you have sent the Pazhaiaarai physician’s son to get medicines for your father from Ilangai? Isn’t that true?”

Kundavai bit her lips in silence. No matter how beautiful one’s lips are, it does hurt when one bites it. Thankfully, she was spared from replying when the crowd cheered madly drowning all the noise around.

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The play ended amidst resounding cheers and claps from the audience. After the audience dispersed, the royal women and their retinue sought their palanquins to return home.

Later, the Empress Vanamadevi and other womenfolk went to the Durga temple the patron Goddess of the Chola Kings. The Empress regularly went to the temple to pray for the health of her husband and during the auspicious nine days of Navrathri, it was customary to stay until the pujari<sup>[104]</sup> made a blood sacrifice and return to the palace during the wee hours of the morning.

Young girls were normally not taken along to Durga Temple as the Pujari<sup>[105]</sup> of the temple would often become possessed by the Goddess. On such occasions, they would dance wildly and recount wars of gore and tales of revenge. No one had the temerity to tell Kundavai that she would be scared and hence, she too went along with her mother to the temple and performed the puja. But Vanathi was left behind in the palace on these nine days for the same reason.

Vanathi’s heart was bubbling with happiness and pride on the day ‘Paranthaka Devar’s’ drama was staged. She felt proud of her grandsire’s achievements and that of her clan as well. She was also reminded of her dead father, whose martyrdom in Ilangai was one of the main reasons for the present military campaign. Also, the man leading the campaign was the beloved prince who had been giving

her sleepless nights. After trying to sleep rather unsuccessfully in her room, Vanathi decided to wait for Kundavai to return from the temple.

Instead of staying in her room, Vanathi found herself walking towards the terrace of the royal palace as one could see the entire Thanjai city from there. Vanathi was not very familiar with the royal palace. By following the winding paths of the palace, she ended up near the emperor's royal quarters by mistake. Suddenly she heard a faint voice that made her tremble.

"Is there no one here who could save me?"

Aha! Isn't that emperor's voice? He seems to be in some distress.

She knew that the empress and her womenfolk had left the palace to go to the temple.

Thinking thus, Vanathi entered a room and found herself on a private balcony that overlooked the emperor's room. Looking down, she saw his private chambers and the emperor himself lying on the bed, alone.

"You wretch! It is true that it was I who killed you. Though I didn't intend any such thing, I will not deny the fact that your death occurred because of me. What is it that you wish from me? How long will you continue to haunt me? Will your soul never rest in peace? It's been 25 years since your death and you are still tormenting me. Will I ever get peace in this lifetime? What is it that you want? What do you want me to do? I will do it! Just leave me in peace. Everybody rushes around to find a medicine to cure me but no one wants to help me find peace. Go! Go! Go away! No! No! Don't. Wait a moment. Tell me what I should do? Don't be silent. Tell me. Tell me!"

Hearing these words, Vanathi's trembling increased. Looking down carefully she leaned down to see 'who' was with the emperor. There stood a figure at the far end of the room behind the pillar. It was a



woman, who was half visible from the shadows cast by the pillars and the dimly lit lamps. Looking carefully at the figure, Vanathi's eyes widened when she recognized who stood there. It was the Pazhvur queen, Nandini Devi!

Why would the emperor talk such things looking at Nandini? How could he say 'he killed her' when she was well and alive?

With fear gripping her senses, she felt weak and knew instinctively that she would swoon soon. She found the room and the world swirling away, ready to whisk her away to the world of darkness. Gritting her teeth, she slowly traced her way back to the room, until she could walk no more.

When Kundavai returned from the temple that night, she found Vanathi lying unconscious in the corridor that led to their room.

## Chapter 16 - Emperor Sundara Chola's Hallucinations

Next morning, the emperor summoned his daughter to his chambers after bidding his servants, bodyguards, handmaidens and the physicians to stay away. He asked Kundavai to sit next to him on the bed to talk confidentially but she could sense that he was struggling for words.

“Appa, [\[106\]](#) are you angry with me?” asked Kundavai.

Her words brought tears to his eyes and he asked, “Why would I be angry with you, child?”

“I came here ignoring your commands.”

“Yes. You ought not to have come here. This Thanjavur palace is not the right place for young girls like you. It must be quite obvious to you from last night's incident.”

“What incident are you referring to, Appa?”

“I am referring to that Kodumbalur girl fainting near my chambers? How is she feeling now?”

“She is fine now. She has fainted many times like this in Pazhaiaarai.”

“Did you ask her Kundavai? Did she tell you why she fainted? Did she hear or see anything in this palace?”

Kundavai thought for a while before answering her father and said, “Yes. She said that she wanted to go the terrace but lost her way and ended up near your chambers by mistake. She said that she heard someone moaning in fear and pain which scared her to death.”

"I thought so. Now, do you realize, dear daughter, a ghost haunts this Thanjavur palace? I don't want you to stay here. Leave this place at once," Said Sundara Chola and his eyes were fixated at a distant place and his body shivered in fear.

Noting this with alarm, Kundavai said, "If that is so father, why do you and mother have to stay here? Why don't you come back to Pazhaiaarai? I don't think your health has improved by any measure after shifting here."

Hearing her words, the emperor smiled bitterly and said, "My health is not going to improve. I have no such hope."

"Appa! Please don't say that. The head physician at Pazhaiaarai says that he can cure you completely."

"And you believed him and sent some men to Ilangai to get medicinal herbs. I heard about it. Your actions attest to your affection."

"Is that wrong father?"

"No. I am fortunate to have a daughter like you. There is nothing wrong in you sending people to Ilangai to get herbs for me. However, I do know one thing for sure, even if you get medicines from Ilangai or some other island or even from the heavens, my health is not going to improve."

"Ayyo! Don't say that father?"

"You came here despite my commands, dear daughter. I can't tell you how happy that makes me. For many days, I have wanted to tell someone this truth. I will not get this opportunity again. Listen to me! If my illness was related to my physical body, then the medicines would work but they won't work on those who are sick in the heart and mind. I don't think there is any medicine for a worried heart."

“Dear Father! You rule over the three worlds. What are you worried about?”

“Child! You are quoting the poets who would hail me as the emperor of the three worlds! I am not the emperor of the three worlds! I am not even an emperor of one world. I rule over a very small portion of land in the world. When I can’t bear the burden of this small portion of the world, dare I hope to rule over three worlds?”

“Father! Why would you want to bear the burden of the kingdom? You have two valiant sons who are peerless warriors. Let them bear the burden of this kingdom.

“Child! That’s what worries me day and night. Your brothers are valiant warriors indeed but if I hand over the burden of the kingdom to them, I will not be doing the right thing. There is a deadly curse on this kingdom that they will inherit from me.”

“Father! What is this ‘curse’ you keep referring to? How can there be a curse on a kingdom that had emperors like Sibi<sup>[107]</sup> who offered his own flesh for a pigeon and Manu <sup>[108]</sup> who sought to sacrifice his heir and son to give justice to a cow? Our ancestors were the peerless warriors like Karikala Vallavan<sup>[109]</sup> and Perunara Killi<sup>[110]</sup> and Vijayalaya Chola who bore 96 deadly wounds to save this kingdom. Aditya Chola built over 108 temples along the banks of River Kaveri and your own grandfather Paranthaka Chola who gave away gold from the treasury to build a roof for Chithambaram. Your uncle Gandaradithar was a king not unlike Dharmaraja<sup>[111]</sup> in the Mahabharatha. How could you call such a kingdom cursed, father? It’s your health that is troubling you, father. If you leave this fort and come back to...”

“Do you know what would happen if I leave this fort? Do you think I am happy to stay here, away from the beautiful gardens of Pazhaiaarai? Kundavai! My presence in this fort is the only thing that is keeping this Chola Kingdom from disintegrating. Did you see what

happened at the play yesterday? I was watching it from the balcony. I had a mind to stop it in the middle.”

“But father, why? I thought that the play was well enacted. I felt so proud to see the valiant acts of my ancestors. Why did you wish to stop it in the middle? Which part of the play did you dislike?”

“The play was indeed well enacted, child. I had no complaints about it, however, I was not pleased with the actions of the audience. Did you not notice how the audience took sides with Pazhuvetarayars and Kodumbalur Vellar and shouted their support?”

“Yes. I did father.”

“If they have the temerity to act thus even when I am here, what do you think would happen if I were to leave? The minute I leave Thanjavur, a deadly skirmish would break out between these two clans and just as Lord Krishna’s Yadava clan<sup>[112]</sup> was destroyed, our kingdom too would be doomed.”

“Father! You are the emperor. Whether it is Pazhuvur brothers or the Vellars, they are bound by their holy oath to follow your orders if they don’t, they will be destroyed by their own hand. You don’t have to be unduly worried about...”

“Child! Both these clans have been the backbone of our kingdom. They have supported us in countless wars and battles. If they destroy themselves, it is but natural that the kingdom will become weak.”

“Father! If it is known that one of these clans is involved in a plot against the kingdom and you.”

Sundara Chola looked at Kundavai with surprise and asked, “What are you saying, Child? Who is plotting against me?”

“Appa! There are people whom you trust implicitly in this kingdom but sadly it is they who have turned against you and your sons. They are involved in a secret plot against you. They want to deprive your sons of their right and crown somebody else as the king.”

“Who? Whom do they want to crown?” asked the emperor hurriedly

Kundavai lowered her voice and said softly, “They want to crown my uncle Madhuranthakan as the next king. Ever since you have become incapacitated by your illness, these people have been hatching this plot.”

The emperor suddenly sat up and said, “If only their plot was successful, how wonderful it would be”

Shocked by his words, Kundavai said, “Father! How can you say such a thing? Would you turn against your own sons?”

“No. I am not trying to turn against my own sons. I wish to do them good. I don’t want this cursed kingdom to go to my sons. If only Madhuranthakan would agree to ascend the throne...”

“Why wouldn’t he agree? He is more than ready to ascend the throne. Are you going to give this kingdom to him? Won’t you speak to my brother about this decision of yours?”

“Yes. I will need to speak to Aditya Karikalan about it. And not only him, we need to ask Sembiyanmadevi’s permission as well.”

“If the son is going to inherit a kingdom will the mother say ‘no’?”

“Even after all these years, you do not know your grandmother well enough. Years ago, I ascended the throne only because of Sembiyanmadevi’s insistence. It was she who pushed me to crown Aditya Karikalan as the heir apparent and crown prince. Child! Your grandmother loves you as much as her own daughter, you can sway

her heart and get her to agree for Madhuranthakan's ascension as the next king."

Stunned by his words, Kundavai could only look at him speechlessly.

"After you speak to her, go to Kanchi<sup>[113]</sup> and convince your brother to give up this accursed kingdom. Let us crown Madhuranthakan as the next emperor. Only then, we will be relieved from this curse."

"Appa! What is this curse that you keep referring to?"

"Child! Do you believe in past life memories? Some people remember things from their past life and recount it accurately. Do you believe in it?"

"Father! I have no opinion about it, as I do not know anything about it."

"They say that Maha Vishnu took ten avatars and Buddha was the last avatar. There are many beautiful stories about him."

"Yes. I have heard about them."

"I keep wondering when gods can have different avatars, why can't a man remember his past life?"

"It is possible."

"I remember many things from my past life, child. I haven't spoken about it to anyone so far. Even if I did, no one would believe it and nor would they understand it. They would say that this paralysis has affected my mind as well and would bring sorcerers along with the physicians to cure me."

"You are right, father. Even now, many are saying that your mind is not sound."

“See? I was right. But I hope you wouldn’t think of me as ‘mad’. I hope you will not laugh at me.”

“Do you have to ask, father? Don’t I know how distressed you are? Would I laugh at you, ever?”

“I know child. That’s why I have decided to reveal certain things in my past life. Listen to me.”

There was a beautiful island, green and lush with pristine sands and emerald greenery all around. A young warrior was hiding behind a large bush and was watching the beach intently. At some distance, one could see a large ship sailing away. The soldier watched the ship until it disappeared from his line of sight and then stood up saying, “Thank God!”

That young warrior was of royal lineage but he had no claim on the kingdom and nor did he crave for that responsibility. His father had two brothers who would succeed to the throne and therefore, he never had any aspiration or dream of ruling a kingdom. He wanted to perform valiant and valorous deeds in the service of the kingdom. So, he went along with their army to fight their enemy across the seas. He took charge of a small army of soldiers but they lost the battle and his men were killed. Though he fought bravely and had every intention of dying along with his men, his life was spared. He joined the band of soldiers who were returning home by ship even though he was not happy to return home. He felt guilty about returning home especially after losing all the men under his command. His ancestors were great warriors. His father, uncles, his grandfather and great-grandfather were great kings who had won every inch of their kingdom with the might of their swords. He couldn’t bring himself to go back home as a failure, who couldn’t even lead his soldiers to victory. When the ship started to move, he spotted a beautiful island and when no one was noticing he silently jumped into the water and swam towards it. He waited in the shrubs until the ship disappeared and then climbed the tallest tree to see his new home. It was a beautiful place, untouched by civilization. He



realized that he was alone on that island. He was not unduly worried about it. He sat down at the base of the tree and thought about his future.

Suddenly he heard a screeching voice of a woman. He turned around to see a woman running through the woods with a wild bear on her heels. He ran after her with his heart beating and even as the bear neared her he threw his spear at it with unerring precision. The bear turned around to attack the youth and a fierce fight ensued between them. In the end, the youth killed the bear and stood panting with exhaustion. He searched for the woman whose life he had saved. He found her looking at him from behind a tree, her eyes expressing her happiness and surprise. Her looks and attire attested to the fact that she lived in the forest well away from the civilized world but it didn't diminish her beauty in any way.

To him, she seemed like the most beautiful woman in the world! Her beauty was so ethereal that he was afraid that she might vanish like a wisp of smoke. He neared her to ascertain whether she was real. She didn't vanish. However, she ran away. He followed her for a while but soon gave up when she outstripped him. Moreover, he didn't think it was seemly to follow a girl thus.

"She lives on this island. I will see her again for sure. Where can she go?" he said to himself and went near the beach and lay down under a tree. His surmise was right.

She came back soon, along with an old man. He learned that the old man was a fisherman who belonged to the Karaiyar<sup>[114]</sup> community and he lived in one of the many islands that lay near Ilangai and the girl was his daughter. He also learned that earlier when he lay hidden behind the shrubs watching the ship leave, the bear had crept behind a tree and was poised to attack him. The girl who had seen all this from a distance had shouted to warn the youth about it. After learning that the girl had saved his life, the youth thanked her most eloquently but the girl did not respond. Instead, her father acknowledged his thanks. This surprised him at first but when he

learned that the girl was deaf and mute, his regard and admiration for her grew.

As hours stretched into days, they became friendly with each other and she took him along to see the vast deserted stretches of beach on the lonely island. To him, she seemed like the most perfect woman created by God. Her inability to hear and speak didn't seem like a big hurdle to form an affection for her person. He learned to speak to her through signs and as days passed, he could intuitively discern her innermost thoughts from the expression of her beautiful eyes. He also noted that as a woman who lived in the forest, her sense of intuition was very high as she could sense danger or threat very easily. Life took on an easy routine for the youth and soon he began to consider that island as his home and found pleasure in her company.

Suddenly one day, the carefree life of the youth came to an end. A ship was sighted near the island and a few men came to the shore searching for him. From them, he learned that many calamities had befallen his family back home. His uncle had died most tragically in a war and his father was at death's door from his war wounds. His uncle who had no children was crowned the king, which resulted in him being the next heir apparent. The youth felt as if he was caught between two storms - on the one hand there was the call of duty and on the other, there was the girl who had stolen his heart. He gave precedence to duty. He could not roam around free and irresponsible when his family, kingdom and people were under imminent threat of war.

"I will come back soon. I will come back after fulfilling my duties," he promised her and left in the ship. She had not come forward to bid him goodbye. Shy and wary of strangers, she had stayed behind the tree where they had first met and watched him leave with sad eyes that haunted him to this day.

"Kundavai! I still remember her standing behind that tree watching me with her beautiful eyes brimming with unshed tears. I cannot

forget that scene no matter what. But there is one other scene that tears my heart to pieces. Shall I tell you about that?" he asked piteously.

Choked with emotion, Kundavai said, "Tell me, father."

## Chapter 17 - Can the Dead Haunt us?

Emperor Sundara Chola who was so long narrating the story in the third person now started telling it from his own perspective.

“My dear daughter! I am about to tell you things that a father wouldn’t normally tell his daughter. Only my dear friend Anirudhan knows about it but even he doesn’t know my present tormented condition. But I am determined to tell you everything. I think it is important that someone from our family know about this. I cannot talk about this to your mother. I have wanted to tell you about this for some time now. You will not laugh at my plight. Instead, you will try to heal my heart and fulfil my wishes. With this hope I will tell you the rest of my story.

“I left that island and came back home to Thanjavur. My grandfather was in residence in this palace. He was on his death bed. He was heartbroken. The great empire that he had built during the forty years of his reign was on the brink of collapse. His heir and crown prince Rajadhithar had died in the Thakkolam war. My father was gravely wounded in the same war and was dying. Kannara Devan’s<sup>[115]</sup> forces were advancing on the Chola Empire and the Pandya King was rebelling against us yet again. With our army crushed in Ilangai, many prominent commanders of the Chola army and their men died. The news about the kingdom’s defeat from all four corners had greatly affected my grandfather’s health. Despairing the loss of his men and army, he had lost his health and was frail and weak but he gained strength when he saw me. Right from my childhood, I had been his favourite grandson. He wouldn’t allow me to go anywhere away from him and I went to Ilangai only because I pestered him to let me go. When we lost the war and I disappeared, he left no stone unturned to find me. He never lost hope. He sent ship after ship scouting the Ilangai borders to see whether I have survived the war or not.

Finally, it was one of these scout ships that found me on that island. He found peace after I came back home by his side. Though his heart agonized over the loss of his children and his army, he truly believed that I would bring back the lost glory to the Chola Kingdom. Many astrologers were also responsible for this belief because they had predicted long back that despite having four sons, the reign of the kingdom would pass onto the grandson. Before he breathed his last, he said to me, "After my death, your uncle Gandarathidhar will ascend the throne and after him, you will get this kingdom. Only during your reign, this kingdom will attain its former glory. I am sure of it." Saying thus, he secured a promise from me that I would not rest until I have restored the pride of the Chola Kingdom.

I had the utmost respect and love for my grandfather. The day he passed away, I had decided to fulfil my promise to him at any cost. Despite my resolution to be the prince that my grandfather wanted me to be, I was disturbed. I couldn't forget the girl who had saved me from that bear on that island. What would happen to her? Can a deaf and mute woman of low-birth become the queen of the Chola Kingdom? Can she live in the palace? Won't my people laugh at me for even considering this? I kept thinking about this and found no solution to my dilemma.

My uncle Gandarathidhar then got married to Sembiyanmadevi soon after this. This was a new development that had the people pondering as to what would happen to me. My uncle was a widower for many years with no living heirs but now he was married. His second wife might give him sons of his own, who could ascend the throne after him. What would become of me, then? Many courtiers and officials were already discussing this openly and when my uncle came to know of this, he arranged for a grand celebration and along with his throne ascension he also crowned me as the crown prince."

"My dear daughter! Just as your brother Arulmozhi is the beloved of the Chola people today, I too was very popular during my younger days. When I was being anointed as the Crown Prince of the Chola Kingdom in the palace, thousands of people had gathered outside in

the streets, waiting to see and welcome the new king and the prince. Everybody wished that my uncle and I greeted the crowds together, so we stood there on the terrace. The crowds went ecstatic. They clapped and shouted cheers of encouragement. Everywhere I saw, there were cheerful faces. When everyone around me was so happy about becoming a crown prince, how could I brood over the fate of a woman who lived on a secluded island? Is it fair to disappoint so many people just to fulfil the promise that I made to that girl?

Pondering over this question, I looked at the faces of the people who were cheering me. There were many young men, women, old people, and children clapping their hands and cheering wildly whenever I looked in their direction. Suddenly amidst all these happy faces, I could see her sad and forlorn with her eyes brimming with tears. It was a wonder that I could see her face amidst thousand others. I couldn't tear my eyes away from her face and soon I could only see her, while the rest disappeared.

"People told me that I had fainted and my uncle cancelled the rest of the festivities because he thought that I was exhausted and asked me to rest. Later, I met my friend Anirudhan in private and asked him to search for the deaf and mute girl and bring her to me. Anirudhan searched all over Thanjavur but he couldn't find her instead he doubted whether I had indeed seen her at all. He said that I might have imagined her presence. I got angry with him and berated him for doubting me and for not finding her. 'What sort of friend are you when you can't even do such a small thing for me?' I said. I asked him to search the roads that led to Kodi Karai.

He dispatched men on horses and they went all the way to Kodi Karai in search of her. They found her living in the house of the caretaker of the lighthouse. To them, she seemed like a mad woman. She couldn't understand what they were trying to tell her and she refused to come along with them to Thanjavur. When I heard this news, I was distressed. I agonized over her for two days, unable to decide where my duty lay. I tried to forget her but couldn't. Finally, I decided to meet her. So along with Anirudhan, I travelled to Kodi

Karai on horseback. My dilemma increased as I neared my destination. 'What should I do after I meet her? Should I bring her back with me to the palace as the 'queen of the Chola kingdom'? How could I make a wild woman who lived in the forest as the queen of the realm?

"My dear daughter! Those days, I was also very popular for my handsome men. I never gave it much thought but people admired it so much so that they forgot my real name Paranthakan and had begun to call me 'Sundara Chola'. That too became a cause for my confusion. How could I bring a woman who knew not how to dress or behave socially to a palace? She wouldn't know what to do. If I can't bring her to the palace, what should I do with her? With these and hundred other questions raging through my mind, I reached Kodi Karai and learned something truly horrific. The deaf and mute karaiyar girl<sup>[116]</sup> had solved my dilemma by killing herself!

Right after the day when my soldiers had met her, she had climbed to the top of the lighthouse and had thrown herself down headlong towards the raging sea. It was an Amavaasai<sup>[117]</sup> night and the tides were extremely high and the fishermen there couldn't even find her body.

When I learned about her fate I felt an excruciating pain in my heart. But after some time, I gained some measure of peace. I was free from the dilemma of what to do with her? I came back to Thanjavur with a heart that was alternatively sad and yet peaceful. I found relief by aiding my uncle with royal affairs and went to war with our enemies and secured the borders of the kingdom. Then I got married to your mother and was fortunate to have you as my daughter.

My dear daughter! Even after so many years, I am unable to forget her. I dream about her. In my dreams, I see her standing on that lighthouse and the raging sea and then she falls headlong to end her life. While I never saw her do it in the real life, my mind has imagined it over a hundred times and recreated it in my dreams. There were many nights when I woke up screaming and sweating. So many

nights, your mother would wake up to my screams, asking, 'What is it? What happened?' Every time I would give her some tale of a deadly battle or some imaginary story to pacify her. As years passed, this horrible dream too became a rare event and I stopped thinking about her. But my hopes were in vain. Truly, it is the dead people who are crueller to us than the living. Kundavai! That woman's spirit hovers around me all the time. She comes to me, blaming me for her death.

My dear daughter! Do you believe that spirits of the dead people can haunt us to seek revenge?"

After asking this question, Sundara Chola looked fixedly at some distance. Kundavai turned around and saw in the same direction but there was nothing there but his terrified eyes and shivering body alarmed her to the point of tears. Burying her face in her father's chest, she cried. After a while, his shivering subsided as he tried to console her. "Father! You have kept this horrible secret within the depth of your heart and suffered for so long! That's why your health has declined. Now that you have told me everything, I am sure your health will improve."

Sundara Chola laughed disbelievingly at her statement and said, "My child! You do not believe me. You do not believe me when I say that the spirit of that deaf and mute woman is haunting me. Yet, she stood there, eying me with venom right behind that lamp. I saw her standing there, just as I can see you sitting here with me. If what I saw was my hallucination, then how could your friend see it too? What did Vanathi tell you? I am sure she saw something too. That's why she fainted. Kundavai! Bring her to me. I want to ask her."

"Father! Vanathi is a faint-hearted girl. I can't imagine how she came to be born in the brave Vellar clan. She gets scared even if sees a pillar in the night and falls into a dead faint. There is no use asking her anything. I am sure, she has not seen anything."



“Is that so? Kundavai! Listen to me. I never thought I would believe in ghosts or spirits. I always dismissed the vision of that deaf and mute woman as my own imagination or hallucination. Do you remember that day when Arulmozhi almost drowned in Ponni river? Don’t you remember how a woman suddenly appeared holding him? She disappeared without a trace after that. Do you remember how everybody in the palace wondered about it? Everybody decided that river goddess Ponni saved him that day. But do you know whom I saw that day? That deaf and mute woman holding Arulmozhi! I fainted then too. While everyone thought that I was alarmed and worried about the child, the real reason was that woman. I saw the ghost of that woman holding him and that’s why I fainted.

“My dear daughter! Do you remember the day we anointed your brother as the Crown Prince of Chola Kingdom? That day after the ceremonies, I took him to the andhapuram<sup>[118]</sup> to get blessings from your mother, grandmother and other womenfolk. I saw her ghost there again, standing there bedecked with jewels and staring at my son, murderously. I fainted once again. Later, when I thought about it, I wondered endlessly. Why should the ghost of that woman look at my son angrily? I dismissed it yet again as my hallucination. But ever since I have come to Thanjavur, I am convinced that I am seeing her ghost. There was a time once when she was alive when I could understand every single unspoken word of hers, just by looking at her eyes. I am able to understand her very well now. Every time she appears in front of me, she gives me a warning.

“She says, ‘You killed me, I forgive you for that but don’t commit a sin, yet again. Do not try to usurp the kingdom that should rightfully belong to somebody else.’ This is what she is trying to say. I am sure of it. My dear daughter! Only you can help me with this. I don’t want the throne of this accursed kingdom for my sons. Let us give it to Madhuranthakan!”

Kundavai interrupted him and asked, “Appa! What are you saying? You anointed my brother as the Crown Prince after getting the

approval of everyone. How can we change it now? Will the people agree?"

"Kundavai! We can't be looking at the people's approval for everything. We need to follow our dharma and do the right thing. I committed a big mistake by becoming the emperor of this kingdom. I have often felt that I had seized something that was not mine in the first place. Rightfully, I should have crowned Madhuranthakan and made him the emperor. Assuming the kingship was a mistake and I am repenting for it now. Let this kingdom pass away from my sons. Let them not become prey to the curse that comes along with it. I wish to crown Madhuranthakan while I am alive and then I can peacefully go to the golden palace that Karikalan has built in Kanchi and die happily.

"Appa! Periya Piratti Sembiyanmadevi must agree to this."

"Kundavai! That's where I need your help. Bring my aunt here to Thanjavur. Her knowledge and piety are boundless yet she refuses to do the right thing. It was she who forced me to ascend the throne. And I don't know why she is so angry with her only son that she refuses to let him ascend after me. This act of hers is so unnatural in a mother. When Madhuranthakan himself was saying that he wished to immerse in religious activities, it was excusable. But now he has changed his mind and wants to ascend the throne and yet she refuses."

"Appa! It is not enough to have the desire to rule the kingdom. One needs to have the capability too."

"How can you doubt the capability of the son born to my uncle, who was a just and pious king and the noblest and devout woman in the kingdom?"

"Fine. What about the people? Don't you think we need the people's acceptance?"

“If you ask the people of this kingdom, they will ask you to crown your brother Arulmozhi as the next king. Would that be fair? Do you think your brother will agree to this? These arguments won’t work Kundavai! Get your Periya Patti<sup>[119]</sup> to come here for any reason. If you want, you can even send her a message saying that I am at the death’s door.”

“That won’t be necessary appa! Patti wants to rebuild Thanjai Thalikulathaar temple. I will cite that as a reason to request her presence. Until then, please do not distress yourself by thinking about the past,” said Kundavai and left his presence.

On her way out, she saw her mother, Vanamadevi and said, “Amma! Please do not leave my father even for a second. Let the others do the puja that needs to be done.”

The audience with her father had cleared many of her doubts. She was now convinced about the fact that somebody was plotting against the kingdom and her family. She instinctively knew that her brothers and her father were under a grave danger and she was the only one who had realized this!

## Chapter 18 - What is the worst betrayal?

Those who have read the history of ancient Tamil Nadu would know that women played a very important role in the social affairs of the kingdom. This is true, especially of women belonging to the royal family. Royal women, princesses and queens had their own income and assets through lands, villages and pastoral property. They used the income through these assets in various ways. Some devout women used it to renovate and rebuild temples, while some donated huge sums to temples to light lamps, some donated food and shelter to mendicants and sages.

While most women spent their income on temples, Emperor Sundara Chola's daughter spent hers in a different manner. She used her income to open free medical clinics. With an intention of providing free medical service, she wanted to open clinics all over the Chola kingdom. We saw that she had established one such free clinic in Pazhaiaarai in the name of her grandfather. She had long wanted to provide the citizens of Thanjavur with a clinic in her father's name. She took the opportunity of her visit to the city to start this service on the auspicious day of Vijayadasami<sup>[120]</sup>.

Outside the Thanjavur fort, near Purampadi there was a Perumal Temple. Kundavai had arranged for festivities at the Garuda Mandapam of this temple to proclaim the grants that were being given for the clinic. People thronged there to participate in the festivities and to have a glimpse at their beloved princess. Important ministers and officials of the Chola court too attended the ceremony. Court scribes and stone inscribers were at hand to engrave the grants that were to be made to the clinic in stone edicts for posterity. Soldiers of the Thanjavur Fort Guard came in large numbers cheering and along with them came the Pazhuvur brothers resplendent atop elephants. Prince Madhuranthakan too came along with them perched on a shifty white horse seemingly uncomfortable with his mount. Princess Kundavai, Vanathi and many other royal

women were in their palanquins, while the Pazhuvur queen was in hers.

Seated in a separate enclosure made of sheer silk, Princess Kundavai and other women watched the inaugural ceremony, which began at the signal of Periya Pazhuvetarayar. The ceremony began auspiciously with a Devaram song ‘Mandiramavadu neer’<sup>[121]</sup> rendered by court singers accompanied by the yazh, and mathalam<sup>[122]</sup>. Their sweet voices brought on a silence and engrossed the audience completely.

However, there was some faint whispering in the women’s enclosure. The Pazhuvur queen and Kundavai were conversing in low tones. “Princess! There was once a time when Sambandha Perumal sang this beautiful song and cured the Pandya king with just his thiruneer<sup>[123]</sup>. Why do you think this song does not work the same for others today? Even the thiruneer has lost its power so people have to resort to other medicines like herbs, roots and odd potions.”

“Very true rani! In those days, dharma was upheld by all. That’s why Sambandhar’s song held the power to cure the emperor. But today, people commit sins without any conscience. For instance, there are people who plot and commit treason against their own emperor these days. That’s why Sambandhar’s song and the thiruneer have lost its potent magic.” Saying thus, Kundavai looked at Nandini trying to discern her thoughts through her reaction.

There was no reaction on Nandini’s face. “Is that so? Are there people who plot against the emperor? Who are they?” she asked innocently.

“That’s what I am trying to find out. Some try to blame others while the other try to blame somebody else. I am finding it tough to glean the truth out of it. That’s why I have decided to stay here for a while. How will I find the truth if I stay in Pazhaiaarai?”

“That’s a good decision, Princess. If you ask me, it would be best for you to stay here and sort things out. I can help you too if you stay and so will the guest who is staying in my house.”

“Who is this guest?” asked Kundavai.

“His name is Kandanmaran. He is the son of Kadambur Sambuvarayar. Have you met him? He is a tall young man who keeps muttering ‘spy’, ungrateful friend’ and ‘betrayal of trust’ all the time. A moment ago, you spoke about raja dhrogam<sup>[124]</sup>. What do you think is the worst betrayal of all?”

“I think that the worst betrayal that anybody could do is to break the heart and trust of a man who has sworn to protect you. A wife who betrays the trust of her husband is surely worse than those who commit royal treason.” Saying this Kundavai yet again waited for some reaction from Nandini but there was none to be had.

Unfazed, Nandini replied, “Very true Princess but Kandanmaran will not agree. He will say that the worst betrayal of all is the betrayal of a friend. Did you know that he was stabbed in the back by someone who he had considered his closest friend?”

“Who is that? Who is capable of doing such a foul deed?”

“Someone called Vandiya Devan it seems. He belongs to a place called Thiruvallam that his ancestors ruled once upon a time. Have you heard about him?”

Kundavai bit her teeth in seething frustration and said, “Seems a bit familiar to me. What happened next?”

“This Vandiya Devan ran away after stabbing his friend in the back. My brother-in-law sent his soldiers to catch the spy.”

“Do we know for sure that he is a ‘spy’?”

“How will I know that? I only know what Kandanmaran says. Why don’t you come and talk to him?”

“I will. I had heard that his injuries were dangerously grievous. Has he been staying at your palace for some time now?”

“Yes. They brought him to my palace right after the day he was stabbed. It fell upon my head to cure him. His wound was very deep and has not fully healed.”

“It is quite surprising that he is not fully healed despite the loving care that you must have showered on him. Rani! I will come and meet him for sure. His father and their clan have rendered many services for the Chola Kingdom right from the time of Emperor Paranthaka I.”

“That’s why I called you. At least on the pretext of meeting Kandanmaran, you will visit our poor little palace.”

At the end of this conversation, the Devaram song ended and the court scribe read out the grants that were to be given to the clinic. As with all royal documents, it began with Emperor Sundara Chola’s great deeds and that of his ancestors. At the end of it read, “The village named Nallur Mangalam whose deeds were drawn up in the name of our beloved daughter Kundavai Piratti will henceforth be declared as an iraiilli<sup>[125]</sup> village. The income from this village will henceforth be used for the Thanjai Purampadi medical clinic.” After reading the olai, the royal scribe handed it over to Periya Pazhuvetarayar, who received it with due ceremonies and gave it over to his tax official.

After this, Kundavai’s grants for the medical clinic that were inscribed on a stone edict were read out aloud. “The lands of the village Nallur Mangalam will henceforth belong to the villagers. Instead of the tax that they have to pay to the kingdom, the villagers under the leadership of their village head man must deliver 200 bags of rice every year. They should also deliver 50 padi cow’s milk and goat’s

milk and hundred coconuts every day to the clinic.” Meticulously inscribing all the details, the court scribes had also engraved the names of those officials who had written the deeds.

After reading the grants aloud, the court official presented the engraved stone edict and the deeds to the village headman of Nallur Mangalam, with due ceremony. The villagers placed the stone edicts atop an elephant that was richly decorated to carry around their village proudly.

The audience gave a resounding cheer and shouted “Long live Sundara Chola Chakravarthi” “Long live the Slayer of Veera Pandiyan, Crown Prince Adithya Karikalan” “Long live Prince Arulmozhivarmar” “Long live Princess Kundavai.”

While there was a loud echo to these cheers when the Pazhuvur soldiers shouted “Long Live Pazhuvur Devar Periya Pazhuvetarayar!” “Long live the Commander of Thanjai Fort, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar!” there was almost no response from the crowd.

Smug with this blatant display of public opinion, Kundavai wanted to see Nandini’s face to discern some truth from her expressions. However, she was disappointed (which was just as well) because if she had seen her face when the crowd was cheering the Crown Prince, she would have been frightened.



## Chapter 19 - The Spy is Captured

Periya Pazhuvetarayar was irritated beyond words at the end of the festivities that day. The event had ultimately bolstered the popularity of the emperor and his children and had become a stage where it was evident as to how unpopular he and his clansmen had become.

“These people! When will they grow brains? Worthless creatures!” he ranted. “By the time the emperor is dead, I am sure the kingdom will be thoroughly ruined! ‘Make this village tax free! Let’s not collect taxes from them.’ If we persist thus, there would no village in the Chola Kingdom that would pay any tax. But I am supposed to get money somehow to pay for the army and the supplies to Ilangai. Where will I send it from?” he shouted.

“Anna<sup>[126]</sup>! There is no point in shouting about all this now. Let us wait patiently until the right time comes,” said his brother, trying to pacify him.

To add to his irritation, he learned that Princess Kundavai was expected in his palace that day. He immediately went to Nandini and asked, “What is this that I am hearing? Why did you call that woman to our palace? Have you forgotten all the insults and slights that she has given you?”

“I never forget anybody’s insult and nor do I forget those who have supported me. You still haven’t understood me, if you are asking this question.”

“Then, why is she coming here?”

“That’s her wish and will. She is the daughter of the emperor. She is a princess. She can do whatever she wants.”

“But I heard that you invited her.”

“I didn’t invite her. She invited herself. “I heard that Sambuvrayar’s son is in your palace. I want to see him,” she said. Now can I say ‘Don’t come’? One day I might be able to do that. Until then, I have to wait on her thus.”

“I cannot and will not wait on her. I don’t want to be here when she comes to this palace. And what’s more, I don’t even want to be in this city. I have some work in Mazhapadi<sup>[127]</sup> today, I will attend to that.”

“That’s a good thing, my Lord! Let me deal with this snake. I know how to counter her poison. However, when you come back, don’t be startled if you hear some unexpected news.”

“What kind of unexpected news?”

“That Kundavai is to marry Kandanmaran or that Aditya Karikalan is to marry Kandanmaran’s sister.”

“What are you saying? If these things happen then what will happen to our plans?”

“Don’t panic. Just because someone is talking about this doesn’t mean that it would actually happen. For instance, you have been telling everyone that Madhuranthaka Devar would be the next king but is that really going to happen? Are we really working so hard to crown that effeminate creature?” asked Nandini and shot a seductive glance at her husband.

Overcome with emotion, the Pazhuvur lord took her hand in his and lovingly touched his eyes and said, “My love! I solemnly promise that you will be the queen of this realm soon.”

.....

Ever since Kandanmaran heard that Kundavai was coming to see him, he had grown not only nervous but also restless. Kundavai’s

intelligence, grace and beauty were well known everywhere. On one hand, he felt very gratified and proud that she was coming to meet him. He wouldn't have minded a few more bruises and injuries if they would make a Princess like Kundavai want to come and visit him.

But he also felt ashamed lying abed injured in the back, stabbed by a friend turned foe. "Why did I have to get injured in this manner? Why couldn't I have been injured in a battle?"

It would indeed have been a proud moment then but instead, she has to come and express regrets over a stab wound given by that scoundrel and that too in the back!

He also felt guilty about the role he was playing in the conspiracy against Kundavai's family. Kandanmaran was a good-natured man, but he was also very naïve about many things in life. While he was enamoured by Nandini's seductive beauty, he was also constantly aware of the fact that she was a married woman. But Kundavai was not married and he found himself getting nervous about how to speak to her.

Should I speak to her normally or should I try to hide my true feelings and talk what is expected of me? Should I act as if I am enamoured by her beauty? What if I forget my oath and become truly besotted with her? No! That will not happen! I might as well say something foolish and drive her away before letting that happen.

With over a hundred thoughts speeding through his mind, Kandanmaran's resolution to act foolish vanished the minute he saw Kundavai. Her enchanting beauty, inherent goodness and sincere concern acted like a medicine on him. Wanting to create a good impression he told her all the great things that he had achieved in the battle against their enemies though he unsuccessfully tried to sound falsely modest about it. He also showed her the wounds that he had got while fighting for the kingdom at the border and regrettably added "I don't really mind him hurting me thus but I can never forgive him for stabbing me on the back. Now I am forced to

explain his treachery to everyone or else I might be branded as a coward who was escaping from the battlefield.”

Kandanmaran’s emotional outburst seemed very genuine to Kundavai and for the first time since she met Vandiya Devan, a germ of doubt grew in her mind.

Did Vandiya Devan truly stab his friend? Did he fool me with his story?

She bid Kandanmaran to tell her all about their fight and he gave free rein to his imagination, so much so that even Nandini was surprised by it.

“Devi, Vandiya Devan was fooled on the day he arrived at our palace in Kadambur. He never told me why he was going to Thanjavur. He gained entry into the fort through a fake emblem ring and has met the emperor. He also lied about bringing a message from the Crown Prince. And, is that all? No, he has also involved your name in this by saying that he has got a message for you! Our Fort Commander tried to hold him under guard here to verify his stories but he escaped. I can’t help but admire his cleverness there. I didn’t believe that he could be a spy. Though I know that he is not straightforward or honest, I still couldn’t believe that he could be a spy. I thought that he must have done some harmless mischief by interfering in some unwanted business. I begged the Fort Commander to forgive him and vowed to find him. I didn’t take along any soldier with me, as I didn’t wish to shame him.

“My instinct told me that he would somehow find his way out of the fort through the Vadavatri River and I was right. I saw him jumping down from the high walls of the Thanjai Fort. I went to him before he ran off again and asked, “My friend! What have you done?” Instead of replying that treacherous cheat started striking me.

“I couldn’t bear the fact that he would attack someone who had come all the way to help him. I attacked him too. And soon we were rolling

on the ground wrestling. After struggling for half an hour, he yielded and I asked him, "Why did you come here? Tell me the truth!"

"Slyly he said, "I am tired. Let us sit and talk." I agreed so we got up and tried to walk towards the bank of the river. I was walking in front of him when he suddenly pounced on me again with a dagger in hand. The last thing I remember is that I fell down and when I woke up next I was in the house of a deaf and mute woman."

Listening intently to his story, Nandini laughed in her head while keeping a serious expression on her face. Kundavai, however, was confused. She couldn't decide what to believe or whom to believe.

"How did you end up in that deaf and mute woman's house? Who took you there?"

"That's a mystery that I haven't solved yet. That woman didn't know anything and we couldn't understand what she was trying to tell us. She had a son it seems but ever since that night he too has disappeared. I will have to either wait for him to return or wait until the Pazhuvur soldiers capture my friend and then ask him about it."

"Do you really think that they will capture him?"

"I am sure of it. Where else can he run? That's why I am still waiting here. I wish to plead for his life with the Pazhuvur Lord and hope that he gets a pardon."

"Ayya! You have the most generous heart," said Kundavai but in her heart, she whispered, "They should never capture him even if he was a treacherous traitor."

Suddenly, one of Nandini's handmaidens came inside hurriedly with a message, "Amma! They have captured the spy. They are dragging him through the streets!"

The minute they heard this, both Nandini and Kundavai looked startled, horrified and miserable. Nandini however quickly brought a calm look on her face but Kundavai couldn't.

## Chapter 20 - Two Tigresses

When Nandini's handmaiden announced about the spy being captured, all present in the room became restless. Kundavai's anxious heart grew more worried when she heard that the soldiers were dragging the spy through the streets of Thanjavur.

"Devi! Shall we go and see this cunning spy?" asked Nandini.

Kundavai hesitated and said, "Why should we bother?"

"Alright," said Nandini and sat down with a smile.

"I am going to see this spy," said Kandanmaran and got up slowly from his bed.

"Don't. You cannot walk that far. You will fall and hurt yourself again."

Restless and anxious, Kundavai had to accede defeat when she said, "Let us go and see how his friend looks like. Can we watch the streets from the terrace upstairs?"

"Yes, we can. Please come with me," said Nandini and got up.

"Devi! If it is my friend, I wish to petition mama (Periya Pazhuvetarayar) to meet him in the prison," Appealed Kandanmaran.

"How will we know whether he is your friend or not?" asked Nandini.

"If that is so, then I will come along with you," he said and hurriedly got up from the bed and followed them with unsteady legs.

On the terrace, Nandini led them both to a small balcony overlooking the streets of Thanjavur. A group of horsemen on a slow trot were approaching and they appeared to be dragging a man bound by

ropes in the middle. The horsemen in the front and the back held his ropes and were dragging him slowly through the streets of the city. Looking from the balcony with her heart in her mouth, Kundavai waited impatiently for the horsemen to near Periya Pazhuvetrayar's palace. At first, they couldn't discern the face of the captured spy who was being dragged ingloriously amidst taunts and disgrace through the streets. Kundavai's anxious eyes scanned through the crowds to see the prisoner while Nandini was busy looking at the street and alternatively noting Kundavai's reaction to the events that were unfolding before them. Kandanmaran relieved their tension when he declared, "No. This is not Vandiya Devan," and Kundavai let out an audible sigh of relief.

By then, the soldiers had come near the palace and their prisoner looked up and Kundavai recognized him as the son of Pazhaiaarai's physician. Though she was relieved that the captured spy was not Vandiya Devan, she was nonetheless incensed when she realized that Pazhuvur soldiers had captured her messengers. "What is this madness? Why did these soldiers capture the son of Pazhaiaarai's royal physician?"

Even Pinagapani<sup>[128]</sup> had recognized the princess on the terrace and tried to say something but he was dragged by the soldiers, away from the gaze of the royal onlookers.

"Is that so Devi? I have always said that my brother-in-law's soldiers are totally incompetent."

"I knew all along that they wouldn't have caught my friend. He was clever enough to outwit me. He would have surely escaped," said Kandanmaran.

"You still call him your friend?" asked Nandini

"What to do? He has turned a traitor yet I feel sorry for him," said Kandanmaran to which Nandini said, "These soldiers might have killed your friend. They went in pursuit of two people all the way to



Kodi Karai. Maybe they killed one of them and brought the other for a trial,” said Nandini with a satisfied smile fully aware of how torturous, Kundavai found her assertions.

Smiling complacently Nandini thought, “My dear headstrong princess! Now I have the perfect weapon to torture you and I will not hesitate to use it.”

Kundavai’s anguish took the form of anger and she lashed out at Nandini’s brother-in-law, “Spies! These old men have become more senile than ever if they see spies everywhere. It was I who sent Pinagapani to Kodi Karai to bring medicines for my father. How dare they capture and drag my messenger through the streets like he is some common thief? I am going to ask your brother-in-law for an explanation.”

“Devi, you sent this man to Kodi Karai? I suspected that it would be so. Did you send only Pinagapani to Kodi Karai or somebody else along with him?”

“I sent another person along with him and he was to go to Ilangai to bring more medicines for my father.”

“Aha! Now I understand everything. It is just as I suspected,” said Nandini triumphantly.

“I do not understand your meaning. What did you suspect?”

“Devi! The man that you sent along with Pinagapani, was he known to you?”

Kundavai hesitated a bit and said, “He was known to me. He had brought my brother’s message from Kanchi.”

“It’s him! It’s him.”

“Him who?”

“He is the spy. He came here too saying that he has a message from your brother for the emperor.”

“Why do they suspect him to be a spy?”

“How will I know about that Devi? Maybe he acted suspiciously and that’s probably why my brother-in-law’s soldiers are after him. If he were not guilty why would he escape from the Fort and hurt poor Kandanmaran on the way.”

“I do not believe that he stabbed Kandanmaran. If he had indeed stabbed him, then why did he save his life?”

“Devi! You are talking as if you were right there when Kandanmaran was stabbed. It looks like this spy has earned your confidence. But what is done is done. I am sure these soldiers would have killed him.”

Kundavai broke into a cold sweat as she tried to control her anguish. “That would never happen, never.” She told herself and countered Nandini with a question, “What if this spy is as clever as he says he is?” pointing towards Kandanmaran.

“Yes, Princess. I don’t think he is dead. He would have escaped surely.”

“If not now, he will be caught one day for sure.” said Nandini

Kundavai almost ground her teeth and said, “Who can predict the future indeed?” and then continued angrily, “I can’t bear to see the kingdom falling apart thus. How dare they catch the messengers that I had sent and brand them as spies? Who gave them this right? I am going to report this outrage to my father.”

“Devi! Please do not disturb your ailing father about this small matter. Why don’t you directly ask my brother-in-law? Maybe he didn’t know

that they were your messengers. If he knew they were your men, I am sure this wouldn't have happened, after all, there is no one in this kingdom who would go against the wishes of their beloved Princess."

Nandini had won this round of the battle of wits and words and emerged a victor while Kundavai was left to lick her wounds in private.

## **Chapter 21**

### **The Dungeons**

Life is a mystery. Sorrow, pain, anguish, happiness, contentment and peace are a part of this mystery. For some, life is an endless canvas of joy and happiness with nary a dark cloud on the horizon but when fortunes change, dark clouds gather and a fierce storm blows through their life. Kundavai felt as though she was living through such a storm.

For many years, life was a happy dream for her. Her parents, brothers, relatives, friends and her people cherished her. It was an endless stream of happiness, contentment and gracious living but sadly, even Princesses were not exempt from troubles and life. One after another, she had been facing innumerable problems for some time.

Her father's health was worrisome and his mental anguish was a cause of worry. While her brothers were away from the capital, the noblemen who had pledged their sword and fealty to her father were busy plotting to crown her uncle. There were rumours and whispers of an unknown danger that would soon overwhelm the kingdom. A comet had been seen in the sky heralding a period of doom and catastrophe. Astrologers and wise men of the kingdom were seen debating and discussing the disasters that would come upon them, while the common people were disturbed by the ill omens that were seen around them.

Kundavai was iron-willed and none of these would have troubled her much. Born in a dynasty of great warriors and wise rulers, she had enough wisdom to solve challenging problems on her own. But something unexpected had happened. She met someone and her heart that was hitherto untouched, experienced love. They had no time to explore their feelings for each other. Their time together was

shrouded with danger and secrets and their love seemed like a flower that would be plucked even before it could bloom.

Troubles and tribulations multiplied for Kundavai after meeting her homeless prince and her heart experienced an anguish that was alternatively new and painful for her. She couldn't bear the pain that was caused by the words, 'Vandiya Devan might be arrested' and when Nandini said that her soldiers might have killed him, it took all the self-control that she possessed to remain calm.

Nandini's poisoned words hurt her so much that she was surprised by it. Could it be possible that her regard for this orphaned soldier surpassed the love she had for her parents, brothers and friends? There was no time to think or debate about these things. She had to find out what happened to that brave soldier she had sent to Ilangai.

That afternoon, right after she had met Nandini and Kandanmaran, she sent a message to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar about visiting his palace. On her arrival, the royal women of Pazhuvur clan invited her respectfully in their midst. After conversing with them for a while, the princess went to the chithira mandapam<sup>[129]</sup> where Chinna Pazhuvetarayar was waiting for her. He showed her around the mandapam proudly explaining the brave feats that his ancestors and forefathers had performed in the service of their kings.

After looking at all the paintings, Kundavai said, "Ayya! Undoubtedly the Pazhuvur clan has performed many great deeds for this kingdom..."

"Princess! We are ready to serve our kings with our life."

"and undoubtedly this kingdom would be the apt prize for such service...."

"Noble Princess! What are you saying?"

“Nonetheless, you could have waited until my father’s demise to seize power.”

It was evident that Kalanthaka Kandar<sup>[130]</sup> was shaken by Kundavai’s words as his face reflected shock, guilt and surprise. Drops of sweat came upon his brow and he chided himself for acting nervous with a young girl like Kundavai.

“Princess! Why are you saying such things? Why are you so angry with me? Do you plan to send me to Yama’s abode with such words?”

“Ayya! They say that even Lord Yama trembles to approach the great Kalanthaka Kandar. Dare I hope that my words have such power? I am but a helpless woman here.”

“Princess! I am shaken to hear such words from you. What folly of mine has angered you thus?”

“My Lord! Who am I to talk about your follies? You need to tell me what mistake I have committed in wanting to cure my father? I sent two men to Kodi Karai to fetch medicinal herbs for my father, could that perhaps be my mistake?”

“Noble Princess! How could that be a mistake?”

“My Lord! Am I wrong in assuming that you knew that it was I who sent the Pazhaiaarai physician’s son to Kodi Karai?”

“No Princess. I knew about it.”

“Today, I saw your soldiers dragging him towards the dungeons. Undoubtedly all this happened with your knowledge and your express commands, even when you knew that it was I who had sent him.”

“Yes, Princess but you could have been taken in by that young man. I fear that you sent them on this noble task without knowing that they were spies.”

“Do you want me to believe the story that our Pazhaiaarai’s physician’s son is a spy?”

“My princess! What if he accepts to being a ‘spy’?”

The commander’s words startled the princess, “What do you mean he has accepted? What has he accepted?”

“He has accepted the fact that his companion was a spy and that he had not come to Kodi Karai to fetch herbs instead he was going to Ilangai taking a message to someone.”

“The physician’s son is a witless fool. Whatever he says should not be considered seriously. It was I who sent his companion along with him.”

“Devi I knew that but I also know that he has fooled you. His name is Vandiya Devan and I know that he is a spy.”

“I do not believe that. He came from Kanchi as my brother’s messenger.”

“Princess! He got a message for the emperor too. Spies often use pretexts such as this to learn information.”

“Ayya! Do you have any evidence that proves that he is a spy?”

“If he is not a spy, then why did he travel through hidden paths instead of using the king’s road? Why did he go to Kudandhai Jodhidar and ask about your father’s horoscope?”

“Even I have asked the jodhidar<sup>[131]</sup> about my father’s horoscope.”

“You are his daughter. You have all the right to ask about your father’s horoscope. But it’s suspicious when someone who is unrelated to the family does so. In my experience, spies from the enemy kingdoms behave thus.”

“This is merely your surmise. Do you have other reasons?”

“Why didn’t he ask for my permission to enter the fort? Why did he show Pazhuvur emblem ring to gain entry and lie that he got from my brother?”

“How did he get the ring then?”

“I do not know yet. I intend to find out.”

“Why haven’t your soldiers found that out for you yet?”

“Noble princess! My soldiers are not magicians. They need to find the spy to learn where he got that ring from?”

“And how would you know whether he is telling the truth?”

“Devi! There are ways and means to make men talk. Our dungeons are proof enough for that. That’s why he escaped from this fort that night and on his way out he stabbed Kandanmaran on the back.”

“Is there any evidence that proves that he stabbed Kandanmaran?”

“Kandanmaran says that it was Vandiya Devan who did it.”

“His testimony is not enough. What if I say that he didn’t stab Kandanmaran?”

“Noble princess! You are talking as though you were standing next to him when he was stabbed.”



“Commander! I have sense enough to discern when a man is telling the truth and when he isn’t.”

“This spy is then indeed lucky. He has somehow hoodwinked you into believing his version of the story.”

“Ayya! Please do not call him a spy again in my hearing.”

“Princess! If he wasn’t a spy then why did he disguise himself as a street actor to enter Pazhaiaarai? Why did he travel to Kodi Karai in disguise? Why did he hide in the woods of Kodi Karai from my soldiers and take a boat to Ilangai in the dead of the night?”

“You are saying that he has escaped to Ilangai?”

“Yes, Princess! That spy is very ingenious. He escaped in a boat to Ilangai during the night and my soldiers couldn’t catch him. Instead, they captured the physician’s son,”

“Ayya! I do not care about this spy but the physician’s son is innocent. I request you to release him from the dungeons immediately,”

“But Princess, even if he was not a spy, he has helped the spy. He has been spinning many wild tales about his friend but I suspect that he has had a hand in helping him escape.”

“I do not care for such suspicions. I want you to release him from the prison immediately,”

“If that is your wish then I cannot take the responsibility. There are dangers lurking at every corner in this kingdom. Our enemies are waiting to march upon us. King Veera Pandian’s bodyguards have sworn a blood oath to kill the seed of the Chola kings. There is treason everywhere.”

“Ayya! If you were to imprison all those you suspect of treason, I am afraid you will run out of space in the dungeons.”

“We can fill it as much as possible.”

“I suggest that you leave some space for the real culprits. Please release the physician’s son,”

“Princess! I refuse to take on this responsibility.”

“Commander! Will you release him if you get the emperor’s orders? Or will you defy that too?”

“Noble Princess! I do not need emperor’s orders to do it; just the princesses’ word would suffice. Everyone knows that the emperor would never refuse you anything. Here is the key to the dungeons. You can free whomsoever you want from the prison and whatever consequences that follow these actions, will rest solely upon your noble head.”

Saying thus, Kalanthaka Kandar took out a large key from his waist cloth and handed it over with mock respect to Kundavai. Kundavai struggled to control her anger and received the key from him. “Alright Commander! Let the consequences rest on my head.”

“Calamities and disasters will come upon our kingdom only through two women.”

“I am one of them and pray who might be the other.”

“Pazhuvur Queen Nandini Devi.”

Despite her anger, she smiled and said, “You are placing me on par with the real power of the kingdom indeed. If Periya Pazhuvetarayar were to hear this, he might just banish you, my lord!”

“I would welcome it wholeheartedly!”

## Chapter 22

### Senthan Amuthan in Prison

The mint where the Chola kingdom made its coinage was as heavily guarded as the Thanjavur fort. That evening, Kundavai and Vanathi made their way through its heavily guarded corridors even as the goldsmiths were departing after a hard day's work. The guards checked each of the goldsmiths thoroughly before letting them leave. When the guards and the goldsmiths noticed the arrival of the princesses, they raised a cheer, "Long live Princess Kundavai!" The commander of the mint and the dungeons came hurriedly to welcome them. He showed them the smithy where the gold was melted and the moulds bearing the ensign of a tiger and the image of a ship. Mounds of freshly minted gold coins lay on one side and their glint caught the light of the lamps dazzling the onlookers.

"See Vanathi! For many centuries, gold has been coming to our kingdom from all our conquered lands. So long, it was the womenfolk who had to bear the burden of this gold as ornaments and trinkets. Thankfully that time is past now as our Dhanadhigari<sup>[132]</sup> started minting the gold into coins,"

"Akka! How do these coins help?"

"They are a big help to merchants and traders as they can now easily sell their wares for 'so many coins' instead of bartering them with something else. It is easy for the common people to pay their taxes instead of giving their produce. It is easy to trade with foreign kingdoms as the coins help to regulate our transactions. That's why our merchants and traders are indebted to Periya Pazhuvetarayar since he has eased their burden. It also helps in many other things especially to those who wish to plot against the emperor and his family. It is easy to buy treason with a bag of gold coins."

The commander of the mint who was standing next to her, heard this and said, “Yes Princess! We have heard of such rumours and that’s why we have increased the guards at this fort. That could be the reason why so many prisoners arrive and leave.”

“I know that Prisoners are coming quite frequently but I didn’t realize that they left too.”

“Yes. That has been happening too. This morning they brought a prisoner to shut in the dungeons and about an hour ago, he was released and taken away.”

“Who could that be?” wondered Kundavai.

The commander took them to the inner chambers of the fort through a small door. As they climbed down the steps to the dungeons, they could hear the blood-curdling growls of many hungry tigers. A guard stood at the end of the steps with a flaming torch to show the way. In the light of the fire, they could see many cages with tigers locked up in them. Some were prancing around majestically, while some were lying down.

Kundavai held Vanathi’s hand tightly and whispered, “Vanathi! Are you frightened? Please do not faint away here, it would be very difficult to revive you.”

Vanathi gave a faint smile and said, “How could I be frightened of tigers, akka? They are the protectors of our clan!”

“Do you know when our protectors join our enemies, they become more dangerous than ever.”

“No akka! Human protectors might do that but these tigers will never turn against us,”

“We can’t say that for sure. These tigers have tasted the flesh of many traitors and that might give them an itch to turn against us.”

Vanathi shivered when she heard these words despite the bravado that she had put up for Kundavai.

“Akka! What are you saying? Do these guards feed the prisoners to these tigers?”

“No! The dungeons have only one door. Anyone who enters has to go past these tigers to the prison below. If a prisoner plans to escape, he needs to come through this chamber and that’s when they become prey to the tiger’s hunger,”

“Shiva Shiva! That’s barbaric!”

“That’s how great kingdoms work. Compassion and cruelty are shown in equal measures here. You should have heard the way Chinna Pazhuvetarayar spoke to me today. I would not have been surprised if he had shut me in the dungeons with these tigers.”

“Akka! There is no one in these 14 worlds who wields power enough to shut you in the dungeons. If someone were to attempt it, the earth that we stand upon would split and swallow everything in its wake. I am a bit worried about our Pazhaiaarai physician’s son. Let’s hope that poor boy did not attempt to escape.”

“He is a poor boy indeed! But one can’t always be sure when people’s mind change.”

As they neared the chamber, the growls of the tigers increased as they noted the new visitors. Kundavai asked the guard, “Looks like the tigers are very angry today?”

“No Princess! They are growling thus to welcome their emperor’s daughter,”

Kundavai smiled at this clever retort and said, “That’s a nice welcome.”

“Moreover it is time for their feed.”

“In that case, we will leave soon enough. Where is the door to the dungeons below?”

The guard took them to the farthest corner of the dungeon and then moved the tiger cage. On the floor, there was a strong iron door, which required two strong guards to open. Built deep within the ground, there was no light save the torch that their guard carried. The dungeons were narrowly built and they had to go in a single file following the guard with the torch. The narrow path ended in a chamber filled with prison cells. Some had single prisoners while some shared a cell. Most of them were skin and bones and their sad sorry selves were pitiful to watch. Yet among these, there arose a soulful sweet voice singing -

“Ponnaar meniyane!  
Pulitholai araikkasaithu  
Minnaar senjadai mel  
Milirkondrai aninthavane!”

Oh Lord with a golden divine body,  
Draped with tiger skin  
and radiant cassia flowers adorning your  
dazzling red braided hair! Oh leader!  
Who is like a precious stone to us,  
The ruby who resides in Thirumazhapadi,  
Who is like a mother to us,  
if not you, about whom will I be thinking hereafter!

The cells in the dungeons were not built in order. They had to move around the chamber like a maze to look into each cell as the guard raised the fire torch. Some prisoners were left to roam in the cell free, while some were chained with iron. Noting this, Vanathi exclaimed, “Akka! This is very cruel indeed. So many prisoners shut down here? Didn’t these people undergo any trial?”

“These men are not ordinary prisoners Vanathi. They have committed treason against the emperor and the crown. Spies and people who help these spies are incarcerated in these dungeons. If they confess their crimes and tell the truth they are banished from the kingdom but most of them have nothing to tell. Their condition is quite pitiful, indeed.”

As they searched for the Pazhaiaarai’s physician’s son, they neared the cell where the prisoner was singing. They found a young man with a slight build in the cell. He was none other than our old friend, Senthana Amuthan.

His innocent looks and thoughtful eyes made them stop there for a while Kundavai asked, “You were the one who was singing?”

“Yes, Princess!”

“Looks like you are quite happy here.”

“There is no dearth of happiness for me here Princess! My God who is omnipresent is here with me in this darkest of the dungeons.”

“You speak like a wise man. Who are you? What were you doing outside?”

“I am not a wise man Princess. I used to present my Lord with flowers as my offering when I was outside. Since that’s not possible here, I am offering him songs.”

“Do you know only this one song or many others?”

“I know many others, Princess. But ever since I came here, I have been singing this song.”

“And why is that?”

“When they brought me here, I came through the mint and there I saw piles and piles of gold coins. The sheen and the glint of the gold reminded of my Lord Shiva who glows like gold. Hence the song,”

“You are lucky! It is easy to corrupt people with gold and fortunate are those who see the God in them. Do you have any relatives living outside?”

“My mother is there. She lives outside the Thanjavur Fort, where we have our garden.”

“What is her name?”

“Vaani Ammai”

“I will meet her and tell her that you are living happily here.”

“That would be useless Princess! My mother is deaf and mute.”

“Is that so? Is your name Senthana Amuthan?” asked Kundavai

“Yes. How is it that the princess knows my name?”

“Do you know why you have been imprisoned here?”

“I didn’t know about it until yesterday. I learned about it today.”

“What did you learn?”

“They have shut me here because I helped a spy to escape from the fort.”

“Who was this spy?”

“I met a traveller near the fort. He was looking for a place to rest that night so I took him to my home. I didn’t know that he would be branded a spy the next day.”



“Do you know his name?”

“His name was Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan. He said that he belonged to the old Vanar clan.”

Excited by his reply, Kundavai and Vanathi looked at each other. Vanathi asked Senthana Amuthan, “Tell us everything that happened after you met him.”

Senthana Amuthan told them all about their meeting and about Vandiya Devan’s return at the dead of the night bearing his wounded friend, Kandanmaran. And then he also described their flight from Thanjavur on the horse and the chasing Pazhuvur soldiers and his subsequent capture.

“Why did you help this stranger? It seems like he got you into a lot of trouble.”

“Devi, life is strange. I didn’t know Vandiya Devan very well but I liked him and trusted him right from the moment I met him. I would have sacrificed my life too if I had to save him from those murderous soldiers of Pazhuvetarayar. Then there are some we meet for a very little while and we feel like murdering them. The guards brought a prisoner today and shut him in this cell along with me. I couldn’t control the anger that I felt towards him. Thankfully, he got released by Pazhuvur queen’s men a short while ago.”

“Is that so?” said Kundavai. She bit her lips with her pearly white teeth and let out an angry sigh, “Do you know this prisoner’s name?”

“I don’t know his name but he is the son of a physician from Pazhaiaarai.”

“What did the physician’s son say to make you so angry?”

“He spoke ill of my uncle’s daughter, Poonguzhali who lives in Kodi Karai. That is why I got very angry. But he also gave me good news so I let him go.”

“What good news was that?”

“This scoundrel went to Kodi Karai along with my friend Vandiya Devan and he double crossed him and betrayed him to the Pazhuvur soldiers but my friend escaped.”

“He escaped? Are you sure about this?” asked Kundavai and Vanathi simultaneously.

“Yes, Devi. My cousin Poonguzhali took him on her boat across the sea to Ilangai and this fool got captured by the Pazhvur soldiers instead.”

Smiling with relief, Kundavai said to Senthana Amuthan, “If you are so happy because a spy escaped, then it is best that you stay imprisoned here in the dungeons.”

“Devi, if that is true, then you both should rightfully occupy the cell next to me.”

His witty reply elicited laughter from both the women. The sound of their mirth sounded as strange and out-of-place as Senthana Amuthan’s song.

“You are very clever indeed! If we leave you here, you might just corrupt the other prisoners with your songs. I will speak to the commander and get you released immediately.”

“Devi, Please do not do that. One of the prisoners here keeps telling me, ‘Teach me at least one song and I will tell you where I have hidden the Pandyan Crown and Indra’s pearl necklace<sup>[133]</sup> in Ilangai,’ I don’t want to leave this place before learning that secret.”

Smiling at his wit, Kundavai said, “So you want to be here until you become mad like the rest of them. What will happen to your mother then? Think about it.” and left with Vanathi. After an hour, the guards released Senthana Amuthan and escorted him out of the fort.

## **Chapter 23**

### **Nandini's Letter**

That evening, Nandini sat alone on a decorated couch shaped like a swan in her garden. She was writing a letter on the palm leaf olai. She would write a few words and then hesitate and stop. Sometimes her body trembled like a small leaf caught in a storm and despite the soothing cool winds blowing through the garden and she had a handmaiden with a peacock fan ministering to her while droplets of sweat appeared on her forehead.

“My prince, I write this letter after much deliberation and hesitation. I hear a lot of rumours about the kingdom, even as your father's ill health worsens every day. I also learned that you have refused to come here despite the summons that he has sent. I am tormented by the thought that you wouldn't come to Thanjavur because I live here. I believe that we could lay aside our differences if we could only meet once more. If you do not wish to come to Thanjavur, then can I request you to meet me at Kadambur Sambuvarayar's palace? Today, I am married to a noble lord whose age matches that of your grandsire and that makes me your grandmother. I see no impropriety in our meeting at Kadambur. I am handing this message to the brave prince of Kadambur, Kandanmaran. You can trust him completely and send a reply to me.

Unfortunate and unlucky Nandini.”

After completing the letter, she read it again and then turned to her handmaiden and said, “Go and fetch the prince of Kadambur.”

When Kandanmaran came, he found it difficult to meet Nandini's eyes. He looked down at his feet and somewhere aimlessly in the garden, unable to behold her mesmerizing beautiful visage.

“Ayya! Please sit down,” said Nandini. The slight tremor in her voice made him look at her face. Nandini continued with a smile, “I know that it would be difficult to see me with eyes that beheld and admired the beauty of the princess.” Her words pained Kandanmaran’s heart, while her smile encouraged him to say and do many foolish things.

He said, “A thousand Kundavai cannot match the beauty of one Nandini Devi.”

“Nonetheless, if Kundavai were to say the ‘word’, you would even travel to the heavens to bring her King Indra’s throne. But you won’t heed my word and seat yourself, would you?”

Kandanmaran immediately sat down on the stone bench opposite to her couch and said, “Devi, you just need to say the word and I would even go to Brahmalo<sup>[134]</sup> and bring one of the heads of the Lord Creator<sup>[135]</sup>.”

Nandini trembled at his words. She turned her head and said, “Lord Shiva left Brahma with four heads when he took one. Even if you take another head, at least he will have three more to live with.”

“Devi, I will listen to whatever you say but please do not talk about Princess Kundavai to me. I couldn’t stand the fact that she supported Vandiya Devan.”

“Still your flights of fancy were very impressive when you described the fight that you had with your friend.”

Nandini’s appreciation made Kandanmaran shy. He smiled foolishly and said, “I had to tell her something about how I met him, so I just allowed my imagination to take over but, in the end, he did stab me, so that was not a lie.”

“Ayya, I think it would be better if you could try to remember everything that happened that night.”

“Devi, do you doubt my word then?”

“No. I believe you but I think you have forgotten a few things that occurred that night. One day, our soldiers will catch Vandiya Devan and bring him here to stand trial for his crimes. Your testimony at the trial would be very vital and that’s why you need to make an effort to remember everything that happened that night.”

“I have no interest in that. I would like to forgive rather than condemn him to a life in the dungeons.”

“You have a forgiving heart. Nonetheless, I think it would be better if we could think back and decide among ourselves as to what happened that night. Do you remember what happened in the underground passage when you escorted Prince Madhuranthakan? Do you remember meeting me and Lord Pazhuvetarayar?”

“How could I forget meeting you, Devi? No memory is dearer to me than that.”

“If that is so, then you must also remember what you spoke on that occasion?”

“No. I remember meeting you that’s all. I can’t recall what I spoke.”

“Thankfully I do. This is what you said to my husband, ‘Ayya, I had heard many descriptions about your daughter but, now I realize that mere words cannot pay homage to her beauty’.”

“Ayyo! Did I really say that? No wonder he was red-faced with anger. Even now, I know that he does not like me much.”

Nandini laughed at him and said, “It does not matter if he dislikes you but you like him, don’t you?”

“Devi! There is no use in hiding the truth from you. I too dislike him very much.”

“That is fine. I like him. That should make up for everything I think. I am very fortunate that God gave me a husband like him.”

Kandanmaran looked a bit embarrassed at her frank admission.

“Do you remember what happened after you met us there?”

“I followed the soldier who guards the underground passage. He had a torch and he opened the door of the passage and waited for me to enter. I entered the passage and that’s when someone stabbed me. Vandiya Devan must have known that I would be coming that way and was probably waiting outside to attack me.”

“Ayya! Your surmise is wrong. He was not waiting outside.”

“Devi, you too believe that he is not a spy and a traitor.”

“No. He is a spy. But I know that he was not waiting outside the underground passage to attack you. I think he was waiting inside the passage.”

“But Devi, how is that possible?”

“You know that he vanished from the fort that day when my brother-in-law’s soldiers were searching for him. I suspect that he somehow entered the underground palace and learned all its secrets. He must have seen you there and followed you. That’s how you ended up stabbed in the back. Maybe he felt remorse at having hurt you so he left you at the house of the deaf and mute woman.”

“Devi, you are right. I have been thinking about this for so long and I couldn’t understand how he came upon me so suddenly. Devi, I have just realized that there are people who are very beautiful but are witless and there are those who are very intelligent but not pleasing to look upon. It is very rare to find wit and beauty in the same

person. Lord Brahma undoubtedly excelled himself when he created you.”

“Ayya, do you really mean these words or are you trying to flatter me?”

“Devi, I am not flattering you. I am merely stating the fact.”

“If that is so, will you do a task for me?”

“I will do anything that is within my powers to please you.”

“You will need to travel to Kanchi for me.”

“I would go to Kashi also if you ask it.”

“You don’t have to go so far. Just Kanchi is enough. I have a message for Prince Aditya Karikalan for you to deliver. And you will need to invite him as a guest to your palace in Kadambur.”

“Devi, what is this you are saying? Don’t you know the arrangement and the oath that your husband and my father have sworn?”

“Yes, I know but I also know many other things that these lords do not know. We are all at the brink of danger and sadly, no one seems to know about this, except me. Do you know who is responsible for it?”

“No Devi, please tell me.”

“The demoness who was here as our guest this afternoon is responsible.”

“Ayyo! Are you referring to Princess Kundavai?”

“Yes, I am talking about that snake. I know the venom that Kundavai is made of. Do you know, she has sent your friend, Vandiya Devan to



Ilangoi? And it is not for getting medicinal herbs for her father. She has no intention of saving her father from his ill health. After his demise, she wants the crown for her brother Arulmozhivarman. If he becomes the next king, she can rule the kingdom in his name as a 'queen'. And do you know who the 'king' would be? Your friend, Vandiya Devan."

"Aha! Devi, we have to stop this from happening somehow. Let us tell your Lord husband and my father."

"There is no use telling about this to them. They will not believe it. We need to counter Kundavai's moves through mine and it is not possible without your help."

"Devi, I am at your disposal. Command me."

"I want you to take this letter to Kanchi and hand it over to the prince carefully. Will you do that?" asked Nandini with her hand outstretched holding the letter and its metal case.

Rendered witless by her beauty and beseeching words, Kandanmaran instead of taking the letter, held her hand and said, "I will do anything for you."

At the same instant, they heard the sound of resounding steps that could only belong to Periya Pazhuvetarayar. Startled they turned towards the sound and saw him marching through the garden path towards them. A chained parrot was perched on a metal cage near the Lata Mandapam. With his anger matching his long strides, Pazhuvetarayar seized the parrot in hand and the poor bird, frightened out its wits gave a resounding shriek.

## **Chapter 24**

### **Wax in a Flame**

At first, they heard the screeching wail of the parrot and the gasp of the handmaiden, who was discreetly standing by the garden path. When Kandanmaran saw Periya Pazhuvetarayar striding towards them furiously with a screeching parrot in his hand, he trembled in all limbs.

What if he had heard their conversation, especially the part where he had said that 'he did not like Pazhuvetarayar'? What if he suspects him of trying to seduce his wife?

He had heard that old men who get married to younger women constantly suffer from doubts and insecurity and thereby making their and everybody else's life miserable.

Is that why this old man is very angry? Will he suspect that I have been having untoward thoughts towards his beautiful wife?

All these thoughts came and vanished in Kandanmaran's mind within a few seconds but little did he know that he would witness a very astonishing scene that day. When Pazhuvetarayar neared them, Nandini got up and welcomed him with a beautiful smile saying, "My Lord! I was afraid that you might be delayed. Thank God, you came back early."

Periya Pazhuvetarayar just had to hear her voice and see her beautiful smile and he transformed from a furious angry man into a tame cat! With a slight smile, he said, "Yes. My errand got completed sooner than I thought, so I returned immediately." He then looked at Kandanmaran and asked, "What is this boy doing here? Has he written a love poem in your honour?" and laughed at his little joke.

Kandanmaran's face reddened but Nandini laughed harder at her husband's joke and said, "My Lord, sadly, this boy doesn't know anything about love or about poems. He knows to fight and get injured. Now that he has healed, he wishes to go back home."

"What do I say about today's young men? I have seen 24 battles in my lifetime and proudly wear the 64 scars as a token of my bravery but never have I lain in the bed to recover from any of them. But then, I bore my wounds on my chest and shoulders while this boy got stabbed in the back. No wonder!"

Incensed by Pazhuvetarayar's remark, Kandanmaran said, "Ayya, you are like my father. If somebody else had said this, I would have..."

"Is that so? Show me what would you do if somebody else had said this," said Pazhuvetarayar and put his hand on his sword.

Nandini interfered and said, "My Lord! This boy is not only injured in the back but he has suffered a grievous wound to his heart. His friend's betrayal has hurt him very much and we should not say anything that would cause him more pain. We do know what really happened on the night he got hurt, don't we, My Lord?"

Pazhuvetarayar understood Nandini's meaningful look and said, "You are right Nandini. He is just a small boy. I will forget what he just said for his father's sake. Nandini! I have something very important to tell you. It's good that he is also here as it concerns him. In Ilangai, at Maandotham, our soldiers have caught a man suspecting him to be a spy. They found a message for Prince Arulmozhivarman on his person and along with that he also had our palm emblem ring. It looks like he might be Kandanmaran's dear old friend. That boy is very clever, or else he wouldn't have escaped our soldiers so easily."

Both the men didn't notice the slight change in Nandini's expression.

“What? He escaped and that too, to Ilangai?” cried Kandanmaran with disappointment.

“My Lord! I am not surprised by the fact that his friend escaped. I have said it often enough that your brother is not fit to command this fort. It is small wonder that his soldiers are as inept as their master.”

“When you used to say this, I thought you were wrong but now I think you could be right. Do you know when our soldiers in Ilangai interrogated this spy about our ring, he refused to answer them?”

Nandini sighed and said, “What game is this? How did he get our emblem ring then? What explanation does your brother give?”

“My brother? You will laugh when you hear what he has to say. He said that this spy might have got our emblem ring from you,” said Pazhuvetarayar and laughed out aloud.

Nandini laughed along with her husband and said, “I admit, there is none wiser than my brother-in-law in this entire kingdom.”

“Do you know what else he is saying? It truly makes for a good story! I can’t but laugh at his wild accusations! He says that this spy met you when you were coming to Thanjavur in your palanquin and that’s when you gave our emblem ring to him. He also says you met him at our palace on that day when our soldiers were searching for him everywhere. He says that either you should have given him the ring or it could have been the Mandiravadi, who comes to meet you. He is saying many such stories to hide his foolishness,” said Periya Pazhuvetarayar and laughed again. However, this time, Nandini did not join him in laughter.

“It was wrong of me to have doubted my brother-in-law’s cleverness indeed. He seems to have outdone himself. But I am surprised that you thought fit to listen to all this without defending my honour,” said Nandini her casual expression of good humour had changed within a second to anger.

Pazhuvetarayar immediately stopped laughing and tried to pacify her. The man, who once bore many grave wounds in countless wars, couldn't bear the thought of his young wife's anger!

"Devi, I did not listen to him quietly. I berated him for his foolishness most sternly. If you had been there, you would have felt sorry for him because my words almost reduced him to tears."

Kandanmaran felt embarrassed and wanted to leave. The domestic scene that he had witnessed made him pity Periya Pazhuvetarayar more than ever and also taught him to be wary of Nandini. He coughed a bit to gain their attention and said, "Ayya!"

Nandini looked at him and said, "We have forgotten this boy amidst the stories that my brother-in-law has been peddling. He wishes to go home and wants your permission to leave."

"He can leave immediately. His father is worried about him."

"I wish to give him an olai. Do I have your leave to do so?"

"Olai? To whom?"

"To the Crown Prince in Kanchi."

Pazhuvetarayar looked at Nandini and Kandanmaran with suspicion and said, "Olai for the Crown Prince? Have you written it? Why?"

"Kundavai wrote an olai for her younger brother and sent his friend to Ilangai. Then why can't I write to the older brother and send him to Kanchi?"

"How do you know that the olai that his friend is carrying is written by Kundavai?"

“Then why do you think the Mandiravadi comes to meet me? I learned this through his sorcery. Now that we know how good my brother-in-law’s soldiers are, we do need his help. They told you that the spy was caught with our emblem ring, my lord but they didn’t tell you that Kundavai wrote the olai that he was carrying.”

“I didn’t hear this from my brother’s soldiers. I got this news from our Prime minister Anirudha Bhramarayar who was in Ilangai a few days ago.”

“Did that wily Brahmin tell you about the Kundavai’s olai?”

“No!”

“My Lord! I have warned you time and again in the past. All these people in the kingdom are trying to fool you. They withhold important information from you thinking that you lack the wits to find out. Do you realize the truth in my warning now? I did not believe in Mandiravadi’s words alone. I questioned the physician’s son from Pazhaiaarai whom your brother’s soldiers had captured. He confirmed whatever the Mandiravadi had told me. It is true that Kundavai has sent a message with this boy’s friend to Ilangai.”

Pazhuvetarayar was lost for words. He couldn’t make any sense of what Nandini was telling. Irritated at large, he cast an annoying glance at Kandanmaran. He didn’t want to ask Nandini for explanations in that boy’s presence. Nandini understood her husband’s annoyance and said, “Let us not delay this boy’s journey anymore,” She then looked at Kandanmaran and said, “Ayya! I request you to hand this olai in person to the Crown Prince. If he writes a reply, please send it to me with a trusted messenger and do invite the prince to your palace at Kadambur.”

Confused and perplexed, Kandanmaran looked at Nandini and Periya Pazhuvetarayar and asked, “What do I tell my father? Shall I tell him that this is the wish of the Pazhuvur lord?”

“Yes, you can. My wish is my Lord’s wish. Isn’t that so, My Lord?”

“Yes. Yes,” nodded Pazhuvetarayar. He didn’t understand anything yet he couldn’t ask Nandini for explanations.

After Kandanmaran left on his errand, Nandini looked amorously at her husband and asked, “My Lord! I fear that the faith and trust that you had in me is dwindling day after day. I think my brother-in-law’s wrong counsel is corrupting your mind.”

“Never. Nandini! I might lose my faith in the heavens above but I would never lose my faith in you. I trust your words more than anything in this world,”

“If that is so, then why did you ask me so many questions that too in that boy’s presence? I felt insulted,” whimpered Nandini with her eyes full of unshed tears.

Periya Pazhuvetarayar felt guilty and tormented. He tried to wipe her tears saying, “My love! Do not, please do not cry.”

After pacifying her, he said, “I can’t understand a few things that you do. Don’t I have the right to ask, why?”

“You have the right to ask me anything and I am beholden to give you my explanations. But please do not question me before strangers and shame me thus. Ask me now, whatever you want to know.”

“Why have you sent a message to Aditya Karikalan? Why have you invited him to Kadambur palace? Isn’t he our first enemy?”

“No, you are wrong. Our first enemy is that snake in Pazhaiaarai. I am calling Aditya Karikalan to Kadambur for the same reason why I had invited Kundavai to our palace. My Lord! Do you remember I used to tell you that Kundavai has a separate plan in her mind for this kingdom? I have found out what that plan is. She wants this

kingdom for her younger brother Arulmozhivarman after her father's demise. I will counter her plans with my move. Now do you understand why I have invited Aditya Karikalan to Kadambur?" said Nandini and shot a seductive glance at the old man.

Though he didn't understand anything, Pazhuvur Lord nodded and said, "I understand now, Nandini."

"My Lord! This glorious kingdom was formed due to the brave deeds of your ancestors and our clan. I intend to see you ascend the worthy throne of this kingdom and I will not rest until I have achieved our goal. But if you lose faith in me, do unsheathe that sword of yours and behead me."

"My love! Please do not talk thus and torment me."



## **Chapter 25:**

### **Maandotham**

It's been a long while since we parted with our hero Vandiya Devan. While our days in Thanjavur dragged on, Vandiya Devan had progressed on foot along the seashore and had reached the banks of the River Palavi near Maandotham. As he neared Maandotham, he was amazed to see its green visage with swaying tall trees, just as it was described during the times of Sundaramurthy Nayanmar and Sambandhar. The coast of Maandotham was rich in greenery with many orchards and fruit-bearing trees. Many trees rose to great heights to cover the skies with their many branches while the twittering sounds of birds sounded almost musical.

The fort walls of this city rose high over the sea even as the waves crashed relentlessly against it. The sea port of Maandotham looked busy with many large ships and boats laden with goods waiting to be unloaded. Though these scenes were very similar to what Sundaramurthy Nayanmar had described in his poems, not everything was the same. The throngs of devotees on their way to Ketheeswaram temple were missing and instead, Chola soldiers patrolled the streets.

The port city of Maandotham had become a garrison for Chola soldiers who came with the prince. Goods sent from the Chola kingdom were unloaded here and messengers and soldiers who were sent on errands from the Chola kingdom came here to take a ship home. Ravaged by war, the city was first controlled by Pandya soldiers and then by the kings of Ilangai. Since the reign of Paranthaka I the city was in the hands of the Cholas.

When Vandiya Devan arrived here, the fort doors were firmly shut and he informed the guards that he wanted to meet their commander but they refused to allow him inside. He then attempted to storm down their door with his horse and was arrested for his trouble and

taken to their commander. He explained to the fort commander that he had come bearing messages for the prince and when they searched his belongings, they found the message and along with it, an emblem ring that belonged to the Pazhuvur clan.

The Lord Commander of the Chola forces was Kodumbalur Periya Vellar who was Vanathi's uncle. When the soldiers informed him about Vandiya Devan, he was with Prime Minister Anirudha Bhramarayar and was travelling to Rameshwaram. Therefore, he ordered the soldiers to imprison Vandiya Devan until he could come back.

The soldiers took Vandiya Devan to an old dilapidated mansion and imprisoned him inside a room there. Our hero was quite happy about being imprisoned, as it was an opportunity to rest and recuperate after a long journey on foot. On the first day, he was able to sleep without any interruption but on the second, his well-deserved rest was disturbed. He kept hearing some weird noise from the next room. It seemed as if one man was trying to frighten another with empty threats. "Chi! Chi! Go away from here. If you come near me, I will kill you." "Be careful! Do not come near me!" "I swear, I will kill you," "I will kick you to death!"

Vandiya Devan could hear only one voice from the other room so it led him to suspect that his next-door neighbour might be a delusional soldier who had lost his mind due to the rigours of the war.

What if this man shouts himself hoarse all through the night? How can I sleep with him shouting thus?

"You will not listen to me! You will not leave me alone! Alright then, let me see what you will do now!" shouted the mad man and after a few seconds, something fell into the room from the upper window. Vandiya Devan who was trying to sleep got up with a start and would have unsheathed his sword except that he started laughing. The thing that fell from the next room was a cat!

"Oh! You know to laugh as well is it?"

Vandiya Devan was now sure of the fact that the man next door was indeed mad but he also found it strange that his voice seemed familiar to him. After wracking his brains over whose voice it could be, he closed his tired eyes to rest awhile. But there was something soft near his feet, he opened his eyes to check and saw that the cat had settled down there. He pushed the cat away and then tried to sleep, again but soon enough there was something soft near his face as the poor cat tried to cuddle near his neck.

He pushed it away yet again and tried to sleep and this time the cat sat near his head and tried to woo him with its tail. Vandiya Devan couldn't bear it anymore. He could easily face a hundred spears and arrows but not the brush of a cat's tail. He picked up the cat by the skin of the neck and threw him back through the window into the next room.

There was a commotion in the next room for a while. The lunatic in the next room was cursing the cat which was meowing fiercely. Soon enough, he heard, "Go! Get lost," and the faint sound of the cat's 'meow' was heard. Vandiya Devan settled down to sleep again and had a very sweet dream.

Princess Kundavai sat next to him while he slept and was running her hand through his hair. While his subconscious mind compared the softness of the princesses' hand and the bushy tail of the cat, he was very sad when the dream ended. He was instantly alert to the fact that he heard some noise that broke his sleep. Listening intently, he heard the scratching of nails and grunts from next door and it looked as though the lunatic was trying to climb the wall.

Vandiya Devan pretended to sleep, though his hand was on his dagger. Through half-closed eyes, he saw two hands coming through the upper window and then a face! It was a familiar face and our old friend, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi!

Why has he come here? How did he come? How did he know that I am here?

While these questions raced through his mind, he sat up and welcomed the fat Vaishnavan, “Vaishnavarey! Welcome! Welcome to the holy Shaivaite site of Thirukedeeshwarar!”

“My boy! I knew it would be you. Who else would sit silently to watch what unfolds next?” said Azhwarkadiyan hoisting his fat self through the window and then jumped into the room.

## **Chapter 26:**

### **The Dagger that Demanded Blood**

Though Vandiya Devan was wondering about the sudden presence of the Vaishnavan, he welcomed him jocularly and said, “Vaishnavarey! You will not believe me when I say that I thought about you just a few moments ago and the next minute, you have jumped into my room.”

“My boy! You thought about me, did you? But why would you want to think about a mere mortal like me? It would be more useful to you if you had thought of Shri Rama.”

“Vaishnavarey, what a coincidence? I did think of Shri Rama at first. When I was coming here, I saw the temple tower of Rameshwaram. That’s where Shri Rama had worshipped Lord Shiva to cleanse himself of his sins for slaying Ravana.”

“Wait thambi! Wait...”

“I would rather wait sitting down, Swami. My legs are too sore. After I thought of Shri Rama, I was reminded of Lord Hanuman, his messenger who crossed the sea for him and the minute I thought of him, I see you jumping into my room. Did you perchance cross the seas with a single leap like Hanuman?”

“Thambi! How can you compare me with the greatest devotee of all, Shri Hanuman? Hanuman came to Ilangai and slew the Rakshaha Prince Akshaya Kumar and scores of other ferocious beings while I can’t get rid of a mere cat. See what it did to me,” he said showing his scratched arms and legs.

“Aha! This is very unfortunate indeed. But why did you have to fight with a cat of all things?”

“I didn’t fight with it. The cat attacked me first.”

“How did that happen?”

“I came here searching for you. I hid from the soldiers and got inside this mansion through the window. Alas, I stepped on the cat’s tail and it swore vengeance on me. Thambi! One can fight the tiger but definitely not the cat.”

“Ah! I know why the cat attacked you.”

“Why?”

“When that same cat came to my room, it sat by my head and brushed its tail on me very lovingly. The only person that it has attacked is you and that’s because the cat is a ‘Veera Saiva’ so obviously it hates Veera Vaishnavars like yourself!”

“Oh! Is that so? Now, why didn’t I think of that? If I had known this, I would have used my staff to teach this ‘Veera Saiva Cat’ a good lesson.”

“It is a good thing that you have not brought your staff with you. Ever since I have come here, I have felt the blood of Veera Saivars running through my veins. My scabbard seems to be screaming for the blood of Vaishnavars. But you once did a big favour for me, hence I am not going to listen to the voice of this sword, for old times’ sake.”

“Is that so? I don’t remember doing any big favour for you.”

“You did. Do you remember, you told me about your sister the Pazhuvur queen, Nandini Devi?”

“Yes, I did.”

“In Kadambur, when the veiled palanquin was going along, didn’t you show me the lady who was sitting inside it?”

“Yes, I did. So what?”

“I saw the same palanquin going near Thanjavur and the palanquin bearers deliberately hit my horse. I sought justice from them and whom did I see inside?”

“Who?”

“Who but the Pazhuvur queen herself?”

“Aha! You are indeed lucky. I tried to meet her on many occasions but was unsuccessful.”

“They say that Goddess of Luck comes on her own in our lives.”

“What happened afterwards?”

“I mentioned your name and that you have sent her an important message.”

“My boy! I have met many people in my life but I am yet to meet another man who could lie so convincingly.”

“Vaishnavarey! My ancestors were patrons of poets and bards. They loved poetry so much so that they have composed many on their own.”

“So what?”

“I have my ancestor’s blood in my veins so that’s why my imagination knows no bounds but unfortunately people like you have never learned to appreciate it, hence you call it ‘lie’,”

“Good, now what happened next?”

“Nandini Devi heard my astonishing tale and then gave me her emblem ring and asked me to come to her palace inside the fort.”

“Did you go then?”

“Of course. I went immediately and regaled the queen of Pazhuvur with many tales of my bravery and she gave me an important task to do.”

“And what would that be?”

“The treasures of Pandya Kingdom, their gem studded crown and the priceless haaram<sup>[136]</sup> that was given to them by God Indra are hidden somewhere here in Ilangai. She has tasked me to find them for her but I didn’t realize that it would be so difficult a task.”

“I have heard that Periya Pazhuvetarayar’s treasury holds jewels that would need more than a thousand donkeys to load. Apparently, all those jewels are not enough for this queen. What did she promise you, if you complete her task successfully?”

“Nandini Devi has promised to make me the fort commander of Thanjavur.”

“Thambi! If you become the fort commander of Thanjavur, will you allow me inside the fort at any time?”

“And how do you think I will become the fort commander of Thanjavur when I am held captive here?” asked Vandiya Devan sorrowfully.

“Do you know why they have imprisoned you here?”

“I had brought the Pazhuvur emblem ring here, thinking that I could use it. That’s why they have imprisoned me,”



“That was a big mistake thambi! The lord commander of the Chola army in Ilangai is Kodumbalur Periya Vellar. Didn't you know about the feud that exists between these two clans?”

“I didn't know. That's how I made this mistake and now I don't know what to do?”

“Thambi! Do not despair. I have come to help you escape from this prison.”

“Really?”

“I had once asked you to aid me but you refused yet I have come here to help you. Come with me, we can leave this place now.”

“Vaishnavarey! I think it would be wise for you to leave this place now.”

“Why?”

“I can hear my sword thirsting for the blood of a Vaishnavan!”

“If that is so, then you should unsheathe it and quench its thirst. I have enough blood in my body to satisfy your sword. Come now.”

“No. I will not come.”

“Why?”

“I want to sleep for a while. I haven't slept in many days as I travelled day and night by foot to reach here. I had thought that I would spend the entire day sleeping and that's why threw that cat away.”

“Thambi! I can't believe that you are talking thus! Is this how you will fulfil the task that Princess Kundavai gave you? Didn't you promise to her that you will not rest until you have handed this message to

‘Ponniyin Selvar’?” asked Azhwarkadiyan and handed over the olai that Vandiya Devan had brought with him.

Vandiya Devan took the olai with care and kept it safely inside his waistcloth. He had been wondering about Azhwarkadiyan’s motives right from the beginning and had guarded his mouth most carefully lest he gave away some information. His mistrust vanished the minute, Azhwarkadiyan gave him the olai.

“How did you get this olai?” he asked

“Commander Vikramakesari gave it to me. He also gave me your Pazhuvur emblem ring. You have his permission to leave whenever you want.”

“Vaishnavarey! I thank you most sincerely for this help.”

“Keep all your thanks safely inside your heart and I will claim them when the time is right.”

“Do you know where the prince is?”

“No one knows about that. The Prince was last seen heading towards the mountain regions near Anuradhapuram. We will need to find our way through the forest and search for him. The commander has asked me to go along with you as a guide. If you need my help, I would be happy to come along.”

Azhwarkadiyan’s offer seemed suspicious to Vandiya Devan. He said, “I need to meet the Lord Commander Periya Vellar before we leave.”

“Of course, you have to. You can’t possibly leave without giving him information about Princess Vanathi, his niece,” said Azhwarkadiyan.

Vandiya Devan was now convinced that the Vaishnavan was adept in magic and sorcery to know everything about everything.

## **Chapter 27**

### **The Forest Path**

The commander of the Chola forces in Ilangai, Kodumbalur Periya Vellar was an experienced warrior and a leader. He enjoyed a close relationship with the royal family as a kinsman and a liege lord. His brother Kodumbalur Siriya Vellar who was Vanathi's father had died on the battlefield in Ilangai along with his army and since then, Periya Vellar had been itching to avenge his brother's death.

Though he was advanced in age, he requested for the command of Ilangai army and was allowed to lead the Chola armies along with the prince. But the battle campaign of Ilangai was fraught with hurdles thanks to the meddling of the Pazhuvur Lords who were determined to undermine any glory that the young Prince was likely to win. This had furthered the deep-rooted enmity between these two clans.

When the Kodumbalur soldiers caught Vandiya Devan with the Pazhuvur emblem ring, they suspected him to be a spy but thankfully, Periya Vellar mentioned his capture to the Prime minister who had learned the truth about our hero's adventures from Azhwarkadiyan. Therefore, Azhwarkadiyan was sent urgently to Periya Vellar to rescue Vandiya Devan from his prison.

Periya Vellar looked long and hard at Vandiya Devan and then addressed him almost kindly, "Thambi! Did my soldiers look after you well? Did you get a good place to stay and ample food to eat?"

"My Lord! Your soldiers were very hospitable. They offered me a good place to stay and then sent in a cat as a night's meal but before I could begin my feast this fat Vaishnavan came and spoiled it. The angry cat scratched him everywhere and ran off."

The commander smiled at Vandiya Devan's wit and said, "This boy is very witty. Thirumalai! Did a cat attack you, truly?"

"My Lord! This boy's ancestors were not only kings but also poets it seems and that accounts for his imagination though in general, he speaks the truth. There was indeed a cat at the place where he was held and it did scratch me everywhere," said Azhwarkadiyan and showed his hands and feet to the Commander.

"I can't believe that you allowed a cat to attack you thus. It is a good thing that I am sending you along with a good warrior to find the prince."

"My Lord! I don't need a warrior to protect me as long as I carry my staff with me. I forgot to take it with me when I went to meet him."

"Alright. Before you leave, prepare ample food to carry along with you. Thambi! We are perpetually running short of food supplies here in Ilangai. King Mahindan's army destroyed many dams and lakes. There is no water here for farming and no farmers either to plant crops either. When the people here are starving how can we expect them to feed our army? We are not getting enough food and supplies from our Kingdom also."

"My Lord! When I was in Pazhaiaarai, I heard the families of our soldiers complaining to Princess Kundavai about this."

"Good! So they too know about our plight. What did the princess say to that?"

"She said that Commander Periya Vellar will never allow his soldiers to starve."

"Aha! I have met many royal princesses in my time, but none can compare to our princess."

"I beg to differ, Commander."

“You do?”

“Yes, Commander. I do think that Princess Vanathi is as gracious as Princess Kundavai too.”

“Thambi! Did you meet my niece in Pazhaiaarai?”

“Yes, my Lord. How can I not meet Princess Kundavai’s inseparable companion? When I took their leave from the Pazhaiaarai medical clinic, they both saw me off.”

“Thambi! Did Princess Kundavai send me any message about my niece?”

“My Lord! I do not wish to lie to you.”

“Thambi! There is no need to lie to anybody.”

“My Lord! If I were to speak the truth in front of this Vaishnavan my head will burst into pieces.”

“So, there is no message for me, from Princess Kundavai?”

“No, My Lord! But I do bear some messages about Princess Vanathi to the prince.”

Beaming at his response the Commander declared, “I have never met a more clever warrior like you,” and genially embraced him.  
“Now don’t waste any more time. You can leave immediately.”

Vandiya Devan neared the Commander and whispered, “Ayya! Do I really have to travel along with this Vaishnavan? Can’t I go alone?”

“Why do you object to his company?”

“I have no objections but it is the dagger that I carry, that seems to be objecting. It thirsts for the Vaishnavan’s blood.”

“If that is so, then you should leave that dagger here with me. You cannot find the prince without his help. No one knows where the prince has gone and he also bears a few messages for the prince from the Prime minister. Therefore, it is for the best that you both travel together. Please do not fight with each other on the way and waste your time,” said Commander and then whispered again to Vandiya Devan, “Thambi! This Vaishnavan will not hinder your work but do be careful with him because he is very clever and crafty. And I would like to know all about the message that he gives to the prince.”

Until then, Vandiya Devan was under the impression that Azhwarkadiyan was sent along with him as a spy to keep an eye on him but when the Commander asked him to spy on the Vaishnavan, he was pleased.

Vandiya Devan and Azhwarkadiyan set off along with two soldiers that afternoon. For two days, they journeyed towards the eastern direction through small villages. As they progressed, they came upon a forest path that was inaccessible and uninhabited with tall trees and dense foliage. They came upon many lakes that lay dry, ruined and damaged by the ravages of war. As they walked by the forest path, Azhwarkadiyan pointed out to him how devastating a war could be for the common people while Vandiya Devan tried to argue with him from a soldier’s point of view. After two days, the direction of their path changed south and they entered the densest forest that they have ever seen.

Conversing about the wild animals that they were likely to encounter here Azhwarkadiyan said that the forests were full of tigers, leopards, wild boars, elephants and jackals. Vandiya Devan was reminded of a dream that he had a long time ago and asked, “If the jackal attacks us as a pack, isn’t that dangerous?”

“A lone jackal is more dangerous in these forests. Here the jackal and the leopard hunt together. The leopard will hide while the Jackal spies on the prey and warns his master. That’s why the jackal is also called as Orri because it spies for its master.”

While they were talking they heard the sound of rushing water that made Vandiya Devan wonder whether they had come near the sea, “What is that noise? Where is it coming from?”

“There must be a lake nearby I think. Sometimes herds of elephants would come there to bathe and drink.”

“Herds of elephants! Isn’t that dangerous?”

“An elephant herd will not attack anybody. If we stay still, they will pass us by without any incident,” said Azhwarkadiyan. One of the soldiers who had come along with them climbed to the top of a tree to see the source of the sound. He hurriedly got down and said, “Ayya! Ayya! It is a lone elephant, a mad one. It is stamping the ground and uprooting trees. It is coming this way!”

“Ayyo! What will we do now? How will we escape?” said Azhwarkadiyan and looked around him frantically.

“You said that a herd of elephants will not attack us, then why do you fear a single lone elephant?”

“We have nothing to fear from a herd of elephants but a lone elephant is dangerous. It will possess the brutal strength of thousand elephants. No one can face it alone and live to tell the tale,” replied Azhwarkadiyan.”

“Three of us here have spears and swords and you have your staff.”

“No spear or staff can stop a mad elephant. Come, let us get on top of that cliff and hope that the elephant doesn’t notice us.”

Saying thus, Azhwarkadiyan ran towards the cliff while the others followed him. After running for a while, they were at the end of the ravine where the cliff ended and the elephant seemed to be coming in their direction. With nowhere else to run, they stood at the edge of the cliff hoping that the elephant would turn away but soon enough it was evident that the mad beast was rooting its way towards them. The mad elephant let out a piercing trumpet when it sighted them and started running towards them. The four of them tried to run in different directions but their options were limited and it looked as if the elephant was trying to catch Azhwarkadiyan who was stuck at the edge of the cliff.

Vandiya Devan took his spear in hand and tried to aim but the sheer size of the elephant and its speed astonished him. Azhwarkadiyan's hilarious actions in the meanwhile distracted him. With his staff aloft in hand, he shouted, "Stop. Stop right there. I command you! I will slay you right away. I warn you. Stop right there."

## **Chapter 28: The King's Road**

Will a mad elephant stop in its tracks just because Azhwarkadiyan started wielding his staff? But one cannot fault him for trying. The elephant ran madly towards him and Vandiya Devan knew at that instant that this might be the end of the fat Vaishnavan. He picked up his spear again tried to take aim while the two soldiers who had come with them were screaming their heart out rooted in one place. The mad elephant rampaged its way through the thicket of trees and bushes and came to the very edge of the cliff where they were



standing. In the next instant, Azhwarkadiyan threw his staff at the elephant while his turban flew in the air and he vanished.

The elephant in its mad fury had come to the edge of the cliff and one of its legs slipped and it fell into the ravine of the cliff uttering a piercing howl that reverberated through the woods. It took awhile for the dust, sand, stones, leaves and broken twigs to settle down before they could see what had actually happened. They now knew that Azhwarkadiyan must have fallen into the ravine when he threw the staff at the mad elephant.

Vandiya Devan's heart was heavy with sorrow and grief. Their journey of few days had passed joyfully amidst jokes and stories and a newfound friendship. Despair and grief washed over his heart when he realized that he would have to find the prince and give him the message without the help and guidance of the Vaishnavan. Worried about the task ahead, he went to the edge of the cliff and stood near the place where the Vaishnavan had disappeared.

The elephant's fall had left a trail of dust in the ravine below and at first, he couldn't see anything below and then he heard a voice, "Thambi! What is this? Will you not give a hand and help me?"

Astonished to hear a dead man's voice, Vandiya Devan looked around and found the fat Vaishnavan literally hanging in the edge ravine from a tree root. His grief disappeared and his happiness knew no bounds when he said, "What is this Vaishnavarey? You are hanging in Trishanku Swargam<sup>[137]</sup> after sending that wild elephant to the heavens?"

Next, he called the two soldiers who had accompanied them and then unwound his waistcloth for the Vaishnavan to catch on the other end. With a lot of groans and grunts, the three of them hoisted the fat Vaishnavan from the ravine.

Azhwarkadiyan lay huffing and puffing for a long time on the ground while the others rallied around him recounting and reliving the

adventure that they had been through. Soon enough Azhwarkadiyan sat up and said, “Let us start now. We need to get to the king’s road before the day ends. Where are my turban and staff?”

“There is no need to hurry. We can leave after you rest for a while,” said Vandiya Devan.

A lone jackal howled somewhere near them and soon there were sounds of other beasts and birds crying and shouting. The forest suddenly came alive with many myriad sounds. A few vultures started flying around the ravine to prey on the dead elephant.

“An elephant’s death is no ordinary event in the forest. Animals from far and wide will come here to feast on its flesh. It is best that we leave right away.”

Agreeing to Azhwarkadiyan’s wise counsel, they left the place almost immediately as fast as their feet would take them. Soon they had left the forest path to reach the king’s road. It was a busy path with many bullock carts, horse carts and large elephants carrying men and soldiers. Looking at the elephants walking calmly by the road, Vandiya Devan was understandably surprised by the ferocity of the wild elephant that they encountered a few hours ago.

“Where does this King’s road lead to? Where have we come and where are we going?”

“We are on the King’s road that leads to Simhagiri<sup>[138]</sup> from Anuradhapuram<sup>[139]</sup>. We should reach Thambilai<sup>[140]</sup> by nightfall.”

“We could have journeyed comfortably on the King’s road. Why did you lead us through that dangerous forest path?”

“They would have stopped us over hundred times to know the purpose of our journey if we had come by the King’s road. At Anuradhapuram, they would have stopped us altogether. I have learned that the person whom we have come searching for was last

seen heading towards Simhagiri, that's why I took a short cut through the forest. Despite all this, I am not sure whether we could find him there. Let's hope that he doesn't go anywhere else."

There were many village homes, market places and ironsmiths working on both the sides of the King's road. Vandiya Devan noted that most of them were the local Sinhala people and they were calmly going about their work and didn't seem to be scared or frightened by the presence of Chola soldiers going along the road.

"Who controls this region?"

"The Chola armies have captured regions until Thambilai. Beyond that, the Fort of Simhagiri and the mountain regions are still under King Mahindan's control."

"And the people who live here..."

"They are mostly Sinhalese. You know, Ponniyin Selvar has changed the face of war after he came here. The Chola armies fight only the soldiers of King Mahindan in the battlefield while the local populace can carry on with their lives without any fear or loss. Even the Buddhist monks are delighted with the prince as he got his soldiers to rebuild and repair many of their monasteries. Isn't this atrocious? When I meet the prince, I will surely tell him that I most sternly object to his actions."

"Of course, you must tell him that. How dare the prince act in a manner that could upset you thus? Who does he think he is? Has he sprouted horns in his head?"

"No, he hasn't but thambi, the prince possesses a strange power. Even those who disapprove his actions behind his back will find it difficult to speak up in his presence. Only one person possesses that power; the power to make him do anything."

“Yes. Truly, only the great Vaishnavar Azhwarkadiyan Nambi possesses the power to make the prince do anything that he wishes. A Prince is surely no match for a man who sent the raging wild elephant to its death.”

“Thambi! You misunderstand me. One cannot compare by any measure a man like Ponniyin Selvar and a poor Brahmin like me. I can bravely face a wild elephant. I might even kill tigers, leopards and bears with my bare hands but when I come face-to-face with the prince, all my bravado vanishes. My heart melts and I find it very difficult to articulate, even a word.”

“Then who is this person, who possesses the power to make him do anything?”

“The whole world knows about this. It is surprising that you do not know. I was referring to Princess Kundavai. The Prince will never go against her wishes.”

“Oh! You were talking about the princess, is it? I thought that you might be referring to your dear sister Nandini Devi.”

“Nandini too possesses a great deal of power but it is different.”

“How? In what way?”

“If someone is about to go to hell, then Kundavai Devi possesses the power to send him to heaven instead. That’s one kind of power. But do you know what Nandini would do? It wouldn’t be amiss to say that her power is a shade stronger than Kundavai’s. Nandini would convince you that hell is a much better place than the heaven and would have you jumping happily into hell. That’s her power!”

Vandiya Devan got goose pimples when he heard this. He was astonished by the fact that this Vaishnavan could describe Nandini’s dangerous charm and seductive power so accurately. He even

wondered whether Nandini could truly be this man's sister?  
Pondering about this deeply, they walked for a while in silence.

The silence was broken by the hoof sounds of a few cavalry soldiers coming from the opposite direction. Within a few seconds, a few galloping stallions passed them by creating a storm of dust and dirt in its wake. Vandiya Devan managed to look at the face of one of the riders. Aha! What is Parthibendra Pallavan doing in Ilangai? What is Prince Aditya Karikalan's close confidante and sworn sword doing in Ilangai? Vandiya Devan was also reminded of the fact that the Pallavan didn't like him very much.

Soon enough an authoritative voice shouted, "Stop!" and all the horses stopped at his command while the Pallavan turned his horse around and came near them. He stared hard at Vandiya Devan and then said, "What are you doing here thambi? I heard that you vanished overnight in Thanjavur. I had thought that the Pazhuvur lords would have taken care of you by now."

"It is quite difficult to get rid of me, my Lord. I am after all the scion of the brave Vanar clan."

"That means you have somehow saved your skin. I always knew that you were clever enough for that."

"Ayya! I know when to save my life and when to sacrifice it. I would rather give up my life with a sword in hand sparring with a warrior like you, rather than die like a spy in the hands of the Pazhuvur lords," said Vandiya Devan and drew his sword.

"I have no intention of granting your wish, thambi! I have more important work to do here. Whatever happened to the messages that our prince had given you?"

"I have delivered both the messages my Lord. To the emperor and to the princess as well."

“What are you doing here then?”

“I had long wished to see Ilangai, therefore I came here along with this Vaishnavan.”

“Aha! This Vaishnavan too seems familiar to me.”

“Yes, Maharaja! I had come to the prince to ask him about my sister’s whereabouts. You were next to him.”

“Who is your sister?”

“She is now the younger queen of the Pazhuvur lord.”

“If you are truly the brother of that snake, then you ought to be put to death.”

“Maharaja! One day, I will come to you on my own to fulfil that wish.”

“It would be impossible to do that unless I have over a hundred men. Be that as it may, tell me something, have you heard anything about the prince’s whereabouts? Has he returned to Anuradhapuram?”

“How will we know, about that Maharaja? We came by the forest path and there was a wild elephant that gave us a chase and do you know what happened then?”

“That’s enough. I have no time for your ridiculous tales. And I might just grant your wish if you continue,” said Parthibendran impatiently and turned his horse.

Azhwarkadiyan in the meanwhile was busy staring at the Pallavan’s companions while he was talking to him and after they left, he turned towards Vandiya Devan and said, “Thambi! Did you notice those three men who had come with the Pallavan? Have you ever seen them before?”

“No. I have never seen them,”

“I have. I have seen two of them at the ruins of Thirupurampayam Pallipadai<sup>[141]</sup> at midnight. I still shudder, when I think about the terrible oath that they swore.”

“What terrible oath?”

“They swore a blood oath to destroy the seed of the Cholas!”

“Ayyo!”

“I am surprised that they arrived here so soon. They are quite cunning and clever. They have now become companions of this rogue Pallavan<sup>[142]</sup>. I don’t know what to make of this.”

Vandiya Devan was reminded of something that he learned at Kodi Karai. Poonguzhali had told him that her brother had ferried two men to Ilangai, two days before he had arrived there.

Could these be the men who had come along with her brother? If these men were plotting to destroy the Chola race, then what is the role of Parthibendran in this plot? Wondered Vandiya Devan even as they neared Thambalai.

## **Chapter 29**

### **The Mahout**

A thousand years before the present events in this epic, there reigned an emperor in Ilangai named Valahambahu. During his reign, a war raged between the Chola kings and the Ilangai forces. Defeated by the enemy, Valahambahu fled from his capital city and sought refuge among the steep mountains of Thambilai. Later he gathered his forces and ousted the invaders from his capital city Anuradhapuram. After he successfully recaptured his kingdom, he expressed his gratitude to Lord Buddha by converting the mountain caves of Thambilai into a sanctuary of peace and piety. The caves of Thambilai were made into a shrine as the sculptors made large and small statues of Buddha and other gods and Goddesses of the Hindus as well. Even today, one can see the wondrous beauty of these statues brought alive by the deft craftsmanship of these talented sculptors.

Vandiya Devan was awestruck by the massive statues of Buddha that were seen everywhere. He felt that he had stepped into a new world filled with astounding things to discover. Many devotees bought baskets of exotic flowers as an offering to Buddha and were seen walking towards the mountain temple. Buddhist monks clad in their customary dull saffron robes thronged the streets and occasionally they raised their voice to shout 'sadhu'.

Vandiya Devan saw all these sights in wonder and said, "I thought we were entering a war-torn region ruled by Cholas, instead we are in a city ruled by Buddha!"

"This city is very famous for their Buddha shrines for over a thousand years now."

"But right now, it is the Cholas who have captured it."



“True.”

“Then why is it that there are no Chola soldiers on the streets?”

“All the soldiers are garrisoned in the woods outside the city.”

“Upon whose orders?”

“The Prince’s. Who else?”

“I have been wanting to ask you. Parthibendran Pallavan came here and searched for the prince in vain and has left. Then why are we searching for him again here?”

“Do you think I would believe that Pallavan’s words and abandon my search? Did Prahaladan<sup>[143]</sup> accept his father’s words when he said that ‘Narayana<sup>[144]</sup> does not exist’?”

“Veera Vaishnavarey! You were constantly fighting the Saivars and Advaitis in our Kingdom, why don’t you challenge these monks for a debate here? Are you scared by their overwhelming numbers?”

“Thambi! I have never feared anything in my life,” said Azhwarkadiyan and approached two people who were standing on the road. He conversed with them for a while and then returned.

“Vaishnavarey! What did you ask them? I hope you didn’t ask them whether Vishnu is a big God. Even you should agree that Lord Buddha is the biggest God here.”

“Thambi! I have put aside my Veera Vaishnavam in Rameshwaram. I am here on a royal errand.”

“Then, what did you ask them? Did you enquire about the prince’s whereabouts?”

“No. I asked them whether there was a festival happening here today.”

“What did they say?”

“They said that they were waiting to see two travellers from the land of China. That’s why the monasteries here have arranged many festivities to welcome them.”

“Where are these travellers from China now?”

“They have now gone to Simhagiri’s mountain fort and would be arriving here soon.”

“Where is Simhagiri?”

“At a short distance from here. It is still under the control of Ilangai armies. During daytime, you could see the mountain fort from here easily. The fort of Simhagiri has a cave with many beautiful paintings. These travellers must have gone there to see it. I wonder how they got up that mountain. It is very steep. Look! They are here now.”

A large elephant was making its way languorously and, on its back, two men were seated in a covered howdah. Their garments and looks bespoke their heritage. Seated in front of them was a mahout guiding the elephant with a goad. All around the elephant, common people and the monks raised many cries.

“Thambi! Did you see?”

“Yes. I saw. Such a big beast! Shall we find out if there is a handy ravine nearby?”

“No! No! Let us stand aside. Come here,” said Azhwarkadiyan dragging our hero aside.

As the elephant neared, Vandiya Devan's attention was captured by the Chinese travellers. He wondered at their piety and devotion that enabled them to step out of their homeland to pay their respects to Lord Buddha enshrined in other kingdoms. No wonder the people here are scrambling to welcome them in their midst. Though what is truly surprising is that they were travelling fearlessly in a land that is in the midst of a war.

Prince Arulmozhivarmar must be responsible for it then. Where is the prince? Will I ever get to meet him?

"Thambi! Did you see?"

"I saw."

"What did you see?"

"I saw the flat noses of those travellers from the land of China. Their clothes look very different."

"I didn't ask you about those travellers."

"Then?"

"Did you notice the mahout?"

"The mahout? No. I didn't notice."

"You are very observant indeed! When the mahout saw us, his eyes lit up suddenly. Didn't you notice?"

"Somehow my observant eye missed the light in the mahout's eyes. How did he light up his eyes? Is that a trick?"

"I truly marvel at your intelligence but mostly I am amazed that Princess Kundavai saw it fit to send the likes of you on such a

dangerous mission. Come with me,” said Azhwarkadiyan and dragged him behind the crowd that was following the elephant.

The elephant stopped at the entrance of the monastery. Bending its legs, it allowed the travellers to get down from its back. The monks from the monastery gave a rousing welcome to the travellers by blowing couches and ringing the bells while some showered them with flower petals.

Buddham saranam gacchami!<sup>[145]</sup>  
Dhammam saranam gacchami  
Sangam saranam gacchami

“I go for refuge in knowledge,  
I go for refuge in teachings,  
I go for refuge in the community.

After the chants ended, the travellers from China entered the monastery and most of the crowd that had gathered there followed them inside.

When the travellers had dismounted, the mahout had led the elephant away from the crowd. A group of four soldiers approached him immediately and then he handed over his mahout's stick to them. Next, he pointed towards Azhwarkadiyan and said something to one of the soldiers and then walked away hurriedly from the street. Soon enough, the same soldier approached them and whispered, “Ayya, are you prepared to come with me?”

“We have been waiting for the summons.”

“Do you have an emblem ring?” he asked and Azhwarkadiyan took out Kodumbalur Periya Vellar's emblem ring to show him. After scrutinizing it carefully, the soldier said, “Fine. Come with me.”

The rest of them followed him through the streets of Thambilai and soon they were on the outskirts of the city. A narrow goat path led

them inside the thick forest where a dilapidated mandapam stood. The soldier asked them to wait awhile there and then nimbly climbed the nearby tree.

“What’s all this mystery? I don’t understand anything,” said Vandiya Devan.

“You will understand soon enough. Be patient,” said Azhwarkadiyan but Vandiya Devan was worried by the fact that there were only two horses tied to the back of the mandapam.

Who was that mahout?

He had not paid much attention to him as he was fascinated by the appearance of the travellers from China. He tried to recollect that mahout’s face but his brain refused to remember.

“Vaishnavarey! Who was that mahout? Won’t you tell me?”

“Who do you think it could be?”

“Was he Ponniyin Selvar?”

“I recognized him only because I noticed his eyes.”

“What if others in this city recognize him?”

“They will not. Who would expect the prince to play the mahout’s role to escort the travellers from China? Moreover, the people here have never seen the prince.”

“But you said that the travellers from China went to Simhagiri fort?”

“Yes, I did.”

“And the fort is still under the control of Ilangai army. Then the prince went all the way amidst his enemies?”

“Not just Simhagiri. The Prince has travelled along with them to Mahiyangana<sup>[146]</sup>, Samandagoodam and many other places.”

“Why did he take such a big risk?”

“The Prince wished to see the beautiful art, architecture, statues and paintings of these places.”

“This is preposterous. The Prince is playing with his life, courting such dangers. And I can’t believe that Kudandhai Jodhidar predicted such great things about him.”

“I don’t need to see the astrologer to know about the prince. I have always known that he was destined for great things.”

Suddenly they heard the hoof beats of galloping horses. The soldier who was perched on top of the tree came down hurriedly and led the horses that were tied at the back of the mandapam. He got on the back of one of the horses and urged Azhwarkadiyan to mount the other.

“In a few seconds, a group of horses will pass through this way. We must be prepared to follow them,” he said.

Vandiya Devan came forward and asked, “What about me? Do you have another horse?”

“I have orders only to bring him along.”

“Whose orders?”

“I cannot say.”

“I have to meet the prince most urgently. I have brought a very important message for him.”

“I do not know about that ayya. I cannot allow you to come along with us.”

“Thambi, be patient. I will go on ahead and tell the prince about you and arrange for you to meet him.”

“Nambi! My message to the prince is most urgent and important. Don’t you know about it?”

“I do. You could also hand it over to me instead.”

“Never!”

“Then be patient and wait here.”

Vandiya Devan’s impatient brain refused to listen and he started thinking about a way to go along with them. It was impossible to follow them without a horse and he didn’t want to let Azhwarkadiyan meet the prince alone. He had promised the commander to spy on the Vaishnavan. The galloping horses were coming near and soon three horses went past them at lightning speed. The soldier and Azhwarkadiyan who were waiting for them to go past them reined the impatient horses to stand by and then prepared to follow. Suddenly Vandiya Devan pounced on the soldier who had mounted the horse and pushed him from the horse by lifting his leg from the stirrup. The soldier fell down with a thud on the other side while he quickly mounted the horse. Enraged, the soldier screamed loudly, swiftly drew his dagger and threw it at Vandiya Devan but our hero bent over the horse to dodge it and urged his horse to gallop faster. With Azhwarkadiyan’s horse following his, they tried to keep up with the horses that were thundering in the forest path before them.

Vandiya Devan deftly controlled the pace of the horse and followed the three horses in front of him without getting too close. Azhwarkadiyan too did the same and said, “That was quick thinking, thambi.”

But Vandiya Devan did not respond to him. He was deeply worried about the outcome of this quest and was wondering whether it was worth his while to come all this way to this hostile kingdom in search of an elusive Prince.



## **Chapter 30**

### **A Fist Fight**

The horses seemed to gallop endlessly for Vandiya Devan through that long winding forest path. As they went deep into the dark forest, Vandiya Devan wondered whether they would roam around the forest until wild beasts consumed them. He knew that Thambillai was the last city that the Chola army had captured in this Island kingdom.

What if this Vaishnavan had betrayed me to the enemies? What if he is luring me towards the enemy? Will he hand me over to them as a hostage?

Thankfully, the moonlight beamed through the trees of the forest lighting their path dimly. The three horses that were speeding ahead of them were mere shadows now though the sound of their hoofs reverberated through the silent forest.

Suddenly they heard other sounds; muffled sounds of human voices, laughter and cheers. Soon enough they could see a clearing in the midst of the forest. Soldiers were seen sitting and chatting under the trees while a large vessel was cooking something appetizing under a huge pit of fire.

Who are these soldiers? Do they belong to the Cholas or the Ilangai king? Why are they in the forest?

Vandiya Devan had very few seconds to wonder about this but that was time enough for one of the horses that were galloping ahead to stop and come towards them. Whilst Vandiya Devan was noting the number of soldiers who had camped amidst the forest, the single horse bearing a soldier approached him suddenly and took him unaware by hitting him on his chest.

Startled, Vandiya Devan tried to hit him back but the soldier was quite fast as he bent down and pushed our hero from his horse. Vandiya Devan fell down from the horse with a thud while his horse galloped away in fear.

The soldier who had pushed Vandiya Devan got down from his horse and came near him. Disoriented by the sudden attack, Vandiya Devan got up and would have unsheathed his sword but the clever soldier was quick on the draw, as he took his sword from the scabbard and threw it away. It was a challenge that not only cleared Vandiya Devan's head but also roused his anger. He immediately made a strong fist and hit him back. Soon they were hitting each other and trying to overpower the other. As the crowd gathered around to see their fist fight, they fought with renewed vigour and force. Their fight could probably be compared to the legendary battle between Hidamba<sup>[147]</sup> and Bheema<sup>[148]</sup> or even Arjuna<sup>[149]</sup> and Lord Shiva who was disguised as a hunter from the tales of Mahabharatham.

Azhwarkadiyan and other soldiers who had escorted them watched the fight with astonishment. Soon the rest of the soldiers from the camp gathered there, shouting encouragement and cheering them madly.

In the end, Vandiya Devan was overpowered by the soldier who sat on his chest and opened his waist cloth and grabbed the message that he had brought across the sea. Vandiya Devan tried his utmost to shake him off his chest but he was rendered powerless.

With the olai in hand, the soldier sprang to his feet and went near the torch that one of the soldiers was holding. He also signalled few other soldiers to hold Vandiya Devan, lest he tried to attack him again.

Maddened with anger and infuriated by his defeat, Vandiya Devan turned towards his erstwhile companion, the Vaishnavan and said,

“You wretch! How could you betray me thus? Grab that message from him, now.”

“I cannot do that my boy!”

“Chi! I have never seen a worse coward than you in my life. I should never have trusted you!”

Azhwarkadiyan in the meanwhile got down from his horse and walked languorously towards our hero with a slow gait and whispered, “My boy! Don’t despair. The message you brought so carefully from across the sea has reached the right person.”

Even as he whispered these words, the soldiers who were watching them had seen the man who was reading the olai and they raised a cheer that would have roused the dead.

“Hail Ponniyin Selvar!”

“Long live our prince!”

Long live Prince Arulmozhivarmar!”

Their hails and cheers brought out the entire army of soldiers who were garrisoned in the woods and noting that the crowds were increasing, the prince addressed them, “I would like you all to help prepare the feast. I will come there shortly,”

The minute he uttered the words, all the soldiers turned around and went back leaving the prince alone with Vandiya Devan and Azhwarkadiyan.

Battered and bruised, Vandiya Devan looked up in astonishment when he realized that he had been fighting the very Prince for whom he had brought the message.

Aha! So, this is Prince Arulmozhivarmar. What strength he bears in his arms? I should consider myself lucky to be alive after an encounter with him. He is as handsome as Arjuna and as strong as Bheeman! It is no surprise that people all over the Chola Kingdom are singing his praises.

It is indeed a shame that the man who lent his name to this epic, who would one day, become the greatest emperor in the history of South India, is introduced to the readers thus but our hero is meeting him for the first time, therefore, it was quite impossible to meet him otherwise.

The Prince neared Vandiya Devan with a welcoming smile and said, "My friend, I welcome you to this beautiful island Kingdom of Ilangai. You came here braving the high seas, so I thought that it would be fit to welcome a brave soldier with a battle of fists. Did you enjoy the welcome that I gave you or would you perchance prefer a warmer one?"

Vandiya Devan sprang to his feet and bowed low to the prince and said, "My prince! The message that your sister had sent with me, has reached your hands. My duty is complete and my mission is accomplished. There is no need to save this life anymore."

"Aha! What do I say? You may not worry about your life anymore. It would be my responsibility from this moment onwards. I am answerable to my sister for your life henceforth. My friend, this letter that you brought for me was written by my sister's own hand. Did she give it to you in person?"

"Yes. My prince. I was fortunate enough to receive it from the princess's graceful hands. After that, I didn't tarry anywhere and journeyed here day and night."

"That's evident enough or else it would be impossible to come here so soon. I am at a loss for words to express my gratitude to you," said the prince and embraced Vandiya Devan.

All the pain and bruises that the prince had inflicted on him seemed to fade away in his warm embrace and Vandiya Devan was in the seventh heaven.

## **Chapter 31:**

### **The Eleyley Singan Play**

In the midst of the woods, over a thousand Chola soldiers had camped near a dried pond. The cooks were preparing the night's meal in giant vessels atop huge pits of fire. The delectable aroma of vegetables and spices was enough to rouse the appetites of our hungry travellers and the soldiers. The soldiers were busy rehearsing for a play until the food got ready and to their delight when the prince joined them, their enthusiasm knew no bounds. Their commander had a tough time reigning in their excitement. With much difficulty, he made his soldiers sit in a crescent formation.

They had cut a giant tree but had not removed the entire trunk portion that was left protruding from the earth. The Prince used this tree trunk as a seat and sat amidst them. He was now dressed as a Prince ought to be, wearing a silk dhoti<sup>[150]</sup>, pearl harams on his neck and a golden crown resplendent on his head. Along with him sat the commander of their border forces, Azhwarkadiyan, and Vandiya Devan.

The soldiers then started the Eleyley Singan<sup>[151]</sup> play that they had been practising a little while ago. A thousand years ago, warriors from across the Chola lands had captured the Island Kingdom of Ilangai under the leadership of Eleyley Singan, while the defeated king of Ilangai hid himself in the mountains.

The crown prince of Ilangai was called Dusthagamanu<sup>[152]</sup>. He was a peerless warrior who dreamed of liberating his kingdom from the invaders right from a young age.

Once when he was very young, he slept on his bed by bending his body uncomfortably without stretching his legs and arms. Seeing this, his mother asked him, "Child! Why do you sleep like this? Free your arms and stretch your legs comfortably."

“Mother! How do I stretch my arms and legs? On one side, there are Chola soldiers while on the other, there is the sea? How can I sleep comfortably in the bed, when I am being suffocated thus?”

When Dusthagamanu came of age, he rallied an army to oust the invaders but his men lost heart and ran away from the battle. Undeterred, he sought out Eleyley Singan at the battle field and addressed him thus, “Emperor! My army has disintegrated against your superior forces, leaving me alone in this field. I know you as a true warrior. I challenge you for a single combat. Whoever wins gets to be the king of this peerless island and the defeated can claim a seat in the heavens.”

Eleyley Singan was astonished by Dusthagamanu’s courage and determination to win his birthright. He agreed for single combat and ordered his soldiers not to interfere. When their battle of fists began, people from far and wide came to witness it. Soldiers who ran away from Dusthagamanu’s army too rallied back to see their Prince fight for their freedom. The fight dragged on for many hours.

Dusthagamanu fought fiercely because his birthright and the fate of his people were at stake. Eleyley Singan didn’t fight with his usual vigour because he felt sorry for the prince. In the end, Eleyley Singan fell dead and Dusthagamanu won his kingdom back. After ascending the throne, Dusthagamanu raised a Pallipadai [\[153\]](#) temple to honour Eleyley Singan’s valour and bravery.

Dramatizing this story, the Chola soldiers enacted it with much drama, songs and poems. Raising enthusiastic cheers and clapping their hands with much enthusiasm the crowds encouraged the soldiers acting in the play. The soldier who played the role of Eleyley Singan was appreciated for his artistic portrayal of the valorous soldier and many in the crowd cheered him madly. While the play was in progress, the prince turned towards Azhwarkadiyan and said, “Thirumalai! In the cave temples of Thambilai, the historic battle between Eleyley Singan and Dusthagamanu is immortalized in a beautiful painting. Did you see it?”

“No, ayya, we didn’t have the opportunity to visit the temples as we saw you in the streets. We didn’t have the time to see anything else after that.”

“Aha! You must see the statues and the paintings Thirumalai. While there are many beautiful statues and paintings in our kingdom, this island is a treasure trove of rare art.”

“My prince, the statues and the paintings of in this island will not go anywhere. We can see them anytime we choose but seeing you like this was a lucky chance. Before we arrived in Thambilai, we saw Parthibendra Pallavan on his way back to Anuradhapuram. He had come searching for you here.”

“Yes. The commander told me that my brother’s dear friend had come here. Can you guess the purpose of his visit?”

“I needn’t guess. I know why he has come here. Your brother has sent him here to take you to Kanchi.”

“Really? What about your friend here? Do you know the message that he brought for me from my sister, after hazarding so many dangers?”

“Your sister has asked you to come to Pazhaiaarai immediately. My prince! When Kundavai Devi secretly handed over the olai to him, I was watching them from the garden house...” Hearing this, Vandiya Devan immediately pinched Azhwarkadiyan in the back.

Azhwarkadiyan winced with pain and said, “What a wretched jungle this is? The insects are biting us even during the night.”

This did however not please the prince, he said, “How dare you spy on my own sister?”



“My prince, you ought to be thankful that I was there to help him on his way here. If we had come by Anuradhapuram, I am sure that he would have fought with someone and died ingloriously. That’s why I got him through the forest path and there too, he tried to fight with a mad elephant. Thankfully, I vanquished the mad beast with the help of my staff and brought him to you safely.”

“Oh! So, you came here only to escort him safely to me?”

“No ayya, I have brought a message for you from the Prime minister.”

“What is it? Tell me quickly.”

“The Prime minister is of the opinion that you should stay in Ilangai for some more time, rather than hurrying back home.”

“So, there are three messages from three elders. I wonder whom I should listen to?”

Vandiya Devan interjected with his opinion now, “My prince, forgive me. You ought to listen to your sister’s words.”

“Why do you say thus?”

“I say it because your heart is asking you to give precedence to your sister’s words more than anybody else’s. If you are not disposed to honour your sister’s words, I am bound by her command. I have promised her that I would bring you back with me at any cost.”

The Prince looked steadily at Vandiya Devan for a while and said, “I have long wished for a brave companion and friend to stand by my side. At last, I have found one.”

## **Chapter 32:**

### **Killi Valavan's Elephant**

The food was ready by the time the play ended. Steaming hot pongal<sup>[154]</sup> and vegetables were served to the soldiers on stacks of lotus leaves. As the famished soldiers ate their meal, the prince moved around them, chatting and enquiring about their health and their well-being. The soldiers singled out by the prince for conversation were elated beyond words while their companions looked at them jealously. Such was his charm!

The prince was very popular with the people from a very young age and their regard for him had multiplied ever since he assumed the command over Chola forces. His soldiers worshipped him because he had tirelessly worked on their behalf to get enough supplies from their homeland while campaigning in Ilangai. They also loved his down-to-earth attitude and the way he casually mingled with them.

As the prince moved amidst the feasting soldiers, many tried to talk to him by asking questions. “My prince, when will we lay siege to Pulathiya<sup>[155]</sup>?” The Prince gave varying answers to the same question, “What’s the point in attacking Pulathiya when Mahindan is in Rohana mountain?” while to some he said, “Be patient. Let us wait until the monsoon season ends, to start the siege.” Some soldiers expressed their displeasure in sitting idle while some said that they would wait patiently if the prince visited them at least once a month.

After speaking to the soldiers, the prince went to his tent along with Vandiya Devan and Azhwarkadiyan. “Did you see how enthusiastic these soldiers are? If I had got ample support from Thanjavur, we could have captured all of Ilangai by now? We squandered a wonderful opportunity there. Now that the monsoon has begun, our soldiers will have to be idle until this season lasts.”

“Prince, there are bigger things to worry about than capturing this Island. The kingdom that your ancestor Vijayalaya Chola established is under grave threat today. Plots and treason are disintegrating it.”

“You are right. You both have brought important messages for me while I am worrying about something trivial. All right, tell me what is happening in the Chola kingdom. Let the prince of the Vanar begin his story first.”

Vandiya Devan narrated all that had befallen him during his journey from Kanchi to Thanjavur. He also recounted his adventures and the very many ruses and tricks that he had employed to escape from his enemies. At the end of it he said, “Ayya, your father is almost imprisoned in his own palace. The noblemen who once swore a holy oath to serve and protect him are plotting against your family. Your sister, Princess Kundavai is gravely worried and requests you to come immediately to Pazhaiaarai.”

After this, Azhwarkadiyan began his story. He agreed with most of what Vandiya Devan had told and also told the prince about spying on Ravidasan and his gang at the Pallipadai near Thirupurampayam and their plans to destroy the Cholas. In the end, he added that as the kingdom faced so many threats and dangers, it would be best for the prince to remain in Ilangai for the time being.

“The Prime minister believes that it would be in the best interests of the kingdom if you complete the campaign in Ilangai. It is important that you gather the entire army and keep them garrisoned at North Ilangai under your command. Before long, those who plot against your family will come out with their true colours. Having an army at your disposal will add to your strength and that of your family’s. He also bid me to tell you that Kai Kola Padai<sup>[156]</sup>, Vanniyar Padai<sup>[157]</sup> and Vellar Padai<sup>[158]</sup> are ready to swear a holy oath pledging their swords at your feet.”

“Thirumalai! What does your Gurunathar think, he is? Is he under the illusion that he is Chanakya<sup>[159]</sup> reborn in this world? Does he want

me to fight with my brother and other relatives?”

“No ayya! My Gurunathar does not think thus. But isn’t it your duty to punish those who are plotting against the kingdom and your family?”

“How can I punish them? If these plots are truly happening then it is my father, the emperor, who must punish them. I cannot act without my father’s command.”

Vandiya Devan interjected now and said, “Prince, your father is not free anymore. He is under the guard of the Pazhuvur brothers. No one can approach him and talk freely. Your brother does not want to go to Thanjavur for some reason. In such a situation, it is your duty to protect your family. It is important that you leave Ilangai immediately and come with me to Pazhaiaarai.”

“Why should the prince go to Pazhaiaarai? I can’t understand it,” asked Azhwarkadiyan.

Before Vandiya Devan could answer, the prince said, “There is nothing worse in this world than a man’s greed for land. That alone can compel him to do vile deeds. I went to Simhagiri mountain fort today. Do you know the history of that place?”

“No,” said Vandiya Devan.

“Around 500 years ago, this Island kingdom was ruled by King Dadusenar. He had two sons, Kasiappan and Magallan. The commander of Dadusenar and Kasiappan plotted together to seize the throne. Kasiappan imprisoned his own father and became the king. Magallan crossed the seas and went to Tamilnadu. Meanwhile, Kasiappan raised the walls of his father’s prison and killed him. After committing this most heinous of crimes, Kasiappan was tormented by the thought that Magallan might come back one day to avenge their father. He came to Simhagiri fort as it is a stronghold that cannot be captured easily. He hid within its walls for about 18 years. One day, Magallan returned home with a large army - the Pandya

King had agreed to aid him. Kasiappan completely lost his mind and came out of his stronghold to confront his brother. As a result, he lost his life. That wretched scoundrel who killed his own father to ascend the throne had built that fortress. Within it are some of the most beautiful paintings and art that I have ever seen. They were made hundreds of years ago and yet they have not faded in time.”

“Ayya! Can I ask you something?” asked Thirumalai.

“Why this hesitation? Ask.”

“Isn’t Simhagiri fort under the command of the Ilangai army?”

“Yes. I have no intention of laying a siege to capture it. It will only lead to pointless loss of life.”

“I was not asking about that. I was more concerned about that fact that you entered the enemy’s fort with nary a thought for your safety. What possessed you to disguise yourself as a mahout and go along with those travellers from China? When I saw you mounted on the elephant’s back, I was astounded. I didn’t know whether I could believe my eyes. Why did you go to the enemy’s stronghold with no care for your life?”

“Is my life so precious, Thirumalai? Do you know how many soldiers from our land have lost their lives here?”

“My prince, those soldiers lost their lives on the battlefield while you sought to endanger it without any cause.”

“There was cause for my actions. I had two reasons to go to Simhagiri. I had always wished to see the beautiful paintings of Simhagiri and I fulfilled it today.”

“My prince, What about the second reason?”

“I knew that Parthibendra Pallavar was in Ilangai right after he came ashore in Trikona Malai<sup>[160]</sup>. I didn’t wish to see him today, so...”

“May I ask why?”

“I also knew that our Prime minister had come to Maandotham and was expecting a message from him. When I get messages from two elders, should I not give precedence to the one I get first?”

Vandiya Devan delighted by the prince’s reply said happily, “Well said, my prince. I have finally won!”

“My prince, he has tricked you!”

“He didn’t. I should rather say that I deliberately fell for his trick. When I sent that soldier to get you here, he pushed him off the horse and got on it instead. So, I wanted to teach him a lesson.”

“That was a good lesson indeed my prince! Each one of those lessons weigh rather heavily on my body. My body and chest throb with pain whenever I think about it. Is this how you would treat a messenger who brought you news from your sister? Never mind, if you are coming to Pazhaiaarai with me...”

“Thirumalai! I am reminded of an old poem that I heard long back.

“Kanchi orukaal mithiyaa oru kaalaal  
Thathuneerth thanthanjai thaamithiyaap – pitraiyum  
Eezham oru kaal mithiyaa varume nam  
Kozhiyar kokkillik kaliru!”

One of my ancestors was called Peru Killi Valavan and the bards sang about a wondrous elephant that he possessed. It was so huge that one of its legs was in Kanchi, while the other in Thanjavur, one other in Ilangai and another in Uraiyur.

Such was the poet's imagination. On this Island Kingdom there are hordes of wild elephants but what's the use? If only we could have one elephant like this, I could be in Kanchi, Thanjavur, Pazhaiaarai and in Ilangai at the same time?"

Vandiya Devan and Azhwarkadiyan laughed at this and then the Vaishnavan asked, "Since you don't have this magic elephant, what do you propose to do?"

"What's there to do? Haven't we decided that he would be coming with me to Pazhaiaarai?"

"Please defer your arguments for now. Let us go to Anuradhapuram tomorrow. I will meet Parthibendra Pallavan and then decide what to do," said the prince.

## **Chapter 33:**

### **The Statue's Message**

The next morning, Prince Arulmozhivarmar, Vandiya Devan and Azhwarkadiyan left for Anuradhapuram before dawn. They sped through the woods and reached the King's road soon. Vandiya Devan was surprised by the fact that the prince did not take his guards or an entourage along with him. Vandiya Devan felt exhilaration, pride and enthusiasm in equal measures all through the ride that morning.

He was exhilarated and proud because he had completed the mission that the princess had tasked him with. And that's not all. He had long wanted to meet the prince to whom the entire Chola Kingdom was devoted. He had accomplished that as well. He also reminisced about their meeting and still found himself surprised by how well the prince disguised himself and had attacked him when he least expected it.

Who could have thought that the prince would be the mahout and who knew that he would turn the horse suddenly and attack him?

The Prince was a strange man indeed! This is how he won the war in Ilangai by taking the enemy unawares and attacking them unexpectedly. Vandiya Devan was also very much taken by the prince's behaviour towards his soldiers. He was completely at ease with them and assumed no airs about being a prince. It was no wonder that the soldiers all over the Chola Kingdom were ready to give up their life for him.

What surprised him more was the benevolence that the prince showed the people of Ilangai. In which conquered land can the people go about their work freely without any fear or persecution? Looking around he saw how the people of Ilangai lived happily and secure in their villages while a war raged in their land. Women and



children who were usually the worst casualties of a war were laughing and smiling!

Vandiya Devan knew that the prince who rode next to him was the man responsible for their happiness. The prince had stubbornly refused to take food and supplies from the conquered people and had convinced his father to send supplies from their homeland. He remembered how this had irked the Pazhvur brothers who had complained to the emperor about the prince's unorthodox warfare in Ilangai.

He also remembered the battles that he had fought along with Aditya Karikalan. He couldn't help compare the Crown Prince's savage war tactics with his brother's benevolent warfare. Vandiya Devan never dared to criticize or think less of his master until then, but he couldn't help it when he noted the happy faces of the people of Ilangai. If his master, Prince Aditya Karikalar, had come campaigning here, would these people be so happy and at peace? He remembered the wails and cries of the people on whom the Crown Prince had warred. One could only see savagery, destruction and death wails of women who had lost their homes and families.

Vandiya Devan wanted to learn more about the prince and share information, opinions and news, but they were on galloping horses that were steadily speeding on the King's road. They did get one opportunity to talk.

They were nearing Anuradhapuram when they saw a huge statue of Buddha alongside the road. Vandiya Devan had seen many such statues in Ilangai and didn't find it strange. But the prince for some reason reined his horse and stopped it abruptly near the statue. The other two did the same and came near the prince. The Prince watched the statue intently for some time and then exclaimed, "Aha! What a beauty!"

"I don't see any beauty here. Ilangai is littered with such big statues everywhere though I wonder why?"

The Prince turned towards Vandiya Devan and smiled saying, “I am happy that you choose to speak whatever your heart feels, truthfully.”

“Ayya, let me assure you that he is speaking the truth only now.”

“Vaishnavarey! When I met you in Veeranarayanapuram, I found myself lying more and more with every passing day. But ever since I met the prince, I feel like speaking the truth. It is true that the company we keep decides our character for better or worse.”

The Prince, however, was not listening to their war of words. He was intently admiring the art of the Buddha statue when he said, “I have found that the art of carving stones does complete justice to two forms – one is the divine form of Natarajar<sup>[161]</sup> and the other is Buddha. But sadly, we do not make such massive statues for our gods in our kingdom.”

“There were many great kings who ruled over Ilangai in the past. Though their island was very small, they were large-hearted and their devotion was true and pure. They showed their devotion to Lord Buddha by building huge statues, gigantic stupas and monasteries. I am ashamed of the temples and the small statues that we have built to pray to our gods in our land.”

Saying thus, the prince dismounted from his horse and went near the statue and bowed low touching the lotus buds that adorned the feet of the Buddha statue. Then, he touched the feet of the Buddha worshipfully, turned around and mounted his horse. As they rode on at a slow trot, the prince heard Vandiya Devan comment, “What is this? Looks like the prince will join the faith of Buddha.”

“My friend! I have immense respect and faith for Lord Buddha but my piety has its own reasons. The lotus feet of Lord Buddha had a message for me.”

“Aha! But we didn’t hear any message.”

“The message was given to me in silence.”

“What message was it? Are we allowed to know?”

“I have been asked to come to near the Simhatharai Pond at midnight by Lord Buddha,” said Prince Arulmozhivarmar.

## Chapter 34: Anuradhapuram

They reached Anuradhapuram even as the sun was setting and the sight of the fortified city took Vandiya Devan's breath away. Many people had described this city to him and he had imagined it in his mind's eye as well, but nothing could compare to the vision that was unfolding in front of him. The walls of the fort were higher than any city walls that he had seen so far. Inside the walls, there were countless palaces, mansions, stupas<sup>[162]</sup> and monasteries built to dwarf a man with their gargantuan size.

Vandiya Devan was astonished to see them all within the walls of a single city! Anuradhapuram is indeed a wondrous city! It couldn't be compared with any other city that he had seen so far - Kanchipuram, Thanjavur or Pazhaiaarai. The great cities of Pataliputra<sup>[163]</sup> during the reign of Emperor Ashoka<sup>[164]</sup> and the ancient city of Ujjain<sup>[165]</sup> during Emperor Vikramaditya<sup>[166]</sup> and the drowned city of Kaveri Pattinam<sup>[167]</sup> during Karikala Vallavan's golden reign might be the only cities that could stand tall beside this.

As they neared the huge city walls, the throng of people entering it grew large. The native people of Ilangai, people of Tamil origin, monks, groups of women and children were moving towards the city with great enthusiasm. The entire atmosphere was electrifying and many in the crowd looked at the prince and his companions and started pointing out. Noting this, the prince signalled his friends to follow him and moved towards the woods that bordered the city walls. They waited silently in the thick woods while the crowd of people passed them by.

"The horses have come a long way. Let them rest awhile. We can enter the city later when it is dark."

They dismounted from their horses and sat down on the large rocks that were littered in the woods.

“What is happening in this city today? Why are so many people coming here?”

“The city of Anuradhapuram is hosting one of the biggest festivals celebrated in Ilangai.”

“I thought that there was a war happening in Ilangai, instead, I find only festivals being celebrated,” said Vandiya Devan cheekily.

“Didn’t you tell me about the Krishna Jayanthi<sup>[168]</sup> festival being celebrated in Pazhaiaarai?”

“Yes, I did but Pazhaiaarai is in the Chola Kingdom, while Anuradhapuram is in Ilangai.”

“That’s right. Sundara Cholar reigns over the Chola Kingdom while his chosen lord rules over Ilangai.”

“But there is a war happening in Ilangai and there are enemies still around.”

“Our enemies are very far away. What would these people do about it? The war will happen only amidst our soldiers and Mahindan’s army. The people of this kingdom cannot be blamed for the foolish actions of their cowardly king. Therefore, they will celebrate their festivals unhindered, while we will battle the king’s forces far away from here. Thirumalai! What do you say?”

“Prince! You have enemies here who are hiding in the mountains whilst in your homeland, there are those who conspire behind your back. They are the most dangerous enemies that one could hope to meet. I think that the prince ought to stay here and destroy his enemies while conducting festivals for these people.”

“That is ridiculous. If these conspirators are more dangerous than the enemies here, then the prince ought to be in the Chola land to expose and punish them. Great warriors ought to be in places where great danger lurks.”

“Now that is beyond ridiculous. Courage and foolhardiness are two different things. If you truly believe that great warriors ought to be in places where danger lurks, then why did you escape and come here?”

“Enough. Please do not start a war here,” said the prince pacifying the two.

They entered the city silently after the darkness had enveloped it like a thick blanket. There was no restriction for entry to the fort and the soldiers stood aside watching them silently.

Crowds thronged the streets of Anuradhapuram and the festive air was stimulating. Many in the crowd shouted ‘Sadhu! Sadhu!’ in appreciation. Vandiya Devan also noted that many monasteries and mansions lay in a dilapidated condition while some had been rebuilt. This led him to wonder about the prince’s strange behaviour towards the people he had conquered.

Why is he so benevolent to the people here?

For more than a thousand years, the kings of Ilangai had been interfering in the affairs of their kingdom by helping their sworn enemies, the Pandyas. No one would fault the prince for destroying this capital city by razing it to the ground, but he did not do that. Instead, he is courting the good will of the people, he had conquered and is rebuilding their city and if that’s not enough he is permitting them to celebrate their traditional festivals.

He felt that the prince must have an ulterior motive to be so benevolent to the people of Ilangai and then out of nowhere a germ of thought grew.

*What if the prince wished to rule this Kingdom on his own? He has no right to the ancient throne of Cholas with his elder brother being the heir apparent and his uncle Madhuranthakan wanting to ascend it as well. That's why he wants to establish an independent kingdom on his own in Ilangai. And what's going to stop this Prince from becoming a king? That's why that Kudanthai Jodhidar compared the prince to Dhruva Nakshatram<sup>[169]</sup>. Didn't he also say that those who believe in him would never be disappointed?*

After reaching this conclusion, Vandiya Devan was very happy that he was with the prince after so many adventures and mishaps.

Soon they were standing outside a dilapidated palace. Dismounting from their horses, they looked around and found that the palace was in a secluded region of the city. The prince went near the palace gates and clapped his hands thrice. Almost like magic, a door opened for them. The prince went towards the door and soon was climbing the stairs to the upper portions of the palace despite the darkness. When Vandiya Devan turned around to see the fate of their horses, the prince said, "The horses know the way," and took his hand to drag him up the stairs. After climbing the stairs in the dark, they entered the inner-most rooms of the palace where oil lamps glittered in the dark.

"We need to be careful here. This is the palace of Emperor Mahasenar<sup>[170]</sup> and these rooms probably belonged to his queens. Who knows he might even come here in his spirit form?"

"Who is Mahasenar?" asked Vandiya Devan.

"Emperor Mahasenar ruled over Ilangai almost 600 years ago. He was a very good and benevolent king and the people were very happy under his rule. They believe that he watches over his kingdom even today as a ghost. They leave clothes for him on the trees here lest he get cold in the night. After he died, no one lives in his palace out of respect to his memory, replied the prince."

Yet there were servants to look after their needs that night in the palace. They had a refreshing bath and had their dinner before joining the prince in the uppermost balcony that overlooked the city.

“Ayya! Didn’t that Buddha’s statue ask you come somewhere at midnight?”

“We have time. The moon has just risen. We can leave when the moon touches the pinnacle of that dagaba (stupa),” said the prince and pointed to the stupa that stood near the palace. They were originally called as ‘dadugarbam’ but with the passage of time, they were now called ‘dagaba’.

“Why did they build everything so big?” asked Vandiya Devan.

“Earlier the kings wanted to tell the people that Lord Buddha was very big. The kings who came later wanted to prove to the people that they were greater than Buddha himself. Hence they tried to outdo themselves by building bigger palaces.”

Suddenly they heard sounds of a huge procession marching through the road outside the palace. Hundreds of decorated elephants stood out clearly among the hundreds of thousands of people holding flaming torches.

Surprised to see such a huge procession, Vandiya Devan asked the prince, “What is this? It looks like an army ready to invade!”

“No. This is one of the most important festivals celebrated in Ilangai – the Perahera Festival<sup>[171]</sup>.”

As the procession neared their palace, Vandiya Devan’s astonishment increased. Never in his life had he seen such a grand spectacle of pomp and piety.



The elephants came first, richly decorated in gold and silk, steadily walking in a formation, trumpeting proudly. Among the thirty elephants that walked on, there was one in the centre that was regal in appearance and more richly decorated than the others. On its back, it carried an ornate box studded with precious gems. It also carried a royal umbrella signifying its importance. People carrying decorative lamps and torches walked along with the elephants while numerous Buddha bikshus [\[172\]](#) came bearing white-feathered fans.

Behind the elephants came a huge crowd of people wearing different costumes and dancing rhythmically to the clanging of bells and drums. Many of them played hand-drums while the others moved forward dancing their way through the procession. Vandiya Devan was fascinated by their dance as he compared it with yet another dance that he had seen many days ago at Kadambur but found that Devaralan's performance couldn't match the enthusiasm and the vigour of these dancers.

A few hundred dancers spiritedly spiralled themselves forward and threw themselves up in the air with such ease that one might suspect them to be boneless. The pomp and pageantry of the festival were such that two pairs of eyes were not enough to drink it in! The shouts and encouragement of the crowd and the music of the pipes made the festival more enjoyable for Vandiya Devan.

As the procession moved on another battalion of thirty elephants richly decorated, came escorting yet another royal elephant bearing an ornate gem-studded box on its back and royal umbrella guarding it. Yet another procession of dancers dressed as Hindu gods, Lord Indra, Rati[\[173\]](#), Manmadhan[\[174\]](#), Shiva[\[175\]](#), Parvathi[\[176\]](#) and many more gods followed.

"How is this possible? How did Lord Shiva come here?" asked Vandiya Devan.

"There was once an King called Gajabah and he brought Lord Shiva to this Island Kingdom and since then he has been here.

“Veera Vaishnaverey! Did you see that? Have you finally realized who the bigger god is?” And before he could finish the question, few more elephants came by followed by dancers dressed as Garuda bearing Lord Vishnu. As they passed by dancing and cheering, the Vaishnavan turned triumphantly towards Vandiya Devan and said, “You see my boy, even Maha Vishnu has come here.”

Next came dancers dressed like soldiers bearing arms and spears dancing a vigorous war dance unlike any they had seen. With jingling bells in their legs and hands, their dance was alternatively robust and graceful. Vandiya Devan who was fascinated by the festival asked the prince about its history.

The island kingdom of Ilangai and the southern kings were not always at war. There was a time when they were friends and bound by marriage. King Gajabahu and the Chera king of those times Cheran Senguttuvan were bound by friendship and when the Ilangai king visited him once he witnessed the pomp and pageantry of the Kannagi<sup>[177]</sup> festival celebrated to venerate women for their chastity.

Fascinated by these festivals, Gajabahu stayed on to witness the other festivals that were celebrated for other gods – Shiva, Vishnu, Karthikeya<sup>[178]</sup>, Durga Parameshwari<sup>[179]</sup>. Later when the Chera king came on a visit to Ilangai, Gajabahu venerated these gods at a single festival that rivalled Senguttuvan’s pageantry. When the people of Ilangai rejoiced and participated in this festival with great enthusiasm he decreed that this festival would be held every year. Lord Buddha holds a special place in the festival and would be venerated first among the gods though.

“But I didn’t see the gods anywhere in this procession,”

“Didn’t you see the decorated elephants carrying an ornate box studded with gems?”

“Yes. I saw. Have they locked the gods inside that? Are they afraid that they will fly across the sea, back to their homes?”

Ponniyin Selvar laughed at his comment and said, “No. That’s not so. The first elephant that came with the box had a tooth that belonged to Lord Buddha. It is one of the most sacred and priceless relics protected by the monasteries of this Kingdom.”

“What did the other boxes have?” asked Vandiya Devan.

“Since they couldn’t find the tooth of Lord Shiva, Vishnu, Murugan and Kannagi, they have kept the divine jewels that these gods wore in the boxes and have mounted them on the elephants.”

Vandiya Devan thought for a while and then said, “Aha! If Periya Pazhuvetarayar had come leading the army here...”

Just then the last of the procession passed by the streets clanging bells and beating drums noisily and the prince said, “It will be midnight soon. Let us leave now,”

They came downstairs onto the streets started walking away from the direction of the procession. The streets were deserted as they walked through them and soon they were near a lake. Silent ripples of water made small waves even as the moon shone brightly upon it. They neared the lake and stood for a while watching the water.

By the lake were many pillars and the ruins of a fountain shaped like a lion’s mouth.

Vandiya Devan tried to remember the Buddha statue that they had seen on their way to Anuradhapuram. There was a row of lotus buds arranged below the statue. The Prince had counted the number of buds as twelve. That seemed to indicate the hour of the meeting and since they were buds, it probably meant night. He also remembered a small vessel with the face of a lion engraved on it. That probably referred to the name of the lake.

All this is fine and good but what are we here for? Who could have asked the prince to come here? Who knew what dangers could lurk for him here? He had forbidden them from bringing their arms. Could this perchance be a romantic tryst?

Vandiya Devan's thoughts took wings across the sea to Pazhaiaarai and his mind's eye could see Princess Kundavai and Princess Vanathi. He thought that he should speak to the prince and learn more about whom they will be meeting today.

"Ayya! This place looks like an old palace garden,"

"You are right. Thousands of years ago, there was a beautiful garden here overlooking the palace of King Dushtagamanu. Look there! You will see some portions of the palace standing amidst the ruins."

Vandiya Devan looked at the place where the prince had pointed out and said, "They might be private chambers of the queen. Who knows - those royal women might even have bathed in these waters every day."

"A very strange thing happened in this garden during the time of King Dushtagamanu. The king had a son name Saali and he was wandering in these pleasure gardens one day when he chanced upon a beautiful maiden. She was watering the plants in the garden and the prince fell madly in love with her. But she was a Chandala<sup>[180]</sup> and her name was Asokamala. The prince refused to listen to reason and resolutely declared that he would marry her, despite his father's threats to disinherit him. When the king refused to consent, the prince refused the crown and the throne, just so that he could marry that girl. Would any other prince in this world have the courage to sacrifice a throne, just to satisfy his heart's desire?"

When the prince spoke thus, Vandiya Devan was reminded of yet another girl who had lost her heart to him.

Was the prince thinking of Samudra Kumari when he recounted the tale of love?

Even while he was thinking about how to ask about that, something strange happened. There was a curved stone seat near the wall behind the fountain big enough to seat two people. Suddenly a light appeared in the farthest corner of the seat and a Buddha bikshu appeared, bearing a lamp in his hands.

Gaping at this sight with great astonishment, Vandiya Devan wondered what would happen next.

## **Chapter 35:**

### **The Throne of Ilangai**

The bikshu who had suddenly appeared, looked around as though he was searching for someone. When he found the prince standing near the fountain, he climbed the stairs to join them. He looked at the prince's face for a while and said, "Devapriya! Welcome. Vaithulya Bikshu Sangam awaits your presence eagerly. Our leader, Maha Dero Guru has come for this meeting. I am happy that you were able to come here at the appointed time."

"Adigaley! I am but a mere boy with many faults but I have never gone back on my word," answered the prince.

"We were worried when we learned that you had not arrived in the city even after the sun had set."

"If I had come early to the city, we might not have come here on time."

"We know that there are those who would seek to harm you. With the blessings of Lord Buddha, your enemies will disappear like dust in the storm," he said and continued, "Who are these people? Do you know them well? Are they completely trustworthy? Will they keep their word and their silence?"

"Adigaley! I trust them as completely as I would trust mine own hands. Nonetheless, if you wish, I am prepared to leave them here and come with you alone."

"No! No! We are not prepared to shoulder such a big responsibility. Though the place that I would be taking you is perfectly safe, one can never tell where danger might lurk. God knows what is hidden behind the darkest of corners and pillars. Let them come with you."

Vandiya Devan's heart raced with excitement when he heard this. He felt gratified when he learned that the prince said that he trusted him completely despite the fact that he had known him for a short time. He had intuitively known that the prince had set out that night on a very important mission. He knew that something very important was about to unfold!

The bikshu strode forward with his lamp held high while the others followed him towards the fountain's stone seat. Within the alcove, the Bikshu opened the secret entrance that lay within the walls. An underground path opened up for them and they entered it. After they were inside the cavernous dungeon, the Bikshu closed the walls using a lever hidden cleverly within the walls. They were now beneath a dungeon that was right under the fountain and possibly even the lake.

The underground path wound its way almost endlessly. The echoes of their footsteps were heard magnified a hundred times in the hollow cavern that lay ahead. Vandiya Devan, despite his excitement, couldn't help wondering whether the prince was walking into a trap.

Soon enough the rocky path of the dungeon ended to make way for a marble mandapam that was built underneath the ground. There were various statues of Lord Buddha in his many forms. Some were lying, some meditating while some were standing. After walking past the marble mandapam, the path became rough again until they entered a mandapam made of some exotic wood. The pillars of this mandapam were carved exquisitely with beautiful art while the roof was painted with some beautiful murals. Soon after they passed this, they came upon a mandapam that was made from ivory. Walking past them, Vandiya Devan looked around and tried to touch the pillars that were embellished with precious stones but the prince didn't look around.

After crossing across mandapams made of different metals, they entered a stone mandapam. While the rest of the mandapams that

they had passed were empty, save for Buddha statues, this mandapam was filled with Buddha Bikshus. Calm and serene, many of them looked like men of great wisdom and piety. At the centre of the mandapam sat their leader, Maha Dero Guru and opposite to them there was a golden throne and on it lay a golden crown and a royal sceptre. The mandapam was well lit from all directions making the throne glow with an ethereal light.

When the prince and his companions entered the mandapam, the Bikshus stood up to welcome him with chants, “Long Live Buddha!” “Long Live Dharma!” “Long Live Sangam!”

The Prince moved towards the Guru and bowed low in respect. The Guru acknowledged his salutations and motioned him to sit on a stone seat next to him.

“Guruvey! You are older and wiser than I am. I beg of you to seat yourself first,” said the prince and sat in his seat only after the old guru had taken his seat.

“Beloved Prince! This Maha Bodhi Sangam is delighted by your arrival. You accepted all our conditions and have graced us with your presence despite various hardships that lay in your path. This proves that you have the complete grace of Lord Buddha’s blessings.” Spoke the guru in Pali<sup>[181]</sup> while the Bikshu who had escorted them translated it into Tamil for them. The monks added their voice to the guru’s welcome and shouted ‘Sadhu!’ ‘Sadhu!’

Maha Guru continued, “We are indebted to Bharathakandam<sup>[182]</sup> for bringing the faith of Lord Buddha to this island kingdom. But sadly, hordes of invaders too came in their wake; Cholas, Pandyas, Cheras, and Kalingas who brought death and destruction to our people. They razed our monasteries to the ground, put our monks to the sword and brought grief upon our people and thereby incurred a deathly curse upon their race. I do not hold only the invaders responsible for our loss. Even our own kings have mercilessly killed countless innocents and have burned our holy monasteries to the



ground. They hunted the monks who dared to raise their voice against such injustice and killed them without any remorse. There was a time when our sacred monasteries occupied this vast stretch of land from end to end but now they lay as dilapidated ruins. None of our kings took an effort to rebuild them for us. That honour lay reserved for Prince Arulmozhivarmar. Beloved prince! Our Maha Sangam is forever in your debt!"

The prince bowed his head low and acknowledged Maha Guru's praise. The guru continued, "Hundred years ago, this city was under the control of the Pandyas and the royal family of Ilangai was in Pulathiya. Since then, this festival has not been celebrated here. It was written by the gods that this festival should be held in this sacred year and by your royal commands. Despite many challenges, you allowed our people to celebrate this holy festival and lent us all manner of help to conduct it. The Maha Sangam is delighted by this action of yours."

The Prince reverentially bowed his head and said, "Maha Guruvey! I am at your disposal. If you need anything else, you just need to command me."

The Maha Guru smiled at Prince's words and said, "Yes beloved prince! We have many great expectations from you and we hope that you would fulfil them. Before I talk about that, allow me to say a few words.

"You must have heard that Lord Buddha was born as many other avatars before he was reborn in this world. We believe that he was born as Sibi Chakravarthy in this world to teach us the value of each and every living being. He sought to save the life of a small pigeon by carving out a piece of his own flesh. You Cholas venerate this great emperor as your ancestor and name yourself 'Sembian' to honour his memory but the Buddha Sangams never believed these stories. We thought that it was merely a tale that poets and bards loved to repeat but after seeing your great deeds in this war-torn

Ilangai, we concede defeat and agree wholeheartedly that you are a worthy scion of Sibi's illustrious race.

"We believe that everything happens for a reason and that's why Lord Buddha has showered you with his grace and mercy. We have received divine orders from him. Look here!" he said and pointed towards another Bikshu who sat reclining on a pillar. The other Bikshus lifted him along with his seat and brought him near them.

The bikshu's body was shivering uncontrollably and his head lolled from one side to another. The Maha Guru said, "The gods have descended upon this bikshu. They have brought a message for you."

The shivering bikshu spoke many words in an unknown language while his bloodshot eyes looked hither and thither.

"Beloved prince! The gods have deigned to shower their bountiful blessings upon you. Hundreds of years ago, Emperor Ashoka brought the entire Bharatakandan under his rule with the blessings of Lord Buddha. The gods say that you too will do that same. You will follow in Ashoka's steps and bring glory and peace to Ilangai. You too would spread the faith of Buddha all over the world just as Ashoka did. Ashoka made Pataliputra one of the greatest cities in this world. The gods say that you too will do the same with Anuradhapuram. Beloved Prince! Do you accept the order of the gods?"

The Prince bowed his head again and said, "Maha Guru! I am ready to fulfil the command of the gods but I do not understand what they want of me?"

"I will tell you about it," said the Maha Guru and signalled his disciples to remove the possessed bikshu.

"Beloved Prince! Please look at this throne here, this crown and sceptre. They belong to the royal family of Ilangai. The kings of Ilangai have donned this crown and with the royal sceptre in hand,

they have ascended the throne to rule over this Kingdom and have been recognized by this Maha Sangam. This is the very throne where kings like Dushtagamnu, Devampiya Tissa, and Mahasenar sat and reigned this island kingdom justly. This is the crown that they wore and the royal sceptre that they wielded. We offer you this ancient throne and this kingdom, will you accept it?"

Vandiya Devan who had been listening to the Maha Guru intently was thrilled with anticipation. If he had not reined in his eagerness, he might have bodily lifted the prince and placed him on the throne. But there was no eagerness or shock in the prince's face. With a calm voice, he replied, "Maha Guru! How is this possible? The king of Ilangai, King Mahindan is still alive, even though he is in hiding."

"Prince! The gods have willed the royal dynasty of Ilangai to change and it will happen. This royal dynasty that was established by King Vijayarajan from Vanga Nadu has seen many Kings. Some followed the strict code of Dharma and reigned the kingdom righteously, while many others invited the curse of the gods through their heinous crimes. This kingdom has seen kings where a father killed his own son, the son killed his own father, a brother killed his brother, a mother killed her own daughter while the daughter-in-law killed her mother-in-law. This dynasty has committed many such grievous sins and is rightly cursed by the gods. They can no longer uphold the divine teachings of Lord Buddha, therefore, they have lost the right to the throne. Our Maha Sangam holds the right to select the next king and we have chosen you. If you accept this honour, we can crown you the king of Ilangai, right away and hold the coronation ceremony."

The Mandapam fell silent after Maha Guru's declaration. It was a silence that could only be compared to the stillness that one might feel at the core of the earth. Not even a draw of breath was heard as the bikshus waited with bated breath to hear the prince's response. Vandiya Devan's eagerness became a fevered anticipation when the prince rose to bow down to the assembly. His heart sang over a hundred songs and he was ready to crown the prince himself.

The prince said, “Wise men of Maha Sangam! Please accept my salutations. I humbly bow my head for the honour that you want to bestow upon me. You offer this ancient throne and the kingdom of Ilangai to this mere boy but sadly, I cannot accept it. I was born in the Chola Kingdom and the waters of Kaveri and the food of Ponni have made this body of mine. I came here at the behest of my father, Emperor Sundara Chola and I cannot accept this kingdom that you offer without learning his wishes.”

Maha Guru interjected here and said, “Beloved prince! Do you know that your father lies imprisoned in his palace?”

“My father is paralyzed in both his legs and is incapacitated from moving. Despite that, I am bound to follow the commands of the lords who govern the realm in his name. If I accept this kingdom without their consent, I will be known a traitor and would be guilty of conspiracy.”

“If you feel thus, then we are ready to send a party of envoys to Thanjavur with our request. Your father has great regard for the faith of Buddha and his patronage to our faith is well known. He will not refuse us.”

“What about the people of this kingdom? Isn’t their consent important?”

“The people of this kingdom will consider it an honour to have you as their king.”

“Everyone might accept this and might even be happy. But you must know that more than anybody else I respect the wishes of my sister, Princess Kundavai Devi. My mother gave birth to me, River Ponni saved my life but it was my sister who gave me the knowledge and opened my eyes to this world. I hold her in high regard but I might even ignore her words but I cannot ignore the voice of my heart.

Maha Guru! Sadly, my heart asks me not to accept this great honour that you wish upon me. Please forgive me.”

There was impenetrable silence in the chambers for a while. Vandiya Devan’s heart and veins were throbbing as he sought to hold his silence.

After a while, Maha Guru said, “Beloved prince, I am not surprised by your answer. It wouldn’t be amiss to say that I had expected it. This decision of yours makes you even more worthy of this ancient throne than anybody else. We who have lived our lives in Dharma and possess the knowledge of the same can vouch for this but we do not wish to force this decision upon you. Do consider our request and reflect upon it. After a year, we will meet again and you can give your final decision then. However, do remember one thing. Hundreds of monasteries have been destroyed in many foolish wars. But this Maha Bodhi Viharam has survived them all because it is built under the ground. Without the guidance of the bikshus convened here, no one can enter this place. The kings of Ilangai are invited to this monastery only once during their lifetime - for their coronation ceremony. This is a sacred monastery and you shall not talk about what happened within its precincts and neither shall your friends. If you do, the curse of the gods will descend upon you.”

“Maha Guru! There is no need for a curse. My friends will not talk about what they saw here. You have my word,” Ponniyin Selvar humbly replied.

After half hour, they were once again on the streets of Anuradhapuram. Vandiya Devan, who had until then held his emotions and thoughts in check, gave them a free rein.

“I agree that the Chola Kingdom is very beautiful indeed but it is incomparable with this island kingdom. How did your heart permit you to refuse the throne of such a beautiful land? They offered you this lovely island on a platter and you kick it away as if it is distasteful. And these bikshus are so witless, they want to crown to

someone who would refuse it, while I was standing right there. Couldn't they have offered it to me?"

The prince tried to pacify him saying, "I told you about Saali who renounced his right to the throne for the love of Asokamala. Didn't you hear it?"

"I heard it but who is this woman that you love so much that you wish to renounce this beautiful island."

"Not one woman but two. Truth and Dharma are the two women that I am in love with. I refused the crown of Ilangai for them."

"Prince! Your speech belies your age. You look so young and yet you speak like an old man," said Vandiya Deva.

The prince replied walking in the shade of an old dilapidated palace, "Young and old is a matter of introspection. How do we know who is young and whose time is about to end in this world?"

Just then, they heard the sound of someone clapping their hands in the street. A woman stood waiting for them across the street. The prince immediately turned in her direction and said, "Come this way."

The others followed the prince and crossed the street after him. And even as they were crossing, they heard the rumbling of the stone behind and to their horror saw that the palace that they were walking by had collapsed. If they had tarried for a few more seconds they would have been buried under the rubble. The prince's words, "How do we know who is young and whose time is about to end in this world?" seemed more meaningful now that they escaped within an inch of being buried alive.

Vandiya Devan, shocked and astonished by the sudden turn of events, stood for a while looking at the rubble and then turned towards the prince.

With the moonlight streaming almost peacefully on the streets,  
Vandiya Devan's heart missed a beat when he saw the woman who  
was standing in the street.

What is this foolishness? Why do my eyes betray me thus? How is  
this possible? How could Nandini Devi who lives under the watchful  
eyes of the Pazhuvur lord come here? Why should she stand on the  
streets of Anuradhapuram?

Even before his astonishment of finding her there could dissipate,  
she had vanished leaving the prince and the Vaishnavan on the  
streets.

## **Chapter 36:**

### **Is there any value for title or talent?**

Vandiya Devan crossed the street hurriedly to reach the place where the prince and Nandini stood. By the time he was across the street, he was not sure whether he had seen Nandini at all.

How could it be Nandini?

Though her face had resembled Nandini's, she was attired simply like a sanyasi, with no jewels and her wind-blown hair moving in waves around her.

By the time Vandiya Devan had reached the prince, the woman had disappeared among the shadows of the dilapidated mansion that stood on the other side.

"Ayya! Who is that woman? She looked very familiar," said Vandiya Devan.

Azhwarkadiyan who had lumbered behind him said, "Whoever that woman was, I am inclined to worship her as a goddess. If she had not clapped her hands and called us to the other side, we would be rotting under the rubble," pointing opposite the street where the massive stones of the mansion lay piled like a small hillock. The rubble from the mansion was big enough to bury an elephant underneath and would have killed them almost instantly.

"You were right to call her a goddess. If she had not warned us on time, we would have died," said the prince.

"Prince! What did you call that woman?" asked Vandiya Devan.

"Why do you ask that? Why did you try to follow her?" asked the prince.



“This Vaishnavan called her a goddess, while to my eyes she resembled the she-demon who has come to destroy the Chola dynasty.”

“Whom are you referring to?”

“I might be hallucinating but to my eyes, she seemed like the younger wife of Periya Pazhuvetarayar, Nandini Devi. Didn’t you notice the resemblance?”

“I didn’t see properly. Nonetheless, you are probably imagining things. How could the Pazhuvur queen Nandini Devi come to Ilangai and stand on its streets alone?” asked Azhwarkadiyan.

“We cannot dismiss what he says as imagination or hallucination. Even I have felt that there is a remarkable resemblance between them. Come! Let us leave this place,”

Instead of walking along the shadows of the mansions and palaces they walked in the middle of the street.

“Prince! The woman who called you across the street, what did she say?”

“She said that two assassins have come here to slay me in cold blood. She said that they would bide their time for the right opportunity.”

“My God! Was it us that she was warning you about?”

Ponniyin Selvar laughed at Vandiya Devan’s horrified statement and said, “No. She didn’t specify and say that it was you two. But it doesn’t matter if it was because she also said that I have a long life ahead. She has saved me from many mishaps ever since I have come here.”

“Ayya! I know who has come here to kill you. I saw them accompanying Parthibendra Pallavan when he came here searching for you. I saw two shadows moving through the ruins of that mansion that almost fell on us. I am sure it must be them.”

“Ayya Vaishnavarey! You are telling now! You both walk ahead, let me inspect those ruins for these assassins,” said Vandiya Devan and tried to turn back but the prince caught his hand and stopped him.

“It is pointless to search for them now. We can deal with them later. You are not to move away from me until I command otherwise. I came to this ruin of a city without any entourage or bodyguards because you were accompanying me. Would you abandon me in the middle of the streets in the dead of the night? What would I do if somebody attacks me after you left?”

The Prince’s words charmed Vandiya Devan and he immediately said, “Ayya! I swear I will not leave you alone even for a second.”

To this Azhwarkadiyan said, “I too swear on my Lord that I will never leave you alone for a second. You can be the prince’s armour while I will be yours.”

After walking for a short while, they reached Mahasenar’s<sup>[183]</sup> palace. A large airy room was readied for them to rest with three large bedsteads to lie down. The three of them lay down. Cool moonlight from the large open windows bathed the room.

“Hundreds of years ago, in this palace kings, queens, princes and princesses probably lay on these very beds and the moon probably peeped on them through those windows just as it does now. How disappointing that it should find ordinary people like us, lying down here?”

“Ayya! You are free to call this Vaishnavan and yourself anything that you choose but I beseech you, do not call me ‘ordinary’.”

“Of course, I forget. You are no ordinary man. You are the prince of Vallam.”

“Yes, I am. I could even tell you what some bards had sung about my ancestors but I am afraid that this Vaishanvan might just die of jealousy.”

“While that may be true, Thirumalai also appreciates great poetry, so let us hear this poem.”

Yen Kavigai Yenduvassam  
Yenkiriyidu yenpari edhu enbarey –  
Mangavan Maavendhan  
Vaanan Varisai Parisu  
Pettre paavendarai, Vendhar Parthu

Ponniyin Selvar listened to it intently and said, “Thirumalai! You are a poet too, tell me the meaning of this poem?”

“Ayya! Looks like you are testing me. Here is the meaning. Outside the palace of the great Vanar king, lords and chieftains are waiting for an audience. But they have to wait for their turn because the king is busy with the poets and bards. Their poems and songs delight him so much that he gives them many gifts and tokens of appreciation. Some get gold coins, while some get bejewelled umbrellas, some take home huge haarams and bracelets studded with large precious stones. Some get elephants, chariots and horses too!

As each one of the poets come out of the palace, the Lords and Chieftains who are waiting outside watch them jealously riding away with the treasures that they had gifted the king once. “Oh no! That’s my chariot!” “That’s my palanquin” “That god forsaken poet is riding away on my best horse!” Such was the greatness of the Vanar king who would reward true talent with the best of the treasures. My prince! Am I correct?”

“How can I fault your interpretation Thirumalai? What a lovely poem this is? What imagination? If only we knew who the poet was! Prince of Vallam, It does not matter whether your kingdom was big or small when a poem such as this was sung for your ancestors. They were great indeed. And you, a scion of this dynasty has as much right as the kings of Ilangai to sleep on this royal bed. It wouldn’t be amiss to say that you are entitled to sleep even on King Dushtagamanu’s royal bed if it is available.”

“Yes! Yes! I am entitled to many things indeed. But sadly, there is no respect for the title and no value for talent in this sad world. Did those bikshus offer the crown of Ilangai to me? No indeed! Instead, they offered to it to someone who was happy to refuse it. I felt very angry when they did that. I almost grabbed the crown from their hands and would have crowned myself the king. I had to control myself because I didn’t want this Vaishnavan competing with me.

Ponniyin Selvar laughed at Vandiya Devan’s hilarious wishes for a while and said, “Didn’t I tell you about truth and dharma? Don’t you think they are enough reasons to refuse the crown of Ilangai?”

“I once used to be fascinated by truth and dharma, Prince, but I have henceforth decided that I will have nothing to do with them.”

“Aha! Why do you want to take such a decision? Why so much anger against them?”

“I am not angry with them. Didn’t you tell me that you were in love with two maidens called Truth and Dharma? How can I think about women who belong to somebody else?”

Ponniyin Selvan laughed yet again at his funny repartee and said, “I am yet to meet another man who jokes so well.”

“Yes, ayya! It’s all a joke to you while I am sitting here regretting a lost opportunity. You didn’t want the throne of Ilangai, which is fine

with me. But then, you could have turned towards me and said, 'Please give it to him'" asked Vandiya Devan with mock anger.

After Ponniyin Selvar had laughed his fill, he said, "Vandiya Devarey! Accepting the throne means accepting the responsibilities of ruling a kingdom and let me assure you, that is not a mean task. And I don't think it is proper to accept the kingdom from the Buddha bikshus. I have always believed that religious leaders ought to stop with leading the people towards the faith. They must not interfere in the affairs of the kingdom. If they do, it will lead to disasters that will not only affect the kingdom and the people but also their faith. Moreover, the Maha Sangam that we met today does not represent all those who follow the faith of Buddha. There are two more Maha Sangams in this kingdom who believe that they have the right to choose the next king. If I had accepted the crown from them, I would be expected to rule the kingdom as per their wishes while the other two Maha Sangams would be against me."

"Does the prince of Vallam understand the situation here?" asked Azhwarkadiyan.

"Yes. I understand. There are fools in our kingdom who would fight and riot about who the bigger god is – Vishnu or Shiva. In the same manner, we have fools here, fighting over other gods."

"Please, don't start fighting again. It is very late in the hour and I can hear the people who had gone to the Perahara festival coming back. Let us get some sleep," said the prince.

"I can't sleep until I know the identity of the woman who saved us from being buried alive in the rubble."

"I do not know who she is but I do know many things about her. If you wish to know more, come and sit here" said the prince.

## **Chapter 37:**

### **Kaveri Amman**

Vandiya Devan and Azhwarkadiyan got up eagerly and sat on the ground near the prince's bed.

“When I was a small boy, I travelled along with my parents on the royal barge on the river Kaveri. My brother and sister too had accompanied us on this pleasure trip but they were busy discussing something. I loved to watch the river flow by, while sitting on the barge. Kadamba flowers would float on the river, and sometimes the current would try to pull them underwater. I used to lean down from the barge and try to rescue the flowers one by one. Once when I was at it, I slipped and fell headlong into the river. I still remember the impact of banging my head on the bottom of the river. When I tried to surface, I was caught in the river current that pushed me in the opposite direction.

“Somewhere in a distance, I could hear people shouting but I was helpless and found myself drifting along with the strong current. My hands had begun to feel weak and I thought that I would drown. My last thoughts at that time were about my family - my parents, brother, sister and all my relatives and friends, who would mourn me. Just before I became unconscious, I felt that someone was lifting me from the water. I opened my eyes and saw that a woman was holding me aloft. Though I saw her face for a few seconds, time could not erase that memory. Her face remained etched in my mind for many years and I still remember wondering about the fact that she looked very familiar to me but her identity was a mystery.

“The woman handed me over to someone and within a few moments, I was back on the barge with my family. Their distress and relief distracted me and I basked in their love. It took a while for them to ask around for the person who had rescued me from certain death. When they asked me, I looked around the barge searching for

the face of that beautiful woman but couldn't find her there. In the end, everybody decided that it was the goddess Kaveri who must have saved me from drowning. Since then, my mother arranges for a puja every year to honour the river goddess Ponni.

"It didn't really matter to me whether it was really mother Kaveri who saved my life because I only wished to look upon that woman's divine face once again. Many a time, when I had strolled by the river bank I would look around, wishing to see whether the goddess would rise above the waters so that I might gaze upon her again.

"As years passed, I had come to believe that she was no goddess but an ordinary woman but my quest didn't end. Whenever I was among the people for a festival or a temple function, I would look at the faces of the women there, hoping against hope to catch the glimpse of the woman who had saved me. When I came of age, I realized I ought to stop looking at the womenfolk thus lest people misconstrued my intention. Also, by then, I had lost hope of seeing her ever again.

"About a year ago, I came here as the commander to lead our forces into battle. Commander Budhi Vikrama Kesari who had reached here ahead of me had captured many cities and this city of Anuradhapuram which had changed hands many times was then under the control of King Mahindan. Our forces had laid siege to this city. I was new to this island kingdom and wanted to learn more about this place, therefore, the Commander handpicked about a thousand soldiers and sent them along with me. I set out with them to see the places that we had captured, cities, mountains, woods and forests. I also visited many beautiful islets and islands that are near the mainland. Once when we were on our way to the city, we were encamped in the woods that were near Yaanai Iravu<sup>[184]</sup>. At this place, the sea waters from both sides enter a narrow channel. Herds of elephants use that route to move across the mainland - hence the name 'Yaanai Iravu'.

“A strange incident occurred during our stay here. In the dead of the night, a screeching noise was often heard. The soldiers ignored it for a while and when they started hearing it almost every night, they tried to find out whether it was a wounded animal or bird. The sound that they heard was almost inhuman but was tinged with sorrow and pain. Soon everybody heard the voice around the camp every night. Some got truly disturbed and scared, thinking that it was the voice of a ghost. I ignored it at first but soon found that the soldiers had nothing else to discuss but this. I told them to go back home and hide in their mother’s lap if they were so scared. My words riled them and they sought to solve the mystery of the voice that night. A few soldiers set out in the direction from where the voice was heard. When they approached the place, they saw a woman running away from there but they couldn’t catch her. Even after learning that the voice belonged to a woman and not to a ghost or a demon they kept discussing it and we continued to hear the voice every night near the camp.

“Then one night, I set out with a few soldiers to find out why the woman was wailing every night. When she saw us approaching from behind a tree, she stood surprised and then started running. We ran behind her but I knew intuitively that it would be impossible to catch her. I asked the others to stop and went after her alone. When she saw that I alone was coming after her, she stopped running and stood there as if she was welcoming me. Now I was hesitant and approached her slowly. It was a full moon night and I saw her face then. She stood there smiling at me and at that instant, I knew who she was. She was Kaveri Amman, the goddess who saved me from drowning.

“I stood there looking at her as if in a trance and then said, “Mother! Who are you? How and when did you come here? Do you know that I have wished to meet you for so many years? Why didn’t you come to me directly? Why do you go around my camp screaming and wailing?” But there was no response from her. I repeated the questions but it was all in vain. She looked at me with tears in her



eyes and tried to say something but couldn't. That's when I understood that she was deaf and mute.

"At that moment, I felt her sorrow and helplessness. She suddenly hugged me protectively as if, I were her child and then ran away from there without looking back. I didn't follow her. When I made my way back to the camp, my soldiers were waiting worried and eager. "She is not a ghost or a spirit. She is as human as you and me. She is demented due to a great tragedy that occurred in her life. If she comes back here again, do not trouble her."

"I was tempted to move the camp from the woods the next day, but I was in a dilemma. I wanted to meet her once more and with that thought in mind, I lingered there. That night, she came again, just as I expected. I left strict instructions with my soldiers about not following me. She stood there just like the night before with a welcoming smile playing on her lips. She tried to tell me something using signs but I couldn't understand.

"Then she took my hand and led me into the forest. I didn't hesitate even for a moment to go along with her. She went ahead moving thorny bushes and branches lest it hurt me. After walking for a while through the woods, we came upon a hut. A small lamp was flickering inside the hut and an old man lay on a cot shivering in fever. His malady was so intense that his body was shivering uncontrollably and his teeth were chattering. His eyes were as red as burning coals and his mouth was blabbering something that no one could comprehend.

"Do you remember that bikshu we saw today at the underground monastery? Maha Guru and the other bikshus said that the gods have come upon him, while I was privately wondering whether he has fallen prey to the shivering fever that is spreading in this kingdom. But I didn't wish to mention it in their hearing. I think I might have made a big mistake in allowing these people to celebrate the Perahara Festival. This city is already half destroyed by wars and if

the shivering fever came upon its people, the rest of them will have to abandon it forever.”

Saying thus, the prince sat silently mulling about the fate of the city and its people for a while. Vandiya Devan waited for a while for the prince to resume. When that didn't happen, he said, “Ayya! Who cares about this city? Tell us what happened in that hut?”

“Nothing happened in that hut. Kaveri Amman didn't allow me to linger there for a long time. She took my hand and led me out and with the help of a few signs she was able to tell me what she wanted. “Do not stay in this region. Leave this place immediately or risk the shivering fever.” I understood that she gave this warning out of the love that she bore me and I immediately moved the camp the next day. My soldiers were very happy about my decision as they didn't have to hear the wailing of the woman anymore.”

## **Chapter 38:**

### **When the Pictures tell a Story**

The prince abruptly stopped his story to ask, “Do you hear the sound of footsteps?”

But Azhwarkadiyan and Vandiya Devan who were intently listening to the story said that they didn’t hear anything.

Azhwarkadiyan then said, “I feel as if this place is getting hotter every second,”

“I can faintly smell smoke,” said Vandiya Devan sniffing his nose.

Azhwarkadiyan asked worriedly, “Ayya! What if there is some danger waiting for us here?”

The prince calmly replied, “If there is any danger, Kaveri Amman will warn us beforehand. No worries,” and continued the story.

“I heeded her warning and left the place immediately with my soldiers. Despite moving the camp, ten of my soldiers fell prey to the shivering fever. This fever will truly test the mettle of any warrior. I have seen soldiers who were unfazed by deadly wounds, pining for their home after three days of this shivering fever. I truly felt that goddess Durga herself had manifested as that deaf and mute woman to warn me away from that place. If I had not left on time, the entire army could have fallen prey to it.

“Kaveri Amman did not give up on me after this. She followed me everywhere and saved me from many a mishap - deadly animals, poisonous snakes, an arrow in the dark, and hidden enemies. Just as she appears suddenly, she would also disappear unexpectedly. These days, I am able to understand what she wants to say by just watching the expression on her face. That’s not all. I can also sense

her presence intuitively without having to see her with my eyes. Even now... you both go and lie down on your beds now! It doesn't matter if you are not sleepy, just pretend to be asleep."

The duo hastened to their beds and lay down but they couldn't close their eyes for more than a few seconds as they lay waiting for the deaf and mute woman to make her appearance.

Soon enough there was a figure standing by the window blocking the rays of the gentle moonlight. She put her finger on the lips and said 'shhh' and beckoned the prince to come near the window. Next, she said something in sign language that the prince understood and nodded. After this, he pointed towards his friends and said something for which the woman nodded and said 'yes'.

The Prince immediately woke his friends and bid them to follow him. Hurrying them, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi and Vandiya Devan exited the Mahasenar palace. Following the woman, they walked silently through a road that had a thick avenue of trees on either side. Suddenly they came to a clearing where a huge stupa stood towering over them and guarding it was a battalion of elephants that looked so real to Vandiya Devan that he was shocked to see the woman touching one of them casually. Not until Azhwarkadiyan whispered in his ears, "Do you see the statues of the elephants, don't they look real?" that he realized that they were made of stone.

Carved closely together, the hundred stone elephants stood poised for an attack. The elephants all had large tusks but one of them had a broken one. The woman went near that elephant and bent down to move a stone slab underneath its legs. A few steps were seen underneath through which they climbed down. The others followed her down to find a small underground mandapam that was well-lit by two large oil lamps.

The woman took one of the lamps in her hands and beckoned the prince to one side of the room. When the others saw that she was

showing the prince some pictures that were drawn on the wall, they relaxed and waited.

To the prince, the pictures on the wall seemed like a story drawn chronologically to represent somebody's life. They were drawn in the same manner as the paintings that he had seen in the monasteries of this Island Kingdom representing Lord Buddha's past life. These pictures on the wall were not Buddha's but that of the deaf and mute woman's past life. The Prince now understood that the woman had brought him there to tell him about herself.

The first picture was that of a young woman whose face resembled that of the deaf and mute woman, living on an island with her father, a fisherman. This was followed by a picture of the woman looking through a thicket to see a man who looked like a prince sitting under a tree. Unknown to him, there was a bear behind him, waiting to attack! The woman shouted a warning and started running, luring the bear away from him. The prince threw his spear at the bear and then started fighting with it with his bare hands. The woman stopped running stood behind a tree watching them fight. The prince won the fight and then approached the woman to thank her but she shed tears and ran away from him. Later, she came back with her father who tells the prince that she is deaf and mute.

The prince is sad to hear this but soon enough they become friends. He made a garland of wild flowers that grew in the woods and put it on her neck and they wandered the island hand-in-hand.

One day, a huge ship came near the island. Some soldiers came down from the ship searching for the prince. When they found him, they paid him homage and requested him to come along with them on the ship. The prince consoled the woman and took his leave.

The woman was disconsolate after he left, so her father took her on his boat across the seas. They arrived at a beach that had a lighthouse and was welcomed by a family that lived there. They got into a bullock cart and went on a long journey. They reached a big

town that had huge fort walls and there they saw the prince standing on the terrace with a golden crown on his head. When the deaf and mute woman saw him there, her heart broke into smithereens and she ran away from there. She reached the beach and tried to give up her life by jumping from the lighthouse. But a fisherman saved her life and brought her ashore. Thinking that an evil spirit possessed her, he took her to the temple and asked the pujari to exorcise it.

A pregnant noble lady who had come to the temple for a visit saw the woman there. The pujari told the noblewoman about her and when she learned that the woman was pregnant with a child just like her, she felt pity for her. She took the woman along with her in a palanquin to a city. In the palace, the woman gave birth to twin children. The noble lady, who turned out to be the queen of the realm, asked the woman to give up one of her children saying that she would bring him up as her own. The woman at first refused to part with her child and then later agreed to the queen's request and left both the children at the palace. For many years, she roamed through the forest and whenever she felt like seeing her children she would hide herself behind the tree and watch them.

Once she saw a palace boat bearing the king and the queen and their children. Unnoticed by either of them, one of the children slipped and fell into the river. The woman immediately swam towards the child and saved his life and then disappeared into the woods after handing him over.

All these incidents were drawn on the wall using a piece of charcoal and the prince looked at each picture intently trying to understand each incident of her life. When he came to the last picture of her rescuing the child, he said, "The child who fell into the river was me and the woman who saved my life was you," using sign language. Delighted by the fact that he had understood her pictures the woman hugged him lovingly.

Next, she took him to another wall in the mandapam where few more pictures were drawn. They were not pictures about her life but about

the dangers that might befall the prince if he were not careful.

Vandiya Devan and Azhwarkadiyan kept an eye on the prince and the woman silently. Vandiya Devan would often compare the face of the woman and that of Nandini's and constantly thought about their resemblance to each other. He didn't ponder about it aloud as it was neither the time nor the place for such a discussion.

Soon they came out of the mandapam from under the elephant's legs. The woman climbed the stupa to reach the top of the building. The others were astonished by her unfailing stamina. Weary and tired, Vandiya Devan climbed after them and halfway up, they noticed a palace burning.

"Aha! Mahasenar's palace is burning!"

"Is that the place where we were sleeping?"

"The very same."

"And if we were there right now..."

"We would be in the belly of lord Agni then..."

"But how can we know that that is Mahasenar's palace that is burning?"

"The pictures that were drawn in the mandapam spoke to me."

"But we didn't hear anything."

"I am not surprised. The pictures will speak only to those who understand their language."

"What else did those pictures tell you, ayya?"

“The pictures told me many secrets about my family. They also told me to leave this island kingdom immediately.”

“That’s great! I agree wholeheartedly with them then. It looks like they too want the prince to come home with me,” replied Vandiya Devan.

“Prince! Did those pictures tell you not to walk near the houses, not to walk under trees and not to sleep inside houses?” questioned Azhwarkadiyan.

“That’s correct! How did you know?”

“You know the language of the pictures while I can discern the language of signs. When Kaveri Amman was talking to you, I was watching the signs of her hands and understood,” replied Azhwarkadiyan.

“Good! There is still time until dawn, let us climb to the top of this stupa and sleep there. We can leave when the sun rises,” said Arulmozhivarmar.

Vandiya Devan found it difficult to get up even after the sun rose. The events of the previous night starting with the Buddha Bikshus had fused along with the pictures that he had seen in the mandapam and they had played on his mind, making it difficult to separate the reality from the dream.

After he woke up completely he saw that Azhwarkadiyan and the prince were ready to leave. They got down from the stupa and walked towards the Mahamegavanam. In the garden of this complex stood the sacred Maha Bodhi tree.

Buddha bikshus and common people were found sitting here and offering flowers and prayers to Buddha. The prince neared the tree and bowed low saying, “In this world, kingdoms and kings will rise



and fall with the tides of time but truth and dharma will always stand tall, unbowed and unbent. This bodhi tree is proof of that.”

Saying thus, the prince looked around and saw two soldiers looking hither and thither with three horses readied for the journey. When the prince neared them, they looked relieved and joyful. The prince conversed with them for a while and took the reins of the horses from them.

“It was Mahasenar’s palace that went up in flames last night. These soldiers thought that we might have died there and were very worried. They were very happy to see us alive.”

“While it is true that a thousand-year old tree lives on, it is also true that dharma has died in this world, a long time ago.” said Vandiya Devan.

“Don’t you ever say that again? How can dharma vanish from this world while I am still alive?” asked Azhwarkadiyan rather pompously.

They mounted the horses and exited the city walls through the northern gate. The city gates were still open to the people and the people who had come for the festival the previous night were camped in front of the gates. It was so crowded with elephants, horses and people that no one noticed them coming out of the gate.

There used to be a city called Mahindalai northeast of Anuradhapura. “Emperor Ashoka’s son Prince Mahindar came to this city and started spreading the faith of Buddha in this island kingdom from there. He was a very lucky man! Despite being a prince, he didn’t take his army across the sea to capture lands. He didn’t have to hide or be wary of hidden enemies. He didn’t have to roam around this island wearing a disguise.”

“Such was the sorry fate of that prince,” said Vandiya Devan.

The prince laughed at this comment and said, "You should not leave me, ever. When you are next to me, even the worst of the troubles become a happy adventure."

"The reverse is equally possible, my prince. Even a happy adventure might just become troublesome too," said Azhwarkadiyan.

Just as they were trotting through the road, they saw a cloud of dust at a distance and it soon became apparent that an army of horsemen was approaching the city on full trot bearing spears. With their arms shining in the glare of the sun, Vandiya Devan warned the prince, "Ayya! Draw your sword!"

## **Chapter 39:**

### **'Here is your war'**

When Vandiya Devan shouted his warning, the prince immediately drew his sword. Vandiya Devan too drew his sword. They were no ordinary swords but were large and heavy with a sharp edge to it. The soldiers who had met them near the Maha Bodhi tree had given it to them.

The prince jumped down from his horse and shouted, "You! Get down now! I can't bear your upstart behaviour anymore. I mean to put an end to it right away."

Vandiya Devan shocked by the prince's words stared at him wordlessly. He couldn't decide whether this was for real or a joke. Nonetheless, he got down from his horse.

"Why are you hesitating now? You didn't hesitate to insult my dynasty last night. Didn't you say that my forebears were made to wait at the courtyard of your ancestors to await the audience of the kings from your dynasty? Didn't you say that the gifts that my ancestors gave yours were given away to mere poets and bards? I can't bear the thought of this insult. I want to avenge it!" cried the prince with anger and came near Vandiya Devan with his sword swirling over his head.

As we mentioned before, these were no ordinary swords. They were massive blades that would require prodigious skill to lift but the way Prince Arulmozhi was swirling it over his head, it almost seemed weightless.

Those who witnessed their encounter would realize immediately that this was no ordinary prince who spent his days cushioned within the palace enjoying the luxuries that his birth afforded. Prince Arulmozhivarmar at that moment resembled the warriors of yore,

Arjuna and Bheema, the Pandava brothers and great Chola warrior kings, Karikala Vallavan and Vijayalaya Cholan.

Vandiya Devan started swirling his sword defensively to parry the prince's strikes. At first, he was confused by the prince's actions and was hesitant to attack but as their dance became intense his eyes could see only the sword that was moving towards him. With his blood up, Vandiya Devan's sword clashed with the prince's and they fought intensely with the sole intention of disarming each other.

Their dance of war soon reached a stage where the noisy clashing of their swords drowned out the sounds of the horses that were approaching them. With their bodies glistening with sweat, they stopped noticing their surroundings and were intent on their swordplay. Azhwarkadiyan didn't understand the prince's actions in the beginning but he knew that Arulmozhi must have had some reason to attack his companion. He soon realized that the prince wanted to stop the horsemen coming towards them so he sought to aid him in this plan by moving their horses to the middle of the road.

The army of horsemen neared them and Azhwarkadiyan was relieved to note that they were holding aloft the Chola tiger flag. But, who was coming?

They learned it soon enough when the drummers came forward to announce, "Hail the commander whose bravery made the king of Ilangai run away to his mountain hideout! Hail the commander who beheaded the king of the Pandyas! Make way for the commander of the Chola army, Kodumbalur Periya Vellar, Budhi Vikrama Kesari!

"Hail the brave companion of Crown Prince Aditya Karikalar! Hail the brave sword that vanquished the army of Vengai! Make way for Parthibendra Pallavar!"

After the drummers and the announcers, there rode thirty horsemen, and in their midst were Commander Budhi Vikrama Kesari and

Parthibendran, mounted on white horses. A large elephant followed the horsemen and a woman sat atop it.

Following the elephant were a battalion of foot soldiers raising a cloud of dust. When the horses reigned suddenly to a halt thanks to the obstruction that Azhwarkadiyan had made, the entire army stopped to watch the men fighting. Soon questions were raised as to who was fighting and men jostled to come to the front to see the spectacle. "Who is fighting? Who are they?"

As the soldiers started following the sword fight between the prince and Vandiya Devan, they started whispering among themselves and cheering for their favourite.

Commander Budhi Vikrama Kesari and Parthibendra Pallavan dismounted from their horses and came forward to watch the fight.

Parthibendran, incensed by the spectacle that was unfolding in front of them, said to the commander, "I told you about that upstart Prince of Vallam. Here he is, fighting with our prince. How can we watch this silently?" and tried to draw his sword.

Budhi Vikrama Kesari held his hand and said, "No, please don't. What a wonderful fight! It's been so long since we saw anything like this,"

As the fight proceeded, the foot soldiers numbering around 300 joined the horsemen to watch the swordplay of the warriors. The woman who had travelled on the elephant dismounted from it and moved among the soldiers to watch the fight. Her face was alight with a delight that was indescribable. Her beautiful eyes followed the movement of the swords and the men wielding them intently. As the fight progressed fiercely, her hands played with a flower imitating their moves. There is no need to introduce her to the readers, as they are quite familiar with our enigmatic boat girl, Poonguzhali.

For a while, the prince and Vandiya Devan were fighting each other from a position where Poonguzhali could watch the former's face. They soon moved from that position and now Vandiya Devan could see her.

Throughout the fight, Vandiya Devan's eyes though focussed on the fight would also note the other things that were happening around them. But when his gaze fell on Poonguzhali, he was distracted for a second. That was long enough for the prince to disarm him. Cheers and hails of victory rose from the crowd. A peal of laughter was heard from the boat girl. When Vandiya Devan tried to retrieve his sword, the prince threw his sword down and embraced him heartily saying, "You were not defeated by my sword. You matched my strokes equally. You fell because you were no match for a woman's beautiful eyes. There is no shame in that. It can happen to anybody."

Before Vandiya Devan could give his explanations about that, Commander Budhi Vikrama Kesari and Parthibendra Pallavan had joined them, "Prince! It was I who sent this boy to you. Did his behaviour displease you? I was very worried when I saw this fight."

"Yes, Commander. He did displease me indeed. Right from the time we met he has been asking me, 'They said there is a war happening in Ilangai. Where is it happening?' So, I decided to show him, 'Here is your war.'"

Hearing this cheers and shouts rang again from the crowd that was gathered around them. The Commander neared Vandiya Devan and clapped his back proudly saying, "Thambi! It has been a very long time since I had seen a sword fight like this. You are undoubtedly a worthy warrior to partner with in battle. The prince often gets an itch to fight. He is after all the great grandson of Emperor Paranthakan who was known as 'Kunjara Mallan'. You should know that those who do not have the temerity to fight him like this will not remain his friend for long."

The Prince in the meantime had greeted Parthibendra Pallavan saying, “Ayya! I hastened to meet you when I heard that you had come. How does my brother fare in Kanchi? Is my grandfather keeping good health?”

“Prince! Your brother and grandfather have sent you important messages. It has taken five days for me to find your whereabouts in Ilangai. Let us not tarry for a second.”

“If the messages were not important, surely you wouldn’t have come here on your own. Tell me about them.”

The Commander who heard their conversation said, “Let us not discuss this amidst this crowd. I see an old dilapidated mandapam there. Let us move there and talk. Thankfully, there is no dearth of old mandapams in Ilangai.”

## **Chapter 40: A Council**

As they moved towards the mandapam, Vandiya Devan asked Azhwarkadiyan, "Why is the prince acting like this? The day we met, he started a fist fight and today a sword fight. Why is he attacking me like this, without any warning? His friendship seems to be very dangerous."

The prince heard this and said, "Yes. My friendship is indeed very dangerous. You would have realized this last night. You should probably stay far away as possible from me."

"My prince, I am prepared to face any kind of danger standing beside you but when you attack like this suddenly..."

Azhwarkadiyan interjected here and said, "Thambi! Don't you realize why he did that? The prince wanted to know who was coming and sought to stop them. Whoever it was, they would stop and watch if two people were fighting in the middle of the road, wouldn't they?"

The prince said, "Thirumalai is correct. You should also know one more thing about me. Many astrologers have said that there is something very special about my horoscope it seems. Friends who are close to me will inevitably invite jealousy and envy. That's why I would fight with them all the time. So, if you wish to be my friend, you should be prepared for this."

"If that is so, then I will not wait for you to start the fight. I will start it myself. Prince! I have been amiss in my duties. I brought you many important messages from your sister but I forgot one particular message. I will have to give it to you now, as there is no other alternative. If you do not wish to hear it, then draw your sword again."



“There is no need for that. Tell me the message.”

“While we were fighting, did you notice a girl standing in the crowd with a kumud flower in hand? You said that she distracted me when I lost the fight? Do you know who that girl is?”

“No. I didn’t look at her properly. I don’t look at women by habit.”

“Ayya! It was she who had sent you the message and I forgot all about it. I have been busy getting defeated in fist fights and swordplay and escaping from burning palaces and buildings that fall on our head ever since I met you. I didn’t find a suitable opportunity to give this message to you. While we were fighting, I saw her in the crowd and remembered the message that she sent you and that’s when you disarmed me.”

“Alright. Who is this girl and why would she send me a message?”

“Ayya! That girl’s name is Poonguzhali.”

“Beautiful name, but I don’t believe I know her,”

“Ayya! Do you at least remember the name ‘Samudra Kumari’?”

“Samudra Kumari! Samudra Kumari! I don’t recall this name. I don’t even remember meeting her.”

“Ayya! I beseech you to try and remember, if you don’t, this girl will be heartbroken. You met her at Kodi Karai when you were ready to take a boat to your ship. Just then you saw a girl rowing a boat coming near the shore. When she came near, you asked her father, “Who is this girl? Her father replied, ‘She is my Kumari!’” To this, you said, “Is that so? I thought she was Samudra Kumari!” That girl did not forget these words of yours and has ever since called herself ‘Samudra Kumari’. She helped me cross the seas to come to you...”

“Ah! I remember meeting her now. But why is she here with these people? What could possibly make a boat girl from Kodi Karai come all the way to Anuradhapuram? Has she perchance come searching for you?”

“No. That is not possible. She wouldn’t come here searching for me. If she has come here it could be only for you, though I can’t fathom the reason.”

Saying thus he chanced a look at the subject of their conversation. She was walking placidly along with Commander Budhi Vikrama Kesari with her head bent but Vandiya Devan could sense that she was intensely aware of everything that Prince Arulmozhi Varman was saying and doing. He also realized that she knew that at that very minute, they were discussing her. That probably accounted for her sudden modesty.

They neared the mandapam and saw that though it had no roof, the surrounding trees and the thick foliage that surrounded it would give them enough shelter. There was a large seat in the centre of this mandapam where the prince, Parthibendra Pallavan and Commander Budhi Vikrama Kesari sat. Vandiya Devan and Azhwarkadiyan stood at a distance near them while Poonguzhali found herself a pillar to lean on, while her eyes were fixated on the prince. The accompanying army, horses and the foot soldiers awaited their commanders near the woods that surrounded the mandapam.

The prince asked Parthibendran, “What message did my brother and grandsire send me?”

“My prince! The kingdom is in grave danger. You probably know about this...”

“Yes, I do. The emperor has been ill for a very long time.”

“That isn’t the only danger that I am talking about. The kingdom is under threat from many factions. Many of your father’s liege lords have turned traitors and are plotting treason against the emperor, the Crown Prince and you. They are plotting to enthrone that pious cat Madhuranthakan instead of your brother. The Pazhuvur lords, Sambuvarayars, Erattai Kudai Rajaliyar, Mazhapadi Mazhavarayar and many others are a party to this plot. But there is no need to worry about it as we have the border armies of West and North under our control and we have the support of powerful lords like Malayaman and Kodumbalur Periya Vellar. We can vanquish these treasonous lords within no time but we should not give them time to plan their next move. We need to destroy everybody who is conspiring with these lords. Your grandsire is of the opinion that you should stay near your brother, lest these lords try to poison your mind against each other. That’s why he has sent me here, to bring you to Kanchi.

“Furthermore, your brother has also bid me to tell you that he has no wish to rule the kingdom. He wishes to travel far and wide and conquer lands that lie across the seas. He wants to travel to distant lands that were once under the rule of Cholas and hoist our tiger flag there. Ever since the Pazhuvur lords restricted him from expanding towards the west, his thirst for battle has increased ten-fold times. After you come with me to Kanchi, he is planning to take an army to Thanjavur and destroy our foes there and then crown you as the king and leave for...”

The prince who was listening to him patiently until then closed his ears and said, “Please don’t say such words. I have no intention of ruling the kingdom.”

“If you do not wish to hear, then I will not talk about it here but it is imperative that you brothers join hands to destroy those who are plotting against the crown. It is important that you leave immediately along with me to Kanchi. Let us destroy the entire clan of these liege lords - Pazhuvetarayars and Sambuvarayars. Let us send that pious

fool Madhuranthakan to Sivalogam<sup>[185]</sup> and then you brothers can decide what needs to be done about the succession.”

“Ayya! Do we decide everything here? Shouldn’t we ask my father, the emperor about his wishes? Did my father convey his wishes about this matter to my brother?”

“My prince! There is no cause to hide the truth anymore. It is impossible to learn the wishes of your father. The emperor is imprisoned in the Thanjavur fort. No one can meet him without the permission of the Pazhuvur Lords and there is no possibility of talking to him in private. Your brother tried all means possible to make him come to Kanchi. He sent him messages, one after another inviting him to the golden palace that he has built in Kanchi but there was no reply.”

“It would be difficult for my father to travel since he has lost the use of his legs.”

“Prince! Those are mere excuses. Your father is the emperor of three worlds. He could travel on an elephant, a horse, a chariot or a palanquin. His loyal liege lords should consider it an honour to carry him on their heads if the need arises. But that isn’t the reason. The Pazhuvur lords are determined to keep him imprisoned in the fort, under their guard. My prince! You will need to come with me to Kanchi if you wish to save your father’s life.”

It was evident from the prince’s face that Parthibendran’s words had shaken him. His forehead creased with worry, the prince sat silent for a while and then looked Kodumbalur Periya Vellar and said, “Thalapathy<sup>[186]</sup>! What do you advise? A few days ago, Prime Minister Anirudhar had come here. You know that he is my father’s close confidante and holds him in high regard. He advised me to stay in Ilangai for some more time and you agreed with him. When I said, ‘The war here is at a standstill, then why should I stay here?’ you tried to convince me about staying here. The Prime minister sent the same message again with this Vaishnavan.

“You know the regard and respect that I have for my sister, Elaya Piratti, Kundavai Devi. I have always acted on her counsel and it was she who had sent me here to lead the army in Ilangai. Now she has sent the prince of Vallam<sup>[187]</sup> with a message, asking me to come immediately to Pazhaiaarai, while my brother wants me to come to Kanchi. What do you suggest, Thalapathy?”

“My prince! Until this morning, I believed that you should stay here in Ilangai. Parthibendran argued until the wee hours of the morning about you going to Kanchi, but I did not agree. But when that girl standing there, came with a message this morning, I changed my mind. I am of the opinion that you will need to go to Kanchi immediately along with Parthibendran.”

The Prince looked at Poonguzhali who had been watching him intently from behind the pillar and said, “They say that Abhimanyu was killed by foes who surrounded him from all directions while I am being killed by messages from everywhere. What is so special about this message that this girl has brought?”

“It is best that you hear it from her own lips.”

“You, girl! Come forward and tell the prince.”

Poonguzhali came forward from behind the pillar but she couldn't utter even a word. With her lips trembling, she stood there looking at the prince.

“Aha! Seems like the entire world has gone mute,” said the prince. That was the last straw for her. She looked up to see his face once more while tears filled her beautiful eyes. She turned around and ran away from there before anybody could react.

Surprised by her actions, everybody looked at her until she vanished among the woods. Vandiya Devan came forward immediately and

said, “Ayya! This girl tried to run away from me once and I was able to catch her. Allow me to go after her.”

“Do that. Thalapathy! In the meanwhile, tell us about this message that she had brought.”

“It is quite simple. Two warships have been sent to Ilangai by the Pazhuvur lords to arrest you for treason. Even as we speak, these ships are anchored near the shores of Thondaimaan<sup>[188]</sup>.”

## Chapter 41: Look There!

When the prince heard the Thalapathy's words, his face wore a smile. "At last, there seems to be a solution for my inner struggle!" he muttered to himself.

But Parthibendran was incensed by what he heard and drew his sword in anger saying, "Thalapathy! What are you saying? Is this true? Why didn't you tell me about this? Now I understand why you dragged that demented girl along with us here. Let me ask you again. Do you really believe that the Pazhuvur lords would send ships to arrest the prince?"

"Yes. It is true, if you believe this girl's account of what she saw and heard."

"Aha! That old man, Thirukovallur Malayaman was right, after all. He alone among all of us knows these Pazhuvur brothers for they really are. Thalapathy! Why are we sitting here after hearing this news? Who are these Pazhuvur lords to arrest our beloved prince? I see no reason for a council now, let us destroy these upstart lords for their treason. Let us sink these ships and the soldiers that they have sent. We can act according to our plan after we have vanquished these people. Why are we still sitting here? Come let us leave now!" said Parthibendran furious with anger.

Commander Budhi Vikrama Kesari looked at him and said, "Parthibendra! I knew that you would be furious and that's why I didn't tell you the news that this girl had brought. We need to think and act carefully. If we act hastily, everything will be ruined."

"Think! What is there to think, Thalapathy? Prince! What is your opinion here? Is there anything left to think? If you were hesitating to act against these lords earlier, they have left no room for such

considerations now. It is time to destroy these lords and their clans,” urged Parthibendran.

The prince intervened now and said, “I would like to hear Thalapathy’s opinion now. Ayya! What is your counsel?”

“My prince! What if the soldiers... what if the soldiers who have come to arrest you, have come under the royal command of the emperor? Do we still resist them?”

Parthibendran laughed out loud when he heard this and said, “How can the emperor issue royal commands when he is held a prisoner in the Thanjavur fort?”

Vandiya Devan intervened here and said, “The Pallava lord is right. I wouldn’t have believed it if I had not seen it with my eyes. The emperor’s palace in the fort is nothing less than a prison. No one can see him or talk to him without the express commands of the Pazhuvur lords. The troubles they brought upon me just because I dared to say a word! Appa! Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s iron grip on my shoulder still pains me.”

“Well said Vallavareya! Tell the prince and the Thalapathy one more time. Let them know that you speak the truth,” said Parthibendran.

The Prince said, “There is no need to repeat, he has told me everything,” and then looked at Vandiya Devan and said, “Ayya! You said that you would go after that girl and bring her to me. Why do you tarry here? I wish to know more about this from her. She seems to be very disturbed, try to convince her with sweet words and bring her to me.”

“I will leave now, ayya! However, I will never allow you to be imprisoned by the Pazhuvetarayars, not until there is life in this body of mine,” said Vandiya Devan and went towards the woods where Poonguzhali had disappeared.



After he left, the prince turned towards Kodumbalur Periya Vellar and asked, "Senathipathy! What do you advise in this situation?"

"I think that you should not meet the soldiers that the Pazhuvetarayar has sent. You should take the ship that Parthibendran has come in back to Kanchi. I will leave immediately to Thanjavur to learn the truth behind this."

"Going to Thanjavur is as good as putting your head in the lion's mouth. You will not return alive from there. They will shut you in the underground dungeons of Thanjavur, as soon as you step into the city. You will not be able to meet the emperor."

"What are you saying? Who would dare to throw 'me' into the dungeons? Is this Pazhuvetarayar, man enough to refuse me an audience with the emperor? Moreover, Prime Minister Anirudha Bhramarayar is there at the capital."

"Bhramarayar is there and that's all. Even he is helpless because he does not get to meet the emperor often enough. Here is his disciple. Let us hear what he says," said Parthibendran. Periya Vellar turned towards the Vaishnavan and said, "Yes. I have forgotten him. Thirumalai! Why are you standing here silently?"

"Senathipathy! God has given us two ears but alas we have only one mouth. Therefore, my Guru has taught me to use both my ears well and the mouth occasionally. He has bid me to remember this lesson especially when the affairs of Kingdom are being discussed."

"Well, you seem to have learned that lesson well. However, we are asking you for your opinion now."

"My opinion about what?"

"Should the prince stay in Ilangai or travel to Kanchi along with Parthibendran?"

“Do you really wish to hear what I think about it? I will tell you if the prince permits it.”

The prince, who seemed to be lost in his thoughts, looked up and said, “Tell us your opinion Thirumalai. I wish to hear it.”

“I think we should find the most secure prison in this island kingdom and keep the prince there under guard.”

“What are you blabbering?” asked the Commander.

“Do you think this is a joke?” asked Parthibendran angrily!

“I am neither blabbering nor joking. Last night, when the prince was walking on the roads of Anuradhapuram along with Vandiya Devan and myself, the front portion of a dilapidated mansion collapsed and fell. Later, the palace that we stayed in for the night was gutted in a fire, though luckily, we left on an errand. Ask the prince whether this is true or not?”

The commander and Pallavan looked at the prince’s face and knew that the Vaishnavan was speaking the truth.

“Do you think that someone might set fire to a palace just to kill Vandiya Devan or me?”

Parthibendran immediately stood up saying, “This means, someone is trying to kill the prince, therefore he should immediately come along with me to Kanchi.”

“No. I would rather allow the Pazhuvur soldiers to arrest the prince than let him go with you.”

“Vaishnavaney! What did you say?” cried Parthibendran gnashing his teeth angrily and drawing his sword.

The commander held his hand and said, "Thirumalai! What do you say that? Don't you know that Parthibendra Pallavan is the sworn sword of Aditya Karikalan and a friend to the Chola dynasty?"

"I know that Thalapathy but friendship alone does not suffice during these troubled times."

"Parthibendran would give up his life rather than allow any harm to befall the prince," said the commander

"While that may be true, I would like to ask him a question. The day before yesterday, when we were walking by Thambilai road, we saw him on the road riding with two men. Who were those men and where are they right now?"

Parthibendran looked surprised to hear Thirumalai's question and he hesitated for a second before answering him, "I met them near Thirikonamalai and they said that they could help me find the prince but they vanished when we reached Anuradhapuram. Why do you ask about them? Do you know something about them?"

"Yes. I know about them. They are a part of a gang who have sworn to destroy the seed of the Cholas. I think it was they who tried to kill the prince yesterday," said Azhwarkadiyan and then cried, "Aha! Look there."

He pointed towards the woods where at a distance they could see a beautiful girl and a handsome man standing between two large trees, talking. It was easy to guess that it was Poonguzhali and Vandiya Devan who were standing there. All of a sudden, Vandiya Devan took out a dagger and threw it into a nearby bush. A cry of pain rang out from the bush.

## **Chapter 42:**

### **Poonguzhali's Dagger**

Vandiya Devan found Poonguzhali standing under a tree in the woods sobbing silently with grief. Softening his voice deliberately, Vandiya Devan called out, "Poonguzhali!"

Startled by his voice, she looked up and found him standing near her.

"Oh! It's you," she said and turned her back on him.

"Yes. It is me. Why are you angry with me?"

"I am not angry with you."

"Then why do you look so displeased?"

"I am displeased with men at large."

"Even the prince?" asked Vandiya Devan, which made her turn around and stare at him with murderous eyes.

"Yes. Especially the prince. I dislike him most of all."

"What did the prince do to merit your displeasure?"

"He doesn't remember me. He didn't look at me at all."

"That's not true. He remembers you well enough. When I mentioned your name, he said, 'Oh! I know Samudra Kumari very well!'"

"You are lying!"

"If you think that, then why don't you come there and ask him?"

“If he remembers me, then why didn’t he talk to me?”

“He did. It was you who ran away from him without answering.”

“That’s not what I meant by ‘talking’. If you know someone, won’t you ask after their health? ‘How are you?’ ‘Are you keeping well?’ I know that you are lying. He doesn’t remember me.”

“Poonguzhali! There is a reason behind his actions.”

“What reason?”

“The prince is undergoing a bad spell according to his stars.”

“Who told you that?”

“All the astrologers say so. Kudanthai Jodhidar personally told me so.”

“What did he say?”

“He said that the prince would face grave difficulties, one after another. He also said that people who are close to him would also suffer. The Prince knows about this and that’s why he is trying to drive away all his friends, as he does not want us to suffer along with him.”

“If that is so, then why are you friends with him?”

“Didn’t you see us fighting just now? He wants to drive me away too or else why would he suddenly challenge me for a swordfight for no reason, in the middle of the road? We stopped it only because the commander had come with the army.”

“Will you leave him and go away then?”

“Never! I will stay by his side and protect him from his enemies.”

“Do you like him so much then?”

“Yes. I like him very much.”

“Why do you like him?”

“I can’t articulate the reason. Sometimes you start liking people immediately, right from the first meeting.”

“I know. It happened to me too,” said Poonguzhali and inadvertently bit her lips regretting the fact that she had confessed her innermost feelings to him.

“I know that you like him, that’s why I came after you. Come with me, now.”

“I will not,” Poonguzhali stressed on each word.

“If you don’t, I would have no choice but to drag you back there, by force.”

“If you lay a hand on me, I will carve you up with my dagger,” threatened Poonguzhali, drawing her dagger.

“You ungrateful woman! I reminded the prince about you and here you are threatening me with that dagger!”

“You are lying. You did not tell him anything about me.”

“Fine. Just come with me and tell him all about those ships that have come here to imprison him. You are free to leave after that.”

“I have told the Senathipathy everything.”

“But the prince wishes to hear it from your lips.”

“My voice fails and I become mute when I come in his presence.”

“The prince has a special place in his heart for mute women!”

“Chi Chi! You are mocking me!” said Poonguzhali and raised her dagger.

“I am asking you once again. Will you come with me?”

“NO!”

“Fine. I am leaving,” said Vandiya Devan and took two steps forward. Suddenly he turned around and grabbed the dagger from her hand and threw it away.

While he threw the dagger on nothing in particular, it fell on a bush nearby and a shriek was heard. Poonguzhali, astonished and murderously angry when Vandiya Devan took her dagger, looked at the bush with surprise.

They walked slowly towards the bush and found the dagger lying on the ground while the mud was stained with fresh blood. They didn't find a wounded bird or an animal anywhere near.

“Did you see that Poonguzhali? Do you now realize the truth that I have been trying to tell you? The prince is in grave danger. I threw your dagger on that bush and it looks like there was someone hidden there, watching and waiting for his chance to kill him. Do you remember when we met in Kodi Karai, you said that two men had gone to Ilangai with your brother? You said that they looked very suspicious and dangerous to you? I suspect that they are the assassins trying to slay the prince. Do you really think that we who love the prince should abandon him now when he is surrounded by danger?”

“What do I do if he asks me to leave?”

“I think that if even tries to make us leave, we should stay close to him.”

“Shall we try and find out who was hidden here?”

“That would be impossible. The assassin could be hiding anywhere in this forest. Let us not tarry anymore or the prince might be truly angry with us. Don’t argue, just come with me,” said Vandiya Devan. Poonguzhali agreed.

As they neared the mandapam, the commander and the Pallava lord asked him, “Why did you throw the dagger?” “What was that noise that we heard?”

“I saw something moving in the bushes so I threw the dagger on it. When we back to retrieve it, there was nothing there.”

“Alright. Let us get back to the matters at hand. My prince, now that this girl is back, please ask her about those ships.”

Poonguzhali, whose gaze was fixed on the prince, was elated when he looked up to see her.

Chi! Why is this heart beating so fast? Why is it so difficult to utter even a single word in his presence? Why are your eyes filling up with tears? Witless Woman! Where did all that bravado of yours go? You who would brave the high waves of the sea during a fierce storm, why do you hesitate now? Why this sudden fear? You, who could fight a tiger barehanded, why do your limbs tremble now? Rein in your heart, woman and face him bravely. Do not let him call you demented. Look up and see his face. Do not offer tears to him while he is looking for answers. Why do you fear him? Isn’t the prince known for his benevolence and generosity? What do you imagine the prince will do to you?



“Samudra Kumari! Do you remember me?” asked the prince, but to her, it seemed as if he was asking from the very depth of her heart.

## **Chapter 43:** **“I am guilty!”**

“Samudra Kumari! Do you remember me?”

“Ponniyin Selva! What sort of question is this? How could you ask me whether I remember you? Is it fair to ask me this, after we have known each other for more than a thousand years or could it be perhaps that you have forgotten me? Haven’t we sailed together on my little boat, beyond the horizon for many eons now? Have you forgotten the journey we undertook on the endless sea? Don’t you remember the time when huge waves rose up tossing our boat to reach the skies only to drown it in the unfathomable depths of the sea? Don’t you remember how we held hands and bound ourselves to one another and faced the onslaught of the storm? Don’t you remember the time when we flew in the skies and you reached up to pluck the stars to adorn my hair? Don’t you remember bringing me the moon saying ‘Here use this silver plate as your mirror?’ Would you forget even the time when you dived into the sea while I stood worrying for your safety and you came out of the depths with your hands filled with pearls and corals? I can never forget our lives lived in these endless dreams, even if you have. My prince! Don’t you remember those countless hours we spent roaming around hand in hand in the bountiful flower gardens? Who can count the number of days that we spent gazing upon each other’s face? Don’t you remember the serene beauty of the flower garden where a hundred pairs of cuckoos sang melodiously while the bees hummed rhythmically to the beautiful dance of fluttering butterflies? How could you ask ‘Do you remember?’ Can I forget these memories ever? Yes ayya! I do remember! I do remember very well indeed.”

While her heart whispered these and hundred more vivid memories her mouth merely whispered, “Yes. I remember.”

“Aha! Samudra Kumari! You spoke! I have seen many beautiful maidens and apsaras immortalized for posterity in stone on this island kingdom. I had begun to fear, that you might be one of them too but thankfully you spoke and dispelled my fears. I want to hear more from you. It’s been too long since I have heard your lovely voice. I believe that you had told the Senathipathy about the two ships that are anchored near Thondaimaan river. You also said that these ships have come bearing Chola soldiers sent to imprison me. Is that true, Samudra Kumari? Did you see these ships, truly?”

“Yes, ayya! I saw them.”

“Aha! I can now hear your voice clearly. My ears are indeed blessed. Good, so after you saw the ships, you took your boat through the narrow canal and waited for the ships to depart. Then you went into the deep forest to rest for the night. But a few soldiers who had disembarked from the ship were also resting close to you and you overheard their conversation inadvertently. Is this true?”

“Yes.”

“Hearing their conversation, you felt that you had to alert our commander. You waited until these soldiers left the scene and started immediately. How did you come, Samudra Kumari?”

“I came half way in my boat and then the rest by walking through the forest.”

“What was your destination Poonguzhali?”

“I was bound for Maandotham, thinking that the commander might be there. On the way, I learned that he was in Mahindalai so I went there. I was at my wit’s end by the time I could meet and give this message to him. I had to meet and explain to so many people to reach here,” said Poonguzhali while her eyes emitted sparks of anger.

“I know that it is quite frustrating but I am not surprised either. It is difficult to meet the commander and I am sure my friend, Vandiya Devan will attest to it. He too faced the same difficulty. I am however glad that you were persistent and met him. Poonguzhali! Can I trouble you to tell me what you told the commander? I want to know more about the conversation that you heard overheard from those soldiers.”

“My prince! I feel ashamed to repeat those words.”

“Poonguzhali! I beseech you, please repeat their conversation to me.”

“They said that they have come to imprison you.”

“Did they mention, whose orders they were following?”

“Yes, but I do not believe it ayya! It must be a plot hatched by those Pazhuvur lords.”

“I will listen to your surmise later but right now I wish to hear about their conversation.”

“They said that they have come here on the orders of the emperor!”

“Good! Did they mention why the emperor ordered me to be imprisoned?”

“They did. It seems that you plotted with the Maha Gurus of the Buddha Sangam to usurp the throne of Ilangai. When I heard those words, I almost carved them up with my dagger.”

“Thank the gods that stayed your hand. Didn’t you know that it is treasonous to stop those who are acting directly under the emperor’s orders? Do you remember anything else that they said?”

“They said that the commander must not know the true nature of their mission as he would try and help you to escape. They wanted to find your whereabouts first and then imprison you without any interference from him.”

“So that’s why you left immediately to alert the commander about my impending arrest. You have rendered a great help for me Samudra Kumari. I am indebted to you! I wish to consult the commander and my friends now, so could you please stay close by – I don’t want to send Vandiya Devan after you again,” said the prince. Poonguzhali bowed and moved to a pillar from where she could see him.

The prince turned towards Budhi Vikrama Kesari and said, “Ayya! You and your forebears have rendered great service to my dynasty. You are my father’s close confidante and friend and I have utmost respect for you and I have so long considered you as my own father. Therefore, I beg you, do not hinder the path that leads me towards my rightful duty.”

The commander looked towards Parthibendran, alarmed by the tone of the prince. The prince turned to address the Pallava lord, “Ayya! You are my brother’s sworn sword and close friend. I have always respected my brother’s wishes and as his representative here, I am beholden to you. I beg you to allow me to do my duty and not hinder it anyway.”

The commander and Parthibendran looked at each other surprised by the prince’s request. The commander then addressed the prince saying, “My prince! I do not understand the meaning of your words. I have spent three-fourth of my life on battlefields and that has left me incapable of understanding anything other than plain speaking. When you say that you have to do your duty, pray what are you referring to?”

“I have but only duty to fulfil now. I wish to obey my father’s commands. He has sent these ships to imprison me. I don’t wish to

make their task any more difficult than it already is. I will go to these ships and surrender.”

“This is unacceptable! Impossible! I will not allow you to fall into their hands!” thundered Parthibendran.

The commander stayed his hand and said pacifyingly, “Let’s not make any hasty decisions!” Turning to the prince he said, “My prince! You talk about your duty now but I too have a duty to discharge towards you. Listen to this old man! I am the only surviving warrior from the Kodumbalur clan. My brother and other kinsmen died gloriously in war, giving up their life in service to the Cholas. I can only hope that God has a beautiful death such as that planned for me as well.

“You were a mere boy when you assumed the command of our forces in Ilangai. Your father called me aside and said, ‘I can’t bear to part from my dearest son. Yet I must. I cannot hold him back in my palace fearing for his safety and deny him the glory of being a warrior. He needs to go out and live his warrior’s dream, like his brave older brother. However, if some harm befalls him at Ilangai, my heart will know and I will die that very second. Senathipathy! I entrust my dearest son to your care and you will ensure his safety at all costs.’

“I cannot believe that the emperor who spoke thus last year, can send soldiers to imprison you for treason. There is no cause for it, as I know for a fact that you have committed no treason by thought or action. Who will believe that you tried to usurp the throne of Ilangai? It is the most absurd notion.”

The prince interjected now and said, “You said that no one will believe the notion that I tried to usurp the throne of Ilangai. But that’s not true. These charges against me are true. I did try to seize the throne of Ilangai.”

Vandiya Devan came forward now saying, “What is this ayya? Until now you have been preaching me about truth and dharma and now you go ahead and utter the biggest lie ever! Commander! Last night we were at a monastery where the Maha Gurus offered to crown the prince the king of Ilangai and he refused. This Vaishnavan and I bear witness to this act of his.”

Ponniyin Selvan smiled at him and said, “Vandiya Devereey! Let me ask you a question? Have you ever known of anyone plotting treason when there are people around him to witness it? I might have rejected the crown, merely because of the fact that you were with me.”

Vandiya Devan looked stumped at the prince’s words.

“Why don’t you ask the Vaishnavan about this? Ask him about the Prime minister’s message? Anirudhar had sent him along with instructions and a warning, to reject the throne of Ilangai in the presence of witnesses.”

The Vaishnavan nodded his head grimly acknowledging the prince’s words. The prince looked at the Commander and said, “Ayya! It is true that I wanted to rule this beautiful island kingdom. It was my sister’s wish and ambition too. She used to say, ‘Thambi! You were born to rule! But sadly, there is no place for you in the Chola Kingdom. Go to Ilangai and carve an empire for yourself there.’ Her words fired my ambition and I wanted to ascend the throne of this beautiful Ilangai. Therefore, I am guilty.”

“My prince! If you wished to rule this kingdom, then I would call the people of Ilangai as most fortunate. This ambition of yours was not nurtured by your sister but by your father. On many occasions, he declared in my presence that he wished to crown you as the king of Ilangai.”

“Senathipathy, if this is so, then why should I hesitate to go to my father? I have two people here who witnessed me rejecting the

throne. Let them come with me and speak on my behalf and clear my name. After that, I will act as my father commands.”

Parthibendran who had been listening to all this restlessly, spoke with difficulty as if he was trying to restrain himself from saying something. “Commander! We are wasting our time, talking about unnecessary things. I see no reason why you should hide the truth anymore. Will you tell the prince or shall I?”

“I will tell him. Be patient Parthibendra!” said the commander and lowered his voice, “My prince! I hesitated to broach this subject because I didn’t wish to alarm you. It is unfortunate that I have to convey such scandalous words into your ears. We know that Periya Pazhuvetarayar married a young woman named Nandini at a doddering old age. She is a sorceress. She is adept in the magical arts of enslaving men and makes them bend to her will. That’s how the brave Pazhuvur lord fell for her charms, which is very unfortunate indeed.”

“Senathipathy! This is nothing new. I believe that the entire kingdom has been talking about this endlessly.”

“Nandini has so far exerted her influence on the Pazhuvur lords but I fear the worst, my prince! Forgive me! What I say now will cause you pain. I think that she might have started using her magical arts on the emperor now. That’s why he has turned against his own sons and this command to imprison you.”

“Commander! I am warning you! Do not utter a word insulting the emperor. I will not listen to these insinuations against my father. I will obey my his commands no matter under what circumstances he has issued them. To me, they are as good as God’s will.”

“We do not deny that, prince, but consider this. Your father is literally imprisoned in the fort and I fear for his life. None of us here knew the full truth about Nandini. I learned about it last night and I think it is important that you know it too.



“Three years ago, the Pandya and Chola forces met near Madurai in a deadly war. Your brother, Parthibendran and I led our soldiers against Veera Pandyan’s army and destroyed him completely. Veera Pandyan, who had by then become very adept at running away from the battlefield, went into hiding yet again. But we were determined to capture him and put an end to his dynasty hence we swore a holy vow not to return to the capital without mounting the head of this cowardly king on a spike. We didn’t trust anyone and scoured Madurai searching for him. Finally, we found him cowering inside a hut near a temple. It was your brother who went inside and when he came out he had the severed head of Veera Pandyan in his hands. We cheered madly and left the place but we didn’t know about the drama that had happened inside the hut.

A woman who was tending the wounds of Veera Pandyan had tried to shield him from your brother’s sword. She begged your brother to spare the life of her lover but Karikalan kicked her aside and decapitated him. My prince! The woman who tried to save the life of our worst enemy was Nandini. Within a few days, she married that old man Periya Pazhuvetarayar and became his queen. It isn’t difficult to understand why she chose to marry that old man. She has come to take revenge against your brother and your family. She wants to destroy the very seed of your dynasty and avenge the death of her lover.

Those who have seen her find it difficult to escape her seductive allure. You can ask your friend Vandiya Devan about the truth of it. She is the head of the gang of assassins who have sworn to kill your family. This Vaishnavan knows the truth of it. It is she who has been supplying them with gold and arms to carry out their plans. I fear that the emperor too has become her puppet. That’s why he has charged you guilty of treason. I beg you not to accede to these commands, as they do not come from him. They have come from her.”

“Commander! This is shocking indeed but your explanation has only made me more determined to get to my father. My primary duty is to

defend him against these enemies who surround him. What use is a kingdom or this life, if I can't defend my own family? Let us have no more discussion on this matter. I have decided to surrender myself to these soldiers. Do not try to stop me," said the prince sternly and then turned towards Poonguzhali and said, "Samudra Kumari! Come here!"

When she neared him, he said, "Poonguzhali! You brought me very important news today but I need your help again. Will you help me?"

*What is this? Why is the prince asking this poor boat girl for help? I hastened through woods and the sea to be of service to him but he turns around and begs me to help! It was as if I came to God to ask for a boon but the God has turned towards me to beg me for one.*

"I am here to serve you, my prince!" said Poonguzhali.

"Samudra Kumari! I need to go to the ships that are anchored in the Thondaiman river. Will you take me there?"

"Woman! Refuse. Tell him that you will not do it," growled the commander.

The commander's voice awakened Poonguzhali from a sweet dream where she had existed along with the prince. She now realized that she faced the biggest dilemma of her life. The prince wished her to take him to his enemies, from whom she had sought to save him in the first place. The Senathipathy's warning, asking her to refuse the prince's request reverberated from all directions.

But a small voice was heard within her heart. "Poonguzhali! Here is your chance. If you accede to the prince's request, you will spend two days in his company. You can gaze upon his handsome face to your heart's content. The breeze that touched his body would soothe yours too. His honeyed voice would bring you more joy than any other thing in the world. The dreams that you feared would never

come to pass would see the light of the day. Why do you hesitate Poonguzhali? Agree.”

“Samudra Kumari! Why do you hesitate? Won’t you render this small service for me?”

“I will take you, my prince.” Said Poonguzhali.

Senathipathy expressed his displeasure by grunting and it seemed like the rumble of the earth just before an earthquake. He stepped towards the prince and said, “My prince! I will not dissuade you from your duty but I beg you to listen to one last request. You will need to allow me to discharge my duty to my emperor. Until you surrender yourself to the soldiers who have come to imprison you, your safety is of paramount importance. Someone attempted to assassinate you last night and those assassins are still at large. I am sorry to say this, but I don’t trust this girl. What if she was in cahoots with those assassins? She could have cooked up this whole story to lure you into danger? Your friend threw her dagger in the woods and it fell on someone. By all means... let her guide you to the place where the ships are anchored but I will not leave you alone with her. I will escort you to Thondaiman and see to your safety until you board the ship.”

The prince listened to Senathipathy with a smile and said, “I will never ask you to forsake your duty. By all means, come along with us.”

## **Chapter 44:**

### **The Elephant Flees**

After the prince announced his decision, the commander took Parthibendra Pallavan aside and spoke to him in confidence. Next, he called the commanders of his army and issued orders, dispatching them in various directions.

Parthibendran bid his farewell to the prince saying, "It is quite unfortunate that I have to leave this Island empty-handed. Your brother will be furious with me for not fulfilling this mission but there is nothing I can do when you are so stubborn. I will call upon all those present here as witnesses to absolve me from any blame."

The prince smiled and said, "Why do you leave so hurriedly then? Why don't you come along with us to Thondaiman river?"

"I will not be a party to this action of yours, prince. My ship awaits me at Thirikonamalai. I wish to hurry back to your brother and give him news about whatever happened here," he said and then turned towards Vandiya Devan, "Vallava! Do you wish to return to Kanchi along with me?"

Startled by this sudden question, Vandiya Devan replied, "No. I wish to go with the prince."

"Very well then. You will regret your decision, I am sure," said Parthibendran and left with an escort of soldiers that the commander had provided.

"What did that Pallavan mean when he said that I would regret my decision of staying back with the prince? Do you know?" asked Vandiya Devan to Azhwarkadiyan.

“I suspect that commander and that Pallavan are up to something. We will learn about it soon enough. If you ask me, Kodumbalur Periya Vellar is solely responsible for the prince’s present predicament.”

“How so? What did the commander do?”

“He has a niece in Pazhaiaarai staying with Princess Kundavai.”

“Yes. Princess Vanathi.”

“Yes. The commander wants the prince to marry her and rule the kingdom of Ilangai as a king. It was ‘he’ who urged the Maha Gurus of Ilangai to offer the throne to him. But was he prudent enough to keep his efforts under wraps? No! The news of his plans reached Thanjavur, which was why my guru, Anirudha Brahma Rayar sent me here to warn the prince. Vandiya Deva, no matter what happens, we will need to keep ourselves safe as we will be called at the royal court to give evidence about the prince’s innocence.”

By then, the commander had dispatched his army save a few soldiers, in all directions with various instructions. After a while, the prince’s entourage started with the commander, Vandiya Devan, and Azhwarkadiyan on horseback and Poonguzhali atop the elephant and the foot soldiers who remained. They travelled north on the king’s road for a while, but their journey was interrupted numerous times by people who crowded them on both the sides of the road to see the prince. The villagers near the king’s road had somehow learned that the prince was on his way and they gathered on the road to cheer.

Long live Arulmozhi-varmar! Long live the prince!

The crowd on the road kept growing with more and more people, making it impossible to travel. Some tried to follow their horses too!

When the prince expressed his displeasure about the situation to the commander, they moved from the king's road and entered the woods to continue their journey. But the journey through the forest was fraught with natural hindrances and their progress was slow. By mid-day they reached a large lotus pond where hosts from the villages had gathered, learning somehow that the prince would be travelling through there. They cheered wildly when the prince's party neared them. The commander stopped his horse and said, "Let me go ahead and find out what they want."

He came back after a while saying, "The villagers around here have cooked a feast for the prince and wish him to partake of their humble offering as they had somehow learned that the prince would be travelling through these woods."

The villagers neared the prince gazing at his face with astonishment. Cheering for him enthusiastically, "Long live the prince!" Long live the conqueror of Ilangai!" "Long live the king of Ilangai!"

The Prince who looked amused by these cheers called their leader nearby and asked, "Why do your people call me 'King of Ilangai'?"

The village head bowed his head respectfully and said, "Prince! Our kingdom has suffered much under the reign of kings who would desert us during our time of need. That's why it is the dearest wish of the people that you ascend the throne of Ilangai."

They partook the feast that the villagers had prepared for them and by the time they bid their farewells, it was very late in the day.

Vandiya Devan and Azhwarkadiyan sat conversing in low voices during the feast. "Thambi! Do you see? This entire feast by the villagers was the Senathipathy's idea of stalling the prince. That's why he sent his soldiers ahead to alert and inform the villagers about the prince's arrival."

“It is quite evident but I don’t understand what he means to achieve by making these villagers say that they want the prince as their king. Does he think that the prince might reconsider his decision of refusing the throne of Ilangai?”

“That might be one of the plans but right now he wishes to delay our journey that much is evident.”

“Why does he want to do that?” Questioned Vandiya Devan.

“I do not know that yet but we will learn it soon enough. Look at the prince! He isn’t relishing the feast or this interruption to his plans.”

Vandiya Devan looked at the prince and noted his displeasure. The Prince who was always composed and calm looked angry and sullen.

Poonguzhali in the meanwhile was sitting in a corner by the lotus pond immersed in deep contemplation about their journey and the disappointment that she felt. She had hoped that she would have ample opportunity to talk to the prince during the journey. She had blithely imagined many a happy hour spent talking and laughing with the prince of her dreams. She thought that she would be able to reveal some of her heart’s desires to him during the course of their journey but none of her dreams came to pass because the prince was forever surrounded by people and crowds.

It looks like I would be blamed in the end for handing the prince over to his enemies. Why should I do it? Why can’t I run away from here while everyone is at the feast? I can escape the commander’s wrath. Why should I bother if the commander is angry with me? I am not answerable to him or to anybody. Why should I allow my desires and wishes to be buried within my heart? Why should I live this life when I can’t follow my heart? Why doesn’t lightning strike me and end my suffering? I have wished for it so many times but the gods haven’t heard my prayers yet. Maybe I could end this life myself and relieve my suffering.

Oh! What is this? Is this a dream? Isn't that the dagger that Vandiya Devan threw at the bushes? It went missing when we tried to search for it. How did it end up here? Could that enemy be near here? Did he try to throw it on me and fell short? Let me tuck it in safely. I will feel safer with a blade in hand. I can fulfil my promise to the prince and then I can use the dagger to end my suffering. No, not in front of him. That would be too cruel. I could take the boat and give up my life in the middle of the sea. My dear dagger, I truly thank the man who threw you my way again.

Poonguzhali's mind's eye conjured a vision where she lay with the dagger deeply plunged in her heart and with her blood flowing freely. The prince would then come to her running and gasping for breath. He would say, "Ayyo! You are giving up your life for me?" Poonguzhali would then look up to him with glowing eyes while he would wrap his arms around her. Her blood would drench his clothes while his tears would drench hers. Poonguzhali would then laugh and say, "My prince! At last, you have divined the secret desire of my heart." The prince would say, "I know your heart's desire, but you didn't have to die to fulfil it." Poonguzhali's heart was singing a hundred songs of joy and she laughed out loud!

"You! Mad girl!" called out a voice and Poonguzhali looked up to see Vandiya Devan standing in front of her. "The prince is angry as it is because of the delay. I won't have you delaying this journey any further. Come with us now."

Poonguzhali got up laughing and cheerfully got atop the elephant that had carried her so far.

They started their journey again but were soon interrupted ominously when an arrow almost fell upon the prince. Thankfully, he reined in his horse at the nick of the time and the arrow flew near him and struck Azhwarkadiyan's turban.



Azhwarkadiyan felt his head for injuries, shocked by the sudden turn of events. Poonguzhali, on the other hand, felt sad that the arrow didn't kill her instead. The commander who looked shocked and surprised came near the prince, saying, "My prince! Did you see? Thankfully, I didn't send you alone. You are in grave danger here." Then he asked his soldiers to search the nearby woods for the assassins but they could not find anyone in the foliage.

Flustered and alarmed, the commander started making plans to safeguard the prince for the rest of the journey. "The prince needs to travel in the middle while we will travel around his horse guarding him from all directions."

The prince interjected saying, "Commander, I have a request."

"Prince! I am here to serve you. Command me."

"Senathipathy! I wish to reach Thanjavur alive. I need to prove to my father that I am innocent."

"Prince! Your father knows that you never aspired to usurp the Ilangai throne."

"I still need to prove that these charges that have been laid against me as untrue. Until then, it is imperative that I keep my life safe."

"My prince, I will use this dagger to end my life if I cannot save yours."

"If you do that, the Chola kingdom will have lost one of its brave commanders."

"Yet it wouldn't be more grievous than losing you, prince. I have sworn to protect you and if I fail, I will fall upon this sword and slay myself."

“Since these assassins seem to be following me everywhere, and I fear that if we travel by horse any longer, we will see more such arrows falling upon us.”

“Are you suggesting that we walk or else...”

“Commander! I know the language of elephants and I have travelled atop them many a time in this island kingdom. For a short while, I will become the mahout and travel atop this elephant. The mahout can ride my horse.”

The commander was silent for a while thinking about the prince’s plan. He looked at the others, hoping that they would have some objection to it.

“Ayya! What if the mahout can’t ride the horse?”

“He can walk or return to the king’s road then.”

“That girl is very strange. What if she refuses to travel on the elephant along with you?”

“She is free to walk or ride the horse if she can.”

“Alright. As you wish.”

The prince dismounted from the stallion and came to the elephant. Poonguzhali’s beautiful eyes widened when she saw the mahout getting down and the prince taking his place.

Their journey resumed again. Poonguzhali was in seventh heaven. The elephant suddenly grew in size enabling her to touch the clouds. It was a dream that she dared not believe. Whose sweet voice is that? But of course, the prince was speaking.

“Samudra Kumari! Would you mind if I travel along with you on this elephant?”

“I will consider it as a boon that the gods have showered on me, My prince.”

“If this elephant starts running suddenly would you be afraid?”

“I will not be afraid even if the sky falls upon us, so long as you are with me.”

“Where did you leave your boat, Poonguzhali?”

“Near Yaanai Iravu [\[189\]](#) on the opposite bank.”

“How did you cross Yaanai Iravu?”

“When I came, the tide was low, so I walked a bit and then swam ashore.”

“Would you get scared if this elephant were to get into the sea?”

“I won’t be scared if it pushes me into the sea. I am Samudra Kumari and it was you who gave me this name.”

“When we reach Yaanai Iravu, let us go in your boat. You would be able to row the boat with two people in it, wouldn’t you?”

“These hands have plied the oars since I was ten years old. They are not soft to touch like those of the princesses who live in palaces. Didn’t your friend Vandiya Devan tell you about how I brought him to Ilangai?”

“He did but today you might have to row much faster than you ever did. We need to reach Thondaiman river as soon as possible.”

“Prince! I came with the news of these ships hoping to save you from your enemies. Why do you bid me to guide your way there? Don’t you have any mercy in your heart for your slave?”

“Poonguzhali! My father is sick and bedridden. Don’t you know it?”

“I know. People fear for his life, ever since the comet appeared in the sky.”

“If he dies before I meet him, I would never forgive myself. He would leave this world thinking that I tried to usurp this Kingdom.”

“The emperor would never think thus. This is a plot hatched by the Pazhuvur lords.”

“If that is so, then I would like to prove to them that I am not a traitor.”

“Why?”

“In truth, I have no wish to rule this kingdom or any other.”

“Then, what is it that you wish for?”

“I wish to sail on a boat on the endless sea. I wish to visit all the island kingdoms that we ruled and lost. I wish to meet the people of these kingdoms and learn more about them.”

“Strange, very strange.”

“What is strange?”

“That you should wish for things that I have wished for years. Will you take me along with you when you set sail on your boat?”

“I need to fulfil my duty to my emperor and the kingdom first. Will you help me?”

“I live to serve you, my prince.”

“There is a rope hanging from both sides of the elephant, grab it in your hands and hold on to it tightly.”

“Why?”

“Because the elephant is going to run now!” said the prince and bent down to whisper something in the elephant’s ears. Soon the elephant’s pace quickened and then broke into a run trumpeting loudly. The speed of the elephant could only be compared to that of a hurricane and soon their companions and the entourage were far behind while the other wild animals of the forest scurried for cover to escape the mad rampaging elephant.

“Ayyo! The elephant has gone mad! What shall we do now?” shouted the commander wildly!

Despite the prince’s warning, Poonguzhali’s heart filled with dread. She felt as if she was stuck in a gigantic whirlpool with no way to escape. The elephant, however, didn’t slacken its pace until they reached Yaanai Iravu.

## **Chapter 45: The Warships**

Almost within the blink of the eye, they left behind the woods, the lakes, the birds the sea and for Poonguzhali life seem to move faster than the waves. For a while, a herd of deer tried to keep pace with the elephant but they soon gave up. Poonguzhali lost track of time and didn't know how long the elephant ran through the woods. She couldn't gauge the hours or the distance that they had travelled. She was however sure only of one thing, that they were still in the island kingdom of Ilangai, which was quite surprising.

Hasn't this elephant roamed around the borders of this kingdom at least three times by now? No. We are not in Ilangai anymore. We are circumambulating the earth instead.

At first, when the elephant ran trumpeting wildly, Poonguzhali was terrified despite the prince's warning. As they left behind the commander's entourage, the prince turned behind and gave her a charming smile and Poonguzhali's fear disappeared and she started enjoying the ride. As the elephant picked up the pace, she lingered on a beautiful dream where the prince took the place of King Indra and she his consort as they travelled through the clouds in their white elephant Iravatham<sup>[190]</sup>. Sweet smelling flowers were showered upon her and the divine music of the heavenly bards followed them everywhere. Apsaras danced beautifully to the accompanying music while Poonguzhali travelled through the stars for a few eons.

Soon Iravatham's pace slowed down and they were back on the earth again. The mahout bend down and spoke something to the elephant.

No. No. That's not the mahout. That's the prince.

The elephant stopped near a pond in the woods. Poonguzhali looked around with trepidation wondering if there was someone about or if the commander and his entourage had followed them but there was no one there. The elephant bent its legs upon the prince's command and he got down.

"Poonguzhali! Don't you wish to get down from the elephant's back?"

Poonguzhali came awake from her enchanting daydream and got down from the elephant saying, "It is rather difficult to come back to this mortal earth from the beautiful heavens."

Standing by the beautiful lily pond, Poonguzhali looked lovely, her eyes brightened by the exhilarating journey. Looking at her reflection in the pond, the prince said, "Samudra Kumari, I like you very much."

The prince's words washed over her like the scent of thousand lilies.

"Do you know why I like you?"

Poonguzhali held her breath waiting for him to continue. The woods, the pond and the sky above seemed to swirl around her as she waited for his reply.

"Most people who are with me want me to act according to their wishes. It was only you who agreed to fulfil my wish and command. I will never forget your help in this matter."

Poonguzhali blushed and stood still.

"Senathipathy and Parthibendran conspired to delay my journey. The commander created many hurdles all through our way by sending his men to the villages near by and asking them to arrange a feast. While I am delayed here, Parthibendran had planned to take his ship from Thirikonamalai and reach Thondaiman river before I arrived there. They thought that I didn't know their plans! Thankfully, I was able to thwart their efforts with your help."

Poonguzhali looked up and realization of what she had done washed over her.

“Ayya! Your companions and friends conspired to help you escape your enemies. I am the wretch that brought you here to be imprisoned.”

“Aha! What is this? I had such a good opinion about you and you turn out to be just like them.”

“I lost my wits thanks to your sweet words. Now that I have regained the power of reason, I realize what I have done. I will leave you here now,” said Poonguzhali and turned to leave. The prince grabbed her hand to stop her from moving away.

His touch was potent enough to drain her energy and she entered her beautiful daydream yet again where the heavenly apsaras showered beautiful flowers on her. Unable to stand anymore, Poonguzhali sat down near the pond and started crying with both her hands on her face.

“Samudra Kumari I wish to tell you something very important but if you are going to cry thus, then let us leave this place right away.”

Poonguzhali wiped her tears and looked up. “Good. Now listen to me. You said that my friends and companions are trying to save me from being imprisoned. You were right but do you know why?”

“They have great affection for you while I am the scoundrel who would take you to those wretched ships to be imprisoned.”

“Wait! Wait! Yes, they do have great affection for me. Do you know why? Astrologers and soothsayers have apparently predicted that I would one day become a king. So, they wish to crown and enthrone me today. They are not only mean but also selfish.”



“But what is wrong in their wishing to crown you as the king. You are capable of ruling all the three worlds!”

“Aha! Even you have started parroting their words. Woman! The palace is as good as a gilded cage of a bird and the throne is good as a sacrificial altar. Wearing a crown is the worst punishment anybody can think of in this world. Most people will not agree with what I say but I thought that you were different.”

Surprised by his words, Poonguzhali looked at him in wonder.

“Samudra Kumari, tell me truthfully. If someone asks you sit on the throne for your entire life, would you do it?”

Poonguzhali thought for a while and said, “No. I will not.”

“Then why do you want me to sit on the throne?”

“But you are of royal birth!”

“What if I am of royal birth? Thankfully, I was not born the heir and the Chola throne has two contenders; my brother and my uncle.”

“Oh! You know about Prince Madhuranthakan’s desire to rule the kingdom.”

“Of course, I know it. The throne of the Cholas will not be bereft without a ruler, I am sure of it and I have no wish to rule the kingdom.”

“Then what is it that you wish?”

“That’s a good question to ask. I wish to travel on an elephant to far away lands. I wish to take a ship to unknown lands and see new kingdoms that are there beyond this island. I have heard that there are many beautiful islands beyond this kingdom. I wish to visit them all.”

Poonguzhali who was listening to the prince with a wide-eyed wonder, said, “Ayya! Will you take me along with you when you go there?”

“These are my wishes and dreams. Who knows whether they will get fulfilled or not?”

Poonguzhali then asked, “Ayya! Why do you wish to go to Thanjavur then?”

“I wanted to tell you that and then we spoke something else. Samudra Kumari have you seen a deaf and mute woman roaming through this island kingdom? Many might even call her mad, have you ever seen her? Do you know anything about her?”

Poonguzhali looked at the prince with a wide-eyed surprise and said, “Yes. I know about her. Why do you ask?”

“I will tell you why later but tell me how you know her?”

“Ayya! I lost my mother when I was very young. It was she who showered me with love and care after that. She is like my mother, my guru and my God. What else do you want to know about her?”

“Does she have a permanent abode somewhere or does she constantly roam around this island?”

“When we travel from Kodi Karai to Ilangai there is an island name Boodha Theevu. There is a cave on that island and that’s where she stays. That’s where I saw you for the first time.”

“What? You saw me there?”

“Yes. Inside the cave, she has drawn some beautiful pictures. One of the pictures that she has drawn looks exactly like you. Later, when I

saw you in Kodi Karai for the first time, I was amazed by the resemblance.”

“Oh! I understand many things now. Things that were hidden in the past are seeing the light of the day. Do you know how I am related to that woman?”

“I had guessed that there is some relation but I can’t understand how?”

“Poonguzhali, she could have been the queen of Chola Kingdom. She is my step mother.”

“God! Could that be true?”

“Fate intervened and changed her life. What can we do now? I had always known that my father nursed a secret pain in his heart. I found out all about it after I came here. My father is under the impression that my stepmother is dead. I suspect that he has been feeling guilty thinking that he was the cause of her death. I want to meet him and tell him that she is alive and well. Only then, his heart will be at peace. You know that he is seriously unwell and could die at any moment. There are all sorts of rumours going around the kingdom and a comet is seen in the sky. I wish to meet my father before any harm befalls and tell him about her. Samudra Kumari, that’s why I am hastening to Thanjavur. Do you realize now, how important it is that I go there?”

Poonguzhali who had listened to every word of the prince whispered to herself, “God! Why do you test the faith of your children with so many trials and tribulations?” and then she said, “Prince! If you think that I can help you in any way I can, I am honoured beyond my dreams but you could have told all this to the commander and they could have helped you reach Thanjavur.”

“I have no wish to reveal any of this to them. They will not understand. They are single-minded about wishing to crown me as

the next king. Moreover, I do not wish to reveal my father's secrets to them. Even if I did, it wouldn't seem important to them. I need another help from you Samudra Kumari. That's why I stopped the elephant, as I wanted to tell you this before we reached the ships. The astrologers that predicted great things about my future have also foretold that I would encounter many dangers to my life. If my journey ends in such a disaster and I am unable to meet my father, would you meet the emperor and tell him about my stepmother. And if he wishes it, would you take her along with you, so that they could meet. Will you do this Samudra Kumari?"

"My prince! Nothing will happen to you. Danger will flee from your presence. You will reach Thanjavur safe and sound, I am sure of it."

"If something happens to me, will you fulfil my request?"

"I will."

"Good. You know, I couldn't have entrusted this to any of my companions."

"Now that you have entrusted this to me, I can take your leave. You probably don't need me anymore," said Poonguzhali harshly suppressing her own sorrow.

"How could you leave now? We have not reached the Thondaiman river yet. We need to see these war ships too. You will need to bear my company for a little while more. Once we near the river and see the tiger flag on these warships, you can take your leave."

Without any reply, Poonguzhali got up and went near the elephant. The prince followed her and bid the elephant to bend down and they mounted it, to resume their journey again. The elephant kept a steady pace and walked fast towards their destination.

"Samudra Kumari I told you about the things that I love. What are the things that you love the most?"

“I love the way Lord Yama<sup>[191]</sup> comes on his buffalo. I love the fire bubbles that appear out of nowhere in the woods of Kodi Karai.”

“You are indeed a very strange girl.”

“You should probably call me ‘mad’ as your friend did. I also love to row my boat on the endless sea with nary a care. I especially love it when there is a storm. The sea would raise my boat to the very heavens only to pull it down to the deep of the sea. Nature’s fury is an exhilarating experience. When this elephant ran wildly through the woods, I felt the same wild happiness.”

“Poonguzhali! If Lord Muruga had come here wanting your smiles, he would have been disappointed. He can’t trick you with elephants and gain your favour so easily as he did with Valli.”

Soon they neared Thondaiman river and Poonguzhali let out a shriek of surprise, “Oh! What is this?”

“What? What?” asked the prince

“I can’t see the war ships bearing the tiger flags. What will you think of me? You might even believe the suspicions that the commander had of me.”

“I will never think of you like that Poonguzhali. You have no cause to lie.”

“There is cause to lie. What if they think that I lied to you so that I can get you here alone, for the sake of love?”

“If the commander was here, then he might have suspected you of the same but he isn’t here. And we both know that there is no room for such foolish madness in our hearts.”

“Ayya! Would you say the same thing to Princess Vanathi who is promised to you?”

“The commander and my sister want me to marry that girl. She probably wants to be the queen and has been nursing many such dreams in her heart. I can’t be responsible for somebody’s day dreams, Poonguzhali. Be that as it may. Where were the ships when you last saw them?”

“They were anchored near the bend of the river. I remember it well.”

“No matter, they might have moved the ships from there. Let us go near the beach and find out.”

“If those warships have moved away, it is all for the good. Why should we go in search of them?”

“Aha! You might think that it is good, but I would be very disappointed it were so.”

Three hundred years ago, Ilangai Prince Manavanman sought shelter at Kanchipuram during the reign of Mamalla Chakravarthy<sup>[192]</sup>. The emperor promised the destitute prince help to recover his usurped kingdom. The Pallava troops that landed with the prince disembarked at Thondaiman. During that period, it was not a huge river as it was in these times. The Pallava troops deepened the river making it convenient for their warships. The region surrounding the river had many bends that offered several hiding places for the ships to anchor silently.

As they neared the river, a devastating sight met their eyes. They saw a ship that had run aground in the shallow mud of the river. Its mast and sail had fallen down along with the tiger flag of the Cholas. The ship seemed deserted and it looked as though the crew that manned it had abandoned it for good. Poonguzhali was more surprised by the irony; the ship that had come to imprison the prince lay imprisoned by the mud!

## **Chapter 46: Heart Aflame**

The Prince bid the elephant to stop and they both got down from its back to have a closer look at the ship that had run aground. The ship was indeed in a pitiable condition with its sails torn and mast broken. They clapped and called out hoping that someone might respond but the sailors who had come along with the ship must have abandoned it. The ship looked deserted.

They both got down into the water and climbed onto the ship. The base of the ship was damaged and the lower level of the ship was filled with water and mud. The Prince who had thought that he might be able to helm the damaged ship was disappointed because it would be impossible. It would take an army of people to repair it.

Saddened by the fate of the ship, the prince bent down and retrieved the tiger flag of Cholas that lay pinned among the sails. His face mirrored the desperation and sorrow that he felt in his heart.

“Poonguzhali is this one of the ships that you saw?”

“It looks like it. The other ship that came along with this must have drowned as well,” she said gaily.

“Why are you so enthusiastic about these ships drowning?”

“Why should I not be enthusiastic and happy when the ships that have come to imprison you are gone for good?”

“This is wrong Poonguzhali. Your happiness is misplaced. Something sudden and unfortunate befell this ship. I am distraught by the thought that our warship has suffered such a fate. The sailors of the Chola navy are very experienced in sea warfare. I cannot believe that they wilfully lifted the anchor and allowed this ship to run into the ground. Why did they abandon this ship and leave? Where did they

go? Let us go to the beach and see if the other ship is anchored there.”

“But it is getting dark. Where do we search?”

“Samudra Kumari where did you leave your boat?”

“My boat is almost midway through this canal. We passed by it because we came on the elephant.”

“Alright. Let us walk to the beach then, before it darkens even further.”

They left the elephant to guard the half-sunken ship and walked all the way to the beach but there was no ship or boat in sight. After surveying the sea for some time, the prince turned towards Poonguzhali and said, “Poonguzhali I will never forget the help that you rendered me. I think that we should part now.”

Poonguzhali stood silent.

“Did you hear what I just said? I have decided to wait in this half-sunken ship. The commander and my companions will soon reach here. I will decide the next course of action after consulting with them. You have no other work here. Find your boat and go home. Just remember what I told about my father.”

Poonguzhali hesitated and then clutched a tree branch for support.

“Poonguzhali! What is it?”

“Nothing. I will take leave of you here, prince. May the gods keep you safe!”

“Are you angry Poonguzhali?”



“I have not grown so headstrong My prince that I dare to be angry with you.”

“Then what is it? Why are you standing here?”

“I am not angry. I am tired. It’s been two days since I slept. I will sleep under this tree tonight and then leave in the morrow.”

It was the night after full moon and a glorious moon had risen in the sky. The Prince looked at Poonguzhali’s face in the light of the soft moonbeams and noted the exhaustion that marred her beautiful features. Her eyes were bloodshot and swollen due to lack of sleep.

“You say that it’s been two days since you slept. How long has it been since you ate?”

“I think it’s been more than two days. I didn’t feel hungry when I was with you,”

“We had a feast this morning and like a fool, I ate with my friends. It didn’t occur to me to ask you whether you ate. Come with me Poonguzhali. Let us go back to the sunken ship. I noticed a bag of rice and grains along with utensils to cook. We can clean and cook a meal. After the meal, you can leave to find your boat,”

“Ayya! If I eat, I might just sleep off there. Even now, my head is swirling,”

“That’s fine then. You can sleep in the ship undisturbed while the elephant and I will keep guard. In the morrow, you can go in search of your boat.”

Saying thus, the prince took Poonguzhali’s hand in his and supported her while they walked back to the ship. His heart was brimming with love towards this poor boat girl who had come to rescue him out of nowhere. He felt that even all the riches of the

seven worlds couldn't repay the love and kindness that she had showered on him.

As they neared the half sunken ship, they could see smoke rising from behind the ship.

Did the sailors who had once manned the ship come back to it? How would they react if we come in their presence suddenly?

They walked slowly and stealthily and reached the ship but no sound was heard from it but a delectable smell of sweet potatoes roasting over fire stirred the hunger pangs of the prince and Poonguzhali. The Prince who had by then realized the state of exhaustion that Poonguzhali was in, decided to throw caution to the winds and walked boldly to the other side of the sunken ship. There he found a woman preparing food on one of the urns found in the ship. It was Kaveri Amman!

She didn't seem surprised to see him and welcomed him with a smile. After the food was ready, she served the prince and the hungry Poonguzhali with tasty rice and sweet potatoes roasted in the fire. To the prince, her simple fare of rice and vegetables seemed more delicious than any elaborate feast served in the palace.

After eating, they came to the upper deck of the ship. The sea was placid and calm and the air was still. The air around them was sultry and hot with nary a breeze to carry a leaf around. Sweating in the humid air, when the prince commented about this to Poonguzhali, the mute and deaf woman whom we will henceforth refer as 'Oomai Rani<sup>[193]</sup>' pointed to the moon. There was a fog around the rim of the moon.

"When the clouds form a ring around the moon, they say that storm and rain will soon follow."

"Let the storm come whenever it comes. I would settle for some breeze right now."

Next, he wondered about how Oomai Rani could possibly have come after them so fast.

“I am not surprised. My aunt can travel very fast and she has great affection and regard for you. There are many things that one can achieve through the power of love.”

Oomai Rani who must have intuitively understood this conversation pointed a finger and they saw a majestic white horse standing next to the elephant that they had travelled. The prince was surprised to see that the horse in question was a steed of a rare breed.

“Did she come here on this horse? Does she know to ride horses?”

“Nothing is impossible for my aunt. She knows the language of horses and elephants. She also knows to ply the boat on the sea. Sometimes, I feel that she knows to travel by air too, as she can travel so fast from one place to another.”

“This is no ordinary horse. This steed belongs to a high breed of family that is reared in the desert kingdoms of Arabia. How did this horse come here? Where did she get it?”

When Poonguzhali asked Oomai Rani about it in sign language, she said that the horse came ashore near Yaanai Iravu and was galloping madly through the woods. Oomai Rani then calmed it down and mounted it to come after them. The prince was even more surprised to learn that an Arab horse was roaming around in the woods of Yaanai Iravu.

Even as he spoke, the prince didn't fail to notice the yawn that she fought to stifle. “You said that you were very tired and sleepy. Why don't you go and sleep?”

Poonguzhali lay down on the upper deck of the ship, covered herself with a sail cloth and was soon fast asleep. The prince watched her

fondly as she slept but soon her lips were mouthing her favourite song.

Alai Kadal Oindirukka  
Agakadal than Ponguvathen

While the waves of the sea are placid and gentle,  
Why does the sea within me surge and rise?

Aha! Vandiya Devan was murmuring the same song in his sleep last night. He probably learnt it from her. Later, when she is awake, I must ask her to sing this song for me.

Soon his attention turned towards the Oomai Rani. Everybody's heart is aflame with desires and passion but when they turn to dust, we cry about its loss to others and hear consoling kind words from our friends but for the Oomai Rani that was not possible.

How many desires, wishes and yearnings did she lock in that heart of hers and for how many years?

Oomai Rani sat near the prince ruffling his long hair lovingly and touched his cheeks tenderly. The prince didn't know what to do for a moment and then bowed towards her with his hands folded but she held his hands to her face and soon they were wet with her tears. Tears that she had held back for years filled the hands of the prince.

After a while, Oomai Rani composed herself and asked the prince to sleep while she stood guard. The prince didn't feel sleepy but he nonetheless lay down. For many long hours, his heart and mind were surging with memories of long past. At a late hour, the sea breeze set in and he slept only to wake in his dreams.

He had many strange dreams. He was mounted on the white Arabian steed and was galloping away towards the skies. Soon he reached the heavens and the abode of Devas. Indra the Lord of the Devas, welcomes him in Amravati and takes him on his white

elephant, Iravatham. Next, he is in the court of Indra and the Lord of the Devas offered his throne to him.

“O! I don’t need this throne. Instead, I would be very happy if you could offer it to my mother, Oomai Rani.”

“When she arrives here, she will ascend this throne.”

Next, he gave him a vessel of nectar. The prince partook of it and said, “O! This is not as sweet as the water of the river Kaveri.”

Next Indra took the prince inside the anthapuram and his queen, Indrani asks him to choose a beautiful damsel as his consort.

“None of these beautiful maidens can compete with the beauty of Poonguzhali.

Suddenly Indrani vanished and in her place, Princess Kundavai appeared.

“Arulmozhi! Have you forgotten my Vanathi?”

“Akka! How long can I stay bound by your love? How long do I live like a slave? Your love has become a prison for me so much so that I would prefer to live in Pazhuvetrayar’s dungeon prison. Release me! If you don’t I might as well become another Uttara Kumar<sup>[194]</sup>.”

Kundavai who is shocked by his speech keep a finger on her lips and says, “Arulmozhi! Why have you changed so much? Who was responsible for it? Thambi, love is a prison and will always be. You can’t simply bow to the dictates of your heart.”

“No akka, I have seen love that does not bind you in any way. Shall I show it to you? Poonguzhali! Poonguzhali! Come here.”

When the dawn broke amidst the cheerful chirping of birds, Poonguzhali rose from her sleep to the sound of horse hoofs. Her

aunt, Oomai Rani had mounted the horse and was galloping away. Though she was intrigued by her aunt's sudden departure, her heart was full of enthusiasm. She got down from the half-sunken ship and walked ashore. The woods were full of birds chirping around. On one of the trees, a huge parrot was perched almost royally and it looked at Poonguzhali with its beady eyes as though it was asking, 'Where have you come?'

"Dear parrot! In a little while, the prince will leave me alone here. Will you keep me company?" spoke Poonguzhali to the parrot.

"Poonguzhali! Poonguzhali!"

Someone was calling her name and at first, she thought that it was the parrot that was speaking to her. But she soon realized that the voice was coming from the ship and that the prince was calling her. When she went aboard the ship, she found the prince asleep and that he was calling onto her, in his sleep. She tenderly touched the prince's forehead and woke him up.

The prince woke up amidst confusing dreams and reality mixed up in his head. It was dawn and the sun had risen gloriously while Poonguzhali's beautiful face was lotus-hued and free of the fatigue that he saw yesterday.

"You called me, why?" asked Poonguzhali.

"Did I? I must have spoken in my sleep then. You sang a song while sleeping last night, then why can't I speak?"

Then he got down from the ship, "I have been asleep for so long. Where is your aunt? Where is Oomai Rani?"

When Poonguzhali told him about her aunt's disappearance, he didn't seem surprised.

“I expected that Samudra Kumari. Looks like you are refreshed now. You can take your leave. I shall wait here for the commander and my friends. Until then I wish to inspect this ship properly.”

“Look there!” shouted Poonguzhali suddenly and the prince looked in that direction to see a large ship cruising along the sea, while a boat full of people was headed towards them.

“Aha! Now we will know what happened here,” said the prince and came to the banks of the canal. Poonguzhali and the elephant too followed them there. The prince smiled at her and then turned his attention towards the ship that was leaving. For some unknown reason, he felt that he ought to be on that ship. Yet another reason for his worry was that someone was missing in the boat that was coming towards him.

There was the commander, the soldiers who had come along, the boatman, the Vaishnavan but where is Vandiya Devan? That brave man who ingeniously escaped the Pazhuvetarayar’s soldiers only to bring him a message from his sister, where did he go?

Though he had known Vandiya Devan for very few days, the prince felt as if he had lost his childhood friend. His absence from the boat made the prince feel as though he had lost a treasure!

When the boat came ashore, the commander and the others got down from it and splashed their way to the banks of the canal. The commander Budhi Vikrama Kesari came towards the prince and hugged him saying, “Ayya! How could you do such a thing to an old man like me? We were so worried for your safety. How did you tame this elephant? I can’t believe this is the same elephant that tore through the woods with you on its back! When did you reach this place? Where are the warships that Pazhuvetarayar had sent?”

“Commander, I will tell you what happened to us later but first tell me where is Vandiya Devan?”

“That boy is on his way to wherever that ship is going,” said the commander and pointed to the ship that was fast fading on the horizon.

“What? Whose ship is that? Why is he aboard that ship?” asked the prince

“Ayya! I am very disturbed. I don’t think I can answer your questions. Ask this Vaishnavan. He knows all about you and about that boy as well.”

The prince turned to the Vaishnavan with an impatient gesture and asked him, “Thirumalai! Why is Vandiya Devan on that ship? Tell me immediately!”



## **Chapter 47: The Ghostly Laugh**

Now let us see what happened to those who were left behind after the prince left them.

When the elephant ran through the woods with the prince mounted on its back, the commander was shocked beyond words. He shouted and rallied his soldiers and tried to give a chase but not even their fastest stallions could match the speed of the rampaging elephant.

Nonetheless, they plodded on through the forest and reached Yaanai Iravu where their journey was interrupted. Vandiya Devan who was ahead of the party got stuck in quick sand and was extricated from it with great difficulty. With his horse maimed, it became difficult to journey further and they halted there.

The commander who was distraught and worried about the fate of the prince, “I have never in my life made such a blunder. Why are you all standing quietly? Why don’t you speak up? How do we rescue the prince now?”

Azhwarkadiyan said, “Commander, I have been thinking about this for long and I have an idea!”

“Were you waiting for an auspicious time to tell this idea? Spit it out fast!”

“I don’t think that the elephant that prince had mounted was mad.”

“Then who is mad, you?”

“No! No! I suspect the prince learned about your little ruse of stalling him with village feasts. That’s why he led the elephant through the woods. He knows the language of the beast and could easily control it.”

The commander thought about this for a while and then acknowledged that it could be true. Though he was piqued by the fact that the prince would leave them unceremoniously, his heart was at peace with the possibility that Ponniyin Selvar might be safe after all.

“Alright. Be that as it may. We should go to Thondaiman river to find out what happened.”

“Yes. Let us walk by the coast and see if we can hail a boatman to take us there, or else we will have to wait until Parthibendran comes this way on his ship.”

“Vaishnaverey! You are very cunning indeed. Did you plant this idea in the prince’s head?”

“Commander I swear on my Lord, I haven’t spoken to the prince ever since we started on this journey.”

With the bulk of the boats and the fisherfolk who ply them shifting to Maandotham due to the war, there were no boats visible on the coast. Nonetheless, they stood by the canal watching for one. Finally, they found a small fishing boat cruising along the canal and he agreed to take them along when he realized that the man who was requesting him was the commander of the Chola army. They decided to take the boat until Thondaiman river but by then the sun had set and darkness was descending upon them. The boatman refused to ply the boat in the dark and risk a collision with the jagged rocks of the coast.

“Ayya! From here on, the trail of this canal will change directions abruptly and there are many jutting rocks all through the way and we need to navigate carefully even with daylight. We can resume the journey only tomorrow.”

By then, the weary party was too tired to argue with him, so they settled down to sleep in the woods for the night.

Vandiya Devan didn't find any of this to his liking and was irritated by the turn of events, so he fought with Azhwarkadiyan instead, "This is your doing!"

"How is this my doing?"

"You reveal everything by half measures. Ever since I met you in Kadambur, you have been toying with me. You knew that the prince is going to leave on that elephant, then why didn't you tell me? I too would have got on it, along with Poonguzhali. After much difficulty, we met the prince and now we have lost him again, all thanks to you. What will I tell Princess Kundavai when I meet her next in Pazhaiaarai?"

"But your mission is complete, now that you have given her olai to the prince."

"No. My mission is complete only when I escort the prince back to his sister. Unfortunately, I have you beside me to create hurdles."

"Alright! If you feel so, I will take my leave from the commander tomorrow."

"Oh! Now that your work is done here, you are trying to slip away. I always had a suspicion about you right from the first moment I set my eyes on you."

They fought for some more time and then went to sleep. When the dawn broke, Azhwarkadiyan woke up to the sound of a boat being rowed. The boatman who had rowed them the previous night was ferrying a few men across the canal that joined the sea. And what was more alarming was that a ship stood anchored in the sea and the boat was going towards it bearing a few men.

*Whose ship was that? Where did it come from? Where is it bound?  
Who are the people on the boat? Why are they going to the ship?*

All these questions coursed through his mind within a blink of the eye. He went near the commander and tried to rouse him, "Senathipathy! Wake up! See what is happening!"

The commander, Vandiya Devan and the other soldiers woke up immediately and hastened to his side by the coast. They first saw the ship anchored in the sea and the Senathipathy said, "Oh! That looks like a Chola ship to me. It could be one of the ships that Pazhuvetarayar had sent. What if the prince is imprisoned in that ship? Ayyo! Woe to me for sleeping soundly while my prince is held a prisoner on this ship. Where is our boatman? Fetch him immediately! We need to catch that ship."

That's when they saw the boatman ferrying a few men on his boat. "There he is! Who are those men? Why are they going to the ship? You there! Stop. Come back here!"

Vandiya Devan who was watching all this silently heard only one thing from the commander's lament. What if the prince is imprisoned in that ship? That thought alone made him jump into the water and swim towards the boat that was fast moving away from them. He didn't have time to spare a thought for anything else. Thankfully, the tide was low and it was easy for him to swim and catch up with the boat. But when he reached the boat, they were in the sea and the water level had risen. He panicked and shouted, "Ayyo! I am drowning. Please save me." He heard someone laughing in the boat and then the boat stopped as the boatman lowered his oar to aid him and he got on board.

Vandiya Devan looked at the men in the boat and was shocked to see that they were from the desert kingdom of Arabia. They were dressed differently and each one of them had a cloth trailing from their turban with which they had hidden their face, except for their eyes. He then looked at the rest of the men and found that they were

not foreigners. To his eyes, they seemed quite familiar and that's when he recognized Mandiravadi Ravidasan.

Didn't he shout like an owl and come to meet Pazhuvur Ilaya Rani? Didn't he try to take the Pazhuvur ring from me in that deserted mandapam? Thank god I got on this boat. The prince is indeed in great danger.

As they neared the ship, Vandiya Devan tried to talk to his companions but they were silent.

"Where are you going?" he asked

"Can't you tell? We are going to the ship," said Mandiravadi.

"Where is the ship going?"

"That we will know once we reach the ship."

Ravidasan then asked Vandiya Devan, "Where are you going?"

"I am going to the ship."

"Once you are aboard the ship, where will you go?"

"That I will know once we reach the ship," replied Vandiya Devan cockily.

When they reached the ship, a rope ladder came down and they climbed over it to board the ship. Many were conversing in the upper deck of the ship in a language that Vandiya Devan could not understand. Vandiya Devan hastened to climb up and jumped into the ship shouting, "Where is the prince? What have you done to him?"

When he looked around, his heart sank more, as all the sailors were fierce Arab warriors, tall and lean with bloodshot eyes. That's when

he realized the blunder that he had made through his hasty decision. This can't be the ship that Pazhuvetarayar had sent. Except for Mandiravadi and his companion, all were Arab warriors and sailors. It was unlikely that the prince would be aboard this ship. He immediately turned and tried to hail the boatman who had ferried them thus far. "You there! Stop! I want to get down."

A hand with an iron grip snaked around his throat choking him while he struggled to free himself. The Arab warriors pushed him to the middle of the deck and surrounded him. Angered by this, Vandiya Devan hit the sailor next to him and he fell down. He heard a fierce growling sound behind him and turned just in time to escape from a short, curved dagger. Soon the warriors had surrounded him and no escape was possible. One of them brought ropes and bound his legs and arms. He was bodily lifted and taken to a room on the lower deck and tied to some wooden logs.

He could feel the ship moving. "*But where is it going,*" wondered Vandiya Devan.

*If I escape from this peril, I will never jump into anything hastily. I would learn to live like Azhwarkadiyan, to think and weigh the consequences of each action carefully before acting on it.*

A ghostly laugh was heard again and he turned his body painfully to see who it was. It was Ravidasan.

"My boy! I came here searching for that Chola tiger. Though I didn't get the tiger, I am happy to capture the jackal of the Vanar clan, which is an unexpected luck."

The boatman who witnessed the capture of Vandiya Devan came back immediately and told the others about what had happened.

The Senathipathy and the others got into the boat and headed towards Thondaiman river. It was impossible to follow the ship on a

small boat in the sea. When they questioned the boatman about his recent passengers, he had no useful information.

“I was sleeping in my boat when those men woke me up. They offered me a lot of money if I could take them up to the ship. I agreed and took them since you were all sleeping, I went with them.”

As Azhwarkadiyan narrated this to the prince, he added, “When Vandiya Devan jumped into the sea, I wanted to follow him too but sadly, I am not a good swimmer and I had my own doubts about that ship. I mentioned it to the commander too. After Vandiya Devan was captured, we couldn’t follow that ship in a small boat, so we came here to check whether you were indeed imprisoned in that ship. We were very relieved when we found you.”

Arulmozhivarmar listened to his narration intently and said, “But I am not relieved to hear that my friend is aboard that ship. What if Pazhuvetarayar catches him and sends him to the dungeon prison?”

“My prince! Why should we bear the authority of those upstart Pazhuvur lords? You just need to say the word and I will rouse an army on your behalf and we can destroy their clan.”

“Ayya! I will never raise arms against my father’s authority. Please do not suggest such schemes to me.”

Suddenly they heard the clip-clop hoof sound of a horse and they turned around to see a woman riding on a white horse with neither bridle nor saddle.

## **Chapter 47: The Captain's Death**

It is easy to guess who the woman was. The prince and Poonguzhali went up to her. The others stood back watching and wondering how a woman could tame and ride an Arab horse with such ease.

Oomai Rani got down from the horse and cast a worried glance at the commander, Vaishnavan and the soldiers behind them. She then proceeded to speak with Poonguzhali in sign language.

“My aunt has seen something strange in the forest. She wants us to accompany her,” said Poonguzhali.

The prince decided to leave with her and asked her if the others could go with them. Oomai Rani thought for a moment and then nodded her assent and they journeyed southeast through the thick forest. As they followed her into the forest, they had to hurry to keep up with her and the prince's eagerness increased with each step. He intuitively knew that something important had happened or else Oomai Rani wouldn't take him on such a long journey through the dangerous woods. They soon came upon it.

In a small clearing through the woods, they noticed bodies of slain men, savagely cut with bleeding wounds and the rotting stink of dead men. The commander and the prince who had seen countless wars were astonished by the savagery of the enemy who had cut down the men mercilessly.

The prince looked around immediately and shouted, “Quick! Quick! See if anyone is alive.”

The commander and his soldiers immediately checked the bodies for life. Oomai Rani led the prince through the clearing and under a tree was a man resting his head on the trunk of the tree. His body was fully covered with wounds and blood. He had been dealt with a



terrible gash on his head from which blood had oozed all over his body. He opened his eyes with difficulty and looked at the prince piteously. He tried to say something and with difficulty opened his mouth.

The prince went near him and carefully held him in his arms saying, "Someone get him water, now!"

"No. I don't want water. This woman gave me some just a while ago. If she had not come here on time, I would have died. Ayya! I came here with the treasonous intent of arresting you and the gods have punished me justly."

The prince recognized him on hearing his voice. He said, "Ah! Kalapathy<sup>[195]</sup>! What are you saying? How did this catastrophe happen? I cannot believe that you tried to betray me!"

"Ayya, I led two ships here on Pazhuvetarayar's command to arrest you. Here is the royal decree with the emperor's seal," said the kalapathy and took out an olai from his waistcloth.

The prince glanced over the olai and said, "What treason did you do here? You followed the orders of the emperor. When I learned that you are here, I hastened to meet you, to give myself up. Who attacked you? Tell me quickly!"

The kalapathy then recounted everything that happened. He left for Ilangai from Nagapattinam on two ships with sailors and soldiers. His heart was not in the task but he couldn't say 'no' to direct orders from the emperor. Periya Pazhuvetarayar too had issued a few orders before he left. They asked him to anchor the ships at a safe secluded place and meet the prince with the emperor's summons. They also cautioned him about Kodumbalur Periya Vellar and that he should not learn about his intentions to arrest the prince under any circumstance. They asked him to find the prince's whereabouts first and then give him the message. They didn't expect the prince to refuse the emperor's summons but if he did, the kalapathy had

orders to arrest him with force. Next, Pazhuvetarayar provided him with a few of his own men to help the kalapathy to fulfil his task.

The kalapathy took the ships onto the sea with a heavy heart. His men had no inkling of their mission and this made it all the more difficult. He knew that he would have to reveal the true nature of their mission to his crew when they neared their destination but he hesitated, fearing the consequences. When they reached Thondaiman river, he left for Gangasenan<sup>[196]</sup> to learn about the prince's whereabouts. He learnt that the prince was near Anuradhapuram and then hurried back to his ship.

When he returned to the ship, he learned that Pazhuvetarayar's men had revealed the true reason of their voyage. The kalapathy's sailors swarmed around him asking him to confirm whether they would arrest the prince. He tried to pacify them saying, "We have sworn our service and sword to the emperor's service and he has ordered us to imprison his son and bring him back to Thanjavur. We cannot defy his orders."

"We cannot do that. These are not the emperor's orders. These are Pazhuvetarayar's orders!"

"What will you do then? Will you defy our emperor?"

"We will go to Maanthodham and surrender to the prince."

"But the prince is not at Maanthodham."

"If that is so, then we will surrender to Kodumbalur Periya Vellar."

The kalapathy tried to convince them to give up this mutiny but they refused and a handful of Pazhuvetarayar's men agreed to stay with him. With just ten men supporting him, it was impossible to sway the minds of over 200 men.

“If you are resolved to do this folly then leave now. I will not shirk my duties to the emperor and defy his orders.”

The mutinous sailors then took charge of one of the ships. At first, they wanted to take the ship to Maandotham but the others rejected the idea. Later, they decided to go there through land and in their hurry to leave, they failed to anchor the ship properly. The ship moved towards the land and ran aground.

After the sailors left, the kalapathy didn't want to linger around their ship. He moved his ship to a secluded cove and anchored it. He had heard a disturbing rumour about an Arab ship that sank near the Gangasenan port. He had learned that fierce pirates from that ship were roaming around the region. So he decided to travel by land to meet the prince and wanted the remaining men to guard the ship until his return. The sailors were disheartened by the turn of events and he was trying to pacify them when they were attacked.

Just as he feared, the Arab pirates surrounded them and attacked them fiercely. They were unarmed and the unexpected attack was a slaughter.

“My prince! I alone escaped their deadly attack with grievous wounds. I wanted to tell someone about what happened to us. Thankfully, through God's grace, I met you. I got my just rewards for my treasonous acts. Ponniyin Selvar...please forgive me!”

“Kalapathy! You did your duty even during the most perilous times. Why do you ask my forgiveness? If there is a heaven for brave souls, you have earned a seat of respect there,” the prince spoke and touched the forehead of the wounded captain. Overcome with gratitude and pain, the kalapathy clutched the hands of the prince and gave up his life.

## Chapter 48: A Ship Hunt

When they cremated the slain bodies of the sailors and their brave captain, the prince allowed his tears to flow unchecked and the commander said, “Ayya, why are you crying for these traitors? God has punished them justly for wanting to arrest you.”

“Thalapathy, they were not traitors and they have earned a place in the heavens. I am crying because the Chola kingdom is on the brink of destruction.”

“We have been on the brink of destruction right from the time the Pazhuvur lords took command in Thanjavur.

“Sailors defying their captain’s command is but a small ripple in this ocean. If this continues, soldiers all over our kingdom will mutiny and the people will suffer its consequences. The very foundation of our kingdom will shake and the Cholas will be laid to waste. It pains me beyond anything that it is I who brought this fate to our kingdom. They say that when Duryodhana<sup>[197]</sup> was born, wolves and jackals howled for a whole day. I am sure they would have howled in the same manner on the day of my birth too,” said the prince.

“Ayya, do you know how many auspicious signs were sighted on the day you were born? The astrologers who cast your horoscope...”

“I have heard enough about my horoscope. Thalapathy! It is time that we part. I have one request though. The soldiers who mutinied and left the ship will come and surrender to you. I want you to imprison them and send them to Thanjavur to stand trial.”

“My prince! We can’t decide that with just what the kalapathy said. We haven’t heard the sailor’s side of the story. How can we pass judgement without hearing both sides? Come with me now and when those sailors come we can...”

“That’s not possible thalapathy! I will leave you to settle that matter. I can’t wait here for one more moment. I need to go. Where is the boatman?”

“Where do you need to go prince? What do you need the boatman for?”

“How can you ask me this question? I need the boatman to go after the ship that is carrying Vandiya Devan. That brave man boarded that ship thinking that I am aboard and has become the prisoner of the Arab pirates. How can I leave him to his fate? How can I betray my friend?”

“Ayya, no one will believe that you would betray a friend. Vandiya Devan is a reckless man and lacks the ability to think before acting. Those pirates captured him because he didn’t stop to think before leaping into the water. How could you hold yourself responsible for this? Moreover, how can he be your friend? I don’t like the sound of it. He was sent here to serve you. Friendship can happen only among those who are in the same status as yours.”

“Thalapathy, I don’t want to stand here and argue with you about this. That would be wasting precious time. I can’t give up on Vandiya Devan. Even if I agree to your surmise that he is not my friend, we Cholas are celebrated as people who never forget a favour done to them. Vandiya Devan braved many dangers to bring a message from my sister. I owe him. I want to leave right away.”

“Where will you go and how will you search?”

“I will take the boat that you came in.”

“That would be like trying to hunt a tiger with the help of a rabbit. How can you search for a ship that is cruising the deep sea with a small boat? Even if you catch the ship, what will you do?”

“I will take this boat. If this boat sinks, I will swim the seas until I find that ship. I will not rest until I find that ship and rescue him. Where is the boatman?”

After speaking thus, the prince looked around to search for the boatman and he found him next to Poonguzhali and the Oomai Rani. He went near them and heard Poonguzhali chastising the boatman severely.

“Poonguzhali, what is this?”

The boatman suddenly fell on the prince’s feet saying, “My prince! I am a traitor but I didn’t do it wilfully. I didn’t realize I was betraying you. Please forgive me.”

“Poonguzhali, what is happening here?”

“I was silent for so long because I was ashamed to speak to you. This man is my brother. It was he who brought those traitors who wished to kill you from Kodi Karai. He has been waiting here because they promised him a bag of gold and that’s why he took them back to that ship.”

“Prabhu! I didn’t know that they came here to kill you. Please forgive me. If I had known about it, I would have refused my service to them. Please kill me for treason.”

“Your life is very precious to me now. Come let us leave. Take me to that ship and I will forgive your past deeds of treason.”

The prince and the boatman walked towards the coast where the boatman’s boat was there. “We can still see that ship. It should be easy to follow it.”

The commander who had followed them there squinted his eyes and said, “What a wonderful coincidence?”

“What? What do you mean?”

“My prince! That is not the Pirates ship that you are seeing now. That is Parthibendra Pallavan’s ship. He is coming here from Thirikonamalai.”

“That’s very good. Then I can hunt that tiger with the help of a lion. But I am not going to wait until the ship nears us. I will take this boat to board the ship.”

“My prince! I would like to come with you on the boat.”

“Ayya, I don’t want anyone to come with me. Thirumalai, didn’t you say that you were afraid of water?”

“Yes, ayya. The prime minister bid me to take care of you until you were in Ilangai. Now that you are leaving, I will hasten to Madurai and inform my master about all that has happened here.”

“Good. Poonguzhali, we will part here. Do not worry about your brother I will take care of him. Find your boat and go back home. I will never forget your help. What is this? Wipe your tears! What will people think?”

Saying thus, the prince went near Oomai Rani and fell at her feet. She raised the prince to his feet and kissed his forehead lovingly. The prince got into the boat and the boatman Murugayyan plied the oars. The rest stood at the shore watching the prince in the boat. The prince turned to look at them. Though he looked at everybody, he found that he could see Poonguzhali’s tear-streaked face more clearly than ever, as he left the shore. The prince remembered his dream and Kundavai’s plea, “Thambi! Don’t forget that Vanathi is waiting here for you,” The prince then turned his eyes away from the shore and looked at the ship.

## **Chapter 50: Pandiyan's Bodyguards**

When Parthibendran saw the prince coming towards him on the boat, he was more than surprised. To him, it was akin to a situation where God himself made his way towards him and had asked him to name the boons that he wanted. He was also surprised by the fact that the prince was coming alone except for the boatman. He wondered whether the prince knew that this was his ship or is he under the assumption that this is one of the ships that had come to imprison him?

Parthibendran soon learned that the prince did not have any such wrong assumptions. The prince related all that had happened and Vandiya Devan's dangerous situation to Parthibendran. "Vandiya Devan is in grave danger and in the hands of fierce Arab pirates. We need to find that ship and rescue him."

"Though all this is unexpected I am happy to hear that the ships that came to imprison you have been destroyed. Yet this boy shouldn't have courted danger without any thought to consequences. Nonetheless, we can't abandon him to those pirates. Their ship must be nearby, we will catch them soon," said Parthibendran and called his captain and told him about their mission.

"If the winds are favourable thus, we can catch their ship by this evening. Once the ship reaches Kodi Karai, it has to go by the narrow coast."

The winds, however, had other plans and there was nary a breeze in the sea. The water and air remained still while the ship struggled to move. The sun seemed intent on boiling the sea water while the humidity increased through the day.



With the weather failing to cooperate, the prince looked around dejectedly and asked the captain, “The winds have failed us and the ship is not moving! How long will the ship remain still? When will the winds blow again? What if that ship escapes?”

“My prince! I think there is a storm nearing us. It might hit us here or it might even leave us alone but the sea will not remain calm for long. You see the sea placid now, but by nightfall, you will see giant waves rising above and tossing us to the depths of the sea!”

“If the storm hits the ship, wouldn’t it be dangerous?”

“It is very dangerous. If the Gods will, we will survive this danger.”

“If that is so, then it is unlikely that we will catch that other ship,” spoke the prince dejectedly.

“The wind and the sea are impartial to all. That other ship too would be stuck in the water just as we are.”

“What if they had gone along the coast?”

“Then there is a chance that people in it might escape. If not, then they too would be immobile in the sea.”

“It doesn’t matter how great the danger is, so long as people dear to us are with us,” said the prince and looked at the sea again. Through his mind’s eye, he could see the Vandiya Devan’s laughing face and Poonguzhali’s haunted looks as she bid him farewell.

Where are they now? What are they doing?

**We left Vandiya Devan in a truly precarious situation. Let us go back to him now.**

The lower deck of the ship was filled with many items strewn carelessly around him. They had left him in the storeroom filled with

such sacks and wooden logs. He sat still for a long time after they left him there. This isolation allowed him to berate himself most severely for not looking before he leapt into danger. After some time, his natural curiosity was aroused making him wonder.

*Whose ship is this? How did these Arab pirates capture a Chola ship? How did Mandiravadi and his companion join hands with them?*

Soon he started wondering what they might do with him? His dejected mind and heart conjured image after image of all his dreams making him more desperate.

*Were they mere dreams? Will I die in the hands of these pirates? No! No! I have escaped from worse troubles than these. Until I am alive there is always hope. I just need to think through this problem and find a way to escape from here.*

He looked around him to see where he was kept. At first, it was very dark and when his eyes became accustomed to it he saw that there were many swords, knives and daggers lying right next to him. Though they had tied him securely to a large wooden log, his hands were not. He could stretch them out to pick a knife or a dagger. He could untie himself by hacking the ropes. Even if he were to untie himself he would still be locked inside the storeroom. He also noticed some coconuts lying in the corner. They should suffice to satisfy his thirst and hunger.

*How to escape from here? Even if I escape, would it be possible to fight with those fierce Arab pirates and Mandiravadi? Moreover, if I kill them all, I would still be stuck on this ship!*

*No! It is best to tarry and wait a while. Instead of killing me, they have tied me. That is a hopeful sign. I need to be patient and wait.*

As hours passed, it became difficult to wait. He felt as if he was thrown in a bowl to steam and boil. Hot and humid, sweat poured out

of his body in rivulets. If someone had told him that a sea voyage would be so uncomfortable, he wouldn't have believed it a few days ago.

The night he had travelled to Ilangai on Poonguzhali's boat had been so pleasant that it hurt to remember.

Suddenly he could sense a change. The ship had stopped moving and it became more sultry and hot inside the room. With his throat dry and he felt that he could kill someone just to quench his thirst. He reached towards one of the blades to cut through the ropes and that's when he heard steps coming towards him. He immediately sat straight and tried to look innocent.

It was Mandiravadi Ravidasan and his companion. They opened the door and stood next to him.

"How is the voyage? Are you enjoying it?"

"I am dying of thirst. Give me some water."

"Ah! Even we are thirsty. But those wretched Arabs have not kept any water on this ship."

"My mother goddess Kali is thirstier than any of us. She thirsts for blood," said Ravidasan's companion.

Vandiya Devan turned and looked at him. "Don't you recognize me thambi? I am Devaralan. It was I who danced in Kadambur after the Kuravai Koothu. The gods came upon me with their divine message and mother Kali demanded blood. Royal blood!"

"Ah! I remember now."

"Yes. We wanted to slake my mother's thirst with the blood of that Chola tiger but we failed in our mission. We tried to send that Veera Vaishnavan to Vaikuntam but that too failed. Thankfully, you came to

us and for now, we will satisfy our mother's blood thirst with a sacrifice of a scion from an old clan."

"Then why do you hesitate?"

"Ah! You might be many things but you are a brave man and we acknowledge it. That's why we want to take you back and give a blood sacrifice to our holy mother with great pomp and piety. Most importantly, our priestess needs to come."

"Who is that priestess?"

"You don't know that? It is Pazhuvur queen Nandini Devi,"

"If it is truly your intention to sacrifice me to your goddess then please give me some water. I will die of thirst otherwise."

"We have no water thambi!"

"But you call yourself a mandiravadi!"

"That was well said. I have used a spell and see the effect; the ship has stopped moving altogether. Tonight, we will be hit by a storm and it will rain."

"If it rains, how can it help me? You will be on the upper deck while I am here."

"You too can come up with us and slake your thirst with rain water... if you heed us."

"Heed you?"

"Yes. We want to sacrifice those Arab fiends to the Sea God?"

"Why?"

“They wish to take this ship to the kingdom of Kalinga while we want to go ashore at either Kodi Karai or Nagapattinam.”

“There are six of them and are very fierce,”

“Three of them are sleeping and the rest are exhausted. If we slay those who are asleep, we can manage the rest easily. What do you say?”

Vandiya Devan stared at them with stony silence.

“What do you say, thambi? If you agree to our idea we will untie you.”

Vandiya Devan’s eyes could clearly see the disapproving lines of Prince Arulmozhivarmar’s forehead. He would never approve of killing those who are asleep.

“I can’t do it. Slaying those who are asleep is a despicable act.”

“Fool! These Arab fiends attacked and slaughtered Chola sailors when they were sleeping.”

“Their vile deeds are on their head. I can’t act against my conscience.”

“Fine. Be that as it may,” said Ravidasan and picked up a long sword from the pile of weapons while Devaralan picked up a stout club.

When they left, Vandiya Devan noted that they did not lock the door. He twisted his body and took hold of a small knife and slashed the ropes that had tied him. Next, he picked up the coconuts that were kept in the room and broke one of them. It held enough water to slake his thirst. Then he put the rest of the coconuts inside a cloth bag.

He then moved to the pile of weapons that were strewn in the room and picked up a long sword and waited with bated breath. Soon he could hear clangs of swords on the upper deck and sound of bodies being thrown in the water. He pounced out of the door and headed towards the deck.

He saw Ravidasan and Devaralan fighting with four Arab pirates with great difficulty. With a loud cry, Vandiya Devan came towards them and started attacking two pirates at the same time. One pirate fell with a deep gash on his fearsome face and while the other was disarmed by Vandiya Devan. Vandiya Devan wrestled with him for a while and then a mast fell on him, rendering him unconscious.

In the ensuing scuffle, Vandiya Devan learned that Ravidasan and Devaralan were not skilled swordsmen by any measure. They each fought with an Arab pirate but couldn't match their adversaries in speed or skill. But when Vandiya Devan threw their friends' body overboard they turned to look and were killed during that moment of distraction.

Exhausted, the trio sat down together after ensuring that their enemies were truly dead.

"My boy! You turned up at the right time. How did you come?"

"Looks like you put a spell on me. The ropes slackened its hold and a sword appeared in my hands."

"What about your thirst?"

"A coconut broke open on its own and offered me its water!"

"You are quite amusing, my boy!" said the other two and laughed.

"Thambi, we were testing you. We had deliberately left those arms near your reach and had not tied you securely to the log."

Vandiya Devan couldn't fathom from their expression whether they were telling the truth or not.

"Listen to me! Do you wish to live? Do you want to live with everlasting fame, power and prestige? If you do, then join us. You will get all that you have ever dreamed of and more!" said Ravidasan.

"You killed them when they were sleeping, didn't you?" asked Vandiya Devan.

"We were able to kill only two of them. The other man woke up. If you had joined us earlier, it would have been easier."

"How could you act so despicably? Killing those who are asleep is against all codes of war and morally wrong. How could you do such a thing?"

"This is nothing thambi. If we hesitate for this, how can we achieve other things that we have planned? If you were to join us..."

"You are asking me to join you, but who are you?"

Ravidasan looked at Devaralan and said, "There is no need to hide the truth from him anymore. He has but two choices, either he joins us or he will be slain and sacrificed to the sea god."

"Tell him everything then."

"Listen thambi, we are Veera Pandiyan's Abathudavigal. We were his bodyguards who had sworn our lives to protect him from his enemies."

"You failed in your oath. Aditya Karikalan won over your king."

"How do you think he won? He won because of a foolish mistake made by a woman. She had more trust in her seductive allure. She

swore to us that she could make that snake, Karikalan dance to her tune. The snake did dance for a while but in the end, it lashed out at our emperor and took his head. Our emperor's head rolled in the mud. They took it all the way to Thanjavur in a decorated palanquin. Aha! Thanjavur! Just wait and watch what we do that city of yours!"

As Ravidasan spoke, his eyes reddened and he gnashed his teeth unconsciously. Devaralan's face too bore the same hatred.

"Whatever happened has happened. What do you intend to do about it now? Do you think you could bring your emperor back to life?"

"No. My spells are not potent enough to breathe life back into the dead. But we can avenge his death by slaying his killer and his entire clan. We will put the entire Chola clan to death and destroy their seed. Will you join us?"

"After killing all the Cholas, what will you do?"

"We will crown whomever our Maharani<sup>[198]</sup> wishes to bestow the honour on."

"Who is your Maharani?"

"You don't know that? The woman who is pretending to be Pazhuvur Queen."

"What about Madhuranthakan then?"

"He is a snake from the same family."

"Then Pazhuvetarayar?"

"Ah! Do you think we will keep that old man around? We are merely using his power and position to fulfil our oath."



“You told me that a woman is responsible for Veera Pandiyan’s death?”

“Yes. Nandini was responsible for his death. She swore to protect our emperor who was injured in the war but she failed to do that. At one time, we thought that she had betrayed us to Karikalan and were about to burn her on our emperor’s pyre. But she swore to avenge his death and took a holy oath along with us so we spared her life. Until today, she has been fulfilling her oath. Ah! We couldn’t have achieved so many things without her help.”

“You haven’t achieved anything so far.”

“Wait and watch thambi!”

“He hasn’t replied to your question. Is he going to join us?” asked Devaralan

“Thambi! What do you say? Will you join us? Who knows by a stroke of luck you might even ascend the throne as the emperor?”

If the Mandiravadi had asked him this question a few days ago, he might have falsely said, ‘I will join you’ but the prince’s attitude towards life had a strong impact on him. He couldn’t bring himself to say such a big lie against the dictates of his heart.

Instead, he tried to change the subject of conversation. “How did you capture this ship? How did you befriend these Arab fiends?”

“That’s because of my spell work thambi. We met them in Thirikonamalai where we bought horses from these Arabs. Thanks to their superior breed of horses, we were able to follow Prince Arulmozhivarmar in Ilangai. We saw the prince fleeing with his elephant near Yaanai Iravu. We wished to reach the coast of Yaanai Iravu before he did and took a shorter route. At the coast, we met the Arabs again. Their ship ran aground near Mullai Theevu<sup>[199]</sup> and they

had captured this ship from the Chola soldiers. They asked us to join to help them during their journey and we agreed.

“Why?”

“We overheard that snake Arulmozhi talking to Budhi Vikrama Kesari. We knew that he would come back to the Chola kingdom soon. We found it impossible to kill him in Ilangai. A ghost woman kept following him trying to save his life. She will not come to the Chola kingdom for sure. So, we decided to wait until he comes back.”

Vandiya Devan remembered the events that happened on the night of the Perahara festival and his first glimpse of Kaveri Amman. Ravidasan suddenly laughed thinking about something.

“You know thambi! These Arab fiends are very strange indeed. They are fierce and barbaric while fighting. Killing men is like cutting trees for them. They have no conscience to speak of nor do they recognize any moral code of war that you were speaking of. But they love their horses. In their kingdom, horses are ridden only after they are fitted with an iron horse shoe. While we ride our horses barefoot, which they believe is worse than barbaric. They don’t want to sell their superior horses to beasts like us it seems. You know what happened this morning?

“Tell me.”

“We were aboard the ship and the sails were raised and we started our journey when they heard a horse neighing near the coast. Our Arab friends immediately took a boat to the coast to see whether it might be one of their own horses that escaped from their ship earlier. They took us also along with them.”

“And then?”

“And that what? We couldn’t find the horse but we found you, which was a lucky coincidence. You were so helpful to us to slay these horse lovers!”

“Ravidasa all that is fine. This boy has not answered our question yet,” reminded Devaralan.

“I will answer your question ayya. I have pledged my service to the Cholas and I will never betray their trust and join you.”

“Have you joined the Velkarar Army? Have you sworn a holy vow in the presence of Mother Kali?”

“No.”

“Then why this hesitation? You are just a soldier who is free to join anybody.”

They didn’t know that no holy vow or oath was necessary for a man who has drunk the bliss of Kundavai’s smiles and her loving gaze. Added to this was the prince’s friendship. Who would indeed turn their back on such treasures?

“No matter what happens, I will never join your murderous gang!”

“If this is your final decision, get ready to sacrifice your life to the Sea God.” said Ravidasan.

## Chapter 51: The Storm

The sea and the air were still all around them. The ship stood immobile defeated by the elements of nature and incapable of moving without the winds. Vandiya Devan stood for a while looking at the placid sea silently. In his heart arose great waves of emotion and a germ of an idea!

He lifted both his hands up in the air and shouted, 'Om! Hreem Hasht!' and then unsheathed his sword with deliberate ferocity and swirled it around twice.

"Yes. The sea god wants a sacrifice indeed. He wants the blood sacrifice of two cowards who would attack those who are asleep. Unless I give this sacrifice, he will not allow this ship to move forward. Come now! Show me your head, let me remove it from your worthless self."

Ravidasan looked at Vandiya Devan surprised at first and then laughed loudly saying, "Thambi! What is this game?"

"So, you think this is a game? When I was in the lower deck tied and bound to those logs, I had a dream. I saw a spectre that rose above the sea to touch the skies. It spoke to me but I didn't understand what it said then. Now I do. It demanded that I sacrifice two Kali devotees. That would be you and your friend here. Once I offer your blood to the sea god, this ship will move. The sea god's thirst for blood was not quenched with the blood of those Arab fiends. Come now, let me sacrifice you," he said twirling the long sword again over his head.

"Thambi, I have never seen anyone so well versed in spinning tales."

"Oh! I am spinning tales now, am I? Then I will let the sea god give you his answer right now," said Vandiya Devan shouting and it

seemed as though the god of the seas had heard him and he responded too!

Yes. The sea that had been placid and still since that morning came back to life quite suddenly. The water seemed to shudder suddenly as the temperature dropped quite dramatically and the burning sun was soon clouded with dark rain clouds that threatened to rain. In the sea, small waves rose up almost simultaneously everywhere and their distinct white foam seemed like budding flowers!

It was an astonishing sight as the sea god released the winds that he had bound for so long. A slight breeze touched the ship rocking it up and down. Mandirvadi and Devaralan laughed out aloud.

“Ha ha ha!”

“Thambi! The sea god has answered your plea. We offer ourselves to the blood sacrifice that he demanded.”

Vandiya Devan was astounded by the sudden change that had come over the weather. The waves that suddenly rose had gone down and the wind was still again. He wondered whether he imagined it all. He even started wondering whether Mandiravadi had truly worked out a spell on the sea! That thought had a sobering effect on him.

*No! This Mandiravadi is a fraudster and I should not fall into his trap!*

The next instant he looked at them and said, “Then why do you hesitate? Come forward, let me sacrifice you now!”

“We wish to pray to the Divine Mother Kali before we are sacrificed. Give us half an hour of respite.”

“Alright. Say your prayers and come soon. Do not try to trick me with your magic spells.”

“We will be back soon. We will leave our weapons here!” said Ravidasan and they threw their weapons down and left him there alone and went to the opposite end of the ship. Vandiya Devan needed that half hour respite more than the Mandiravadi did. He needed that time to understand what was happening around him. He looked at the sea for answers. He wanted to kill those scheming murderers with a single slash of his sword but the sea’s resounding answer to his call had astounded him, rendering his sword arm weak.

He looked towards the southwest yet again. The rain clouds that were earlier small had grown big enough to cover the entire space of the sky until the horizon. A cool breeze started blowing through the ship and the sea came alive all around him. Small waves started rising up all around him rocking the ship gently. Soon enough the breeze became a wind and with every passing second, it became strong enough to steer the ship right into the eye of the storm.

Suddenly there was a splash in the sea as if something was thrown in. Vandiya Devan turned around and saw that Ravidasan and Devaralan were missing! He made his way to the opposite end of the ship and what he saw astounded him. Ravidasan and Devaralan had lowered a small boat and had jumped into it leaving him alone on the ship. Vandiya Devan expected them to scheme their way through their voyage but he didn’t think that they would abandon him on the ship.

Ravidasan gave his signature smug laughter and said, “Thambi! We don’t wish to sacrifice ourselves!”

Vandiya Devan who understood the situation berated himself for underestimating Mandiravadi. He also realized his own precarious situation. He knew nothing about sea voyages, leave alone navigating a big ship alone through a storm. He was clueless about where they were and in what direction they were going and the danger was only compounded by the fact that those two scoundrels were leaving him alone on the ship.

“You sinners! Can’t you take me with you?”

“Thambi! The sea god needs at least one sacrifice today,” said Ravidasan and soon he and his companion were plying the oars steadily and pulling away from the ship.

He thought of jumping into the sea to try and catch the boat but rejected the idea almost immediately for various reasons. He didn’t know how to swim properly yet and if he reached the boat, what is to stop those scoundrels from murdering him? After rejecting their offer to join their gang, they have more reasons to kill him than to keep him alive. They could turn those oars on him and it would be impossible to try to be afloat while trying to fend them off.

*Let them go! It is better to be alone in a big ship rather than suffer their company in a small boat. I have escaped from many dangers with the help of God’s grace. I will escape this too unscathed!*

He also wondered if it was right on his part to let them escape alive. God knows what these murderers have planned and what they might accomplish once they reach the shores.

*God will see to them surely, what else can I do here? If only I could go back to Prince Arulmozhi! He shouldn’t have abandoned me in the forest that day. If he had only signalled me to get on that elephant I wouldn’t have jumped into the sea to catch this ship so foolishly. If ever I meet him again, I will fight with him saying, “Is this how you repay someone’s gratitude? Is this how you treat your friend?” But will I ever meet him again or not? The commander and Azhwarkadiyan saw me and must have told the prince about my predicament.*

Even as he stood thinking thus, the boat had gone very far and soon would vanish from his line of sight.

*How did the boat move so fast?*

And that's when he noticed that the ship too was moving. The sea was becoming choppy and soon it began to toss the ship around. He also noticed that the sky was becoming dark.

*How is this possible? How could it become dark in the middle of the afternoon?*

He looked southwest again and found that storm clouds had blotted out the sun completely! The clouds kept rolling in the sky as Vandiya Devan watched the sight fascinated by its wild beauty. Soon the sky was filled with dark clouds with nary a ray of light from the sun. The wind too had picked up pace and was blowing steadily.

The waves were no longer small and had started tossing the ship around while its sails flapped wildly around. He realised this is the cyclone that Poonguzhali spoke about all those days ago. He had heard from someone that when a storm blows, the sails need to be brought down. But bringing down the sails of a warship is no mean task. It required muscles and the brute strength of ten men. What would he do alone? Let god take care of this ship.

But his innermost heart whispered the truth out aloud. The ship would be tossed around for a while in the sea and then it would sink. Before it sank, it would probably break and along with it, he too would drown.

*I will soon die in the sea! If only I could meet that Kudanthai Jodhidar again, I will show him the consequences of lying. What's astrology then? Just a bundle of lies! If only I could meet him again. What is this madness? Where am I going to see him again?*

Suddenly something hard fell on Vandiya Devan's shoulder and a hail storm was unleashed. Frozen water fell all over the ship. Vandiya Devan who had never seen hailstones in his life touched and held one in his hands with wonderment. He was happy to experience them before he could breathe his last. He sat down on



the deck and touched the icy hailstones and watched them melt away back into the sea.

The hailstorm stopped as abruptly as it began and then normal rain started. As he sat there, he noticed something that he didn't know. Even when huge waves rose and tossed the ship around, the water never stayed inside the ship. This also meant that the ship was built to withstand huge waves and this realization gave him some hope. He immediately got up and went down to the lower deck and closed the door of the store room where he was locked up. He decided to lock himself in the room again when the rain and the storm above became unbearable and the rest is up to the gods. He also felt gleeful about the fact that Mandiravadi and his friend had left a ship like this and had opted to escape in a small boat. That boat was just as carefully constructed as the ship. Even if the storm broke it apart they could escape with their life by just clutching the wooden log that was built with it. They might escape this storm and go ashore to Kodi Karai. From Kodi Karai his thoughts sprang towards Pazhaiaarai.

*How would Princess Kundavai learn about my fate? Who would tell her that I lost my life trying to fulfil her commands? Will these waters tell her about it? Will this wind whisper it in her ears? Why didn't I lose my life before I met her? Why didn't the gods bless me with a beautiful brave death? Why did they show me the path to the heavens only to cast me down to the depths of hell?*

The wind blew strongly, its speed picking up with every passing second. The sails of the ship flapped around madly, just as one would expect in a ghostly ship. The sky was lit up with lightning from one end to another casting a ghostly glow around the sea. A clap of thunder pierced his ears.

Vandiya Devan had seen many storms and a lot of lightning and thunder but none of that could match this experience. As the gods unleashed thunder and lightning one after another, Vandiya Devan soon began to wonder why the skies hadn't split yet.

The sea threw up one gigantic wave after another. Mountains of waves took the ship almost up to the heavens in one instant and then plunged it deep into an abyss the next. Caught in the maelstrom of winds, the ship with its sails spread out spun round and round.

Vandiya Devan soon began to wonder how long the ship would be able to endure the storm. As time passed his enthusiasm and joy grew. He was convinced that his death would be beautiful indeed and before he died he was determined to enjoy nature's work at play. As the waves lashed out at the ship, he laughed out aloud. He tied himself to the mast of the ship and spun with the sails. He lost track of time. He could have spun for a few seconds or for hours together, he didn't know. He had attained the consciousness that people reach just before they see death marching upon them.

The speed of the wind lessened with time and the torrent of rains stopped. The thunder and the lightning too had stopped and the dark sea danced a wild dance.

Vandiya Devan had closed his eyes tight unable to bear the glare of the lightning and had shut his ears fearing that he might go deaf from the thunder. He opened his eyes and removed his hands from his ears and looked around.

*Aha! Did I indeed escape from this storm? Has the storm passed us? Did the gods save my life? Will I see the princess again? Will I meet the prince again? It is too early to thank the gods now. I am still not safe. Who knows where this ship is right now and god knows how many more dangers are out there waiting for me.*

Even as he thought this, god seemed to answer his question with a lightning so potent that Vandiya Devan felt as if he saw over a thousand suns gleaming in front of him. One can see even in the dark once the eyes got adjusted but in this extreme light, nothing can be seen. Soon he had to shut his ears too as the thunder that reverberated through the sea was the loudest that he had ever

heard. If Indra had unleashed his Vajrayudham<sup>[200]</sup> it might probably make the same sound.

For a while, Vandiya Devan couldn't open his eyes, but soon he sensed a light from above and looked up to see the sails on fire. He understood why the thunder had been so loud. The lightning had struck the ship! Of the five elements of nature, two elements water and wind had repeatedly struck the ship and had failed. The gods Varuna<sup>[201]</sup> and Vayu<sup>[202]</sup> had failed to sink the ship but now Agni<sup>[203]</sup> had set fire to it.

## Chapter 52: The Broken Ship

When Vandiya Devan saw the sails on fire, he knew that the ship wouldn't escape the rage of the sea. His fate too was tied to this ship and therefore he too would give up his life along with it. Despite the realization that he would die soon, the thought didn't drown him with despair or sorrow. On the contrary, his enthusiasm grew by leaps and bounds. He unbound himself from the ropes that he had tied around himself and laughed aloud. He was happy that he didn't have to die burning in the fire that would soon spread through the ship. Death by water was much more preferable.

He didn't wish to waste the precious few moments that were left to live. He wanted to enjoy the terrible beauty of the stormy sea before he left this world. He looked around the sea in the light of the burning sails and tried to guess where he would drown precisely. He had heard people say that those who die with unfulfilled wishes and dreams would rise again as ghosts and haunt the place where they gave up their life.

*Will my ghost float through these skies? Will I fly through these waves in a spectral form? Aha! One day, Princess Kundavai might make a journey through here and will the sailors show her this place saying, 'This is where Vandiya Devan died!' Will her beautiful eyes shed a few pearls of tears for me? Would I be allowed to wipe her tears then?*

Just when his thoughts raced towards death the ship was raised high on a huge wave that allowed him to see the sea from a great height. Like a moving light, the ship illuminated the entire surroundings and he looked around eagerly to enjoy the last few precious moments of his life. And that's when he saw it!

He saw a ship and it was flying a tiger flag!

*Dear God! Is there no end to your miracles? That ship must surely bear Prince Arulmozhivarmar. He must have come searching for me!*

Parthibendran's ship that had come searching for Vandiya Devan too was tossed around by the cyclone's mad fury but the ship was manned by experienced sailors who traversed the sea in many a storm. They brought down the sails from the mast and had tied it securely and held the ropes of the ship together to prevent it from capsizing. The waves played around with the ship tossing it up and down as if it were a toy. When the force of the wind increased the ship would have spun around uncontrollably but the brave sailors of Chola kingdom prevailed.

"I have seen worse storms and cyclones than this and have brought my crew safely through them, my prince," said the captain of the ship. But there was another danger that might prove fatal.

"With the storm raging all around us, it is very dark as it is and the rains have been pouring without any respite. I fear that we might get very close to the ship that we have come searching for and in the darkness the possibility of colliding with it is very high. That ship too must be stuck in this cyclone just as we are and we may not even know that we are too close to it until we collide with it. That would be fatally dangerous! Both the ships will be break apart. That's why I am not worried about this storm as much as I am worried about this darkness."

The prince was aware of this danger. He was on the upper deck ignoring thunder and rain, looking around with his sharp eyes whenever the lightning struck. His heart was heavy and worried.

*Will I ever meet Vandiya Devan again? That courageous man who bore my sister's message came to me braving so many dangers, what would be his fate, stuck in the hands of the murderous Arab pirates? And if these dangers were not enough, the weather was posing the biggest challenge for the prince. What if we die here just*

*as the commander feared, by colliding on the other ship in this darkness? Who would tell my father the news about Oomai Rani?*

He had no intention of revealing their family secret to Parthibendran. The Pallava warrior was loyal but his attitude irked the prince to no end. Until now, the prince had never faced an outright defeat in any of the missions that he had undertaken. But his heart wondered often, that night, 'Will I fail in this mission?'

The prince heard a loud thunderclap and involuntarily he had to close his eyes and when he opened it again, his eyes followed a light that had newly appeared in the sea. At a distance they saw a ship with its sails flapping wildly and the top of the sail was burning and on the deck of the ship was a lone man standing! That must be Vandiya Devan!

*But why is he standing there alone? Where are the others?*

But there was no time for any more thoughts. The prince decided almost immediately as to what he would do now.

The others in their ship too had seen the other ship now and raised an alarm. The prince went and stood next to a small boat that was tied to their ship and spoke to the sailors who stood next to it.

"Who among you is prepared to come with me?" When the sailors learned his intention, they were understandably shocked but soon many came forward. Parthibendran and the captain tried to stop the prince.

"My prince! What is this? How is it possible to ply a boat in this storm? It would be almost impossible to reach that burning ship to rescue Vallavareyan but still we will make an effort to do that. You need not go - there are others here who will."

"Be careful! I will not forgive those who try to stop me now," said the prince sternly and lowered the boat into the sea and then turned

towards the sailors and said, "I need two of you to come with me."

The prince then jumped into the boat along with the two sailors and the boat moved away from their ship. The prince and the sailors plied their oars with much difficulty and slowly the boat approached the burning ship. By then, the fire that had started at the top of the sails had burned it half way down. Vandiya Devan looked at the approaching boat in the light of the fire but didn't move towards it. His astonishment rendered him speechless and had robbed him of his mobility. He watched the prince silently.

"Jump! Jump into the sea now!" shouted the prince but Vandiya Devan didn't hear him. He stood still like a statue. The prince saw that the fire was fast spreading through the ship and if they tarried any longer it would be disastrous for all. Within a second, he decided what to do and set things in motion. He tied a rope to himself and asked the sailors to hold it tightly and jumped into the sea. The sea played around with the prince lifting him high into the air and taking him to the abysses the next second. The prince swam steadily towards the ship when a huge wave aided him and threw him into the ship. Vandiya Devan ran towards him and lifted him up. The prince held him tightly and said, "Hold onto me! Don't let me go!" and they both jumped into the sea. The sailors from the boat put their oars down and were pulling the rope steadily. The prince and Vandiya Devan were soon near the boat and they climbed onto it with great difficulty.

"Row fast now!" shouted the prince. The burning ship would soon sink into the sea and the prince didn't want to be near it when it happened. When a ship sank, the turbulence of the water would naturally increase and the displacement of water would in turn, place the other boats in the vicinity in danger.

The ship soon began to sink and it was unbelievably terrible to watch the scene and yet their eyes were drawn towards its dark beauty! Just as the prince anticipated, huge waves rose again even as the sea ate up the Chola ship. With the burning ship gone, they were

plunged into darkness yet again and Parthibendran's ship was nowhere to be seen. They could be lost in the sea with no sense of direction or worse, they might even collide with the ship and break their small boat.

Though the storm had passed them by, the turbulence of the sea didn't die down soon enough. The cyclone in the meanwhile travelled to Kodi Karai and other coastal cities and towns bringing destruction and loss in its wake.

After surviving the burning ship, the small boat that bore the prince, Vandiya Devan and the two sailors was floating around. They didn't row as they were clueless about their direction but soon they encountered another danger. A mast that was half burned from the drowned ship floated in their direction and in the darkness, they didn't spot the danger until it was very close to them.

"Row fast now!" shouted the prince but before he could finish, the mast had hit the boat splitting it into half. The prince immediately grabbed Vandiya Devan saying, "My friend! Don't be scared, this mast is more secure than that small boat. Hold onto it!"



## Chapter 53: A Saviour's Song

Commander Kodumbalur Vellar stood at the banks Thondaiman river watching the prince even as he moved towards Parthibendran's ship. He was pleased by the turn of events and spoke to himself, "This just proves that the gods are favouring us. The auspicious marks on the prince's hand and favourable planets on his horoscope will prevail and lead him towards greatness. Parthibendran will take the prince back to Kanchi safely and it is time that I took my troops to Thanjavur and oust those who have usurped the power." When he realized that he had spoken his innermost thoughts aloud, he looked around warily and spotted Azhwarkadiyan standing next to him.

"Vaishnavaney! You are still here? Not that I am worried that you overheard me, after all there is no secret in this world that the Prime Minister Anirudhar doesn't know. Alright, what do you intend to do now? Will you come with me to Maanthodham?"

"No ayya! There is one more thing that my master had tasked me with..."

"And what would that be?"

Azhwarkadiyan looked towards Oomai Rani and stood silent. Oomai Rani was then speaking to Poonguzhali through sign language.

"Is it about that woman?"

"Yes. My master once told me to try and bring that deaf and mute woman to Thanjavur if it is possible."

"That's a good task that he has given you. Taking her to Thanjavur would be as easy as taking a cyclone along with you. I don't know who she is but it looks like she has love and affection for our prince

and he is very respectful towards her. What else do you know about her?”

“I know that she is deaf and mute and I also know that it would be impossible to take her to Thanjavur or make her do anything that is against her will, yet I can’t resist myself and try to make an attempt.”

“Looks like that boat girl also knows her. See how they are conversing using signs. Call that girl here, I need to warn her about something.”

Azhwarkadiyan asked Poonguzhali to meet the commander and then moved towards Oomai Rani. Poonguzhali approached the commander and stood at a respectful distance.

“Now, look here girl! You are very clever, that much is evident. You came at the right time to give us news about those Pazhuvur ships. The entire Chola kingdom is indebted to you for saving its prince. I will never forget your help. I will reward you for this, at the right time.”

Poonguzhali respectfully bowed her head and said, “Ayya, I don’t need a reward for helping the prince.”

“Ah! I will not accept that. Let our affairs get settled first and I will search for the bravest soldier in our army and get him married to you. I will ensure that you get a groom who is as valorous as Bheemasena and anything lesser than that would be unacceptable, as you can make anyone dance to your tune,” said the commander jocularly and smiled at her.

Poonguzhali was silent. The commander’s idea of a reward had infuriated her but there was no point in showing her anger to the old man. She controlled her anger with difficulty.

“However, remember one thing. Just because you have rendered a service for the prince, do not imagine that you can lure him with your tricks. There is a wide-open sea for you to catch any fish that you

fancy but don't try the same trick on the prince. I am warning you now. I will not tolerate your presence around him anymore."

As the commander's harsh voice droned on Poonguzhali fought against rising anger. She almost retorted a fitting reply to him but she couldn't speak. Her voice had clammed up and her anger manifested as tears in her eyes as they flashed at him.

With her head down, Poonguzhali walked away. Her pace kept increasing as she kept walking. She looked at Oomai Rani but found Azhwarkadiyan attempting a conversation with her. Craving loneliness and solitude, she started walking in the direction of Yaanai Iravu where she had left her boat. At that moment all that she wished to do was row away to a place where there was no one.

*Men are such beasts! Why do they talk so harshly to me? Why do they say such things to me? Why can't the gods strike at them and turn them mute?*

With thoughts racing through her mind, she soon reached the place where she had left her boat. She couldn't wait to get into her boat and row until she could sit back and enjoy the silent sea with nary a voice to bother her. Only there, she would find a balm to calm her anguished heart.

*That wily old man! What did he say?*

*There is a wide-open sea for you to catch any fish that you fancy but don't try the same trick on the prince.*

*How dare he insinuate that I am trying to catch the prince for my own desires? Chi Chi! How could that old man even think about me thus? His words have proved that animals and beasts are far better companions than men. In truth, wouldn't it be better if we were just fishes swimming through the sea all day long. They have no worries, no dreams nor do they experience distress like this. If only she and the prince were two fishes then there wouldn't be people like the*

*commander trying to pry them apart. They would be free to pursue their heart's desire. No. That can't be. Even in the deep sea, a fisherman could cast his net and catch them one of them leaving the other alone with despair and loneliness for company.*

While her heart was bleeding with anguish, she untied her boat and dragged it into the water and soon she was rowing out to sea. The boat had been her refuge and a safe haven that comforted her through many a storm.

*I don't really care. The world can end today for all the difference it would make. Let that commander protect the prince from all the young women in the kingdom and he could give his own niece in marriage to him. How can it affect me? I have my boat and there is the sea. Samudra Raja! Even if the whole world turns against me, you will give refuge to your daughter, won't you? The prince did name me your daughter after all!*

Poonguzhali rowed mechanically and soon she was nearing the sea. When she reached the sea, she knew that a storm was brewing nearby. She was familiar with the signs that portend a storm's arrival and the previous night she had seen the moon surrounded by clouds that clearly indicated a cyclonic storm. She knew that soon huge waves would rise up tossing everything in its wake. She decided to go to Boodha Theevu and wait out the storm there. After it had passed, she would make her way to Kodi Karai. There was no reason to hurry back home.

*The prince is on his way to Mamallapuram by now but why am I thinking about that now?*

Poonguzhali was not familiar with the navigation of big ships and didn't realize that ships too would be immobilized when the winds drop before a storm. The commander's words had hurt her beyond anything and therefore she decided that it would be better not to meet the prince again. She rowed towards Boodha Theevu and was

also soon looking forward to enjoying the storm's terrible beauty from the safety of the island.

The island was very near and within an hour's time, she reached there. She tied the boat securely to a tree and then climbed the tallest stupa of the island to watch the storm. The winds tore through the trees making them shake like blades of grasses and the fierce beauty of nature reflected the storm that was playing through her own heart. The lightning and thunder that accompanied the storm didn't deter the boat girl's strong heart. Her long curly hair unwound and rose through the wind with a life of its own. She stood for a long time watching the storm play through the sea and the island. She felt as though the storm had come there on her command just so that she could enjoy its terrible beauty!

That night she stood alone on the stupa enjoying the fury of nature and slept in a cave. She didn't find peace in her sleep and dreamt many unconnected dreams about herself and the prince. When she woke in the morning, the storm had abated. She walked towards the beach and found many trees uprooted by the wind's brute force. Near the beach, she saw a small raft floating by and the waves brought it ashore. A man was clinging to the raft. Poonguzhali helped him up and brought him some water to drink. He was a fisherman from Ilangai who had gone to fish the previous day. Describing the storm's fury, the fisherman told her that his companion and friend died in the sea. He also had other important news.

"Last night, when the storm abated a bit, lightning struck us at sea and by its light we saw two ships and one of them was burning. The people in the other ship were trying to rescue someone from the burning ship that sank after sometime."

After hearing this Poonguzhali felt a germ of worry growing in her heart.

What if this ship was the one that bore the prince? No. That's not possible. There are many ships traversing by this route. It could it

any of those ships.

She then decided to take her boat into the sea. There might be other survivors from the ship that drowned. She felt that it would be worthwhile to help people rather than bear a life that was bereft of her Prince.

She immediately took her boat into the sea. For some reason an unexplained enthusiasm and happiness took over her heart and she started singing the song that she normally sang while rowing her boat.

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The prince and Vandiya Devan were floating endlessly, their hands clutching the mast that had wrecked their boat. Though they were in the sea for a few hours since that night, for Vandiya Devan it seemed as though he had been floating for years. He soon lost all hopes of reaching ashore and was sure that he would die. Whenever the waves rose, he was sure that he would die and when he didn't, he was surprised. He often looked at the prince and said, "My thoughtless actions have brought this danger upon you." But the prince tried to console him with encouraging words. "I know people who have survived in the sea after floating in it for three or four days."

"How many days have we been floating?"

"We have been here for just a few hours, my friend."

"Lie! That's a lie. We have been here for many days!"

Very soon another torment was upon him. His throat dried up and he felt extremely thirsty. He found it ironical that he was floating in water of fathomless depths and yet there was not a drop for him to drink. When he told the prince about this, he said, "Be patient, the sun will rise soon and we will be ashore."

Vandiya Devan couldn't bear the torture anymore and beseeched, "Ayya! I can't bear this anymore, please untie me from this mast and survive this ordeal. Allow me to die in peace."

When the prince tried to encourage him, he wouldn't listen and tried to untie himself by force. The prince then hit him on the head and rendered him unconscious. When he woke up again, the sun had risen from a nameless direction and the prince looked at him kindly and said, "My friend! Don't despair. I am sure we are near the coast. I spotted a coconut tree at a long distance. Be patient for a while, we will reach the shore soon."

"No, my prince. These are but mere words. Allow me to die."

"Don't lose hope so soon. I will never allow you to die. Aha! Do you hear that? Someone is singing!"

That's when they heard Poonguzhali's beautiful song. For Vandiya Devan it signified hope and life, after the deluge that almost took his life.

"That's Poonguzhali's voice. She must be coming this way on her boat. Thank the gods, we are saved."

Soon they were able to see the boat at a distance. Poonguzhali looked at them with an astonishment that was indescribable. The prince untied Vandiya Devan and got into the boat and then he helped him to get in while Poonguzhali sat transfixed, unable to believe her eyes.

## **An Excerpt from Ponni's Beloved Volume 3**

### **Chapter 1: At *Kodi Karai***

The storm that began in Ilangai crossed the sea and made its way through the coastal cities of Chola Kingdom leaving behind destruction and death in its wake. From Kodi Karai to Kaveri Pattinam, the cyclone rendered many people homeless, uprooted trees and destroyed many a property. The backwaters of Kodi Karai were flooded and the quick sands became more deadly and dangerous than ever, capable of swallowing large elephants.

Two day after the storm, Periya Pazhuvetarayar and his entourage came to Kodi Karai. A veiled palanquin followed the entourage but this time, it was indeed Nandini who travelled in it. There was no reason to take Prince Madhuranthakan with them and Lord Treasurer felt that it was important that Nandini travelled with him sometimes. It might be necessary to take Madhuranthakan again in the same veiled palanquin and if the Pazhuvur queen were to travel genuinely with her husband on some trips, no one would suspect otherwise. This was one of Nandini's arguments, but it didn't take long to convince her husband. Pazhuvetarayar readily accepted her suggestion and gleefully anticipated a romantic trip by the coast, along with his beautiful wife.

Just before storm struck Kodi Karai, they were in Nagapattinam for a day, where Pazhuvetarayar met people on affairs of the Kingdom.

Nagapattinam in those days was one of the busy ports of Cholas and was a trade route for many merchant ships. Ships laden with goods would often anchor in the sea port and boats would ply their way to the coast to unload and ferry them back to the mainland. Trade merchants and officers of the guild would be at hand to levy taxes on the goods that are brought by the ships and the merchant ships



would trade for items that they wish to take back to their respective Kingdoms. There were many royal officials at the Port to conduct this business and as the Treasurer of Chola Kingdom, it was his duty to oversee their records.

After meeting the guild of merchants, Pazhuvetarayar headed to Chudamani Viharam (Buddhist Monastery). The bikshus graciously invited him in their midst and accorded him the respect and courtesy due to his status.

A few days ago, two Buddha Bikshus from this Viharam visited Thanjavur and requested permission to meet the Emperor. The Pazhuvur lord allowed them to meet Sundara Chola and they blessed him with good health and showered praises about his benevolence towards them. They also had many good things to praise about Ponniyin Selvar who was helping the Buddha Sangam in Ilangai by renovating their monasteries and temples. They also imparted a very important information to the Emperor...

“Chakravarthy! The Buddha Sangams in Ilangai are so delighted with the Prince’s benevolence that they have decided to offer the crown of Ilangai to him. This news has not only made us proud but also very happy! There is no higher praise for this Chola Kingdom than this!”

Periya Pazhuvetarayar who was present there had an unusual idea that he voiced to Sundara Chola after the Bikshus left.

“My Lord! While there is no doubt that you rule over this vast kingdom, unfortunately your sons rarely listen to you and nor do they respect your wishes. The reason for this is the ill advice given to them by certain people who have coveted important positions in our royal court. Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan refuses to come to Thanjavur and is instead asking you to travel to Kanchipuram. He is being taught by your noble father-in-law Malayaman to disrespect your wishes. Similarly, I have sent messengers one after another across the sea asking Prince Arulmozhivarmar to come home but in

vain. These messengers find it difficult to meet the Prince, thanks to the schemes of Commander Kodumbalur Vellars. If Prince Arulmozhi knew that you wished to see him, he would immediately set out from Ilangai, I am sure of it. I would like to propose a plan that would make it hard for the Prince and the Commander to ignore your commands. If you permit, I can elaborate...”

When the Emperor nodded his ascent he said, “Let us send a war ship with the Emperor’s royal commands to imprison the Prince on charges of trying to usurp the throne of Ilangai. Kodumbalur Vellar cannot ignore a direct command from you and our men will have to meet the Prince directly to hand the Olai. The Prince will never disrespect your orders, he will return immediately,”

When Sundara Chola heard this, he smiled. It was a strange idea and by all accounts it might even work. The Emperor wished to see Arulmozhi as soon as possible because he had lately realized that he was nearing his death. He wanted to speak to the young prince about the giving up their claim on the throne to Prince Maduranthakan. He hoped that the Prince would aid him in this plan and help change his older brother’s mind.

Thinking thus, Sundara Chola acceded to the Pazhuvetarayar’s idea of sending warships to Ilangai to imprison the Prince. Periya Pazhuvetarayar arranged for the warships and sent his own soldiers along with the sailors to Ilangai. The Captain of the ships had strict instructions not to cause any bodily harm to the Prince and to treat him with utmost respect.

After the ships departed to Ilangai, Periya Pazhuvetarayar started worrying. He was concerned about his own reputation and if something untoward were to happen to the Prince whilst on his journey home, he would be blamed for the same. He, therefore, decided to go to Nagapattinam to welcome and receive the Prince ceremoniously and to bring him back to Thanjavur, under his protection.

There were few other reasons for this decision. He didn't want the Prince to meet the Dowager Queen Sembiyanmadevi or Princess Kundavai before he spoke to his father, the Emperor. Both women had a lot of influence with the Prince and they hated the Pazhuvur brothers. He feared that they might change his mind. He didn't want anything untoward to upset his plans and wanted to implement them carefully until the right time, which in other words meant, until the Emperor's death.

Periya Pazhuvetarayar had many other worries too. The soldier who guarded the treasure chamber and the dungeon pathway was found dead and it had given rise to many suspicions in his mind.

*Was someone hiding in the treasury? Could it be that spy from Karikalan, who his brother had foolishly lost sight of? If that were so, then he would have learned many other secrets!*

*Could Nandini be involved in this?*

His brother had warned him about the Mandiravadi who came to meet his wife.

*Could he be a spy?*

He decided that he needed to find more about the Mandiravadi. When he learned that Princess Kundavai had sent Vandiya Devan to Ilangai with a message for her brother, he was more than worried.

*What message did she send to her brother? Did she warn him about the conspiracy that they had planned?*

Be that as it may, he had decided that once the Prince reached the shores of Chola Kingdom, he would be taken into his custody and protection. He had also asked the Captain of the warships to imprison Vandiya Devan, if he was found in the company of the Prince. He wished to interrogate him personally and find out what he knew.

Thinking thus, the Pazhuvur lord travelled to Nagapattinam to await the Prince's arrival. Nandini had more reasons than her husband to travel to Nagapattinam. She was eager to meet Vandiya Devan and to know what message Kundavai had sent along with him to the Prince. She also wanted to know how far Mandiravadi's mission in Ilangai had been successful. Hence, she insisted that she too would travel along with Pazhuvetarayar. The Pazhuvur Lord agreed to take her along without much argument. He wanted to go on a romantic trip by the boat along with his beautiful wife and had hoped that this might quench his desires to some extent but sadly it didn't come to pass.

While they were in Nagapattinam the storm hit the city and it was impossible to go anywhere on the boat. However, Nandini enjoyed the high winds and huge waves that rose up in the sea from the safe confines of her palace balcony, while her husband brooded about his crushed dreams.

After the storm passed them by, Pazhuvetarayar was busy with the city officials to check the damages that have been caused. The destruction to property and life was minimal within the city since they had largely anticipated the storm. However, he heard many disturbing rumours from ships and boats that returned from the sea. He heard that in the middle of the sea, two ships were sighted in the storm and that one of them was burning and it caused him immense worry.

*What if this was one of the ships that he had sent? What if the Prince had been in one of these ships?*

He knew that if some mishap were to befall the Prince, he and his clan would be blamed for it. The Prince was popular among the people and they would never forgive him any danger that befell him. Desperate for more news, he decided to travel to Kodi Karai. There might be fishermen who probably saw those ships and they might be able to tell him what happened.

When he told Nandini about his decision she immediately acceded to his plan. “I have never seen Kodi Karai. I have heard that it is very beautiful. I wish to see it along with you,”

There were two ways to reach Kodi Karai, through the canals that lead them to the backwaters or through the roads. Since their entourage was large, they decided to go by the road. Moreover, Nandini didn't want to travel by boat since she feared that it might encourage Pazhuvetarayar's romantic overtures. She also told him that if they travel by road, they might get a chance to speak to the fisher folk who might have come back from the sea.

Though they met some fishermen on the way, they didn't get any new information about the ships. When they reached Kodi Karai, the guardian of the lighthouse Thyaga Vidagar offered his humble home for the Pazhuvur couple, as there was no palace or mansion for them to stay.

However, Nandini refused his offer and opted to camp in tents near the lighthouse. After the tents had been struck, they noticed a large ship in the horizon of the sea, and it came as close as possible to the sea.

Periya Pazhuvetarayar got very excited to see the ship. The ship looked very careworn thanks to the storm and its sails were ripped and torn.

*Who could be in this ship? Could it be the Prince?*

The fact that it didn't have a flag atop the sail was not surprising since the stormy winds might have torn it away.

Pazhuvetarayar sent a boat full of men to learn more about the ship. The ship seemed to be waiting for the boat, as two men immediately got into it and came ashore. One of them was Parthibendra Pallavan.

Prince Arulmozhivarmar who left his ship to save Vandiya Devan didn't come back that night. Parthibendran and his crew searched for them fruitlessly in the sea. They rescued one of the sailors who had gone with the Prince and learned from him that after saving Vandiya Devan, their boat was broken into two by a sail mast.

Parthibendran was in huge despair and they searched for the Prince for few more hours and then decided to go to Kodi Karai with a faint hope that he might have come ashore here.

When he learned that Periya Pazhuvetarayar had come to Kodi Karai along with Nandini he got irritated. He remembered everything that Karikalan had told about her. At the same time, he was also curious to see the woman who had stolen the Crown Prince's heart and his sleep. That curiosity grew more and more as they neared the shore so much so that he feared whether he would be allowed to meet her!

He needn't have worried so much because as soon as he came ashore, the soldiers took him to Pazhuvur Lord's tent. Pazhuvetarayar was standing at the entrance of his tent watching Parthibendran. When the Pallava Lord saw him, he realized that he was doing Pazhuvetarayar a huge injustice by calling him an 'old man'. He realized that it would indeed be a difficult prospect to find a young man who would match his stature, build and stamina indeed!

While he was thinking thus, a beautiful maiden came out of the tent. To Parthibendran, it seemed as though the clouds had parted to reveal a peal of lightening. Like a beautiful flower creeper, she came around Pazhuvetarayar's gnarled old form. Her beauty had astonished Parthibendran so much that it robbed him of speech.

"My Lord! Who is this warrior? I have never met him before," she said, her voice dripping with honey that was as intoxicating as nectar.

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[1] **Kodi Karai** – Known as Point Calimere, Kodi Karai is a low headland on the Coromandel coast in Nagapattinam district.

[2] **Sundaramurthy** – The Nayanmars were a group of 63 devout poets. Of them, Sundaramurthy was an 8th century poet who composed many poems about Lord Shiva during the Bhakti movement of South India. He is the most popular of the Nayanmars and his compositions are sung even to this day.

[3] **Kuzhagar Temple** – Known as Kodi Kuzhagar Temple or Amrithakadeswarar Temple, it is believed to be built by the Cholas. There are many inscriptions on the temple that date back to the 9<sup>th</sup> Century.

[4] **Devaram or Tevaram** – The first seven volumes of Tirumurai which is a twelve-volume collection of Shaiva poetry. All seven volumes are comprised of divine hymns sung by popular Nayanmars – Sambandar, Tirunavukarasar (Appar) and Sundarar.

[5] **Gopuram** – Ornate tower of the temple, usually set atop gateways.

[6] **Battar** – Temple priest.

[7] **Prasadam** – Food offered to the gods in the temple is distributed among the devotees. In other words, it is a gracious gift from the gods.

[8] **Ayya** – A respectful term in Tamil used to address men.

[9] **Nandi** – The divine bull and the guardian deity of the gate to Kailasa, the abode of Lord Shiva.

[10] **Lord Rama** – Believed to be the seventh incarnation of Lord Vishnu, Rama was the first son of Emperor Dasaratha who was exiled by his father for 14 years.

[11] **Pachavati** – A part of Dandakaranya forest, Lord Rama, Sita and Lakshmana lived in the Panchavati forest for a while during their exile.

[12] **Thanjavur** – The historical capital of medieval Cholas. Today, it is considered an important center of art and architecture with many UNESCO protected monuments and temples.

[13] **Devendran** – Another name for Indra, the King of the Devas.

[14] **Anni** – Kin term for brother's wife in Tamil.

[15] **Ilangai** – The ancient Tamil name for Sri Lanka, which is still used.

[16] **Pazhaiaarai** – One of the capitals of the medieval Cholas. This historic town is situated on the outskirts of Kumbakonam in Tamil Nadu.

[17] **Sanjeevini Mountain** – In the epic Ramayana, Hanuman was tasked with finding a life-saving herb to revive Rama's fallen brother Lakshmana. Hanuman went to Drongri Mountain in the Himalayas but was unable to locate the plant. Since time was running out, Hanuman brought the entire mountain. When he was taking the mountain back to the Himalayas, chunks of it fell in Sri Lanka. Five places in Sri Lanka are traditionally identified as these chunks: Kachchativu island, Thalladi, Ritigala, Dolukanda and Rumassala. These places are abundant in medicinal herbs.

[18] **Hanuman** – Son of the wind god and Rama's messenger in the epic Ramayana.

[19] **Mandiravadi** – Means 'magician' in Tamil.

[20] **Kalidasan's** – Classical Sanskrit Poet believed to have lived in the first century BCE. His epic poems Kumarasambhava, Raghuvamsha and drama Shakuntala are still popular.

[21] **Krishna** – An incarnation of Vishnu

[22] **Gopis** – Cowherd girls in Vrindavan who offered unconditional love to young Krishna

- [23] **Appa** –Father
- [24] **Olai** – Palm leaves on which messages were written.
- [25] **Sethu Karai** – Coast of Sethu in Ramanathapuram
- [26] **Thambi** –Younger brother in Tamil. It is also used to address men who are younger than oneself.
- [27] **Dhoomketu** – A comet.
- [28] **Kumbakarnan** – Younger brother of Ravana, the antagonist in the epic Ramayana. Kumbaranan is a giant who used to sleep for six months at a stretch.
- [29] **Asura** – Powerful superhuman demigods and the evil cousins of the Devas (benevolent demigods)
- [30] **Kolli Vaai Pisasu** – Fire bubbles that form near marshy areas and quicksand.
- [31] **Murugan** – The God of War, younger brother of Ganesha and the son of Shiva and Parvathi. According to Tamil legends he had two wives – Devasena and Valli.
- [32] **Valli** – The consort of Murugan, Valli belonged to the Vedda tribe in Sri Lanka. Murugan wooed and married her by eloping with her against the wishes of her parents.
- [33] **Mandapam** – A stone canopy for sheltering wayfarers and travellers
- [34] **Indra** – God of Lightning and King of the Devas.
- [35] **Vajrayudham** – Indra's weapon – a thunderbolt.
- [36] **Samudra Raja** – King of the sea in Tamil
- [37] **Samudra Kumari** – Daughter of the sea in Tamil
- [38] **Thai, Masi** – Months in the Tamil calendar. Thai – Mid January to Mid February. Masi – Mid February to Mid March.
- [39] **Kondal Kattru** – Safe winds
- [40] **Vaigasi** – Tamil month that lasts from mid-May to mid-June
- [41] **Chozha Kattru** – Monsoon winds
- [42] **Parvathi** – Consort of Shiva
- [43] **Muruga** – Son of Shiva and Parvathi and the God of War.
- [44] **Maha Vishnu** – A principal Hindu deity
- [45] **Seven Sages** – The constellation of Ursa Major (Great Bear). In Hindu mythology, this constellation is associated with the seven sages - Bhrigu, Atri, Angirasa, Vasishta, Pulastya, Pulalaha, and Kratu.
- [46] **Dhruva Natchatram** – The Pole Star. In Hindu mythology, Dhruva was a devotee of Vishnu and was made into a star due to his immovable devotion.
- [47] **Naga Theevu** – Now known as Nainativu, this is a small island off the coast of Jaffna Peninsula in Sri Lanka. This island is mentioned in Sangam literature and in Mahavamsa.
- [48] **Maandotham** – Now known as Manthai, this coastal town is an ancient harbor and an important religious site for Hindus due to the Ketheeswaran Temple – a popular Shiva Temple.
- [49] **Pulastiya Nagaram** – Now known as Polonnaruwa, this is the ancient city of Pulastipura.
- [50] **Boodha Theevu** – Ghost island



- [51] **Rameshwaram** – A pilgrimage town in the Ramanathapuram district. In the epic Ramayana, this is where Rama built a bridge across the sea to take his army to Sri Lanka to rescue his wife Sita.
- [52] **Narasimha** – One of the incarnations of Vishnu. Narasimha was half-lion and half-human.
- [53] **Tirthas** – There are sixty-four tirthas that are holy water bodies in and around Rameshwaram in which the pilgrims can take a holy dip.
- [54] **Rama** – The protagonist in the epic Ramayana, and the seventh incarnation of Vishnu.
- [55] **Brahmahathi Dosham** – The act of killing a Brahmin, which according to Hindu scriptures, is a grave sin, worse than the murder of others.
- [56] **Rama Tirtham, Lakshmana Tirtham, Hanuman Tirtham, Sugreeva Tirtham** – A few among the sixty-four tirthas in and around Rameshwaram.
- [57] **Hanuman Tirtham** – Also known as Hanuman Kundam – located at North of Ramanathaswami Temple.
- [58] **Sita's** – Rama's wife in the epic Ramayana
- [59] **Shiva** – One of the principal deities of Hinduism
- [60] **Brahma** – One of the principal deities of Hinduism
- [61] **Namazhwar** – One of the twelve Alwar saints of the Vaishnava tradition.
- [62] **Adey** – An expression of anger, disrespect and disdain.
- [63] **Tribhuvana Chakravarthi** – Emperor of the three worlds.
- [64] **Gurunatha** – Teacher
- [65] **Maya** – Illusion
- [66] **Advaita** – A Vedantic doctrine that identifies the individual self (atman) with the ground of reality (brahman).
- [67] **Advaiti** – Someone who believes and follows Advaita.
- [68] **Saivaite marks** – Three horizontal lines on the forehead, arms and chest marked with holy ash to signify one is a Saivite
- [69] **Brahmadi Rajare** – A respectful form of addressing Anirudhar.
- [70] **Navarathna** – Nine precious gems.
- [71] **Haaram** – A long ornamental chain.
- [72] **Nana desa tisaiyayirattu ainnutruvar** – A popular merchant guild during the Chola times.
- [73] **Manka vaar Theevu** – The Malay Peninsula.
- [74] **Sri Ranganathar** – Presiding deity of Srirangam where Vishnu is depicted in a reclining form.
- [75] **Therinja Kaikola Padai** – Elite personal bodyguards of the emperor. During the medieval Chola Period the Kaikola were an elite army that was formed to protect the merchants. A selected handful of soldiers and commanders from this army would become the bodyguards of the king. These brave soldiers were called *Therinja Kaikola Padai* and they took the name of the ruling king.
- [76] **Ramayana** – One of the great epics of India.
- [77] **Maha Mandiri** – Prime Minister
- [78] **Vengai, Kalingam** – Vengai – is region spread over Godavari and Krishna districts. Kalingam – Orissa.

- [79] **Karikala Vallavan** – Karikala Chola, who ruled over South India around 190 CE.
- [80] **Sundara Chola Therinjakaikola Padai**–The elite bodyguard army of Sundara Chola.
- [81] **Om! Hreem Shreem Hasht!** – A mantra
- [82] **Azhwars** - Twelve poet saints of the Vaishnavas
- [83] **Narayana Mantram** – An invocation to Vishnu
- [84] **Kala Moogar Saivan** – A sect of Saivaites who used to sport matted locks and skull garlands
- [85] **Nammazhwar** – One of the twelve Azhwar saints of the Vaishnava tradition
- [86] **Sadagopar** – Vaishnava saint and poet
- [87] **Frogs in the well** – In the olden days, Brahmins were forbidden from travelling across the sea because they believed that they should not be away from the Vedic fire and it would be impossible to do certain rituals while abroad. Hence those Brahmins who travelled were treated like outcasts or polluted.
- [88] **Traditional service of Ranganathar** – Anirudhar's family took care of the priestly service for Ranganathar temple in Srirangam.
- [89] **Mahindan** – Mahinda V of the House of Lambakanna was the king of Anuradhapura
- [90] **Rohana** – The ancient kingdom of Rohana is a region in the present day Southern and Eastern Sri Lanka.
- [91] **Buddha viharas** – Monasteries where Buddhist monks live.
- [92] **Podhigai Malai** – A range of hills in the southern part of the Western Ghats of South India.
- [93] **Rakshashi** – A demoness
- [94] **Sambuvarayar's son** – Kandanmaran
- [95] **Thakkolam** – A Panchayat town in Vellore district. It was also the site of a battle in 949 CE where Crown Prince Rajadithan lost his life fighting the Rashtrakutas.
- [96] **Navarathiri** - Nine nights. A festival for the goddesses Lakshmi, Saraswathi and Durga.
- [97] **Aandal Kondai** – Ladies' hair worn in a side bun, named after the hairstyle of poet saint Aandal. Even today, brides traditionally wear this hairstyle for their wedding.
- [98] **Thanjai** – Thanjavur
- [99] **Indra** – King of Devas
- [100] **Sita, Arundhati, Nalayani and Kannagi** – Women in Indian mythology known for their virtue
- [101] **Chidambaram temple** – Thillai Nataraja temple in Chidambaram.
- [102] **Irattai Mandalam** - Rashtrakuta kingdom
- [103] **Rani** –Queen
- [104] **Pujari** – Priest
- [105]
- [106] **Appa** - Father
- [107] **Sibi** – An ancestor of Rama from whose lineage Chola Kings claim descent. According to legend he offered to placate the hunger of an eagle with his own flesh so that it would

spare an innocent bird.

[108] **Emperor Manu** – A Chola emperor known for his sense of justice.

[109] **Karikala Vallavan** – Karikala Chola, who ruled over South India around 190 CE.

[110] **Perunara Killi** – A legendary Chola emperor.

[111] **Dharma** – In the epic Mahabharata, Yudhishtra was the eldest of the protagonists, the Pandava brothers, and was also known as Dharma.

[112] **Krishna's Yadava clan** – Krishna's Yadava clan killed each other in a skirmish. Krishna's brother Balarama gave up his body in deep meditation while Krishna himself was killed by a hunter's arrow. After Krishna's death the city of Dwaraka drowned was destroyed by a tsunami.

[113] **Kanchi** – Kanchipuram

[114] **Karaiyar** – Fisherfolk

[115] **Kannara Devan** – Rashtrakuta king

[116] **Karaiyar girl** – Fisherwoman

[117] **Amavaasai** – New moon

[118] **Andhapuram** – Women's quarters in a palace

[119] **Periya Patti** – Elder Grandmother. Here they are referring to Dowager Queen Sembiyanmadevi.

[120] **Vijayadasami** – Tenth day after navrathri, considered very auspicious to begin new ventures

[121] **Mandiramavadu neer** – A hymn composed and sung by boy saint Thirugnana Sambandar that cured the fever of Pandya king Nedumaran who had converted to Jainism.

[122] **Yazh and mathalam** - Ancient musical accompaniment – a string instrument and drums

[123] **Thiruneer** – Holy ash that Hindu devotees used in their daily ablutions

[124] **Raja dhrogam** – Treason against the emperor, a capital offence

[125] **Irailli village** – Village from which the tax income would not go to the imperial treasury

[126] **Anna** – Brother

[127] **Mazhapadi** - Thiru Mazhapadi is a village on the banks of the river Kollidam.

[128] **Pinagapani** - Physician's son

[129] **Chithira mandapam** – Hall of paintings

[130] **Kalanthaka Kandar** – Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's given name.

[131] **Jodhidar** – Astrologer

[132] **Dhanadhigari** - Royal treasurer Periya Pazhuvetarayar

[133] **Indra's pearl necklace** – A pearl necklace, part of the Pandya crown jewels, that was supposedly gifted by Indra.

[134] **Brahmalokam** – Abode of Lord Brahma

[135] **Lord Creator** – Brahma is the four-headed creator in Hindu mythology. He once had five heads and one of them was plucked out by Shiva to punish him for lying.

[136] **Haaram** – A long ornamental necklace

[137] **Trishanku Swargam** – Trishanku's Heaven. Trishanku, an ancestor of Rama, wanted to ascend to heaven in his mortal frame. As he was launched into heaven by the sage

Vishwamitra, the Devas pushed him out. This made Trishanku hang between heaven and earth. In the end, Vishwamitra used his yogic power to create a heaven of his own for Trishanku.

[138] **Simhagiri** – Now known as Sigiriya or Lion Rock, it is located near Dambulla.

[139] **Anuradhapuram** – Ancient capital of Sri Lanka

[140] **Thambilai** – Also known as Dambulla, the city is situated in the Matale district of Sri Lanka.

[141] **Thirupurampayam Pallipadai** - A small town near present-day Thanjavur in Tamil Nadu where a deadly battle between the Cholas, Pallavas, Gangas and Pandyas took place in 879 CE.

[142] **Pallavan** – A scion of the royal Pallavas

[143] **Prahaladan** – Son of the demon Hiranyakashipu and a devotee of Vishnu. When his father tortured him for his devotion, Vishnu assumed the avatar of Narasimha to protect him.

[144] **Narayana** – Another name for Vishnu

[145] **Buddham saranam gacchami** - A Buddhist chant

[146] **Mahiyangana** - Mahiyanganaya is a town situated close to the Mahaweli River in Badulla District, Uva Province of Sri Lanka.

[147] **Hidamba** – King of Rakshashas in the Mahabharata

[148] **Bheema** – The second Pandava brother, protagonist in the Mahabharata, and a renowned wrestler

[149] **Arjuna** – The third Pandava brother and a master archer

[150] **Dhoti** – Traditional men's clothing in south India.

[151] **Eleyley Singan** – Chola emperor Manuneechi Cholan was also known as Eleyley Singan.

[152] **Dusthagamanu** – Sinhalese king who ruled from 161 BC to 137 BC

[153] **Pallipadai** – Memorial temple

[154] **Pongal** – A dish made of rice and lentils

[155] **Pulathiya** – Ancient name for Poonnaruwa in North Central Province in Sri Lanka

[156] **Kai Kola Padai** – Elite bodyguards of the emperor.

[157] **Vanniyar Padai** – A unit in the Chola army

[158] **Vellar Padai** - A unit in the Chola army

[159] **Chanakya** – Teacher, political strategist, kingmaker and advisor to Chandragupta Maurya in the 4<sup>th</sup> Century BCE. He is also the author of Arthashastra – a treatise on statecraft and politics.

[160] **Trikona Malai** – An ancient port city in the Eastern province of Sri Lanka

[161] **Natarajar** – Another name for Shiva

[162] **Stupas** – Ancient religious monuments

[163] **Pataliputra** – Modern-day Patna, and the ancient city in the kingdom of Magadha

[164] **King Ashoka** –Mauryan emperor who ruled from 268 to 232 BCE

[165] **Ujjain** – Ancient Indian city

- [166] **King Vikramadithya** – A mythical emperor of Ujjain known to be just and revered as the ideal ruler
- [167] **Kaveri Pattinam** – An ancient port city in India which was covered by the sea in 300 BCE
- [168] **Krishna Jayanthi** – Popular Hindu festival celebrating the birth of Krishna
- [169] **Dhruva Nakshatram** – The star Polaris in the Ursa Minor constellation
- [170] **Emperor Mahasena** – Emperor of Sri Lanka from 277 to 304 CE
- [171] **Perahera Festival** - Kandy Esala Perahera also known as The Festival of the Tooth is a grand festival celebrated with elegant costumes and is held in July and August in Kandy.
- [172] **Buddha bikshus** – Buddhist monks
- [173] **Rati** – Wife of Manmadhan.
- [174] **Manmadhan** - God of love
- [175] **Shiva** – One of the Principal deities of Hinduism
- [176] **Parvathi** – Consort of Shiva
- [177] **Kannagi** – Protagonist of Silapathikaram, a Tamil epic, she takes revenge against the Pandya king who wrongfully kills her husband
- [178] **Karthikeya** – Another name for Murugan
- [179] **Durga Parameshwari** – Consort of Shiva. Also known as Parvathi
- [180] **Chandala** - A person belonging to the lowest caste
- [181] **Pali** – An ancient language used in Buddhist literature
- [182] **Bharathakandam** - Land of Bharata, another name for India
- [183] **Mahasena palace** – A UNESCO site in modern Anuradhapura
- [184] **Yaanai Iravu** - Known today as Elephant's Pass
- [185] **Sivalogam** – Abode of Shiva
- [186] **Thalapathy** – Commander
- [187] **Prince of Vallam** –Vandiya Devan
- [188] **Thondaimaan** – A brackish water lagoon in the Northern Province of Sri Lanka
- [189] **Yaanai Iravu** – Known today as Elephant's Pass
- [190] **Iravatham** –Indra's white elephant
- [191] **Lord Yama** – Hindu God of Death
- [192] **Mamalla Chakravarthy** –Narasimha Pallavan, Pallava emperor who ruled from 630 CE to 668 CE
- [193] **Oomai Rani** – The Mute Queen
- [194] **Uttara Kumar** – In the Mahabharata, a prince who has no battle experience and gets frightened when he sees the Kauravas in the battlefield
- [195] **Kalapathy** – Captain of a ship
- [196] **Gangasenan** –Kankesanthurai, a sea port in the Northern Province of Sri Lanka
- [197] **Duryodhana** – The main antagonist in the Mahabharata
- [198] **Maharani** –Queen
- [199] **Mullai Theevu** – A fishing settlement in Northern Province in Sri Lanka

[200] **Vajrayudham** – Indra's thunderbolt

[201] **Varuna** – God of the seas

[202] **Vayu** – God of wind

[203] **Agni**– God of fire